# Gossamer Threads

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/28231158.

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Mature

**Archive Warning:**
Major Character Death

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

**Relationship:**
Entrapta/Hordak (She-Ra)

**Characters:**
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**Additional Tags:**
Alternate Universe - Canon Divergence, Hordak (She-Ra) Redemption, Wrong Hordak is Named Kadroh (She-Ra), Escape, Uneasy Allies, Revolution, Love, lost heritage, Horde Prime's Ship (She-Ra), Horde Prime Is His Own Warning, Hive Mind, Canon Disabled Character, Eldritch, Parallel Universes, Outer Space, Violence, Hordak-centric (She-Ra), Season 5 AU, The s5 story I WISH we'd gotten, Fix-It, Canon Rewrite, Not Catradora Friendly, Glimmadora is a background ship in later chapters

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# Gossamer Threads

by Entrapdak_Nation

Summary

This is a canon divergent fanfic that takes place after the events of "Destiny, Part 2". What if Hordak teamed up with Glimmer and Catra to escape from the Velvet Glove? What if he found his way back to Etheria, where an overwhelmed Rebellion and a broken Horde awaited him?

# Hope

From sleep, he slowly awakened.

Inside his head, silence, emptiness.

Images dimly appeared in the darkness of his mind. Specks of light? A green haze? Words, faces floated at the edge of the emptiness, just out of reach.

Weightless, he floated in liquid, without armor, without garments. The liquid was cool against his skin, while hot pain throbbed in his muscles and bones. His neck port felt raw and sore.

He opened his eyes. A vitrine. He was floating in a vitrine. Around him was liquid, faintly glowing chartreuse. A soft humming came from thick cables plugged into his ports. Beyond the glass were other empty pods.

Faces, voices, scenes bubbled up into his awareness. A woman with long fuchsia hair and red eyes. A green-lit laboratory. A throne shaped like a peacock's tail. A toddler with blue skin and bat wings. Cables writhing around a man's head like serpents. The toddler again, perched on his arm. The woman again, bright-eyed, smiling, lit from behind by yellow sparks.

*Imperfection is beautiful – You have given yourself a name -- As a scientist, I'm not going to stop – You have forgotten who you are – I'm a failure – But you have become an abomination!*

Slowly, names congealed out of the emptiness in his mind. Entrapta. Imp. The Fright Zone. The Velvet Glove. Horde Prime, emperor, savior, destroyer.

Hordak.

He had given himself a name. Hordak.

He began to remember. He remembered Horde Prime's cold hands on his face, Horde Prime's consciousness pouring itself into his mind, an emerald green arcus cloud billowing over his thoughts. Every doubt, every secret was illuminated with blinding light. His empire on Etheria. His throne. His little spy. His friend. His name.

His blasphemous name, his blasphemous empire had enraged his emperor. With a hand at his throat, Horde Prime had condemned his sins and vowed that he would be reborn. Then came a cable. A stab to his neck. Searing green light. Terror.

But now, Hordak was alone in his head. Prime was gone.

His limbs ached. His eyelids felt heavy. He closed his eyes.

Before him, in the space of his mind, stretched a black void. An emerald storm cloud – Horde Prime -- undulated in the distance. Many years before, Prime was a constant presence in his head. Now, Hordak could see his master, but could no longer feel his presence. Did Prime deem him unworthy to rejoin the hive mind?

Other objects appeared in the void. Orbiting the green cloud in all directions were thousands of crystalline spheres, with brilliant golden fires burning within each one. Gossamer green threads ran from the emerald storm cloud to each of the spheres. A vast sea of golden lights, sparkling in the void like stars, with living threads dancing among them.

Exhaustion overtook him. The cloud and sphere were replaced by darkness, by sleep.

"The strength of the Galactic Horde lies in its numbers. Here, in the nursery bay, my soldiers are cloned en masse from my genetic template."

Horde Prime's voice woke Hordak from unconsciousness. In the void of Hordak's mind, the green storm cloud was close now, as were four of the blazing crystal spheres.

When he opened his eyes, Hordak saw Horde Prime in his long white robes, standing outside the vitrine several yards away. Flanking Prime were four clones, standing at attention, impassive and silent.

Four clones. Four spheres, now close to him in the void of the hive mind. Were all those spheres his brothers? Why could he see them now?

Standing in front of Prime, staring into one of the cloning vitrines, were two young women. One, a stocky woman with short hair that shimmered. The other, a wiry feline woman with long, wild hair.

"It takes only eight Etherian days to create a mature clone," Prime explained. "Each one is programmed with all the knowledge he will need to serve his emperor. Cybernetic augmentation makes them stronger and faster. A miracle of science. Wouldn't you agree, Queen Glimmer?"

Queen Glimmer. Hordak slowly remember her. An Etherian princess. An opponent. A leader of those who opposed his Horde.

"The Sacrament of Clarity takes place soon after a clone emerges," Prime continued. "It binds his mind to me, letting me see his thoughts and pilot his body. Afterwards, he adores his emperor above all else. He would gladly die for the glory of Prime."

Glimmer gazed into one of the vitrines, saying nothing.

"No matter how many are struck down, more of their brothers can be cloned to replace them," Prime said. "Over here are reconditioning chambers. Injured clones are brought here for accelerated healing. Injuries that would incapacitate an ordinary warrior for months can be repaired in a matter of days."

The feline woman stood in front of Hordak's vitrine. Her wide eyes locked with his half-closed eyes, and she clenched her jaw as she

stared at him. Through the liquid and glass, Hordak recognized Catra's face.

"Why did you come back to this?" Catra whispered.

Memories stirred. Mocking laughter. War plans. A city by the sea in flames. A crystal wrenched from his armor, then agony. A lever, and a portal opening. *Nothing matters but this mission – Defect – Let the princesses in? -- We're going to show them all – Vanity projects – And I don't need you!*

"Do you see now?" Prime asked his guests. "The futility of resisting the light and order I bring?"

Catra slowly backed away from Hordak's vitrine, frowning. Prime walked up behind her and placed a hand on her shoulder. She tensed.

"Oh, that rare error will be reconditioned enough to function," Prime explained to Catra. "He'll be sent back to Etheria. To fight until he perishes. Death in the service of Horde Prime is a great honor, one he will earn soon."

Prime turned to the four clones. "Escort Queen Glimmer and Catra to the banquet hall, I will join them shortly."

Glimmer, Catra, and the clones disappeared. Now, Horde Prime stood before his vitrine, all four eyes glaring at Hordak's face. Several moments passed in silence.

"Why can't I see your thoughts?" Prime asked quietly.

With weary eyes, Hordak gazed back at Horde Prime for several more moments. Suddenly, Prime slammed his fist against the vitrine glass.

"WHY CAN'T I SEE YOUR THOUGHTS?" Prime bellowed.

Prime stepped back from the vitrine, breathing hard. Then, he too disappeared.

Pain still burned within Hordak's limbs. His spirit ached. He closed his eyes and slid back into unconsciousness.

A dull roar woke Hordak. The vitrine shook violently. The glow of the liquid dimmed, plunging him into darkness. Moments later, light returned. The vitrine was still and silent for minutes thereafter.

The aching in Hordak's muscles had lessened, and the rawness in his neck port had dissipated. How long had he been recuperating in the reconditioning chamber? Hours? Days? Floating in the oxygenated vitrine medium, his mind growing clearer in the silence, Hordak felt an emptiness spreading in his chest.

It had all been for nothing. All the conquests of the Etherian Horde seemed so futile now. So many soldiers trained, battle plans woven, villages invaded, and cities incinerated, only to be met with Horde Prime's insults and a cable to the back of the neck. So many years, wasted.

But wasn't Prime a just lord, rewarding the faithful? Had he not served Horde Prime faithfully? Hadn't he worked tirelessly to conquer for Prime's glory and return to his side? Why had Prime punished his devotion? Why had his piety earned him nothing but wrath?

Memories of Entrapta and Imp pushed their way into his thoughts. Imp's smile when Hordak rubbed his cheeks. The gentle weight of the child resting on his shoulder. The light in Entrapta's eyes when Hordak spoke to her of portals and faraway planets. The excitement in her voice as she described her engineering plans.

Both were forever beyond his reach now. Imp had been left behind in the Fright Zone. Was he flitting through the hidden corners of the Fright Zone, lonely, alone? Were kindly Horde soldiers caring for him? Had the Rebellion kidnapped him? Hordak would never know. And what of Entrapta? Had Beast Island's

pain-signal and flesh-eating creatures slain her? Was she still alive, wandering the wilderness, wondering why he had abandoned her? Hordak would never know. He had failed them.

Hordak bared his teeth. Tears spilled out of his eyes and floated in the green liquid. He clenched his fists and trembled.

So many sacrifices, and for what end? Weren't Hordak's efforts plain to see? Where was Prime's love? Where was his just wisdom?

An animal scream poured out of his throat. More tears seeped out of his eyes, floating around his face. His fist struck the vitrine glass.

Entrapta was lost to him, and possibly dead. Imp was lost to him. Horde Prime's love was never to be his. At the end of it all, Hordak had nothing. *Nothing.*

His fist struck the glass a second time. Hordak screamed again, punching a third time. With a loud crack, a break appeared in the vitrine glass. The break grew, making crackling sounds as it spread upward and downward through the glass. Then, the glass shattered outward. Green liquid and glass fragments spilled onto the floor outside the chamber.

As oxygenated vitrine medium poured out, Hordak sunk to the floor of the tank. Slumped at the bottom of the now empty chamber, with wet blue hair covering one eye, arms and legs at odd angles, he coughed violently. With each cough, green liquid flew out of his nose and mouth. At length, the coughing stopped, and he inhaled a long breath of air through his mouth. The air felt cold and harsh in his lungs. He shivered.

"There he is. Found him," said a hoarse woman's voice. Hordak heard two sets of footsteps running nearer.

"Watch your feet. There's glass everywhere," warned another feminine voice.

Suddenly, Glimmer was standing in front of the damaged vitrine, staring at him through the giant hole in the glass. Her face was pale, and her eyes were wide. In her left arm, she was carrying his boots against her ribs.

A moment later, Catra appeared next to her. In her right hand, Catra was dragging the upper portion of his old exoskeleton, its components spread apart and connected with metal filaments. Slung over her left shoulder was his black dress.

"We're all getting out of here," Catra announced hoarsely. "We need your help. We help *you*, and you help *us*."

"Hordak, we have things you want. Things you need," Glimmer added, putting the boots down. "I know what happened to Entrapta. The day before Prime took us, three of my friends went to Beast Island to rescue her. They came back. One of them fired at you in the Fright Zone."

Glimmer leaned into the hole in the glass. "If Entrapta is still alive, she's with my people. If you want to see her again, I can take you to her at Bright Moon. But we *have* to get out of here, and we need your help."

She extended a hand to Hordak. "Please," she pleaded.

Hordak stared into the young queen's eyes, his mouth open. *Entrapta might not be dead.* Entrapta could still be alive. If he could return to Etheria, he could see her again, tell her that he hadn't forgotten her, apologize for everything. Hope had appeared.

He pulled the cables out of his neck and abdominal ports. Unsteadily, he planted his feet on the floor of the vitrine. He placed his right hand in hers.

As Glimmer helped a stooping Hordak step out of the hole in the glass, Catra coughed and cleared her throat. Glimmer shot her a worried glance. Hordak stood to his full height and looked down at Catra, who had placed the exoskeleton armor on the floor. He

noticed small red spots – petechiae – in her eyes as she returned his gaze, frowning.

"We found your armor on that table. But there's something else you need too," she said, reaching into a pocket on her right sleeve. She pulled out a pink diamond-shaped crystal, engraved with First One's script. "You need this to power it. You can have it back. Just help us escape."

The pink crystal sparkled in the light of the nursery bay. Hordak was reminded of the day when Entrapta gave him the crystal, the armor, the realization that his imperfections were beautiful.

"I … will help you. We're returning to Etheria," he answered breathlessly.

# Escape

Chapter Summary

> Hordak, Glimmer, and Catra navigate hidden corners of the Velvet Glove during their escape. They make their way to a Galactic Horde ship, but clone soldiers will not let them leave without a fight.
>
> Content warning: violence and blood.

Chapter Notes

> This chapter includes a tragedy involving one of the characters. Before anyone gets upset, here's a small spoiler: She-Ra has healing and resurrection powers, remember? Stay tuned.

The floor of the catwalk felt cool and wet underneath Hordak’s feet, and was littered with glass shards. Most of the liquid had spilled off the catwalk onto the ground floor. He slid his feet into the metal boots, then slipped the black dress over his head onto his frame. His muscles ached as he moved, but not as severely now.

In the glass of a nearby empty vitrine, he saw his reflection. His eyes glowed red. Vitiligo still formed jagged blue and white patterns on his arms and shoulders. Holes still gaped between the radius and ulna bones on his arms, but were narrower than before. The muscles in his upper body had gained mass, but were nowhere near as toned as those of his healthy brothers. The reconditioning chamber had healed some of the damage inflicted by his cloning defect, for now.

Glimmer turned from him to look over the railing of the catwalk at the nursery bay ground floor. No clones soldiers had entered the room so far. Hordak noticed that some of the hair on the back of her head was singed. Some of the violet leather on the back of

her left boot had been seared off, revealing a burn wound on her left heel.

"Where … did you get those injuries?" he asked.

"The ship lost power a few minutes ago. The walls shook and everything went dark. The force field outside our room went down, so we made a run for it. Then, it came back up again behind me as I was fleeing. My hair and heel got burned."

"If she's been a split second slower, the force field would have sliced her in half when it came back up," Catra pointed out.

Catra held up the exoskeleton. Hordak bent over and slid his head and arms into the armor, whose components were spread apart. Once the exoskeleton was sitting on his torso, he stood straight and pressed a small button on the back of the collar. The components came together and sealed the exoskeleton. The armor was heavy, and he had to focus to remain upright and balanced. Catra extended the pink crystal in her palm, which he snatched away and clutched firmly, glaring at her. Catra glared back and said nothing.

In the diamond-shaped gap in the collarbone of his armor were two delicate wires. After affixing the wires to the back of the crystal, he inserted the crystal in its rightful place. Immediately, the aching in his limbs dissipated. A thrilling strength coursed through his muscles, and his nerves crackled with warm vitality. Hordak inhaled deeply.

He turned to Glimmer. "How did you two get in here without being seen? Did you teleport?"

Glimmer shook her head. "I can't teleport here. I'm too far from the Moonstone."

"We darted from room to room and hid. Well, I darted. She limped," Catra explained. "The clones were running around everywhere. They were too distracted to notice us."

“We don’t know what’s going on,” Glimmer said, “but if the clones are distracted, this might be our only chance to escape. Hordak, how do we get off the ship?”

Hordak narrowed his eyes. “If we can reach a launch bay, we can use a ship. We can’t travel through the hallways. Soon, the other clones will notice your absence and will search for you there. Crawling through the ventilation ducts would create too much noise.”

He paused. “The service tunnels,” he realized. “Follow me.”

Catra hesitated. “Hordak, can’t Prime—"

“He can’t see my thoughts,” Hordak noted. "He won't know where we are."

Hordak stepped out of the green puddle and scraped the soles of his boots along a dry section of the catwalk floor. Catra and Glimmer did likewise. He led Catra and a limping Glimmer down the catwalk, past twenty empty reconditioning chambers. The nursery bay glowed a soft green from the light of the chambers and the hundreds of cloning vitrines beneath them on the lower floor.

The trio arrived at a wall at the end of the catwalk, just past an open staircase leading to the lower level. The wall was white and smooth, except for a silver panel with a greenish-yellow display screen, keypad, and blank black rectangle. Hordak pressed his left hand to the rectangle, which beeped. With a soft hum and a hiss, an eight-foot-high rectangular hatchway appeared in the seemingly smooth wall.

Hordak opened the hatchway, revealing a dim green and white tunnel behind the wall. He gestured Catra and Glimmer forward, and they stepped into the tunnel. Hordak followed and closed the hatchway behind them.

Overhead lights activated, illuminating the tunnel. Panel after panel of screens and glowing green keypads covered the tunnel’s

walls. Silver conduits gracefully curved around the panels. Sleek metal cylinders were embedded in the walls. The air was cold and dry, keeping the ship's internal machinery cool.

Glimmer leaned back against a panel and sighed, lifting her injured heel slightly off the floor. Catra coughed, winced, and rubbed her throat.

Hordak felt motion in his mind. He closed his eyes, and in the hivemind, he saw two brilliant flaming spheres drawing near. Two brothers were coming closer.

"Shhh. Do not move," he whispered. The three froze.

A few seconds later, rapid footsteps sounded from the other side of the hatchway. Baritone voices called out from the nursery bay.

"This one broke out!"

"Or *they* broke him out."

"Keep looking."

More fleeting footsteps. Two blazing spheres darting to and fro before him in the hive mind. After several minutes, Hordak saw the spheres float away. He opened his eyes.

"They're gone. Let's go," he said.

The three made their way into the tunnel, which stretched for hundreds of yards. Walking behind his former enemies, Hordak was puzzled.

"Why are you doing this? Fleeing?" he whispered. "You'd have a place in Etheria's new order. Former leaders are spared and permitted to administer Prime's acquisitions, usually."

"No," Glimmer whispered grimly. She stopped, turning to face Hordak. Catra stopped as well.

"The Rebellion discovered a superweapon, the Heart of Etheria," Glimmer explained. "It's a magical energy weapon capable of taking out whole planets. The First Ones buried it in Etheria's core. Prime needs She-Ra and the other princesses to fire it. But firing it will kill people on Etheria's surface."

Glimmer sighed. "I won't let him use my planet to destroy other worlds. And I won't let him kill Etherians to do it."

Hordak's eyes narrowed. "How did he learn of this?"

Glimmer shot a knowing glance at Catra, who was learning against the tunnel wall, arms folded.

"Don't look so offended," Catra said to Glimmer. "I saved us both by telling him about the Heart."

Catra turned her gaze to Hordak. "Now me? I'm not doing this anymore," she said flatly. "I spent how many years conquering? For what? I didn't gain anything, and I lost everything. This wouldn't be any different."

Under the service tunnel lights, Hordak could see the red spots in her eyes more clearly. The petechiae, the coughing, the hoarseness – he'd seen those symptoms in other clones and conquered leaders who offended Prime in some way.

"He strangled you," Hordak realized.

Catra's ears flattened. "He said I was being "evasive" about where to find She-Ra. The next thing I know, he's holding me in the air by my throat, and everything is turning gray. I'm done. I'm not serving him." She snarled. "It's not the first time someone took the breath out of my lungs. I'll live."

Her ears perked up again. "Or maybe," Catra whispered with a sneer, "maybe I just think Horde Prime's an asshole, and keeping him from using his precious Heart is the perfect way to tell him to go scratch himself."

The three reached the end of the service tunnel, which opened to a vertical shaft hundreds of feet across. Green and white lights sparkled against titanium machinery. The vertical shaft stretched upward and downward for what seemed like miles, sleek and clean and cold. A dizzying number of other service tunnels opened onto the shaft in both directions.

The hair on Catra's tail bristled. She spun around and bared her teeth. "I heard something. The hatchway. They're opening it. They'll find us any second!"

Hordak gestured to two service ladders leading downward into the shaft. "The ladders. Go downward. Quickly. Glimmer, can you climb down with your injury?"

"I'll have to," she answered, lowering herself onto a steel ladder, grimacing. With each step downward on the ladder, she gasped. Catra followed down the same ladder. The two women stretched and wobbled, struggling to maneuver on ladders designed for seven-foot-tall clones. Hordak lowered himself onto the second ladder and descended alongside them.

"Go down four levels," he instructed. "We'll take the service tunnel there to the launch bay."

The three descended the ladders in silence. After several minutes of downward climbing, they reached the service tunnel Hordak had pointed out. Glimmer rested her back against the wall of the tunnel and lifted her injured foot off the floor again.

"There's something else," Glimmer added. "Horde Prime asked about Entrapta."

Hordak stiffened. Prime penetrated his memories of Entrapta during their psychic link, and now he knew of her genius.

"He said the strength-boosting armor she made was "most intriguing", and that she could aid the Galactic Horde," Glimmer

said. “He’s looking for her too.”

Catra, who had been watching Glimmer, averted her gaze. Her tail twitched. “We should get moving. We need to reach the launch bay.”

The three made their way down the service tunnel. Glimmer limped, clenching her teeth, determined to move at a steady pace. At the end of the tunnel, Hordak leaned toward Glimmer and Catra.

“Horde Prime’s genetic code is the master key to all of the Galactic Horde’s technology,” he whispered. “The ships will only respond to a pilot with Prime’s genetic code – either a clone, or Prime himself. It’s meant to prevent outsiders from using any of his technology against him. Once we board a ship, I will pilot it out of the Velvet Glove.”

Glimmer nodded. Catra stood straighter.

“And if any guards try to stop us, we’ll make them sorry they were ever cloned,” Catra said.

Hordak closed his eyes and stared into the hive mind. The emerald green cloud was churning. Above and below him, spheres were darting to and fro. In the distance, two spheres were floating in their direction.

“We have to move quickly. Be ready to fight. Are you both ready?” he asked.

“Yes.”

“Ready.”

Hordak pressed his left hand to a black rectangle on the tunnel wall. With a hum and a hiss, the hatchway opened. The three walked into the launch bay, a pristine white runway where dozens of green and white Galactic Horde ships sat side by side. A wide door was open to the rest of the Velvet Glove. A sleek control

panel sat beside the door. The ships were long, thin, and sharply pointed, each occupying an aisle divided by a transparent wall with sliding doors.

Hordak, Glimmer, and Catra ran toward the nearest ship. Hordak slammed an open hand onto a black rectangle on the starboard side of the ship. Double doors rose out of the smooth, seamless metal and parted.

"Stop!" shouted two male voices behind them. Two clones armed with crackling shock batons were sprinting toward them.

"Stay behind me!" Hordak bellowed, charging at one of the clones. Catra ran in front of Glimmer, fist clenched, and punched the second clone's jaw.

Hordak grappled with a soldier wearing the garb of a young clone – a white cuirass and black tights -- rather than the white tabard of clones more than one month old. Hordak wrestled the shock baton away from the young clone, hurling it to the side.

"I don't want to kill you, brother! Stand down!" Hordak demanded, grappling with the young man.

His opponent yanked his right arm free and punched Hordak in the abdomen. "Glory be to Horde Prime!" he cried.

Hordak's hold loosened for a split second, long enough for the clone to free his left arm. The young clone grabbed hold of the collar on Hordak's exoskeleton and swept out Hordak's leg. The two men fell to the floor, struggling. Hordak planted one hand on the young clone's collarbone and the other hand on his head, preparing to push him off.

Suddenly, a presence collided with Hordak's mind. A fiery, blazing consciousness overwhelmed him. The image of a green gossamer thread danced in his mind's eye. Thoughts that were not his own spilled into his head: *For the glory of Horde Prime! The apostate must be struck down! The Promised One will deem me worthy!*

“NO!” Hordak shouted, recoiling from the onslaught. His mind writhed against the words, against the presence shouting inside his head. The green gossamer thread undulated like a serpent, pulsing with unearthly energy. Hordak screamed, pushing against the gossamer thread with his mind.

Something snapped. Something tore in the hive mind.

The green gossamer thread split in two. Then, it faded into nothingness.

The young clone froze. Hordak and the young clone stared at each other, wide eyed, for a harrowing second before Hordak dislodged himself. The moment he removed his hand from the young clone’s head, Hordak was alone in his mind again.

“I cannot … feel … Horde Prime,” the young clone whispered in a small voice. “I cannot hear him.”

Hordak rose to his feet, panting. Did the two of them just telepathically link? Horde Prime linked with him by touching his face. Had he unwittingly linked with the clone when he touched his head? Impossible. How?

“I am alone?” the young clone whimpered. “I am alone! ALONE!”

The young clone curled up on the floor, howling.

“What did you do to me? How will Horde Prime know that I am loyal?” he sobbed.

Hordak stared at the weeping clone in horror.

Meanwhile, Catra had been fighting the mature clone, who was clad in a white tabard, white cape, and black tights. After punching him and knocking the shock baton out of his hands, Catra bobbed and weaved. The clone was unfazed by the blow, moving as fast as Catra, blocking her punches and claw swipes.

“I’m not going to rot here! I’m going back to Etheria!” she told him.

Horde Prime’s earlier neck-lift had not left her unscathed. Soon, she was breathing heavily, and a cough burst out of her mouth. The split-second distraction was all the mature clone needed. He swiped.

Blue talons met flesh. Catra’s neck now bore four fresh gashes. She clutched her neck with both hands, blood spilling through her fingers.

“Catra!” Glimmer shouted.

Hordak spun around. Catra was teetering, clutching a neck wound, blank faced. Glimmer, who had been standing at the door of the ship, was running toward her.

““The wicked must be cast out from Prime’s light!” the mature clone growled. “You, blasph—"

The clone’s insults were interrupted when Hordak lifted him off the ground, hoisted him over his head, and threw him at a third clone about to enter through the launch bay doors. The clones collided with loud grunts and fell down on the floor in the hallway.

Before they could regain their bearings and stand, Hordak had already torn the twelve-foot-high, six-foot-wide control panel out of the wall beside the door. He slammed the pillar of sparking machinery against the door, blocking it for now.

The young clone’s sobbing echoed through the launch bay.

Catra had collapsed. Crimson puddles had formed on the white floor. Glimmer had dragged a limp Catra into the ship by the fabric on Catra’s shoulders. Hordak ran onto the ship after them.

The bridge of the ship was a gleaming ring of titanium, black computer screens, and glowing green keypads. Tall and wide windows allowed for a panoramic view of what was outside the

ship. At the front of the bridge was a towering black display screen. In the center of the bridge was a circular dais, partially rimmed with a silver railing, its floor adorned with the green Horde symbol. A thin cable, rooted in the floor, was draped over the railing. Two poles, about four feet high and topped with metal spheres, were affixed to the dais floor.

The bridge lacked chairs, however. Glimmer sat on the floor, with an unconscious Catra's head resting on her lap. One of Glimmer's hands was pressed to the wounds on Catra's neck. Both women were covered in blood.

Hordak's heart was pounding. He flung open a compartment near the floor, underneath one of the computer panels. Out of the dense machinery and circuitry, he pulled a gray sphere about the size of an apple, with sparking wires dangling from its base. The ship's tracking device had to be removed, or the Velvet Glove could track the ship's escape route.

Tracking device in hand, Hordak darted to the door of the ship and hurled the device into the launch bay. On the other side of the launch bay door, a growing group of clones were slamming against the uprooted computer panel, furiously trying to dislodge the obstacle.

The young clone continued to weep. As the clone wailed, a painful memory stirred.

*He wept. He had been sent to die in battle against the Toevah revolt. And he had failed. He had fallen through a spacetime anomaly, and suddenly his ship had crashed. The lights in the bridge had gone dark. A faint smell of smoke drifted through the air.*

*He could not feel Horde Prime's presence. He could see no green holiness in the center of his being. Inside his mind was only darkness, emptiness. For days he sat, weeping, curled up in a ball on the bridge of his wrecked ship. He was alone.*

In that moment, with the young clone's crying ringing in his ears, Hordak made a decision. He ran out of the ship, seized the clone by the bicep, and pulled him to his feet.

"Get up! We're leaving."

With a hand wrapped around the clone's bicep, Hordak pulled the crying clone into the ship. The clone, too disoriented to resist, followed.

Once inside, Hordak pressed buttons on the wall, and the door closed. He threw open a compartment containing restraints, which were normally used when transporting "guests" to the Velvet Glove. He found a pair of large wrist cuffs and bound them to the dazed clone's wrists.

"What are you doing!?" Glimmer shrieked. "He's one of them!"

"He was disconnected from the hive mind!" Hordak replied. "If I leave him, Horde Prime will condemn him as a defect. He'll sentence him to death!"

At the mention of Horde Prime, the young clone began weeping anew.

"Has Horde Prime forsaken me!?"

The young man slid his back down against the wall of the bridge until he was sitting on the floor, his head bowed.

Outside, a clamor of male voices was growing louder. A banging noise sounded repeatedly as the clones threw themselves against the barricade.

Hordak was breathing quickly, and a bead of sweat ran down the side of his head. He stepped onto the dais, plugged the cable into his neck port, wrapped his hands around the two metal spheres at the end of the two poles, and inhaled.

"Systems on."

The spheres under his hands briefly flashed green, then beeped. Lights came on above them. Computer screens around the bridge glowed with green script. The giant screen at the front of the room now showed the launch bay and a scroll of green numbers. A deep humming rose from the back of the ship. Two holographic screens appeared in front of the dais, on either side of Hordak's head.

"Hangar one. Open."

On the giant screen, double doors parted at the end of the hangar. Beyond them was space, stars, freedom. Amidst the smell of blood, the sound of weeping, the pounding of his heart, Hordak gave the command.

"Launch."

The hum from the back of the ship grew louder. The ship slid forward. In a matter of seconds, it emerged from the Velvet Glove into space.

Glimmer and Hordak both gasped at what appeared on screen. Before them was Etheria, a colossal green and blue planet beneath the Velvet Glove. Floating above Etheria were hundreds of Galactic Horde ships.

*Why a fleet this size? Etheria is primitive,* Hordak thought.

A dazzling green light shone through the windows of the bridge. Behind the ship, a blazing green light was shining off of a single point on the side of the Velvet Glove. The tractor beam was about to deploy.

"What is that?" Glimmer asked.

"A tractor beam!"

Hordak clenched the metal spheres. His mind sent a flurry of commands to the ship's computer through the cable in his port.

“Initiate portal jump!”

A low tone sounded through the ship. Space folded. Light warped. Etheria, the Velvet Glove, and the invasion fleet distorted and faded into nothing. Now, before them was only empty space and distant stars.

# Grief

Chapter Summary

> Catra makes the ultimate sacrifice. Light years from Etheria, Hordak, Glimmer, and the young clone are safe from Horde Prime, for now. The young clone struggles with his disconnection from the hive mind.
>
> Content warning: blood and character death.

Chapter Notes

> I imagined Horde Prime inviting Glimmer and Catra to a banquet like the one we saw in season 5. The foods he served in the season 5 dinner scene looked like American foods from the 1960s and 1970s. So, in this story, Prime destroyed 1970s Earth ("Urth"), but not before collecting ingredients and recipes for guacamole, aspic ("ess-pick"), and brisket ("briss-cat").

"Where are we?"

Outside the ship's windows, and on the display screen, Glimmer could only see inky blackness, nebula clouds, and thousands of stars.

"The edge of the Tolosani system," Hordak answered. He pulled the cable out of his neck port and stepped down from the dais. "The Velvet Glove's tractor beam was about to activate. I had to transport us far away, or we'd be recaptured."

Glimmer sat on the floor of the bridge, with Catra's head on her lap. Catra was not moving. Both women's clothes were soaked with blood. Hordak knelt next to them and placed two fingers on Catra's carotid artery, opposite her neck wounds. No pulse.

"She's gone," Glimmer said softly.

Silently, Hordak and Glimmer both stared at the now-still Catra.

Gently, Hordak lifted up the cat-woman's body, now limp, smelling of copper, and carried her to the room behind the bridge. Glimmer followed, limping.

Between the ship's bridge and engine room were the sleeping quarters. Four hard cots, arranged on two double decker bunks, were embedded in the walls on either side of the room. The cots were each covered with a white sheet but lacked blankets. A small square pad sat at the head of each bed, providing support for the sleeper's neck but little in the way of cushioning. Past the cots, underneath two white cabinets, sat two long obsidian chambers on the floor. The jet black chambers were eight-feet-long and cylindrical.

Holding Catra's body in his left arm, Hordak slid open one of the obsidian caskets with his right hand. Then, with both hands, he laid Catra's body inside. Inside the long, wide chamber, Catra looked small.

"When clones die in battle, their brothers place their bodies in these stasis chambers," Hordak explained to Glimmer, who was standing in the doorway to the sleeping quarters. "These hold the bodies in suspended animation to prevent decomposition, until the bodies can be returned to the Velvet Glove for the Rite of Outpouring."

"Is that like a funeral?"

Hordak thought it best not to describe the ritual. "Yes," he replied. This answer seemed to satisfy Glimmer.

"We will bury Catra on Etheria," he continued. Hordak gently slid the stasis casket closed and tapped a keypad on its cover. The keypad beeped and glowed yellow-green.

The blood. The copper odor. Catra's tiny body in the stasis casket. The mind-link with the other clone. Not knowing if he'd make it to Entrata and Imp. The day's shocks all whirled around in Hordak's

head, colliding with each other. His adrenaline began to rise again. He breathed heavily and shoved the anxieties down.

He opened a cabinet. Inside the cabinet were clear canteens full of water. He removed one of the canteens and awkwardly handed it to Glimmer. "We … should clean up," he said haltingly, pulling a sheet off of a cot and tearing it into rags.

Back on the bridge, Glimmer sat down and used the water and rags to blot some of the blood off of her clothing. The garments remained a crimson mess. Her eyes were glassy and unfocused. Hordak knelt down, wiping red stains off of the floor.

The young clone was no longer wailing, but softly weepy. He buried his face in his shackled hands and sighed. He had not moved from the spot where he sunk to the floor earlier.

Glimmer looked up and studied the clone. "Why are you crying?" she asked.

"I'm alone … alone in my head," he moaned. "I can see Horde Prime! But he has forsaken me."

Glimmer cocked an eyebrow. "Does someone want to explain?"

"I'm no longer bound to the hive mind," Hordak finally said, "and I disrupted his connected to it as well when we scuffled. We telepathically linked. I'm not sure how."

As the young clone muttered something about a "fire sphere" and "all the strings", Glimmer and Hordak looked at each other, then back at him.

"What are you talking about? Strings and a sphere?" Glimmer asked the young clone.

"I see them. In my head," sighed the clone.

"I believe … I can enlighten you," Hordak said slowly. "I see them too, in my mind. The sphere you see is … me. Our brothers

appear as blazing globes. The green threads bind them to Horde Prime. And your thread … my thread … were severed."

The young clone lifted his head from his hands. Hordak froze. The young man's eyes were no longer green, but scarlet, like his own.

After a moment, Hordak found his voice again. "I don't understand any of this, why I can see them. Why *you* can see them. Why your link to Prime was broken."

"But Horde Prime wouldn't allow that!" the young clone protested. "I served him faithfully! He would never forsake a dutiful servant! He would never allow a servant to fall from his sight! Horde Prime is a just lord!"

"No, he isn't!" Glimmer interjected. "He's a dictator. He's a monster. He doesn't care about anyone."

"He forsook me as well," added Hordak. "I served him faithfully, and was still found unworthy."

The young clone stared at them, slack-jawed.

Glimmer crept a few feet closer.

"My name is Glimmer. Tell me your name."

The young clone blinked. "Clones do not have names."

"But … Hordak here has a name," she pointed out.

"That is blasphemy!" the clone gasped.

"It seems my entire existence is blasphemy, to Horde Prime," Hordak said bitterly.

The young clone stared at the shackles on his wrists. "What … purpose do I have now? What am I … if I cannot serve him?"

Hordak knelt next to the clone. "Do you want a purpose? I will give you one. Serve and protect this woman," he said, pointing to

Glimmer. “She is precious to Horde Prime. If any harm befell Glimmer, Horde Prime would be outraged. Will you do this?”

The clone looked up at Hordak, then Glimmer. His eyes were now focused.

“It’s true,” Glimmer said. “I’m important to Prime. And I could use your help.”

The clone cocked his head to the side. “If he cherishes you, why did you flee from the Velvet Glove?”

“I, uh, hurt my heel! See? I needed to get medical treatment.”

The clone was silent for a moment, before realization flashed across his face. “The reconditioning chambers *are* calibrated for members of my species, not yours. And our medical equipment is designed for clones. Of course!”

The young man exhaled, smiled, and his face relaxed. “Yes! I will serve and protect Brother Glimmer! Cherished One of Horde Prime!”

Hordak looked back at Glimmer, who nodded. He opened the compartment from which he pulled the shackles earlier and removed a small silver disk the side of a coin.

“If I remove your shackles, you will remain peaceful?”

“Yes!”

“If you behave treacherously, there will be consequences,” Hordak warned.

Hordak touched the disk to one of the shackles. With a click, the shackles fell loose, and the young clone’s hands were free. He rose to his feet.

“Wait here, Brother Glimmer! I will find supplies to sooth your injury!” the clone proclaimed. He disappeared into the sleeping

quarters.

Once the young man was out of earshot, Glimmer sighed heavily.

“He’s a slave. They’re all slaves. Prime put shackles on their souls. And you were one of them. You wanted to conquer Etheria so that Prime would praise you.”

Hordak, who was putting the shackles and disk back in the compartment, stood still. “I suppose … that’s true,” he said grimly.

“But … what about Entrapta? What about Imp?”

Hordak spun around, frowning.

“You learned how to care about people other than Prime. Why did you put them in danger?” she continued. “Why did you summon Prime? He was going to destroy Etheria before he found out about the Heart. You had to know that was a possibility.”

“I …” Hordak struggled to find words. “I … wanted to be worthy in Prime’s eyes. I didn’t … think about the danger.”

“Didn’t you care about them?”

“Of course I cared! I … didn’t reflect on--”

“You also put my friends and family in danger. My people. I’ve already lost both parents to your war. Did you think about them?”

“It … it was for the glory of Prime.”

Hordak had no answers. Glimmer’s gaze bore down on him in the silence.

He bared his teeth and growled, throwing back his shoulders to appear larger—and then stopped.

No. That was an old posture. That was the posture of Lord Hordak the Tyrant, making himself imposing before enemies and subordinates. But that warlord was no more. There was no longer

a throne to defend, an army to command, only a lost man. His snarl disappeared. He stared back at Glimmer, silent.

"I bring you first aid supplies for your heel, Brother Glimmer!" announced the young clone, returning to the bridge with an armful of sundries. "Antimicrobial polymeric hydrogel! These will protect your burn until you are treated."

Both Glimmer and Hordak sighed. Hordak sat back down on the floor. The young clone gently removed Glimmer's damaged boot, cleaned the burn with a small white cloth and a clear solution, and applied a thin, rubbery sheet of hydrogel over the injury.

"When did you last eat, Brother Glimmer?" the clone asked, gingerly placing the boot back on her foot.

"Before I was beamed aboard the Velvet Glove. I'm starving!"

"Horde Prime usually welcomes "guests" with lavish banquets. Did he not serve you a meal?" Hordak asked.

"He did. He had the clones prepare Urth delicacies for Catra and me. Ess-pick. Boiled briss-cat. Guaca-something. But," Glimmer paused. "He told us they were foods from a planet that no longer existed. I just … couldn't eat after that."

"I brought us liquid rations," the young clone said. Among the sundries he'd taken out of the sleeping quarters were three sealed vials, each filled with about two ounces of forest green liquid. He handed Glimmer and Hordak a vial each.

As Hordak unscrewed his vial, Glimmer held the vial in her open hand.

"Catra didn't eat a bite either, after that."

Hordak and the young clone each threw back their vials with one gulp. Glimmer slowly unscrewed her vial.

“I couldn’t understand her,” Glimmer went on. “She tried to destroy Etheria once, with the portal. She’s the reason my mom is trapped between worlds. But then she intervened with Prime. She died protecting me today.”

“Catra was difficult for me to understand as well,” Hordak admitted. “Helpful one moment, cruel the next. She cost me Entrapta. But now, her actions may let me reunite with Entrapta and Imp. I’m still unsure what to make of it.”

Glimmer was tilting her vial back and worth, watching the viscous liquid slowly slide against the glass. She lifted the vial to her nose, sniffed, and instantly wrinkled her nose.

“Uhhhh! I’m sorry. I can’t drink this.”

“The rations are not pleasing to you, Brother Glimmer?” the young clone asked.

“No. It’s … I … I can’t.” She resealed her vial and handed it back to the clone.

Hordak stood up. “You need treatment for your burn, and suitable food. I can take you to a nearby planet for both. We should wait several days before returning to Etheria anyway. Prime will likely be searching for us.”

“Another planet? What kind of planet?”

“Planet Kadroh. It’s part of this planetary system, one of many in Prime’s empire. There’s an Eternian diaspora in Kopar-nik. You could easily pass for one of them. A large Battani diaspora resides there as well. My brother and I can pass ourselves off as residents.”

Glimmer squinted. “Eternians? Battani?”

“One is an anthro species, like your own. The other is our species.”

“It’s as good a plan as any. Let’s go.”

Hordak stepped onto the dais and reached for the cable. “Clone soldiers are stationed there as well. We’ll need to be inconspicuous. Replacing those bloodied clothes will be essential.”

As he plugged the cable into his neck port, Hordak realized that the bright red Horde symbol on his exoskeleton was hardly inconspicuous. He looked down at the bat-shaped decal on his chest. Horde Prime despised him, and he had committed treason by helping Glimmer escape. After this, he would never again have a place in the Galactic Horde. The thought made his adrenaline rush and his blood run cold. And yet, he was still wearing Prime’s symbol.

He picked at the edges of the decal with his talons. Slowly, he peeled off strips of the bat-symbol. After tossing the strips aside, he planted his hands on the metal spheres.

“Initiate portal jump!”

# Cityscape

Chapter Summary

> Hordak, Glimmer, and the young clone arrive on planet Kadroh. In the city of Kopar-nik, Glimmer sees daily life in the Galactic Horde empire.

Chapter Notes

> How can people from different interstellar civilizations all speak the same language? They're speaking Galactic Common, the modern name for the Eternian language. The ancient Eternian empire, of which the First Ones were a splinter, imposed the Eternian language on all the planets they conquered. Eventually, Eternian became the lingua franca of the galaxy, even among planets that were not part of the empire, such as Battaniya (the home planet of the Battani). Horde Prime, who heralded from Battaniya, would have spoken Eternian as an administrative language. Long after the fall of the Eternian empire, the Galactic Horde would impose Eternian on conquered worlds as well.
>
> When the First Ones colonized Etheria, they brought the Eternian language with them. However, the Etherians developed their own writing system in the centuries following the Despondos incident, which is why most Etherians cannot read First Ones (Eternian) script.

A diamond-shaped space station and multiple Galactic Horde ships floated above planet Kadroh, looking down on its blue, black, and tan surface. The station hailed the solitary ship.

"Our sensors cannot pick up your designation signal. Identify yourself," said a clone over the audio frequency.

"Galactic Horde Vessel 08022019," replied Hordak. "Our flock passed through an ion storm in the Galil Belt. Visual display is

offline. Our tracker and sensors sustained damage. Reporting to the Kopar-nik base for repairs."

"Acknowledged."

Hordak, Glimmer, and the young clone emerged from the ship into a grassy clearing. Underneath their feet were charcoal gray sedges and sandy soil, and in the distance were stout trees with black leaves. A large orange dwarf star hung overhead in a pale blue sky. The air was cool and smelled of salt, not unlike Salineas back on Etheria.

Glimmer's eyes darted all over the landscape, so unlike Etheria. The young clone gaped at the vegetation, the pale sky, the saline breeze that ruffled his hair.

"First time off the Velvet Glove?" Glimmer asked him with a smirk.

"Yes. Everything is so different! So intense!"

"I want to see your face when you take in Etheria for the first time."

Hordak said nothing, remembering a moment years ago when he too gazed up at an alien sky, breathless.

*After days of weeping, he emerged from his broken ship, numb. Before him was a desert, cold and dry, with a settlement in the distance. The landscape was flanked on either side by jagged stone formations that seemed ready to clamp on him like animal jaws.*

*The night sky held pastel moons but no stars. The sight of the deep blue void sent a chill down his back. The nearby settlement did not emit enough light to obscure the stars with light pollution. Where were the stars? Panic rose in him.*

*He heard movement. About a hundred feet away, a dozen people were walking toward him. The silhouettes had humanoid outlines, but their forearms were oversized, curved, and without hands. Segmented tails curled out of their lower backs.*

“We are a few minutes’ walk outside of Kopar-nik,” Hordak said. “I recommend we find some clothing to make ourselves less conspicuous.”

The three walked slowly, on account of Glimmer’s limp, through grasses and trees. Glimmer found a fallen branch, peeled off the black leaves, and used it as a walking stick. The trio followed a steel track for a high-speed quantum train which led to a seaside city in the distance. Occasionally, the group would stop to allow Glimmer to take weight off her injured foot for a moment. The young clone offered to carry her, but she politely declined.

"Kadroh is what the Galactic Horde calls a mosaic planet", Hordak explained as she rested on a fallen tree. "Sometimes, to prevent revolts, Horde Prime exiles a portion of a planet's population to different worlds in his empire. Kadroh was one such destination. Eternians, Battani, and Andreenid diasporas are here, among others."

“If Etheria can’t resist Prime, he could do that to my people,” Glimmer realized.

“Yes. He could.”

Soon, small homes covered with white tiles appeared amidst the vegetation. Behind one home was a clothesline on which several salt-white garments were drying. The three quietly plucked several items from the clothesline and returned to a wooded area to dress themselves.

Glimmer discarded her old bloodied clothes and put on a lightweight tunic and baggy trousers that flared at the ends. The young clone put on a long, lightweight robe over his Galactic Horde uniform. Hordak disguised himself with a lightweight

chasuble over his exoskeleton. In the cool temperatures, the clothes would not look out of place.

Hordak had also stolen two headscarves from the clothesline. His unmistakable clone features – the long face, the prominent chin, the mohawk hair style – would draw unwanted attention. He covered his head and lower face with one of the headscarves and handed the other headscarf to the young clone.

"Brother, why are we hiding our faces?"

"This mission requires secrecy," Hordak answered. "Not even the other clones must know of our presence here."

Black vegetation gave way to ivory white streets and looming buildings. The trio had arrived at Kopar-nik, a metropolis overlooking the Kopar ocean. A needle-like green and white spire jutted out from the city center. Smooth, pale buildings dominated the cityscape, evoking the style of the Velvet Glove in their sterility. Towering over a grassy park was a green jade statue of Horde Prime, smiling serenely, hand extended as if offering the viewer an invisible gift.

"This place is *huge*," Glimmer whispered to the young clone. "Etheria doesn't have any cities this big."

Merchants sold water and sundries from wheeled carts. Residents passed them as they walked the city streets. Anthros with beige or brown skin. Anthros with purple skin, pointed ears, and black talons. Lanky humanoids covered with brown and yellow stripes, with segmented eyes, antennae, and delicate wings. People who resembled the Galactic Horde clones, but old and young, slim and stocky, with crimson eyes and skin tones everywhere from light blue to indigo. Most of the residents were wearing flowing, salt-white clothing. Some wore darker, heavier clothes befitting manual laborers. All spoke in a language comprehensible to the trio: Galactic Common.

Glimmer walked up to a cart selling rust-colored bars that smelled like grains.

“Hi. I need some food,” she announced to the hulking woman behind the cart, wearing an apron. The merchant was covered in red fur and had a hunched back and fangs.

“Two avidecos. Hot or cold?”

Glimmer reached into the pocket of her tunic and pulled out an Etherian gold dinar. “Do you take these?”

The hulking woman squinted at the coin, then shook her head. “Sweetie, we don’t take antique coins. Just imperial avidecos.”

“I don’t have those. I really need something to eat. Can you make an exception?”

“Okay, look. There’s a destitution refuge three blocks that way,” the woman said, pointing a meaty hand west. “They’ll give you a meal. It’s clinic day too, so they have people doing check-ups and teeth.”

Glimmer glanced back at Hordak and the young clone and gestured west. Once they were no longer in earshot of the food cart, Glimmer learned toward Hordak.

“What’s a destitution refuge?” she whispered.

“An altruistic institution. It provides rations and shelter to those on the margins of society.”

“Why would Kopar-nik need that?”

“Because the city’s economy is structured around the needs of the empire. Prime is concerned about order and supply lines, not his subjects’ standard of living.”

Glimmer leaned against a retaining wall for a white stone courtyard, lifting her foot off the ground for a moment. While she

paused, Hordak closed his eyes and gazed into the hive mind. The emerald cloud was far away now, a green blur in the distance. All around him, hundreds of blazing spheres hovered in place or floated about, a few with gossamer threads connecting them to Horde Prime, but most without threads. When he opened his eyes, he saw the owners of some of the free-floating spheres: ordinary Battani, going about their business on the city streets.

"Brother!" whispered the young clone excitedly. "I see them! In my head! Those Battani!"

"I do too. What are they doing in the hive mind?"

Many years in the past, before Horde Prime sent him to die on the battlefield, Hordak had been stationed on Kadroh for several weeks. The clones guarded and maintained Galactic Horde installations, ensured that goods flowed to imperial supply lines, and policed the populace for any disloyalty to Horde Prime.

Before his flock arrived on Kadroh, they had been instructed never to touch the ordinary Battani there, as they were “unclean” and carried pathogens that could sicken clones. Most clones looked upon the ordinary Battani with contempt, as they were but flawed mockeries of Horde Prime's perfect form. Some clones felt pity for them, as they were not part of the hive mind and would never know the holiness of Horde Prime's constant presence. But now, Hordak and the young clone could clearly see them in the hive mind.

He closed his eyes again. Among the different free-floating spheres were two spheres bound to gossamer threads. The two clone-spheres were about fifty feet away, moving back and forth quickly.

“Trouble lies ahead,” he told Glimmer and the young clone. “Two __”

Before he could finish, the doors to a home up ahead flew open. Two Galactic Horde clones stormed out, each wearing the tabard

uniform of a mature soldier. Each man was equipped with a small arm canon mounted on his right arm. One was clutching a long, teardrop-shaped dulcimer carved from black wood. The other soldier clutched a small painting of rose and purple geometric patterns. The two clones threw the objects on the ground, where they broke into pieces.

“Stay back,” Hordak instructed Glimmer and the young clone.

A stout Battani woman with shoulder-length mauve hair appeared in the doorway. She was baring her teeth, and her face was flushed.

“Those aren’t yours!” she shouted at the clones. “Those—”

One of the clones raised his arm cannon and pointed it at the woman. “Stay in your house! Do not come any closer.” The woman froze in the doorway.

“Cultural retentiveness is an affront to Horde Prime. You know that!” barked the second clone. “You need not look to old, heathen artifacts for joy. Horde Prime provides all joy.”

A small crowd had formed near the trio to see the commotion. Hordak noticed an insectoid man in the crowd with large eyes, full lips, and four blue legs who was staring at Glimmer. He growled at the man, who cowered and walked away.

Up ahead, the second clone fired his arm cannon at the broken dulcimer and painting lying in the street. A moment later, all that remained of the objects were smoke and ash.

The two clones left, and the murmuring crowd dispersed. As they walked past the smoldering stain on the street, Glimmer leaned toward Hordak.

“What just happened!? It’s not like she had weapons. Those things were harmless!”

“Prime seeks to erase the cultural distinctiveness of all the societies he controls. He preaches that all subjects belong to one culture, that of his empire. But some people still cling to their old ways, in secret.”

The trio arrived at the destitution refuge, a wide, white building with open doors. The building resembled an old warehouse, with high ceilings and broad green windows that bathed the interior in green light. When the three stepped inside, they found nearly a hundred people packed into the mess hall, standing in lines for meals or seated at curvy, minimalist tables. Their white clothes looked older and coarser than those the trio had stolen from the clothesline earlier.

Glimmer and Hordak sat at one of the tables. A few minutes later, the young clone joined them, carrying three mugs of water and a trapezoid-shaped plate on which a gray square sat.

“Brother Glimmer! I brought you nourishment!” he announced.

Glimmer inspected the food. “It’s a ration bar,” she realized. “Adora said she lived on these when she grew up in the Horde.” Glimmer held the bar with both hands, sniffed it, and sank her teeth into it.

“Mmph. When you haven’t eaten, even these things taste amazing,” she said with her mouth half full. “There’s other kinds of food in the city, right?”

“Unlikely. Cuisine is another expression of cultural distinctiveness,” Hordak pointed out. “Prime insists that his subjects eat ration bars for that reason.”

As Glimmer wolfed down her food and the young clone sipped water, Hordak gaze floated over the room. Most of the people were absorbed in conversations, food, and drink, but a few caught his attention. A blonde anthro woman who was staring at Glimmer. An elderly Andreenid woman who was staring at *him*. Something was off.

“We’ve got one more slot for medical check-ups!” called out a slim, bald woman with purple skin in the back of the room.

“Brother Glimmer, you should get your burn treated,” the young clone gingerly suggested.

“Right,” she replied, placing the last bite of food in her mouth and standing up.

The bald woman led Glimmer, Hordak, and the young clone to another wing of the building, this one with smaller, quieter rooms where doctors and dentists tended to visitors.

“You’re Physician Rigel’s last patient of the day. Have a seat inside,” said the woman, gesturing into a spartan white room.

Glimmer entered and sat down on a curvy, minimalist chair, while Hordak and the young clone stood just outside the open doorway. Inside was Rigel, a middle-aged Battani man wearing a long-sleeved white tunic and white trousers. Rigel’s build was stocky, and his skin was a deep, saturated indigo. His sparse blue hair had been cut into short waves and resembled a fin on top of his head. Unlike the clones, who had long, angular faces, this man had a square face.

Rigel stood next to a curvy table, on which different silver medical devices and glass vessels filled with different liquids. He held a data pad, tapping the screen, not looking up.

“Welcome. Name?” he asked, eyes still on the screen. This voice was gravelly.

Glimmer opened her mouth to speak, but Hordak frowned and gave her a look of warning. Glimmer understood.

“Um, Shadow Weaver,” Glimmer answered.

“Shadow. Weaver,” the doctor repeated, tapping the pseudonym into his device. “All right, Ms. Weaver. We’ll take your height and __”

The doctor went silent. He was now looking up from his data pad at Glimmer. He shot glances at Hordak and Wrong Hordak.

"You two. Come in and close the door," he said furtively. They obeyed. Once the door was closed, he turned his gaze to Glimmer again, brow ridges furrowed.

"And what brings you here, exactly?"

"I have a burn on my foot," she answered slowly. "Is everything all right?"

"Let's look at that burn."

Rigel placed a paper mat under Glimmer's feet. He then knelt in front of her chair, removed her damaged boot and the hydrogel dressing, and inspected the burn. "This wasn't from fire or electrical equipment. It's perfectly oval. The edges are regular."

The trio said nothing. Rigel took a hand-held tissue regenerator off the table. The device was silver, L-shaped, and had a small screen on the back of the handle.

"Let's calibrate this for your tissue. Species?"

"Eternian."

Rigel looked up at Glimmer and arched one of his brow ridges. "Eternian," he repeated gruffly.

His attention returned to the tissue regenerator. "Anthro, non-specified," he said as he tapped the tiny screen. A moment later, Rigel was gently holding Glimmer's foot with one hand, and holding the device an inch from Glimmer's burn in his other hand. The device cast a soft blue light onto the injury. Over the course of several minutes, dead, charred tissue fell off Glimmer's foot, and layers of healthy tissue spontaneously appeared, until her skin was healthy again.

“Wow. That was quick. Thank you,” Glimmer said as she put her boot back on. Rigel placed the device back on the table.

“Do you want to tell me what this is all about?” Rigel asked grimly, picking up the paper mat flecked with burned skin flakes. “Your name isn’t Shadow Weaver, you aren’t Eternian, and these men you brought with you are not ordinary men.”

Glimmer turned pale. “How … did you … know that?”

Rigel grimly stared at her for a moment, before letting out a short snort-laugh. “You’re safe here, Queen Glimmer! You have nothing to fear from me.”

Hordak loudly exhaled, relieved. Glimmer’s shoulders relaxed. The young clone watched everyone’s reactions, puzzled.

“You’ve become famous, your majesty”, chuckled the raspy-voiced doctor. He waved his hand over a gray square on the table. The disk projected a small holographic screen into the air, just above the table. On the holographic screen was an image of Glimmer, tense and unhappy, seated at the banquet table of the Velvet Glove. The image slowly changed to an image of Catra seated at the banquet table, a plate of untouched aspic in front of her. Catra’s photo faded, and was replaced by two pictures side by side. One was of Hordak, kneeling in the Velvet Glove’s throne room shortly after he was beamed aboard, disheveled and fearful. The other of a generic clone on a white background, blankly staring ahead. At the bottom of the holographic screen, a chyron of First Ones script scrolled from right to left.

“—treason against the Galactic Horde Empire. Queen Glimmer is considered a high-value imperial asset, and the Throne has promised a reward to those who assist in her retrieval. Anyone with information about the escapees—” droned a serene clone’s voice.

Rigel waved his hand again over the square, and the holographic screen and audio vanished. Hordak now understood why random

strangers were staring at Glimmer, and at him.

“The current events broadcast came out with that about fifteen minutes ago,” Rigel explained. “Lucky for you, most of the city hates Horde Prime. Including me. Where is your cat friend?”

“She … didn’t make it,” Glimmer answered softly.

“I’m sorry,” Rigel replied. "She was brave, going against Prime."

The doctor turned to Hordak and the young clone. “And what about you two strapping men? I thought clones were too brainwashed to disobey Prime.”

Hordak removed his headscarf, and nodded at the young clone to do the same. Their mohawk hairstyle, long faces, and angular cheekbones were now on full display.

“Clones with red eyes? A clone who dyes his hair blue? Now I’ve seen everything,” Rigel said, studying their faces.

“I am Hordak. My brother and I are no longer part of Prime’s hive mind. Glimmer and I are trying to return to Etheria.”

Rigel digested Hordak’s words, then flashed a fanged smile. “Don’t you think you could use some help?”

# History

Chapter Summary

Rigel tells Hordak and the young clone about their heritage and the true origins of Horde Prime.

Chapter Notes

Battani share an evolutionary ancestry with microbats, and this is reflected in the Battani language. Their native tongue includes both "conventional" sounds that are within the human range of hearing and supersonic sounds outside of the human range of hearing. The Battani larynx is equipped to make both types of sounds.

Much like Hebrew and Arabic, Battani uses clusters of “root” consonants to form related works. The root HRD is present in words for family members:

Hord (Horde) – Brethren

Horda - Brother

Hordani - Sister

Hurdat - Household

Oharada -- Family loyalty

In the dream, Hordak stood on a dry, rocky cliff overlooking Dryl, where wind ruffled his hair. On his left shoulder, he felt the gentle weight of a child. Imp was perching there, silently taking in the landscape. A fuchsia lock of hair rested on his right shoulder. Entrapta was standing before him, eyes sparkling, arms wide, talking excitedly about technology.

Over Entrapta’s shoulder, Hordak saw a thunderstorm brewing in the sky. An emerald green storm cloud was billowing on the

horizon. Thunder split the air.

Hordak abruptly woke up. He was sleeping on the floor of Rigel's home, his head resting on a cushion. In the darkness, he saw Rigel's outline, sleeping on the floor on the other side of the sitting room. Nearby was the young clone's silhouette, lying with his back to Hordak. The young clone sniffled softly, and Hordak could smell tears.

A hollow ache filled Hordak's chest. He closed his eyes and tried to sleep.

Dawn arrived. Gold and orange light poured through the windows of Rigel's home, an apartment just a few minutes' walk from the destitution refuge. Rigel was already awake, plucking fruit off of two shrubby black plants sitting under the wide kitchen window.

Rigel belonged to an underground network of resisters who helped those fleeing from Galactic Horde persecution. The evening before, the doctor had quietly hidden the trio in his home. After washing up, his guests wanted nothing more than to sleep. Glimmer was given the bed in the bedroom, while Rigel, Hordak, and the young clone slept on the floor in the sitting room.

Hordak sat up. The young clone was already on his feet, stretching his arms. Around them on the hard floor were the white fabric mats and cushions on which guests would sit. A white island divided the sitting room from the kitchen, and it was on this island that Rigel was setting out plate piled high with small orange fruits.

"It's a special occasion. I have guests just as the morelas are ripening. Come have breakfast. Leave some for Glimmer when she wakes up."

Hordak rose to his feet. The young clone was already standing at the island, holding one of the orange fruits in his fingertips. He eyed the morela with a puzzled expression.

"A friend who works on the farms smuggled me the seeds for these," Rigel said, finishing the last bite of the fruit in his hand. "They grow these to add to the purple ration bars. Oh, but those bars are nothing compared to the fresh fruit."

The young clone took a bite out of the fruit, chewed, and paused. His eyes suddenly widened and sparkled. He took another enthusiastic bite out of the morela.

Hordak stood at the island and plucked a fruit from the plate. The skin of the fruit was smooth, and its flesh was tender. Layers of tart, sweet, and floral flavors bloomed from the first bite he took. Before he knew it, he'd finished the first fruit and was reaching for another.

"These were … well-cultivated," Hordak admitted. The young clone was already sinking his fangs into a second morela.

"What's more Battani than a big plate of fruit?" asked Rigel, beaming at the young clone. "Ah, look at him go. I'll bet you never had fruit like this on the Velvet Glove."

The young clone swallowed a bite. "I never had fruit at all. Horde Prime decreed that his clones subsist on liquid rations. May I have another?"

"Take another. You mean to tell me he never lets you have real food? Like this?" Rigel asked, gesturing at the plate.

"No. It was Horde Prime's will that we keep our bodies pure with his rations, and not pollute ourselves with unclean food. Low food was meant for beings outside of the Galactic Horde."

Hordak thought back to his first days on Etheria. When his liquid rations ran out, he had no choice but to subsist on the natives' food. Every bite felt blasphemous.

"He told you that?" Rigel sneered. "Narcissist. He just enjoyed the control."

The young clone’s ears flattened. “But Horde Prime is all-wise. He is a living god whose perfect—”

Rigel was shaking his head and waving his hands. “No. No. God? No. He really told you that?”

The doctor leaned forward onto the island. “Don’t you even know what he is? Where he came from?”

The young clone could only look back at Rigel with lowered ears. “He is … eternal.”

“He really has kept you in the dark. All right. Sit down,” Rigel instructed, pointing to the white mats and cushions on the sitting room floor. He sat cross-legged on a cushion atop one of the mats, and Hordak and the young man did likewise.

“Young man, he lied to you. He’s not a god. He’s a monster, using a man as a steed,” Rigel said grimly. The young clone’s ears were still flattened, and his posture was rigid.

"The Battani still remember, even if Prime wants the galaxy to forget. A lot of our history has been lost, but some of it has been preserved through underground texts. We also pass it down, secretly, though the jeweled-mind-link," Rigel explained.

Hordak had never heard of this jeweled-mind-link, but was too curious about Prime's origins to ask just yet.

"Centuries ago, our home planet, Battaniya, was a galactic superpower. An oasis of civilization after the Eternian Empire collapsed. The empire had split into warring factions -- the Ramstone Brotherhood, the First Ones, the Gar -- but Battaniya held them off and remained independent."

"I've heard of these First Ones," Hordak said. "On Etheria. They left behind advanced technology from a bygone age."

"Etheria was probably one of their outposts. They used early portal technology to travel all over the galaxy," Rigel replied.

The doctor sat straighter. "Battaniya was a spacefaring civilization as well. Back in the Warring Factions Era, a Battani scientist named Annilis was researching space travel technology. Now this Annilis believed that the hyperspace dimension could allow for a new means of space travel. Exciting and dangerous work."

“Oh, we clones know of hyperspace,” the young clone chimed in. “Horde Prime expressly forbids us from entering portal coordinates to the hyperspace dimension.”

“The dangers are too great,” Hordak added. “The laws of physics become unstable there.” Hordak thought back to the malfunctioning portal on Etheria, the flash of white and purple light, and the dreamlike world on the other side. “I had an encounter with the realm once, and I never wish to repeat it.”

"Ah, so you know of that place," Rigel said. "The clones do well to avoid it. During his research, Annilis opened a portal to hyperspace, and a ... *being* came through. It took over his body, spoke through his lips. And you, young man, worship that creature as your lord."

Hordak and the young clone stared at Rigel, wide-eyed.

“Our race has psychic propensities,” Rigel continued. “That may have made him vulnerable to this creature. Or maybe it made him a desirable host. The being called itself the Prime. Over months, Prime mutated Annilis’s body. His sclera turned green, and his pupils darkened. Two extra eyes formed on his face. His jaw became deformed. The jeweled-mind-link allowed Prime to brainwash powerful Battani for his cause. Within a generation, he was the leader of a new empire.”

Rigel learned forward and rested his hands on his knees. "Prime wanted something more for his grand ambitions. He cloned new bodies to wear when Annilis’ body grew too old. He cloned an army out of Annilis' DNA. He forged a psychic link with his new slaves, apart from the other Battani. A hive mind, with him in the

center. Prime surrounded himself with the clones, and the Battani race became just another conquered people."

“You keep bringing up this ‘jeweled-mind-link’. I don’t know what that is,” Hordak interjected.

“The psychic bond between all Battani!” Rigel said with a smile, beaming. “Our birthright! Battani can telepathically link with a touch to the head. It’s how we’ve passed down our history all these centuries.”

It was all beginning to make sense. Hordak’s ears flattened, and he looked at the young clone. The young man was gazing back at him, a look of realization on his face.

“When we were struggling, and you placed your hand on my head…” the young man whispered.

“We linked,” Hordak replied.

Hordak turned back to Rigel. "The hive mind … he used our innate propensities to fashion it. But we clones cannot link with each other. Or not until now, with the two of us. Horde Prime must have disrupted the clone's psychic bonds with each other, somehow.”

Rigel nodded solemnly. “He stole their birthright. *Your* birthright. Do you understand now, how much he has stolen from you?"

Silence hung over the room.

“But you two broke away from the hive mind,” Rigel finally said. “I want to know more about this.”

Hordak swallowed. “When I fell through a spacetime anomaly into Despondos years ago, my link to the hive mind was severed. Even when I returned to Horde Prime’s side, he could not see my thoughts. But now … I see the other clones in the vastness now, when I close my eyes. I see gossamer threads binding them to Prime. I see *him*, but I cannot hear him or feel his presence.”

Hordak turned to look at the young clone again. “When I was fleeing from the Velvet Glove, he and I grappled. I touched his head during the struggle, and our minds linked. I saw the thread binding him to Prime. I pushed against it. The thread disintegrated.”

The young clone cast his gaze to the floor. “And then, I could no longer sense Horde Prime. I was alone in my head. And now, I see the clones in my head. And the other Battani. All flaming spheres,” added the young clone.

“Prime would have condemned you to death, once he learned of what happened,” Hordak reminded him. “And so … I brought you with me.”

"Now this is fascinating," Rigel said softly. "Normal Battani can't see the clones in our minds. But I can see your spheres there. You can see your brothers, and us too. And you freed one of your brothers from the hive mind! Do you know what this means? Other clones can be freed too.”

Rigel was silent for a moment, before rising from his cushion and sitting in front of the young clone. “Young man, your link with Hordak was frightening. It shouldn’t be that way. I can show you how Battani should link with each other. May I?”

The young clone blinked and sat up straighter.

“I would put my hand on your head, and you’d put your hand on mine. It will not hurt. If you want to stop, we stop. Do you want to try?”

The young man said nothing for a few moments, his gaze still averted. Finally, he looked at Rigel. “Yes!”

Slowly, gingerly, Rigel placed his right hand on the side of the young clone’s head. Awkwardly, the young clone did likewise, and the two men closed their eyes. For several minutes, Rigel and the young clone held this pose, expressions focused but calm, as Hordak looked on.

It was so unlike the way Horde Prime linked with him in the Velvet Glove's throne room, Hordak observed. Serene. Willing. No wincing, no facial groping, no shouting.

Rigel and the young clone eventually removed their hands from each other's heads and opened their eyes. Rigel chuckled warmly and patted the young man on the arm. The young clone was smiling softly, face relaxed, awe-struck tears welling up in his eyes.

"There's so much more of life, isn't there?" Rigel asked. "Your journey is just getting started."

"I … I had no idea," said the young man, smiling gently, then broadly. A tear raced down his cheek. He sighed happily.

"I had no idea either," Rigel said gently, "what kind of lives you lived under Prime. We don't get to link with clones. They avoid us. They shoot or recoil from Battani who get too close."

"I heard words. Not Galactic Common." the young man asked.

"Our native tongue. We keep the Battani language alive, in secret. *Ju vali va oharada o ji horda tam, ji horda farak hord laniakea.*" ("You have much familial loyalty to your brother here, your brother from the Galactic Brethren.")

Some of the sounds Rigel uttered were high-pitched, while others rumbled out of his throat at a low pitch. The Battani words seemed achingly familiar to Hordak, and a memory stirred.

During his first nights on Etheria, Hordak had wept himself to sleep on board his crashed ship. In the hazy space between wakefulness and slumber, strange words flashed across his mind, and he instinctively knew their meaning. *Horda* (brother). *Ṛdak* (worthy). *Worthy brother.* He vowed that he would prove himself a worthy brother to Horde Prime and return to his side, someday, against all odds. When the Etherians insisted on calling him by a name, he formed a portmanteau out of the two words: Hordak.

“Long ago, I remembered some of these words,” Hordak admitted. “But I am unsure how. No one had ever spoken Battani in my presence before.”

“A …a brother did as well.” the young clone added. “He had been decanted and given the Sacrament of Clarity on the same day as I had. He uttered words like this in the presence of Horde Prime. Prime was enraged and ordered him to be purified in the baptismal pool. It was … Battani. I know that now.”

"So the clones have ancestral memories, like we do," Rigel realized. "Prime couldn't take that away, could he? The jeweled-mind-link connects the living to each other, and sometimes, it connects the living to the ancestors. Sometimes, in dreams, or emotional moments, we remember fragments of our ancestors’ memories. Words, sensations. Or an image."

Hordak remembered a dream that had shaken him years before. In a laboratory, white and purple light spilled out of a hyperspace portal as it tore a hole in the fabric of reality. He glanced down at a data pad in his hand, and in his reflection on the screen, a face like Horde Prime’s gazed back at him. However, this Horde Prime had two red eyes instead of four green eyes, and long white hair instead of cables. Upon waking, Hordak assumed the dream was about Horde Prime opening a portal to Despondos to retrieve him. Now, he wondered if the dream was a vision of Annilis, his true ancestor.

“Hordak,” Rigel said softly. “Do you want to link as well?”

Hordak hesitated. Did he want his thoughts laid bare? Did he trust this man with his memories? Would he miss something fascinating if he declined?

“Very well,” Hordak finally answered.

Rigel sat in front of him and slowly placed his right hand on the side of Hordak’s head. Hordak extended his right hand and did likewise. A presence, radiant like glowing embers, glided over his

mind. Images, sounds, and sensations poured into the space between them. The smell of the Kopar Ocean. A grandmother teaching him old Battani songs in secret as a child. An elderly Eternian man at the destitution refuge with sunken cheeks and tired eyes. A morela seedling peeking out of soil in an earthenware pot. Running down an alley as a young man with four other resistance cell friends, clones shouting far behind them in the night, fear, exhilaration, camaraderie. A secret feast at a cousin's home, the air thick with aromas of black market fruits.

It was so unlike Horde Prime's mind probes, which wrenched out memories like a harsh hand yanking roots out of the earth. Instead of blinding light, a fiery glow. Instead of violation, communion.

Hordak's mind breathed out its memories as well. Imp flying through the rafters of the sanctum, repeating gossip. Fear one night at the Kopar-nik base when he first noticed white blotches on his blue arms. Entrapta, smiling, bright-eyed, lit from behind by sparks. The halls of the Velvet Glove, cold and white and sterile. Pain in his forearms, and sunken flesh between his radius and ulna bones. Horde Prime lifting him by his throat, roaring that he was a "cloning failure" and "worthless". Tears, emptiness, aching. Imp's wicked smile. Entrapta's silken hair touching his shoulder.

Other memories flooded the space between them. Adrenaline coursing through him as his laser bore holes into the Sea Gate. The odor of smoke as he watched Salineas burn. Soldiers kneeling before a green-lit throne. A feline force captain in restraints, scowling, refusing to meet his gaze.

Short waves of emotion rippled through the link. Alarm. Disgust. Pity? Rigel removed his hand from Hordak's face, and Hordak found himself alone in his head again. When he opened his eyes, Rigel was frowning, and his red eyes were narrowed.

"Well. It seems I welcomed a warlord into my home," the doctor rasped. "You failed to tell me this."

Hordak bore Rigel’s gaze. “I feared that you would not have taken us in if you knew.” The words came out quieter than he had intended.

Rigel stared at Hordak for a long time, studying Hordak’s face, frowning. The young clone glanced back and forth between them, unsure of how to react.

"What you did was monstrous," Rigel finally said, "That's not up for dispute. But I think I understand why you did it.”

Rigel sat back down on his cushion and mat. "“Maybe if I were a slave of Horde Prime, I would have ended up a warlord too.”

The doctor sighed. “When I looked into your minds, I saw the loneliness. The dependency. Prime made you both believe that you were nothing without him. You would have done anything to win back his love.”

Hordak nodded. “I would have. I thought that conquest would prove my worth to him.”

"But you’re not going back to that life, are you? You know the futility of it now, don't you?" Rigel continued.

“Yes,” Hordak replied.

“No more people will be sacrificed on that sad altar,” Rigel declared, with finality. In the silence that followed, Hordak was reminded again of the wasted years, the pointless warring. Over the years, princesses and rebels had hurled words of condemnation at him, but he was unmoved. Why did Rigel’s ire sting?

A door opened. Glimmer emerged from the bedroom, yawning.

“Oh good! You’re awake,” Rigel said, trying his best to sound cheerful. “Help yourself to the morelas on the island.”

Glimmer plucked two fruits from the platter and sat down on the remaining cushion on the floor. “These remind me of apricots. They smell different, though.” She bit into one of the fruits.

Rigel breathed deeply and turned to the young clone. “You know, I can’t keep calling you young man. You need a name.”

“You do,” Glimmer agreed, talking with a mouthful of fruit. “You should pick out a name. Prime doesn’t control you now.”

The young clone thought for a moment. “I want to be called … Kadroh. Planet Kadroh is where I learned the truth!”

Outside, a heel slammed against the door of the apartment. The door flew open, its lock dangling uselessly off the door frame. Three clone soldiers now stood at the threshold, pointing their arm canons inside.

# Imperfection

Chapter Summary

> Hordak and Kadroh fight with the clones seeking to capture Glimmer. Rigel calls upon allies. Hordak, Glimmer, and Kadroh make unexpected discoveries upon returning to Etheria.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning: mild violence. Kadroh just learned that Battani can psychically link with a head-to-head touch, not just a hand-to-head touch.

The three clone soldiers stormed into the apartment, arm canons pointed out. Hordak and Kadroh sprang from their cushions and hurled themself at two of the clones. The third clone barked ordered at Glimmer and Rigel, shouting at them to rise to their feet.

Kadroh swung outward, knocking his opponents arm to the side. The clone's arm canon accidentally fired into the floor, leaving a blackened, smoking dent in the white marble. The two grappled until Kadroh eventually restrained the clone with a bear hug.

"We do not wish to fight you, brothers!" Kadroh insisted. "You've all been deceived!"

Hordak swung at the second clone's arm canon, pointed at his torso. The punch cracked the arm canon, and the green glow inside its barrel faded. Just as the punch landed, Hordak threw an elbow at the clone's chin. The clone teetered backwards for a moment, then bared his teeth and swung the cracked arm canon at Hordak's head. Hordak blocked the blow with his forearm and delivered a jab to the clone's ribs.

As he fought with the clone, Hordak strove to reign in the power behind his blows. The cybernetic exoskeleton enhanced his

strength enough to damage his opponent's arm canon, but too much force behind his punches could kill the clone.

The clone let the cracked arm canon fall from his arm onto the floor. With both arms free, he wrestled with Hordak, growling, snarling.

As they struggled, Hordak had a terrifying realization. The three clones would soon communicate Glimmer's whereabouts to Horde Prime. If Prime's attention were to be diverted from Etheria to Planet Kadroh, they could even do it through the hive mind. *They could not be allowed to alert Horde Prime.*

Entangled with the snarling clone, Hordak understood what he had to do. He yanked his right hand free and pressed it to his opponent's head. A fiery consciousness poured into his mind, and a green gossamer thread dangled between them. Images flickered before him: the insectoid man with four legs he'd seen on the street, describing Glimmer. A clone handing the man a pouch of avidecos. *Horde Prime will praise us for returning her.* The clinking sound of the coins. *She turned our brothers against Horde Prime? How?*

The clone grunted. Emotions vibrated within their mental link. Confusion. Fear. *He sees my thoughts like Prime?* In the psychic space between them, Hordak called out to the other clone. *Horde Prime lied to us,* he told the clone.

Hordak focused on the pulsing gossamer thread, calling forth all his pain, his grief, his longing to see his loved ones again. Shaking, he roared at the thread.

It tore. The gossamer thread's broken strands floated limply in their minds, then faded to nothingness.

Hordak removed his hand from the head of the now frozen clone. He disentangled himself from the clone's arms and stepped back. The clone stood in place, blank-faced, arms hanging limply at his sides.

“Horde Prime is gone,” the clone mumbled. “I cannot sense him. He is gone.”

Hordak turned his head and saw Kadroh holding the second clone in a bear hug. Kadroh was leaning his head forward and pressing his forehead to the clone’s head. Both clones were baring their teeth and squeezing their eyes shut. Suddenly, both gasped. Kadroh released the clone from his bear hug, and the clone stumbled forward, passive, wide-eyed. Hordak ran over and pulled the arm cannon off the clone’s arm.

“I did it. I can sever the threads too,” Kadroh gasped. He reached out to the second clone. “Brother, your soul is tormented, but you are now free—"

The clone’s ear-splitting scream interrupted him. The second clone threw his head back, and loud, heaving sobs escaped his throat. The first clone was still standing in place, silent, staring at nothing.

Meanwhile, the third clone had ordered Glimmer and Rigel into the kitchen. Glimmer stood between Rigel and the clone, arms extended to her sides.

“You, stay back! Stay where you are. Queen Glimmer, step away from him,” shouted the clone. His arm cannon was pointed to the floor between them. Glimmer refused to budge.

“*I* should be protecting *you*,” Rigel rasped to Glimmer.

“You won’t fire that canon if I’m in the way!” Glimmer argued. “You wouldn’t risk shooting me. Horde Prime would be *furious*.”

A hint of fear broke through the clone’s hard expression. Then, the second clone’s scream rang through the air, and the third clone glanced behind him, startled. It was the distraction Glimmer and Rigel needed. The third clone yelped as Glimmer threw herself around his arm canon and Rigel seized his free arm with both hands. Suddenly, Hordak seized the third clone from behind,

wrapping his right arm around the clone's neck and grasping his head with his left hand.

Their blazing minds poured into each other. Thoughts flickered rapidly, furiously: *that unclean one hid Queen Glimmer – pathogens – Horde Prime must know of my devotion – recalcitrant woman – who is in my head!?* Jagged anger was replaced by alarm. Again, Hordak called out to his clone brother in the space between them: *Horde Prime lied to us.*

Then, a third presence shone into their psychic space. Rigel's consciousness was now watching them both, watching the green gossamer thread, watching Horde Prime's hazy green cloud in the far distance. Awe. Fear. Curiosity.

Hordak drew in breath and focused on the thread. With a shout, he snapped the green thread and watched it fade away. When he and Rigel removed their hand from the third clone's head, Glimmer had already pulled the canon off of the man's arm and placed it on the island. Rigel was still grasping the man's other arm with his right hand.

Hordak stepped back. "Rigel, release him. Brother, I couldn't let you reveal our whereabouts to Horde Prime. Prime can no longer __"

*"Can no longer see me!"* the third clone bellowed, spinning around to face Hordak. *"What have you done to me!? You tore me from him!"*

The third clone's cheeks turned red as he clenched his fists. His green eyes slowly turned crimson. "What kind of devil are you? I am alone! How did you do this to me?" he screamed at Hordak.

The first clone blankly stared at Glimmer, who was now standing in front of him, speaking softly. His eyes, now crimson, seemed to look through her. The second clone was sobbing convulsively as Kadroh rested a hand on his shoulder, saying nothing. On the floor

were scattered cushions and mats, a cracked arm cannon, a cannon without an owner, and a blackened laser smudge.

"You defiled them as well!" the third clone shouted. "You tore them from Horde Prime's light!"

"No. No. No. He would not forsake us," the first clone mumbled, shaking his head. "He will know that we were wrenched from his sight. He will make us whole again."

Glimmer leaned closer to the dazed clone. "Does Prime know we're here, in this apartment?"

"No."

"Then how did you find us?"

"A man told us."

"But Prime knows we're on this planet. How?"

The dazed clone stared at her.

"We all saw the broadcast about Queen Glimmer and her friends," Rigel said. "He had to know she came here, or else why alert the whole planet? She's asking how Prime knew."

"He broadcast that alert on every planet in the empire! Simpletons!" the angry clone hissed.

Hordak and Glimmer glanced at each other. "He doesn't know where we went," Glimmer realized. "He's still in the dark."

The second clone spoke through tears. "He—he—has to know. That you. Tore us from him." Kadroh gazed at him softly.

"He will know that you wrenched his servants from his sight!" the angry clone warned. "Horde Prime knows all! Horde Prime sees all!"

Rigel snort-laughed bitterly. “Are you listening to yourself? He doesn’t know everything. He doesn’t even know where Queen Glimmer is.”

“No! He is all-knowing,” wept the second clone, who was rubbing his wet, reddened face with his hands. “He is perfect in his wisdom. He will find us. Make us whole.”

“He isn’t all-knowing!” Glimmer complained. “He put out an alert through the empire because he didn’t know where I was. He needs me because he doesn’t know how to use a superweapon without my help.”

The dazed clone was still staring at Glimmer, but now with a wrinkled brow. The angry clone could only sputter, “Horde Prime knows all! Horde Prime sees all!”

“Horde Prime deceived you,” Kadroh said gently. “He is a false god.”

Hordak stepped into the middle of the sitting room, exhaling loudly. He felt underneath a groove on the left shoulder of his exoskeleton, where his fingertips found a small button. He pressed the button, and the components of the armor on his left arm spread apart, connected by fine metal filaments. He lifted up his bared arm, showing everyone the narrow gap between the ulna and radius bones, the atrophied muscles, the jagged white and blue patterns on his skin. The dazed clone and weeping clone stared at him. The angry clone's eyes were now wide.

“Brother,” Kadroh whispered. “Your arm …”

“There was a genetic error in my cloning,” Hordak explained, “but Horde Prime did not know it until long after I was decanted. He created an imperfect clone without meaning to. I am living proof of his fallibility. My flesh reminded him that he was imperfect, and so he cast me out. He is not all-knowing.”

Hordak pressed the button on his left shoulder again. The armor components came back together and sealed over his arm.

“Horde Prime sent me to die on the battlefield,” Hordak continued, “but my ship fell through a spacetime anomaly into a pocket dimension, where I crashed on Etheria. For many years, I lived without his presence. I gave myself a name. I made a life of my own. I made … a friend. You will make lives for yourselves too.”

“I *do not want* a new life!” raged the third clone. “I want to bask in his holy light again! He will not forsake his servants!”

Hordak glared at the angry clone. “I served him faithfully, and I was still cast out. I conquered in his name, and he still forsook me. We are nothing to him. He neither knows nor cares about your anguish.”

“He made you slaves,” Glimmer added, “and then used you to enslave other people. Don’t you want to be something more?”

As Hordak, Kadroh, and Glimmer pleaded with the three clones, Rigel was tapping a console on his kitchen counter. A holographic projection of a Battani woman's face appeared, hovering over the counter.

"Is everything all right?" the woman asked. "You look stressed."

"I need you and the others to come over now," Rigel replied. "Uninvited guests just came over."

"Are they--"

"No. They're not attacking. I'm not hurt. It's a long story. I need help with this."

"I hear crying. Is somebody crying?”

Hordak would remember the next few days as a whirlwind. Four of Rigel's friends from the Kopar-nik resistance cell came over later that morning. The assembled Battani somehow talked the clones down from their panic. After repeatedly reassuring them

that they did not carry diseases, the Battani resisters persuaded the clones to follow them to safe houses. Arrangements were made for Rigel, Hordak, Kadroh, and Glimmer to stay at another safe house. Rigel would soon go underground, before resurfacing in another city under a new name, with the help of resistance friends. As Rigel hurriedly packed his bags, he made a point of bringing along a small envelope of morela seeds.

That night, multiple members of the resistance cell gathered at one of the safehouses, chatting excitedly with the offworlders. Glimmer told them about Etheria, the Heart of Etheria superweapon, and Horde Prime's determination to harness it. Hordak and Kadroh explained how they severed the gossamer threads binding the clones to Horde Prime. Rigel chimed in, describing what he saw when he linked with Hordak and the third clone.

Hordak and Glimmer realized that they had already attracted too much attention on Planet Kadroh, and that the danger of capture would only grow the longer they stayed. Glimmer worried that her presence at the safe houses would endanger her hosts, if she were discovered by clones.

"I'm tired of hiding. Horde Prime has invaded my home. I have to get back there," she told Hordak one night as they ate gray ration bars.

She then looked at Kadroh, who was finishing the last bite of his bar. "Kadroh, do you want to come back to Etheria with us? Or do you want to stay here with the other Battani?"

Kadroh paused. "No one ever asked me what I wanted before."

"It is your choice," Hordak said. "You have that freedom now."

Kadroh was silent for a long time, his gaze focused downward. Finally, he lifted his head. "I will return to Etheria with you. You both liberated me. I wish to follow you there."

"It's dangerous there," Glimmer reminded him.

"Correct, but it is dangerous here. I wish to show loyalty to you and Brother Hordak. *Oharada*."

Hordak was surprised, but soon found a strange comfort in the idea. "*Oharada*," he repeated.

When the three of them were ready to depart, their hosts packed them each a small satchel with ration bars, water, and a few avidecos. All three wore headscarves this time, now that Glimmer's face was familiar to the entire planet. When Rigel learned that they were ready to depart, he insisted on meeting with them one last time before going underground. At night, behind a warehouse, the four of them said their goodbyes.

"You're shouldering more burdens that any young person should have to," Rigel told Glimmer, "but I believe in you."

"Thank you. For everything," she replied, hugging the doctor.

Rigel patted Kadroh's arm. "Your journey's just starting. And you have good friends to help you. Good luck, Kadroh."

Kadroh smiled. "Thank you, Brother Rigel."

Rigel's face grew solemn when he stood before Hordak. "You're free from Prime, again. Don't squander this chance. For the sake of your friend and your little boy, don't make that mistake again."

Hordak held Rigel's gaze. "I won't."

"You need to fix what you broke, back on Etheria," Rigel continued. "I have faith that you will."

"I will," Hordak whispered.

The three set off through the city that night, walking some distance apart so as not to attract attention. City streets gave way to small homes, which gave way to black trees and grasses. Under high-mast lights, they followed the track for the quantum train,

until they returned to the grassy clearing where their stolen ship was waiting.

Earlier, they'd plotted their strategy for returning to Etheria. When Horde Prime besieged technologically advanced planets, he placed ships in orbit around the planet, but usually not around the poles. If they portal-jumped at a distance away from Etheria, they might be able to quietly approach the planet and fly down to the surface over one of the poles. The other ships and the nearby Velvet Glove might see nothing odd about a new ship flying among the fleet, especially if Prime was still summoning reinforcements. On the other hand, their ship gave off no tracking signal. If this struck the Galactic Horde as suspicious, they could be in danger. Another portal jump and more time in hiding on a faraway planet might be necessary … if they survived.

The ship soared through the sky. Planet Kadroh's surface fell farther and farther away. Soon, they were rising above the planet, where a diamond-shaped space station and multiple ships floated in the distance.

"Our sensors cannot pick up your designation signal. Identify yourself," said a clone over the audio frequency.

Hordak piloted the ship higher.

"Identify yourself," the clone repeated.

"Initiate portal jump!" Hordak commanded.

A low tone sounded through the ship. Stars blurred and twisted as space warped around them, then faded. The ship emerged in starry space, about ten million miles from Etheria.

Minutes passed. A tense silence hung over the bridge as Hordak piloted the ship closer to Etheria. The blue and green dot in the distance grew larger, until the planet was in full view, with the

Velvet Glove orbiting above. Glimmer gasped at what she saw on the giant screen. Hordak grunted, confused.

The Galactic Horde fleet had vanished.

"Prime had hundreds of ships here!" Glimmer said. "Where are they?"

"I don't know. Perhaps they landed on the surface. But Prime always keeps *some* ships deployed above planets slated for conquest," Hordak replied, eyes narrowed.

Hordak glanced at the two holographic displays floating on either side of his head. No sensor readings. No signal from the Velvet Glove. No signals from other ships on the surface. No data on Etheria. The teleporter controls identified no planet beneath them.

"Something's wrong. Sensors are offline," he growled.

The Velvet Glove made no effort to hail the ship. Cautiously, Hordak guided the ship through Etheria's upper atmosphere. As the ship descended, oceans and green land masses came into focus.

Suddenly, a pillar of iridescent light shot out from the Salindrus Ocean in the distance. The blast of light fired into the sky for several seconds before dissipating.

"That light!" Glimmer cried out. "Did you see that?"

"Yes!" Kadroh replied, staring out the panoramic windows. "It was beautiful. Does Etheria emit light displays often?"

"No! It doesn't emit--what was that?"

"Sensors did not detect it," Hordak noticed. “I don’t like any of these developments.”

With no geospatial readings, Hordak was forced to steer the ship manually over the Whispering Woods. Soon, they emerged over

the Kingdom of Bright Moon, with forests, low mountains, and a river passing underneath them. Hordak remembered the geography of the kingdom from their war, piloting the ship in the direction of Bright Moon castle. However, no castle appeared on screen. No Moonstone could be seen. Only lush forests and a small lake sat where the castle should be. Glimmer, strangely, was calm.

"There's a clearing two miles north of here. Land there. Once we come out, I'll lead the way," Glimmer instructed.

# Return

Chapter Summary

> Hordak, Glimmer, and Kadroh land on Etheria. They find Adora, Bow, and Swift Wind battling a group of Galactic Horde battle robots.
>
> Content warning: mild violence and blood.

Hordak, Kadroh, and Glimmer emerged from the ship. In Hordak's arms was a small body, wrapped in a white sheet pulled off of a cot in the ship's sleeping quarters.

Underneath their feet were wildflowers and long grasses in many shades of green, and in the distance were broad trees and man-sized mushrooms. Overhead, the day-moon glowed gold against a cloudless blue sky. Kadroh's eyes widened at the sight of so much greenery and the smell of earth and wind.

"It's just as magnificent as you described, Brother Glimmer!" he cheered.

Hordak was more astonished by Glimmer's nonchalance.

"Glimmer," Hordak began. "Where are we going?"

"Home," she replied, extending her hand with fingers spread. The battle staff of King Micah materialized in her hand, a purple rod topped with an ornate crescent moon head.

"But Bright Moon castle no longer stands."

"Do you trust me?"

Hordak grunted. He and Kadroh strode through a patch of knee-high grasses and followed Glimmer into the forests.

After a few minutes of walking, Glimmer stopped. Hordak and Kadroh came to a halt behind her. A faint smell of burning wood hung in the air. The sounds of laser fire and metallic blows burst from the willow grove up ahead. Glimmer ran toward the sounds, with Hordak and Kadroh running close behind.

In the willow grove were four battle robots, each about seven feet tall, smooth and white like the walls of the Velvet Glove. Each robot had a vaguely humanoid shape, with a single green lens sitting in the middle of its "face". The robots fired at unseen opponents with laser rifles attached to their right arms. The lasers splintered nearby trees, leaving charred and smoking wounds in their trunks. The robots advanced, slicing through shrubs with long jointed blades in place of left arms.

Leaves rustled. An arrow lodged itself in the lens of one of the robots, exploding in a flash of fire a split second later. The three remaining robots turned and fired in the direction of the rustling leaves. Suddenly, a winged white horse sprang out from a dense patch of blooming rhododendrons, scattering pink blossoms on the forest floor. The horse reared up on his hind legs and slammed his front hooves into the blinded robot, cracking its breastplate and knocking it to the ground. The horse galloped back into the underbrush, narrowly avoiding a hail of laser fire.

Glimmer swung the battle staff in an arc, hurling a burst of white light at one of the robots. The ball of light struck the head of one robot, shattering its lens. Glimmer vanished, leaving a cloud of sparkles in her wake. Spontaneously, she rematerialized a few yards to the left, hurling another burst of light at the machines.

Hordak placed Catra's body on the ground. "Kadroh, stay low. Do not make a sound," he ordered his brother before racing toward the robots.

The fallen robot had since risen to its feet, sparks leaping from the crack in its breastplate. Blindly, it swung its bladed left arm to and fro, slicing the occasional shrub. The winged horse sprang again from the vegetation and slammed his front hooves into the

robot's back. The robot's white shell cracked, and it fell face-first onto the forest floor. The horse darted back to the trees as the robot sparked, no longer moving.

Another arrow zipped through the air. It struck a robot's head with a plume of beige dust, coating the robot's lens with chalky powder. As the robot blindly swung its blade, Hordak charged at it from behind. The robot, hearing his footsteps, slowly turned, only for Hordak to slam his fist into the side of its head. The robot's head toppled off its shoulders, and its body lurched to a halt. Ahead, Hordak saw a brown-skinned man with a bow and quiver, crouching in the branches of a tree, staring back at him.

"Hordak?" Bow asked.

Several yards away, a blond young woman dropped from a nearby tree, landing beside a robot. Clad in a a red jacket and gray slacks, she wielded a steel staff with both hands. She thrust the tip of the staff into the robot's lens, shattering it. The robot fired its laser canon in the direction of her footsteps as she sprinted away in a zig-zag pattern.

Glimmer vanished and rematerialized through the canopy, flinging orbs of white light at the robot she'd blinded. Adora saw bursts of light strike the robot, denting its shell. Looking up, she saw Glimmer teleporting among the leaves.

"Glimmer!" Adora cried out, narrowly dodging a laser. "Glimmer! You're alive!"

Glimmer materialized in front of Adora, threw her arms around her, and teleported them both away. Laser fire struck the stones and tree trunks where Adora had stood a split-second before.

Hordak raced through the trees toward the remaining robots. To his right, Bow was running between the trees as well, sprinting ahead of him. Behind him, Hordak could feel the vibrations of hooves hitting the ground. Ahead of them, he could hear Adora shouting. Words about honor, words about Grayskull.

A burst of light flashed through the trees and stones. Hordak, Bow, and Swift Wind found themselves face to face with She-Ra, glowing gold, long hair rippling in the wind. In her right hand, instead of the Sword of Protection, rested a sword of light.

The light-sword arced through the air. Metal split. Sparks crackled. The remaining robots crashed to the ground in pieces. She-Ra stood among the wreckage and the smell of ozone, staring at the light-sword glowing in her hand.

"She's back. She never left me. She was always here," she said breathlessly. The light-sword faded into nothingness. She looked up at Glimmer, who was standing nearby, eyes bright. "*You're back.* You're safe."

She-Ra ran to Glimmer and threw her arms around her. Bow ran to them and threw his arms around Glimmer as well.

"I'm sorry," Glimmer whispered. "For the Heart. For the things I said. I'll fix this, somehow.

She-Ra and Bow hugged her harder.

Swift Wind, meanwhile, hovered near Hordak. He held his muzzle close to Hordak's head and snorted. "What are you doing here? With her?" the horse demanded to know. Hordak leaned away from the horse and snarled.

She-Ra raised her head. Glimmer extracted herself from She-Ra and Bow's hug and walked over to Hordak and Swift Wind. She-Ra and Bow followed.

"He's not with the Galactic Horde anymore. He helped me escape. He protected me while we were in hiding," Glimmer explained.

Swift Wind lifted his head and glared at Hordak sideways. "*Him*?"

Bow was wide-eyed, incredulous. "You trust him? He waged war on your kingdom! The last time I saw him, he was about to bludgeon you with a piece of concrete!"

“Glimmer, he’s a warlord,” She-Ra said slowly. “He’s the one who summoned Horde Prime.”

“I haven't forgotten that. I know how ridiculous it sounds. But I’m here thanks to his help,” Glimmer insisted.

Hordak stiffened. “I have no place in the Galactic Horde now. Horde Prime despises me. I no longer fight for him.” She-Ra, Bow, and Swift Wind were still frowning.

Hordak turned to She-Ra and drew in a sharp breath. “Is Entrapta … alive? Did you find her on Beast Island?”

“We did. She’s safe,” She-Ra replied flatly.

“So is Imp. We found him in the Fright Zone,” Bow added, still frowning.

Hordak closed his eyes and exhaled. She was alive. They were both safe. Warmth filled his limbs, and his heart beat faster.

“Hordak and I made a deal,” Glimmer explained. “He would help me escape from Horde Prime, and I would take him to Entrapta. He kept his word, and I’m going to keep mine. He’s coming back to Bright Moon with us.”

She-Ra and Bow shared a tense glance. Bow sucked in air between his teeth. “You-know-who isn’t going to like this,” She-Ra muttered.

Bow turned back to Glimmer. “There’s someone at Bright Moon who wants to meet you.”

“Who?”

“It’s better if you meet him face to face,” Bow maintained.

“Don’t you think this is a trick?” Swift Wind interjected. “Couldn’t Hordak be a spy for Horde Prime?”

Hordak folded his arms and grunted. “I assure you, I am no spy.”

“He’s not here to spy,” Glimmer replied. “He really is on the outs with Prime. And he can free clones from the hive mind. I’ve seen him do it.”

She-Ra cocked her head. “What’s a hive mind?”

“Clones? You mean the soldiers?” Bow asked..

“I’ll explain everything back at Bright Moon. But before we go, there’s more,” Glimmer added. “We made an ally. He protected me too. He’s back in the woods. And …” Glimmer hesitated, staring at She-Ra. “We weren’t the only ones Horde Prime beamed onto his ship. Catra was with us too. She … she didn’t make it.”

She-Ra’s expression went blank. “Where is she?”

“Come this way,” Hordak instructed, walking back into the forest. The others followed. Swift Wind trailed him closely.

“Kadroh!” Hordak called out. “The skirmish is over. Show yourself.”

Kadroh stood up, a splash of white and gray amidst the forest greenery. “Brothers! Did you sustain injuries?”

“No. Come meet the others.”

As Kadroh emerged from the vegetation, the others gasped.

“He’s one of them!” Bow realized. “One of the soldiers.”

“No. Not anymore. Kadroh is a friend. He doesn’t serve Horde Prime,” Glimmer said, walking to Kadroh’s side.

“Horde Prime is a deceiver and a tyrant!” Kadroh announced. “He holds me in bondage no longer.”

“We’re all about dethroning tyrants here,” Swift Wind called out, shooting Hordak a dirty look. “Are you really on board with that?”

Kadroh's eye's lit up, and his mouth hung open as he beheld Swift Wind. "An ungulate who speaks! You're sapient!"

"Um, yes. I get that a lot. I'm Swift Wind."

"Hello, Brother Swift Wind!"

"These are my other friends. This is Bow. This is She-Ra. She's Adora when she's not in this form. It's complicated," Glimmer said, gesturing to the others.

"Glimmer, where is she?" She-Ra reminded her.

"Over here," answered Hordak, pointing behind a mountain laurel. He crouched down next to the body, gently parting the sheet to expose Catra's head.

"She got between me and one of the clones," Glimmer told She-Ra. "She died protecting me."

Hordak took several steps back as She-Ra gazed at Catra's remains, eyes soft, saying nothing. After several moments, She-Ra knelt down next to the body.

"I healed Shadow Weaver once. Bow too. But I've never healed the dead. I don't know if I can," She-Ra said quietly. She placed her hands on either side of Catra's face, closed her eyes, and breathed deeply. Iridescent light began to glow faintly under her palms.

"Brother Glimmer," Kadroh .

"Shhhh," Glimmer replied.

The glow brew brighter, until both She-Ra and Catra were engulfed in shimmering light of many colors. With a blinding flash, the light dissipated. She-Ra removed her hands from Catra's head and waited. The others looked on in silence. The forest itself seemed to watching and waiting.

A hand twitched underneath the sheet. An ear flicked slightly. The sheet rose as the body underneath drew in a long, deep breath. Catra's eyes flew open.

"She did it," Glimmer murmured.

Catra's eyes were now wide and locked on She-Ra. The cat-woman sat up, freeing her arms from the sheet, mouth slightly open. She-Ra stood up and took a step back, holding Catra's gaze.

Throwing off the sheet, Catra unsteadily rose to her feet. She quickly turned her head to and fro, taking in the Etherian forest, her clothes now stained and stiff with blood, Hordak, Glimmer, the other Rebellion warriors, and a wild-eyed clone who was holding his hands over his mouth. She ran her hand over her throat, feeling the intact skin under the bloodied fur.

"I'm … home?"

Glimmer nodded. "You're back on Etheria."

Hordak watched the scene unfold, awed. The She-Ra was a formidable warrior, yes, but she could also raise the dead? How? He glanced at the others, who were also dumbstruck.

Catra smiled weakly. "Hey Adora," she said softly.

She-Ra studied Catra, then turned her gaze downward. Her eyes remained soft, while her face took on a hard and grim air.

"We're going back to Bright Moon. Let's go," she said, turning her back to Catra and walking off.

Catra's smile vanished, and her ears flattened.

The group made its way through trees and shrubs, laurels and rhododendrons, large stones and oversized fungi. At the front of the group, She-Ra, Glimmer, and Bow talked solemnly. She-Ra

revealed how she thought She-Ra was gone forever after the Sword of Protection had been shattered, until the joy of Glimmer's return awakened her powers. Every few moments, She-Ra or Bow would nervously glance to the side, scanning the area for Galactic Horde robots. Bringing up the rear were Swift Wind and Kadroh, chatting enthusiastically about "toppling unjust hierarchies" and "tearing down tyrannical lies." In the middle of the group, Catra and Hordak walked silently, several feet apart.

"It's … it's good to be back here. To see familiar faces again," Catra remarked, looking over at Hordak.

Hordak was absorbed in his own thoughts. Imp was accounted for, not lost and alone in the Fright Zone. Entrapta was alive. Soon, he would see them both. Would Imp be angry over being abandoned? Would Imp greet him with happy chirps, or hisses? He would reveal the truth to Entrapta, and offer her contrition for believing Catra's lies. Would Entrapta hate him? Flee from him? Would she weep, thinking he had forsaken her all those months? No. He could not bear the thought of her tears. Hordak mulled these possibilities, saying nothing.

Catra's ears flattened again, and she turned away from Hordak, gazing forward at She-Ra.

Suddenly, the ground shook. Leaves rustled and fell as the forest floor quaked. Swift Wind bent his legs, lowering his center of gravity to stay upright. Bow pressed against a nearby tree. Hordak pressed against a desk-sized stone, almost losing his footing. A flash of iridescent light beamed in the sky, far to the west. The beaming light faded, and the quaking stopped.

"Second time today!" Swift Wind shouted.

"We've never had more than one in a day," a tense Bow noted. "That's not good."

"What just happened?" Hordak growled.

“A magical energy jet,” She-Ra replied. “Magic has been shooting out of the planet for days. It started right after Horde Prime arrived.”

Glimmer swallowed hard. “It’s the Heart of Etheria, isn’t it? Something went wrong with the Heart.”

She-Ra and Glimmer shared a wordless glance.

The shaken group hiked on in silence. Soon, they came upon a sapphire blue lake, its shores curling around low-lying forests. Hordak knew this location from his battle maps. Bright Moon Castle and the Moonstone pillar *should* have stood in the distance, shadowed by steep cliffs and waterfalls.

“Glimmer …” he began.

“Do you trust me?” she repeated.

She-Ra, Glimmer, and Bow approached a cluster of oak trees, then vanished into thin air. Hordak, Kadroh, and Catra came to a halt.

“Go ahead,” Swift Wind instructed. “Just walk forward. Toward those trees.”

Hesitantly, the three complied. As Hordak stepped toward the oaks, his field of vision undulated. Suddenly, towering over him was Bright Moon Castle, golden, proud, soaring beside lavender cliffs. In front of the castle, a slender pillar held the Moonstone, a colossal opal that gave off a soft silver light. Standing on top of rock formations and towers were more than twenty people, barely visible from a distance. In the sky above them, magical energy lines formed intricate geometric patterns.

“Mystacore is Bright Moon’s closest ally,” Glimmer called out to them. “The castle is under a magical veil. See why I said to trust me?”

Several yards ahead, four Bright Moon soldiers were standing guard on the stone path leading to the castle. At the sight of

Glimmer, they gasped and stood at attention. Glimmer spoke with them for several minutes, gesturing to Hordak, Kadroh, and Catra.

Hordak did not know what fate awaited him in that castle, but he trusted Glimmer. He trusted her to treat Kadroh well. He trusted her to keep her word about Entrapta.

Somewhere in those towering pillars were Entrapta and Imp. Soon, he would see them again. But would they want to see him?

# Face to Face

Chapter Summary

> Glimmer and Micah reunite. Micah angrily confronts Hordak about his exile. Rebellion members tell Glimmer, Hordak, and Kadroh about events that have transpired on Etheria since the arrival of the Galactic Horde. Hordak comes to a startling realization.

"You're alive! You're safe!" Castaspella cooed, throwing her arms around Glimmer. "We were terrified. Days went by. We had no idea what Horde Prime had done to you."

Glimmer hugged her back. "It's good to be home."

Castaspella and Glimmer hugged for several moments outside the doors of the throne room, where the throne of Bright Moon sat. Behind them, Bow and Swift Wind looked on, relieved. She-Ra glowed faintly before reverting back to Adora. Kadroh was taking in the pastel-colored murals lining the hallway. Hordak rigidly faced forward, refusing to look at the scowling faces of the guards stationed through the hallway.

Castaspella placed her hands on Glimmer's shoulders and scrutinized her face. "You look so pale. Did you get enough food and sleep? Oh, what if you're anemic? I'll bet your iron is low. I'll tell the kitchen staff to include some leafy greens in your dinner."

"It's okay! I'm fine. Really."

Castaspella's gaze wandered over Glimmer's shoulder, landing on Hordak and Kadroh. She winced. "What are they doing here?"

"Hordak helped me escape. He and Kadroh left the Galactic Horde."

The mage stared at the two men, speechless, before glancing at Adora. "Does he know they're here?" She-Ra and Bow shook their

heads.

“Who’s he? Will someone tell me what’s going on?” Glimmer complained.

Castaspella removed her hands from Glimmer’s shoulders, stepped back, and opened the door to the throne room. Glimmer walked through the doors. Adora, Bow, and Swift Wind waited at the threshold, with Hordak and Kadroh standing behind them. Hordak’s height allowed him to see over Adora’s head, as a breathless scene unfolded in the throne room.

Inside the circular throne room, guards stood at attention against the rose-colored walls and gold arches. At the far end of the room, an arched opening led to a golden throne, hovering in the air hundreds of feet above the ground. On the opposite side of the room sat a gleaming gold panel covered in keyboards and screens, manned by more guards. Each screen showed a bird's eye view of some Etherian location: robots marching through the Whispering Woods, clones standing guard near the shores of Salineas, a Galactic Horde starship sitting on frozen earth in the Kingdom of Snows.

Studying one of the screens was an athletic man with long black hair, clad in a purple tunic and deep purple slacks. In his right hand, he held a wooden staff with an assymetrical head, covered in mauve blisters. Next to him was a general wearing a long rose cloak and the elaborate helmet of a Bright Moon soldier. The man and the general were discussing an overhead image of the Heart-Blossom, when the general turned her head. Noticing Glimmer, she grew quiet. A moment later, the man turned as well. Dark-eyed and bearded, the man laid eyes on Glimmer.

He froze. Glimmer froze.

“It’s you,” he whispered.

Stillness. Silence. Glimmer walked forward.

“Is this real? Are you real?” she asked softly.

Now they stood inches apart, staring into each other's faces. With a sigh, the two collapsed into an embrace. Glimmer clung to Micah like a shipwrecked woman clinging to flotsam, holding back tears. Micah held Glimmer close, eyes shut, an exhausted smile on his face.

"You're here," he said faintly, his voice cracking.

Father and daughter held each other for a long time. Adora, Bow, and Swift Wind quietly entered the throne room, followed by Hordak and Kadroh.

At last, Micah opened his eyes. Across the room, standing near his Rebellion allies, was Hordak. Founder of the Etherian Horde. Leader of armies. Destroyer of villages.

"You," Micah said.

Micah's smile faded. The light in his eyes dimmed. He slowly untangled himself from Glimmer's hug and strode toward Hordak.

*"You."*

A growl rose in Micah's throat. Micah swung his staff, flinging a purple arc of light at Hordak. Before Hordak could dodge, the purple arc struck him in the chest. Hordak was suddenly encased in harsh red light, unable to move his limbs.

*"You!"*

Micah was inches from Hordak now, clenching his teeth. Through the red glow of the spell, Hordak could see the dark circles under Micah's eyes, the lines on his face.

"Don't," Adora called out. "Glimmer said he—"

"You're the reason Horde Prime is here!" Micah roared. "You're the reason for the war! You're the reason I rotted on that island for years! You're the reason I couldn't watch my daughter grow up! YOU!"

Micah clenched his blisterwood staff. The purple glow of the staff head grew brighter as he raised it above Hordak's head.

*"We had a deal, Glimmer!"* Hordak shouted.

"Stop!" Glimmer demanded.

Kadroh tackled Micah, sending him tumbling backwards. The clone clasped the king-father in a bear hug as the glow from the blisterwood staff faded. Guards charged toward them.

"I will not let you harm Brother Hordak," Kadroh said, gently but firmly.

"EVERYONE STOP!" Glimmer bellowed.

The guards halted. Kadroh and Micah stopped struggling and stared at her, bewildered. Hordak, still encased in glowing red magical energy, was wide-eyed.

"I am still sovereign. *I* will decide what we do with Hordak. Kadroh, let him go." she commanded.

Kadroh released Micah, who glared at him.

Adora, Bow, and Swift Wind looked on in alarm. Glimmer stood before Hordak, tracing geometric patterns of light in the air with her right index finger. She pressed her palm to the light construct, and it vanished in a burst of silver light, along with the red glow encasing Hordak. Now free to move, Hordak clenched his fists and growled.

"I have no idea what you're talking about! I was told you perished in battle!" Hordak contended.

"*You* had me captured and exiled to Beast Island!" Micah replied.

"I gave no such order!"

"Don't lie to me!"

*"I gave no such order,"* Hordak repeated, slowly and forcefully. "Exile was used to punish internal offenses. Treason. Dereliction of duty. It was never used for Rebellion prisoners of war."

Hordak huffed. "Why would I exile a bargaining chip like the King-Consort of Bright Moon? I could have demanded surrender from Queen Angella. Only a fool would exile such a valuable asset. Shadow Weaver reported that you—"

Both men's expressions went blank.

A cold realization dawned on Hordak. "She deceived me."

Something heavy and bitter came over Micah's demeanor. "She betrayed me. A second time."

Glimmer returned to Micah's side. "Where is Shadow Weaver?"

"In her room, under heavy guard," he answered. "When I arrived, she was sitting on your throne. I had her confined to quarters."

Glimmer turned to the guards. "Shadow Weaver is to remain confined to quarters until further notice. Hordak and Kadroh will be housed here at Bright Moon as well. *They will not be harmed.* Is that clear?"

The guards nodded.

"Please have the housekeeping staff bring chairs into the throne room. We all have a lot to discuss."

One of the guards left the room. Glimmer turned back to Micah. "We brought back Catra as well. She was Hordak's second-in-command after Shadow Weaver. She was the one who … activated the portal."

Micah glared at Hordak. "*Your* portal. The portal that took my wife."

Hordak stiffened. “The portal was not ready for safe activation. Catra opened the portal without my permission. The catastrophe that followed was not part of my plan.”

“But you still let her stay on as second-in-command after that. After she nearly killed us all.”

He had. As hard as he strove to find words, Hordak had no reply.

Micah looked back at Glimmer. “Adora told me about what happened with the portal when I got back. Where is she? This Catra?”

“I had guards take her to the POW camp," Glimmer answered. "She went quietly.”

Anthro housekeepers carried in seven ornately carved rosewood chairs. Two more housekeeping staffers laid down cushions and a large woven rug for Swift Wind. As the anthros took their seats, Swift Wind repositioned cushions with his mouth before settling down on the ornate lavender rug. Hordak and Kadroh shifted around on their chairs, trying to balance their seven-foot-tall bodies on chairs designed for smaller beings.

Now, seated in a circle were Micah, Castaspella, Glimmer, Adora, Bow, Swift Wind, Hordak, and Kadroh. Hordak frowned and sat stiffly. Micah was calm, but his eyes smoldered. Glimmer’s face was drawn, and her eyelids seemed heavy. Castaspella’s gaze floated back and forth from Micah to Glimmer. Kadroh rested his hands on his lap and waited. The others looked tense and tentative.

“A lot of things happened to me – to us – while we were off-world,” Glimmer began. “I learned things about Horde Prime’s army and empire that we didn’t know before. The situation is worse than we thought.”

Glimmer glanced over at Hordak. “Before I start, you need to know why they’re here. Hordak and Catra helped me escape from

the Velvet Glove. He had a falling out with Horde Prime, and he isn't part of the Galactic Horde anymore."

She gestured toward Kadroh. "This is Kadroh. He was born a clone soldier in Horde Prime's army, but he turned against Prime. He and Hordak protected me. I consider him my friend, and I want all of you to treat him as such."

"I talked with him on the way back. He sounds sincere," Swift Wind added. Kadroh smiled.

Glimmer recounted the events of the past week, with Hordak and Kadroh offering details as needed. The expressions on the Rebellion members' faces grew more and more horrified as the trio described the Galactic Horde. The vast technology. Horde Prime's otherworldly origins. His hunger for the Heart of Etheria and the princesses needed to arm it. The clone army. The hive mind that kept the clones enslaved, body and soul. Hordak's ability to sever the hive mind connection, a skill Kadroh had learned as well.

When Glimmer had finished, the others sat in stunned silence.

"We … need a new plan," Adora finally said.

Micah placed his elbows on his knees and rubbed his face. "We do. This changes things." He sat up straight again. "We need to bring together a war council. Very soon."

"A lot happened here on Etheria while you were gone, too" Bow told Glimmer. "Now it's our turn to bring you up to speed."

Adora, Bow, Swift Wind, Castaspella, and Micah took turns recounting the events of the past week. Adora explained how she narrowly stopped the Heart of Etheria from firing, destroying the Sword of Protection and Light Hope in the process. Glimmer stared at the floor, unable to hold Adora's gaze as she recounted the crisis.

Adora had been unable to transform into She-Ra since the Sword of Protection had been destroyed. When Glimmer came to her aid in battle earlier, joy freed something inside her, and She-Ra flowed through her. Upon hearing this, Glimmer looked up at Adora, who smiled.

The same night that Horde Prime abducted Glimmer, starships bearing the Horde symbol appeared in the sky. Citizens panicked over the new lights scattered across the night sky, and over the ships hovering overhead. Near Bright Moon, Rebellion forces were holding captured Etherian Horde soldiers in a prisoner-of-war camp, but none of the Horde soldiers knew where the starships had come from.

Hundreds of tall, sleek vessels landed on Etheria's surface, all gleaming titanium and green steel. The next day, they simultaneously projected a hologram of Horde Prime, colossal and god-like. Towering over the landscape, he demanded that the Etherians turn over She-Ra and the princesses, promising that their planet would become "the resplendent jewel of his empire" if they complied. Just as he was warning of dire consequences for refusal, earthquakes erupted in several locations. A stream of magic burst out of the planet's crust near the Kingdom of Snows, firing a jet of magical energy into the sky for several seconds. The holographic broadcast abruptly stopped.

Hours later, hundreds of Galactic Horde starships touched down on the surface. Identical soldiers clad in white, all of whom looked suspiciously like Hordak, poured out of the starships. As their battle robots scoured the landscape, the Galactic Horde soldiers swarmed the lands surrounding the Runestones. The soldiers were stronger, faster, and better armed than the Etherians, and the Rebellion forces soon found themselves on the run. One by one, the Fright Zone, the Kingdom of Snows, Plumeria, and the ruins of Salineas fell to the clones. Mystacore remained untouched due to its magical veil.

The overwhelmed princesses sought refuge at Bright Moon, the only Runestone-holding kingdom yet to fall to the Galactic Horde.

A contingent of mages from Mystacore erected magical veils over Bright Moon Castle, the nearby POW camp, and a refugee camp to which Etherians from the countryside were flooding. The veils created the illusion of uninhabited forests, hiding the structures from the enemy. From time to time, Adora and Swift Wind checked in on the refugee camp, which swelled with more refugees each day.

“No one *likes* staying in the camp, but it’s safe,” Swift Wind notes. “There’s nothing more heartbreaking than telling a nice old lady, ‘No, Razz, you can’t pick berries outside of the camp because it’s too dangerous.’”

"It's all hands on deck now," Bow explained. "Entrapta worked day and night to set up surveillance technology, so we weren't fighting them blind. That command center behind you was her handiwork," he said, pointing to the panels of keyboards and screens against the wall.

Entrapta had wasted no time constructing a fleet of drones, crafted to look like hawks and ravens, that could monitor Galactic Horde forces from the skies. When that task was complete, she created nerve induction devices to mildly enhance the strength and speed of the wearers. The devices resembled arm bands and garter belts, and were worn against the skin under clothing. Adora, Bow, and the other princesses wore them into battle, harnessing any edge they could get over the enemy. When the Rebellion brought back one of the clone's arm-mounted laser cannons, Entrapta set about studying the technology, in the hopes of recreating it. One night, she and Emily even crept near a spire to gather data, but Swift Wind admonished her never to do so unaccompanied again.

Pride swelled in Hordak's heart. Beast Island had not dampened her enthusiasm for her craft.

Now, the princesses and the other Rebellion insurgents swept the lands surrounding Bright Moon day and night, fighting off robots and clones to prevent them from piercing the magical veil. Tanks,

all-terrain vehicles, and skiffs plundered from captured Etherian Horde forces made the task easier for the common Etherians. Occasionally, Rebellion forces would encounter Etherian Horde deserters in the countryside, who reported that the robots and clones attacked them as well.

In those early battles, the clones demanded to know if their opponents were princesses. The princesses answered with bolts of lightning, wrathful tree roots, whirlwinds, energy-nets, crashing waves, and ice-clad punches. Clones frequently tried to kidnap princesses after seeing displays of their powers, but so far had failed.

Silently, Hordak wondered why Horde Prime simply didn't teleport the princesses off the surface, as he did with Glimmer, Catra, and himself days before.

“Oh, and don’t forget that nice man who sings shanties!” Castaspella reminded them. With major kingdoms occupied, many of Bright Moon's supply lines had been cut. A mariner named Sea Hawk was now the head of Bright Moon's blockade runners, using plundered Horde ships to bring a trickle of supplies to the Rebellion.

Between combing the lands around Bright Moon Castle for enemies, and guarding the castle, the POW camp, and the refugee camp, Rebellion forces were stretched thin. The princesses and other warriors were exhausted, and lacked the numbers to reclaim the occupied kingdoms without leaving Bright Moon vulnerable. No matter how many robots they smashed or clones they battled, more would appear.

“He’s wearing you down,” Hordak said. “Horde Prime is fighting a war of attrition, and he knows it. Your troops are finite, while he can clone new troops each day. Your supplies are dwindling, while he can draw supplies from anywhere in the galaxy. Soon, Etheria will be too depleted to fight any longer.”

A heavy silence came over the group.

“Prime has done so on planet after planet, at least the worlds he could not overwhelm with brute force,” Hordak continued.

“That’s not the worst part,” Adora confessed. “Every day, there’s an earthquake somewhere, and a magical energy jet erupts.”

“They’re flooding the atmosphere with magical power,” Castaspella said. “There’s more ambient magical energy in the air right now. Mages are having an easier time casting spells, which helps with the veiling.”

“The Runestones are more powerful too,” Micah pointed out. “All of the princesses can feel it.”

“I definitely felt in when I was fighting those robots earlier,” Glimmer admitted.

“Entrapta theorized that the Heart of Etheria malfunctioned when it was armed but not fired,” Bow added. “It’s old technology, and it hasn’t been maintained for centuries. She thinks the Heart’s containment field is failing. She’s pouring over her data, trying to figure out a solution.”

“Etheria’s in danger if we can’t find a way to repair the containment field,” Adora warned. “There might not be a planet left for Prime to conquer if the Heart fails.”

“But we have no idea how to fix a short-circuiting superweapon while fighting off the Galactic Horde,” Micah reminded them. “Which is why we need to convene a war council.”

Glimmer sighed and closed her eyes. “This is my fault. I’m so sorry. I will do everything I can to fix this.”

“*We* will fix this. All of us,” Micah said.

Hordak digested all of the new information. He narrowed his eyes.

"It's making sense now. Why the Galactic Horde armada landed. Why the Velvet Glove ignored our arrival. Why sensors

malfunctioned on our ship. Why Horde Prime won't simply teleport the princesses onto the Velvet Glove. He's been blinded," Hordak said.

The others turned to him.

"Etheria's atmosphere is saturated with large quantities of magical energy now. Galactic Horde technology was not designed to cope with magical energy," he explained. “Magic is poorly understood outside of Etheria.”

“It’s true,” Kadroh added. “It exists almost nowhere else. Even the Galactic Horde lacks working knowledge of it."

“But your Horde’s technology worked just fine, all those years you waged war on us,” Bow pointed out.

“The Etherian Horde technology *had* to be designed to compensate for the planet’s background magic," Hordak replied. “It was one of the first obstacles I had to overcome when I arrived here.”

Hordak sat up straighter. "When we approached Etheria, our ship's sensors went offline, so the sensors on the other ships probably went offline too. They couldn’t gather readings or teleport troops down to Etheria. They had to manually transport robots and clones to the surface. That's why the armada landed en masse."

He scratched his chin with a blue talon. "The Velvet Glove's sensors must be malfunctioning as well. There’s too much magical energy in the atmosphere over Etheria. That may be why the Velvet Glove didn't hail our ship when we returned."

"Wait," Glimmer said, eyes widening. "On the day we escaped, the whole place shook and lost power for a few seconds."

"A magical energy jet must have struck it!" Kadroh realized. "If Brother Hordak is correct, that would have disrupted the Velvet Glove's systems."

"It would have, at least momentarily" Hordak agreed.

"Horde Prime's broadcast ended in the middle of his message, right around the time of the first eruption," Bow said. "Maybe that was the energy jet that did it."

“Do you realize what this means?” Adora asked, standing up from her chair. “We have an edge now!”

A wave of relief washed over the group.

“But for how long?” Micah asked. “How long does the planet have?”

Glimmer rose from her chair as well. “We have a lot to think about. We’ll develop a plan soon, when we bring everyone together. Let’s take a rest for now.” She walked to her father. “You and I have some catching up to do.”

“We do,” he agreed, standing up and taking Glimmer’s hand. Micah turned to Hordak, his expression hard and cold. “You helped Glimmer escape and kept her alive. You brought her home. She trusts you, even if I don’t. Do you want a chance to prove which side you’re on?”

“I’m no longer on Horde Prime’s side. I made that clear,” Hordak replied.

“Make it clearer. Atone for what you did here. Help us,” Micah demanded.

“Hordak, I’m not going to lie. If we get out of this in one piece, you’ll be brought before a tribunal,” Glimmer explained. “Help us with Prime and the Heart, and I will plead with the tribunal to show you leniency.”

Hordak’s heart began to race. Entrapta, Imp, and now Kadroh were all in danger from Prime’s invasion and the malfunctioning Heart. A tribunal was far off, but the dangers facing his loved ones loomed right now.

“Very well. I will help you.”

“And what about you, Kadroh?” Micah asked the young clone. “Can we trust you? Will you help us?”

“We can trust him. I trust him with my life,” Glimmer asserted, smiling at Kadroh.

“I will not stand idly by while Horde Prime oppresses another planet. I will help you as well!” the young clone announced, standing tall.

“Will Kadroh be treated well here?” Hordak asked.

“Yes!” Glimmer replied.

“I would like to remind you that we made a deal. I am ready to see Entrapta and Imp.”

Glimmer turned to the guards. “Escort him to Entrapta.”

# Embrace

Chapter Summary

> Hordak reunites with Entrapta and Imp. He mulls his deal with Glimmer, remembering a deal he'd made with the Scorpioni high prince many years before.

Chapter Notes

> I want to thank kuroneko4276 for their headcanons regarding Dryl, Crypto Castle, and Entrapta's upbringing, some of which I borrowed with permission. More here.

One of the Bright Moon guards walked ahead of Hordak, leading him through the castle's pink halls and lavender stairwells. A pair of guards flanked him as he walked, saying nothing. As the group navigated the castle complex, Hordak mulled the deal he'd just made with Glimmer: assist the Rebellion in exchange for possible leniency at his war crimes tribunal. Glimmer had kept her first deal with him by bringing him to Bright Moon and permitting him to reunite with Entrapta. He trusted her to honor this deal as well.

Trustworthiness was a welcome trait in a noble. Other nobles could be deceitful. Years before, after he had crashed on Etheria, Hordak made a deal with another member of the nobility.

*He eyed them wearily. Men and women with oversized claws and scorpion tails asked him if he was injured, if he came with others of his kind. They inspected his ship, marveling at the dormant battle robots inside. The Scorpioni guards led him through the desert night to the settlement in the distance, Tip-of-the-Stinger. In his exhaustion and numbness, he did not resist.*

*The settlement was a sprawling town of adobe brick buildings, tall and white with domed ceilings. At the center of Tip-of-the-Stinger,*

*surrounded by date palms, was a white marble ziggurat, in which the high prince of the Scorpioni held court.*

*"Our visitor from the sky is here!" the high prince shouted with a broad smile. The monarch was a tall, broad-shouldered man with short white hair, a white goatee, and a jovial baritone. "We thought you were injured when you didn't emerge from your sky ship."*

*The monarch was reclining on a granite throne. The gray walls behind him were painted with stylized portraits of himself and other Scorpioni men and women, all sharp angles and saturated colors. To the right of his throne stood a raven-haired woman, proud and silent, clad in scarlet armor. To his left, seated on a cushioned divan, was a white-haired Scorpioni woman in a flowing white dress. In her arms sat a chubby Scorpioni infant, dressed in gold-trimmed silks.*

*"I am High Prince Leiurus of the Scorpioni," the monarch said. "Welcome to my home. And who are you, traveler?"*

*"I am a servant of Horde Prime, Emperor of the Known Universe."*

*Leiurus blinked. "I've heard of Queen Angella, and the princesses and high princes of the kingdoms, but I've never heard of this emperor."*

*"He rules the universe beyond your world. He sees all and knows all from his holy throne on the Velvet Glove."*

*"But there is no world beyond Etheria," Leiurus replied, amused. "There's nothing in the sky except moons. Where did you come from?"*

*"I came from the Velvet Glove. Horde Prime's ship. Quadrant 1, sector 28:48:91."*

*Leiurus chuckled, shaking his head. "You are a strange one, traveler. But you haven't told me who you are."*

*“I am a servant of Horde Prime.”*

*“I know that. What is your name?”*

*“Clones do not have names.”*

*The armor-clad woman stifled a laugh. The woman holding an infant parted her lips, clearly uncomfortable. Leiurus stared at the clone, then laughed.*

*“You don’t have a name, and you come from beyond the world. All right, traveler. Where were you going when you crashed?”*

*"I was leading a fleet of automated ships. I was to pour Prime’s wrath upon the Toevah revolt, on the front lines outside the Aristarchus system."*

*“Leading ships to battle? So you’re a general?”*

*The word was unfamiliar. “General?”*

*“Like my daughter-in-law, Chactida,” Leiurus explained, gesturing to the armored woman standing beside his throne. “She commands units. She leads troops into battle. You were leading other ships into battle?”*

*“I was.”*

*“Ah, so you are a general!” Leiurus concluded. “And you’ve been separated from your troops, from your emperor. You’re alone in a foreign land.”*

*The clone said nothing.*

*“But I’m a benevolent man,” Leiurus continued. “You won’t have to fend for yourself here. I offer you my hospitality.”*

*Leiurus rose from his throne and descended from the stone dais on which it sat. "We can help each other. I propose an arrangement between the two of us."*

*The monarch now stood in front of the clone, smiling warmly. "Your sky ship is like nothing Etheria has ever seen. The guards told me all about the marvels on board your ship. Robots, like Dryl has, but larger, sleeker. Make technology like that for my kingdom, and I'll give you anything you desire."*

*Leiurus' dark eyes sparkled. "Make me weapons, flying machines, robot soldiers. Make my kingdom the strongest on Etheria, and you can have anything you wish. Land. Gold. Slaves. Anything."*

*The clone pondered the offer. The absence of stars, the prince's ignorance of the cosmos, the sudden severing of his hive mind connection meant one thing. He had fallen into a pocket dimension. He would need to repair the ship before he could perform a portal jump back to the wider universe. With enough raw materials, he could still carry out Prime's will.*

*"I will do so for materials to repair my ship. Titanium, steel, and carrefourium. Will you give me these materials?"*

*Leiurus clasped his claws together. "Of course! We have a deal, then."*

The guards led Hordak outside. Many hours had passed since he landed on Etheria, and the day-moon was setting against a pink and orange sky. The guards led him down pristine white staircases, past domed towers and lush trees.

His breathing had quickened, and his heart beat faster. He would see them soon, Imp and Entrapta. Whether their faces wore relief, or sorrow, or anger, he needed to see them. They could berate him for abandoning them, chastise him with sharp words and shrieks. He would accept it all without complaint, just to see them both alive and safe.

*Outside the banquet hall's wide windows, the day-moon was setting against a pink and orange sky. Gold light fell a long marble table decked with flatbreads, spiced meats, all manner of soups and stews, dates, sliced melons, and pomegranates. Seated on backless chairs, two dozen Scorpioni nobility ate, drank wine, and chatted excitedly. The court mage -- a bald, middle-aged man with pointed ears and gray skin, clad in blue robes -- sat among them, feasting. A menagerie of slaves replenished food, filled wine cups, and carried away bones and fruit rinds: cat-folk, sea elves, reptilians, and the occasional anthro. All of the slaves wore gray silk tunics and went about their duties with downcast eyes. In the corner, a squid-man strummed on a lute while a bear-woman slapped the head of a goblet-shaped drum.*

*At the head of the table sat Leiurus, savoring a slice of pink meat. To his left sat the clone, numbly eyeing the table of food, his plate empty. To his right sat his daughter, Princess Zabia, who exchanged soft words and tender glances with her wife, General Chactida. On Chactida's lap sat their baby daughter, Scorpia, whom Chactida was feeding spoonfuls of pulverized vegetables and tubers. The court mage had used fertility "magic" to allow the two women to bring forth a child together, the clone would later learn.*

*Zabia's warmth vanished when a reptilian man extended an earthenware mug to her. She swatted the mug out of his hands with her claw, sending the mug crashing to the floor.*

*"This is dawnherb tea. I told you to bring me fangleaf tea," she said coldly. The reptilian man silently wiped up the spilled tea and picked up fragments of the broken mug.*

*"Some of these slaves aren't very bright, so you'll have to be patient with them," Leiurus said to the clone. "Eat something! This banquet is in your honor. You must be hungry."*

*It was true. The clone's liquid rations had run out the previous day. Before him were unclean foods, fit only for lower races. Partaking of the food would be a sin against Prime, but his empty*

*stomach begged for nourishment. If he starved himself, he realized, he would never leave Etheria, never carry out Prime's command to die on the front lines of the Toevah revolt. He was a flawed clone, an abomination; perhaps it was only right that he debase himself with lesser food.*

*The clone plucked a slice of green melon from a platter to his left. He held it with trembling hands. Finally, he sank his teeth into it. The flesh was sweet, juicy, messy, wicked.*

*"You and I are going to do amazing things together," Leiurus remarked, reaching for a platter of flatbread. "Your creations will help me put down those insurgents once and for all."*

*The melon rind, denuded of its flesh, slid out of the clone's fingers onto the plate. His cheeks were red with shame, but his stomach rejoiced.*

*"May Horde Prime forgive me," the clone whispered. With self-loathing and a watering mouth, he devoured a second melon slice.*

*Leiurus swallowed a bite of flatbread. "Those slaves refuse to accept their place. Zabia and my army have been trying to put them down for over a year. But soon, they'll kneel."*

*The high prince leaned toward the clone. "You can't let the rabble get out of control. That was Dryl's mistake, and look at them now."*

*"Dryl?" the clone asked.*

*"A kingdom to the northwest. Our closest trading partner. The Medusae nobles were all assassinated, except for the royal family. The king and queen weren't ruthless enough with all the commoner uprisings."*

*Leiurus' face grew solemn. "Do you know how bad it got? The royal castle is rigged with deadly traps. To stop rioters from reaching the interior. I visited once. It's a technological marvel.*

*The king and queen only eat tiny foods. If a commoner tries to poison them, they'll have only eaten a small amount of poison that way. They give their daughter carbonated drinks, so any poisons will float to the surface. A pair of robotic nannies care for the girl, because they don't trust any of the commoners to watch her."*

*The high prince sat up straight. "Is that any way to live? Constantly in fear of your inferiors? No. I won't let Scorpia grow up in a kingdom like that," he said firmly, gesturing to his baby granddaughter. "And that, traveler, is where your technology comes in."*

The guards led Hordak to an open air courtyard beside one of the towers. The courtyard was paved with lavender stones and flanked on either side by flowering rhododendrons. Hundreds of feet away, at the far end of the courtyard sat two tan tents. Beyond the courtyard, a diamond-shaped spacecraft rested in a grassy clearing, bluish-gray against the pink sky.

In front of one of the shrubs was a spherical green robot, its display screen glowing pink: Emily. Someone had fashioned a flower crown out of pink rhododendron flowers and placed it on top of Emily. Imp was kneeling next to Emily, digging in the dirt with a twig.

Hordak drew in breath. "Imp?"

Emily beeped and spun around. The little boy looked up from the dirt, and his eyes widened when he saw Hordak. With a shriek, Imp took to the air. A moment later, his tiny arms were wrapped around Hordak's neck in a hug. Imp chirped, pressing his face to Hordak's face.

"I missed you too, Little Spy," Hordak whispered. He supported Imp with his left forearm, petting the boy's head with his right.

“(There you are! You’re okay! I’m so glad I found you!)” the boy replayed. Hordak immediately recognized the voice as Entrapta’s.

“Horde Prime beamed me into his ship,” Hordak told the child, “but I escaped, and I’m here now.”

In spite of his disappearance, in spite of all the chaos that followed, his Little Spy still loved him. Hordak did not understand why. He could only hold the boy close for several minutes, stroking his head, feeling the warmth of the boy’s cheek on his face, saying nothing.

He would fight for this, Hordak thought to himself. He would fight Horde Prime for this feeling. For this little boy. For a planet where this boy could live.

Hordak looked up at the guards. “I … appreciate … your humane treatment … of Imp,” he said haltingly. “It was … generous of Bright Moon to take him in.”

Imp removed his arms from Hordak’s neck and fluttered back to Emily, who was beeping loudly and tapping the ground with her legs. Imp perched on top of Emily and smiled wickedly, pointing in the direction of the tents.

“(Entrapta.)” Imp replayed in Hordak’s voice. Then, in Bow’s voice, “(You need to see this.)”

Emily trotted toward the tents, carrying Imp. Hordak and the guards followed. Halfway down the courtyard, Hordak stopped, turning toward the guards.

“I wish to have privacy when I speak with Entrapta,” he stated. “I will not attempt to flee. You have my word.”

“Go,” replied one of the guards. “We’ll watch you from here.”

Imp and Emily had come to a halt about thirty feet from one of the tents. The little boy smiled at Hordak, watching and waiting.

The entrance to one of the tents had been tied open, and inside, a woman in violet overalls with large fuchsia twintails stood with her back to them. Her head was bowed, and her arms moved as she busied herself with a task.

Hordak's breathing quickened again, and he felt warm underneath his exoskeleton. A thrill ran up his spine. He swallowed, before struggling to bring her name to his lips.

"Entrapta."

The woman's arms froze. Her hair bristled. She lifted her head.

"Entrapta," he repeated, taking a step toward the tent. "I … I did not know. I didn't know you'd been banished to Beast Island."

Entrapta quickly turned around. Her mouth was open slightly. Her wide-eyed gaze met his. The sight of the red eyes, the tan skin, the curves of her face sent adrenaline coursing through his limbs.

"I would have retrieved you, had I known," he said, taking another step. The words ached as they rose from his throat. "Catra deceived me. She told me you had rejoined the Rebellion. I thought you were among the princesses. I was a fool … to believe her."

Entrapta stared at him, wide-eyed, silent.

Suddenly, she burst out of the tent, bounding toward him, using her prehensile hair to carry her forward.

Hordak closed his eyes and exhaled. Finally, he had seen her face and told her the truth. He braced himself, expecting a slap, or a barrage of furious words. But neither came.

He gasped as Entrapta collided with him. Her arms wrapped around his torso, holding him firmly. Fuchsia hair wrapped around his shoulders.

“You came back to me!” she shouted, tightly pressing her face to his chest.

Hordak looked down at Entrapta, breathless. He swallowed hard. “You … you still …”

“Scorpia told me everything!” Tears raced down her cheek. “All those months, I thought you hated me, and that I’d failed again, but after they rescued me, Scorpia told me what really happened, and then I knew … you hadn’t …”

Entrapta’s rapid-fire words gave way to sobbing. She clung to him tighter, weeping into his chest. Hordak felt his chin quivering. Tears poured out of his eyes. A loud whimper escaped him. Slowly, his arms encased her. As the day-moon set, they held each other, crying.

He would fight Horde Prime for her as well.

# Creations

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta and Hordak reconnect after their tearful reunion. Kadroh meets Imp for the first time.

Chapter Notes

> This turned out to be a breather chapter, allowing the characters to settle in before the action picks up again in chapter 11.

He told her everything.

They sat near the tents, with Hordak seated on a chair and Entrapta perched on a seat fashioned out of her hair. She studied him with red-rimmed eyes, occasionally fluttering her hands. Emily crept closer, settling down a few feet from the pair, with Imp lounging on her.

Hordak told Entrapta about Catra's lie, and Catra's decision to open the portal without his permission. He told her about the days he languished in his sanctum, mourning her "betrayal", grieving over the death of all the new possibilities she represented. He told her about Catra's ambush.

He told her about the weeks he brooded in his workshop, fine-tuning Horde robots and constructing an arm-mounted laser canon. He told her how he threw himself into conquest with new vigor, convinced that returning to Horde Prime's side was the only meaningful future open to him. He told her about how he longed to see her on the battlefield, not so he could fight her, but so he could strut like a peacock.

He told her about the shapeshifting mercenary who revealed the truth to him. He told her about his tears, his rage, his certainty that she had died on that island. He told her about his fight with Catra, and the fall of the Etherian Horde.

He told her about Horde Prime.

"The conquest, the portal, the signal to Prime, it was all a mistake," he admitted to her. "I was a fool."

As he recounted his reunion with Prime, Entrapta lowered her insect-mask and bowed her head.

"When I saw clones for the first time, I knew something was off about them," Entrapta admitted. "I knew Horde Prime had done something awful to them. And that's when I realized you were in danger."

The eyes of the mask reflected the setting sun, making them glow red. "The ship behind the tent is a First Ones spacecraft. I spent all of yesterday making sure it was space-worthy. The Rebellion was going to use it to storm the Velvet Glove and rescue Glimmer. I would have insisted on joining them … to rescue you."

Hordak drew in a long breath. "I was worth saving, in your eyes."

"Yes," she said softly.

A gentle silence came over them. Warmth spread through Hordak's body. *To her, he was worth saving.*

"Horde Prime would have erased my memories in the purification pool, after my reconditioning," Hordak explained. "He would have sent me to die fighting the Etherians, if not for Glimmer and Catra."

He described his deal with Glimmer, and their escape from the Velvet Glove. Entrapta's shoulders stiffened when he described Catra's death.

"Good," she said. The bitterness in her voice was new to Hordak.

He told her of the young clone, and planet Kadroh, and Rigel. She lifted her mask.

“I want to meet Kadroh. He sounds fascinating.”

“He’s eager to meet you and Imp,” Hordak replied. “I spoke warmly of you both.”

The sky grew dark, and stars began to sparkle. Entrapta reached into the tent with a strand of her hair and extracted an electric lantern. She placed it on the ground between them, where it emitted a soft, bright glow.

Hordak recounted everything that had happened after they returned to Etheria. When Hordak spoke of how She-Ra resurrected Catra, Entrapta frowned.

“Oh,” she muttered, pulling her mask over her face again.

When Hordak finished, Entrapta lifted her mask. Her eyes were bright now, and she smiled at him.

“You’re back now. We’re together,” she said. “And you understand now. You don’t need Horde Prime.”

“It was you who first helped me entertain that possibility,” he confessed. “For that, I will always be grateful.”

“All that time, you wanted to see me again. You hadn’t forgotten me.”

“You are impossible to forget.”

Hordak lowered his gaze, staring at the lantern. “Entrapta, if we survive this, the Rebellion is going to hold a war crimes tribunal. I agreed to help them fight Horde Prime. In return, Glimmer will encourage the tribunal to show me leniency. I suspect that leniency will mean allowing me to live.”

He lifted his head and held Entrapta’s gaze. “When this is over, we’ll be separated again. I will be exiled, or imprisoned.”

Hordak and Entrapta were silent.

“Unless…” Entrapta finally said. “Unless, you’re so useful to the Rebellion that they can’t just throw you away.”

A strand of pink hair gently caressed Hordak’s hand.

Hordak grunted. “Your optimism is naïve.”

“Is it?” she asked, winding her hair through his fingers. “The Rebellion’s pretty merciful if you’re useful. That’s why they welcomed Adora and Scorpia. Shadow Weaver too. That’s why they rescued me.”

Hordak closed his eyes. He ran his thumb over the thick strands of hair woven between his fingers. “Do not tempt me with empty hope.”

“They’ll need your knowledge after the war,” Entrapta insisted. “You know things about the galaxy that they don’t. You understand the other clones. You know Galactic Horde technology better than anyone, except for Kadroh.

“All things Kadroh can assist with,” Hordak huffed. “He isn’t despised here.”

“Hordak, if we defeat Horde Prime, the Rebellion will have a mess on their hands. Tech they don’t know how to operate. Clones everywhere. A whole galaxy that’s foreign to them. Kadroh can’t do *everything*. They’ll need your help too.”

Entrapta was standing beside him now. Her eyes reflected the lantern light. “You can’t help them from a cell. If they forget that, we’ll remind them.”

Hordak knew that a day would come when all the technology had been explained, all the clones had been housed, and all the details of the galaxy had been shared. On that day, the Etherians would clamor for punishment, and guards would haul him before that tribunal. He held his tongue, clinging to the present where Entrapta and Imp were beside him.

A huge smile spread across Entrapta's face. A strand of pink hair curled around his bicep. "Now come inside!" she shouted, lifting him out of his chair and pulling him toward the tent. "I've got so much to show you!

*Vultak, Leiurus' court mage, couldn't believe his ears. The clone had never heard of magic.*

*In the days ahead, Vultak lit a lantern with flames from his fingertips, snickering at the clone's wide-eyed expression. He drew geometric patterns of light in the air in front of a captured cat-man, then smirked at the clone when the insurgent answered his every question about Miksita's latest attack.*

*"Magic is the life force of Etheria," Vultak explained to the clone afterwards. "Mages like myself channel ambient magical energy from the environment. Princesses like Zabia draw magical powers from Runestones around the planet. You've never encountered magic, anywhere?"*

*Magic would be a thorn in the clone's side. In the weeks that followed, he constructed autonomous battle robots without difficulty, using the minerals Leiurus gave to him. Spherical robots with insect-like legs took shape out of steel. Their intricate electronics took shape out of gold, copper, and tantalum. When the robots successfully scuttled across the desert and fired lasers at stone targets, Leiurus was delighted.*

*Other technology gave the clone only grief. The data pads he constructed displayed no readings. The geospatial mapping devices showed no land. It was the background magic, he realized. The strange energies of Etheria were interfering with some of his devices.*

*He found his salvation in gifts that the Dryl monarchs had given to the Scorpioni royal family. At the wedding of Zabia and Chactida, the Medusae royals had given ear pieces to the Scorpioni royals,*

*allowing the royals to communicate over long distances. Later, Dryl sent them a robotic dove that cooed and flapped its wings as a gift for Scorpia, shortly after the baby's birth.*

*With the royals' permission, the clone gently examined the Dryl technology. All had ganeshium alloys in their circuitry. Later, when ganeshium circuitry made his data pads brim with readings, he felt grateful for those ear pieces and that mechanical bird.*

Inside the tent, lanterns hung from the ceiling. Three tables were covered with Entrapta's projects. A mechanical drone shaped like a condor was perched on one table, hooked up to a data pad. The cracked hilt of the Sword of Protection sat next to books with titles such as *First Ones Archeological Finds, Volume 1* and *The Heart Theme in First One Texts: Current Theories*. Tools, circuitry, data pads, and papers covered with notes and diagrams sat everywhere. Next to a tiny white cup of espresso was a plate of food: six tiny medallions of wild rice topped with tiny mushrooms in a brown sauce. In a corner of the tent was a giant pillow, a box of crayons, and a pad of paper on which a child had drawn cartoonish pictures of Imp, Emily, Hordak, and Entrapta,

Imp perched on Hordak's shoulder as Entrapta described the First One's spacecraft, the command center, the bird-drones, the nerve induction devices, the remains of the sword. She paused every few moments to eat bites of her dinner.

"But I always take an hour or two out of the day to study readings on the eruptions," she pointed out, chewing the last bite of rice and mushrooms. "I was doing some calculations when you arrived."

"Do you think the Heart can be stabilized?"

"The containment field has so many unknown variables! And it would have to be massive to contain large quantities of magical energy. She-Ra wouldn't be able to repair it instantly, like she did

with the Sea Gate. We might not be able to stabilize it. Instead, we might have to discharge the magical energy some other way."

"Without bringing about a catastrophe in the process."

Entrapta nodded. She lifted the hilt of the broken Sword of Protection with a strand of hair. "The gem in the sword functions as an administrative key. Even if She-Ra has been unbound from the sword, the embedded tech could still be useful. If we could find the control center for the Heart, the administrative key might unlock information on how to stabilize the Heart."

Entrapta returned the hilt to the table and picked up *The Heart Theme in First One Texts: Current Theories*. "Bow brought me this book from his dads' library. A heart is mentioned in several First Ones texts, but they're all so vague. No wonder historians didn't know what it was. The only recurring theme is a basin."

Hordak drank in the sight of Entrapta, moving among her technology. She was back in her element again, surrounded by data and equipment, enamored with new challenges.

"Your work is impressive," he observed. "The Rebellion must be overjoyed to have a mind such as yours on its side."

Entrapta came to a halt. The excitement on her face faded. She lowered her mask.

"They're grateful for the *tech*. Me, not so much."

She turned her masked face away, focusing on the tent wall.

"With Micah, it's all business. I hardly see Adora. Netossa and Spinnerella don't say much to me. Perfuma, Mermista, Frosta … they avoid me. I'm tolerated because I'm useful. So I stay useful. It's just like before."

"They're fools," Hordak growled. "They should acknowledge you."

Entrapta lifted her mask. “Some of them do. Bow has been helpful. He brought me these books. He asks questions and always looks so impressed with my work. So I don’t think he hates me.”

She smiled. “Scorpia visits me every day, even if it’s just for a few minutes,” she added. “She always has something positive to say about my work.”

She paused, as if lost in thought. “We had a long talk after I came to Bright Moon,” Entrapta said softly. “She was really apologetic about the whole … Beast Island thing. She left the Horde in order to tell the Rebellion where I was.”

“She’s loyal to you. I should thank her for that,” Hordak admitted.

Entrapta extended a strand of hair to Imp, patting his head. “And Imp loves hanging out with me.”

“Thank you for finding him. For bringing him here,” Hordak said.

Imp chirped. “(I really missed you. I thought about you a lot, all those months)” he repeated in Scorpia’s voice.

Hordak paused, digesting what Entrapta had told him. Finally, he spoke.

“If these princesses have failed to praise you, I will praise you in their stead,” Hordak said, standing taller. “What you’ve accomplished in one week is impressive. Your technological acumen is amazing.”

“Thanks,” she replied.

“And … you are … more than what you can give to the Rebellion. Just as you were more than what you gave to the Horde.”

Entrapta stood close to him. Hesitantly, she took his hand in hers. The rough fabric on his skin felt comforting. Silently, they held each other’s gaze, holding hands.

“A TINY BROTHER!” Kadroh gasped. Imp was sitting on his lap, looking up at the bright-eyed clone. “He’s so small! And his cheeks are so plump!”

“(So small! So plump!)” Imp repeated in Kadroh’s voice.

Hordak, Kadroh, and Imp had been assigned one of Bright Moon's conference rooms as living quarters. Castle staff had removed the table and chairs from the room, replacing them with two cots. A lacy lavender bassinet sat in the corner, for Imp. Sharp, angular murals of famous Bright Moon soldiers covered the walls.

Kadroh was seated on one of the cots, with Imp on his lap. Hordak sat opposite on the other cot.

"He enjoys having his chin gently scratched," Hordak remarked.

"May I scratch your chin, Brother Imp?" Kadroh asked. Imp nodded, and Kadroh gingerly scratched the underside of the boy's face. Imp closed his eyes and smiled.

“This is the first time I’ve seen a hybrid child,” Kadroh admitted.

“Imp is the second I’ve seen. Horde Prime had Governor Zed of Azophi on board the Velvet Glove once, when I was stationed there. He was one of Prime’s many children with women across the galaxy.”

“But only Prime was permitted to sire children. Fatherhood was forbidden to clones. If he had discovered Imp—”

“—he would have been enraged,” Hordak noted. “My attempts at cloning a replacement body would have enraged him. As would have trying to stabilize my experiments with bat DNA. But when one of my cloning attempts gained consciousness, I felt affection for the baby. I wanted to keep him near me. The impulse was strange, but I could not disobey it.”

Hordak's expression softened as he gazed at Imp. "I decided that when Prime reunited with me, I would pass off Imp as an orphaned Etherian child that the Horde took in. I wanted my Little Spy to have a place in the empire."

"Horde Prime would have uncovered your lie when he saw your thoughts," Kadroh reminded him as Imp snuggled against his chest. Kadroh looked down at the child, uncertain but awed.

"I know. But I deluded myself. About so many things," Hordak confessed. "I assured myself that if I conquered Etheria and proved myself worthy, Prime would forgive my transgressions."

Imp fluttered over to Hordak's cot and sat next to him. The boy pointed at Kadroh. "(Thank you for finding him. For bringing him here)", Imp repeated in Hordak's voice.

Hordak found himself smiling. "But I harbor no regrets about Imp."

The door to the room opened. An anthro woman clad in a purple uniform entered the room and erected a small folding table. Another anthro woman placed a carafe of water and three glasses on the table. An anthro man handed out three plates of sliced fruit; a large plate each for Hordak and Kadroh, and a small plate for Imp.

"Brother Glimmer's attendants asked me what foods our people consume. I told them fruit," Kadroh explained. He turned to the anthro man. "I've never been shown such opulence before! Thick blankets, and enormous pillows! Five kinds of fruit at one meal!"

The man squirmed and gave Kadroh a confused look, saying nothing. The castle staffers left, closing the door. Imp and Kadroh eagerly ate the apple slices, starfruit, grapes, melon balls, and berries on their plates. Hordak picked up a starfruit slice with his talons, studied it, and ate it.

*No regrets.*

# Prisoners of War

Chapter Summary

> The Rebellion captures two Galactic Horde clones. Micah and Glimmer approach Hordak and Kadroh with a dangerous proposal.

Chapter Notes

> The scene with Netossa and Spinnerella is a nod to the "What have the Romans ever done for us?" scene from Monty Python's *Life of Brian*.
>
> Content warning: electrocution.

The pillow was cool under his head. The stillness of the night helped his swirling thoughts settle. Hordak took deep and slow breaths as he closed his eyes.

He had held Imp and Entrapta. Glimmer had kept her promise. His thoughts wandered to the past, when another Etherian royal broke a promise.

*Carrefourium did not exist on Etheria.*

*Leiurus had arranged for the clone to have all the steel, copper, aluminum, and trace minerals he needed to create war technology. As the weeks turned into months, however, he never gave the clone carrefourium. The clone asked Vultak, guards, and nobles about the metal, only to receive the same blank stares. No one had ever heard of the mineral.*

*He stormed into the throne room and bellowed at Leiurus. He was promised carrefourium. How would he carry out Horde Prime's will without carrefourium? How would he return to the battlefield if he couldn't repair his ship's portal drive? The high prince had defied Prime's will. He raged at the high prince's lie, loudly.*

*Too loudly for Leiurus, who sneered and shouted, "Zabia! Humble him!" The princess, who had been sitting on the divan beside the throne, rose to her feet. As she extended her hand, her eyes glowed with red light.*

*A thundering boom. A flash of white light. Howling. Agony. His head colliding with the floor. His heart pounding. Gasping for breath. Writhing.*

*The new few minutes were a blur. When his head began to clear, he found himself lying on a cool stone floor. Marble walls and lead bars surrounded him.*

*"Why don't you take a few days to cool off, traveler?" he heard Leiurus say. "Once your attitude improves, we'll renegotiate our deal."*

*The clone heard the sound of footsteps, the clang of a metal door slamming shut, and then whispers. Men whispering. Women whispering.*

*Slowly, the clone sat up, groaning. His face was hot, and his body felt heavy. The fabric on his chest had been burned, and the skin there felt raw.*

*He glanced around at the prison cell holding him. A bucket was its only furnishing. A small barred window near the ceiling let in gold light. On either side of his cell, separated by bars, were more cells. All the cells were arranged in a circle around a dais, where a Scorpioni guard was leaning back in his chair, dozing.*

*Eyes peered at the clone from the other cells. To his left was a cell with two teenage girls, a stocky sea-elf with green skin and octopus tentacles, and a younger girl with pink skin, pointed ears, and long white hair tied into a ponytail. In the cell next to theirs were two young men, a hulking bear-man with a long beard, and a yellow-eyed man covered in dense blue fur. The bear man looked bitter, while the others looked anxious.*

*To his right was a cell with a lanky cat-woman, standing up, leaning against the bars.*

*"It's you," she whispered. "The man from far away."*

*She looked about thirty, with wheat colored fur, and long, wild hair. Her jade eyes looked tired. She wore a weathered leather cuirass and leather knee-breeches, but no shoes. Instead of a furry tail, a thin scorpion tail without a stinger hung from her lower back. A bumpy red carapace covered her shoulders. A raw, pink burn stood out against the red chitin on her left shoulder.*

*"Zabia packs a punch," she said coolly. "At least your bladder was empty when she hit you."*

*The clone eyed her wearily. "You've seen her use electricity?" he asked.*

*"Seen it, and been on the receiving end. That's how we all got captured this morning." Her ears twitched, but her face emoted very little.*

*The clone glanced at the other prisoners again. All wore clothes made of leather and coarse fabric. "You're members of the slave revolt."*

*The cat-woman nodded. "I'm Miksita. That's Octavia and Huntara. Behind them are Cobalt and Grizzlor."*

*Miksita crouched so that she was at eye level with the clone. "I've heard about you. You're making weapons for Leiurus. What happened? Why did he throw you in here?"*

*The clone clenched his teeth. "Leiurus promised to give me minerals with which to repair my ship. In return, I promised to create war technology for him. He deceived me, and I berated him for it. Then Zabia attacked me."*

*"What's your name?"*

*"I am a servant of Horde Prime."*

*"But what's your name?"*

*"Clones do not have names."*

*"What's a clone?"*

*"A man made in Horde Prime's image. A soldier crafted from his genetic material."*

*Miksita squinted. "Is he … a god?"*

*"He is my creator. He is eternal. He is Emperor of the Known Universe."*

*"So, your god, then."*

*The clone swallowed hard, fighting back tears. "How will I leave this planet? How will I carry out Horde Prime's will? Will I just languish here?"*

*Miksita's face showed little emotion, but her scorpion tail batted back and forth. "It sounds like your god abandoned you. Just like mine did."*

*"No. Horde Prime did not send me here. He intended for me to die in battle. I will return to the battlefield and carry out his will."*

*Miksita shook her head. "This piety? Abandon it. Why serve a god who won't help you?"*

*The cat-woman sat down on the floor of her cell. "My mother used to tell me stories about the goddess Noh-El. How she heaped blessings on cat-folk she favored. There was an ancient warrior Noh-El loved more than all others. She could claw through metal, shatter a weapon with one kick from her foot, and punch out men twice her size. Noh-El blessed another cat-girl by making everyone who saw her fall in love with her, even her enemies. But*

*no matter how much I prayed, I never earned her favor. I was still a slave."*

*Miksita's scorpion tail twitched. "I think those were just bad stories. Or maybe Noh-El isn't really the goddess of this world. I realized that I couldn't rely on some invisible god to write my story. I had to write my own story."*

*The clone trembled, too grief-stricken to react to the cat-woman's blasphemy.*

*"That story involves their freedom," she said, nodding to the other prisoners. "We're fighting to free the slaves. That includes you."*

*"I serve Prime alone! I am not one of Leiurus' slaves!"*

*"You are. Or soon will be. Leiurus will force you to make war machines for him. You'll rot in his palace for the rest of your life. Or…you could write a different story for yourself."*

*Moments passed in silence. The clone stared at the floor, trembling. Miksita studied the clone's face. Finally, she spoke again.*

*"Don't you want revenge?" she asked.*

*The clone raised his head. "What?"*

*"Leiurus lied to you, and Zabia hurt you. You thought they would help you do what Prime wanted, but they manipulated you. Don't you want revenge?"*

*The clone stared at her.*

*"We want revenge too," Miksita said matter-of-factly. "I heard that you were a general where you came from. You could help us fight."*

*The cat-woman leaned forward. "If you stay here, you'll be a slave. If you help us escape, you can join us. We'll seek revenge*

*on the Scorpioni together. Will you join us?"*

*Silence. The revolutionaries waited for the clone to answer. The grief on his face bled away. He sat up straighter. His frown deepened. A cold, hard light shone in his eyes.*

*"I will join you."*

*Miksita glanced at the Scorpioni guard, who was slumped in his chair and softly snoring. "He's asleep. Good. We need to come up with a plan."*

*The clone reached into his sleeve pocket. He pulled out a thin silver plate the size of his thumb. "Zabia's lightning may have damaged this. I make no promises."*

*"What's that?" Miksita asked.*

*"A homing beacon. The guards neglected to search my person."*

*The battle robots might have been left with with Leiurus' guards, but the clone had kept the master key. He pressed a button on the device with a talon. Nothing.*

*"What are you doing?" Miksita inquired.*

*The clone clenched his teeth and pressed the button several more time.*

*"No. She must have shorted—"*

*Suddenly, the device hummed. Three beeps sounded from the beacon.*

*"Move to the front of your cells and lie down on the floor," he instructed the captives. "Be ready to flee."*

*Miksita and her compatriots glanced at each other. The blue man shrugged. After a moment of hesitation, they complied. The clone lied down as well.*

*Minutes passed. Suddenly, the sound of shouting and the rhythmic tunk-tunk-tunk of metal hitting stone came from behind the cell walls.*

*"Cover your heads," the clone warned. Miksita and the others obeyed.*

*A thunderous roar shook the room. Hot stone debris pelted them as the cell walls exploded in laser fire. Through the dust and smoke, the clone saw four battle robots standing amidst the rubble. In the distance, Scorpioni warriors were running toward the wreckage, shouting. Miksita and the others rose to their feet. The bear-man growled, and the sea-elf's tentacles rose menacingly.*

"Hordak, wake up."

Hordak opened his eyes. Imp had climbed out of his bassinet during the night and was nestled against his neck. The other cot was empty.

"You," Hordak grunted.

"Get up," said Micah coldly. "We have work to do."

The door to the room was open. Micah was standing in the doorway, with several Bright Moon guards behind him. Hordak blinked, sat up, and slid on his boots as Imp stretched.

"Where is Kadroh?" Hordak asked.

"Visiting Entrapta. He'll be joining us, as will Glimmer. Let's go."

Micah handed Hordak a small basket of apples. "Breakfast for you and Kadroh. You'll need to eat them on the walk over."

Imp rode on Hordak's shoulder as he walked through the castle complex with Micah and five guards. Micah fixed his gaze ahead, refusing to make eye contact with Hordak.

"Two new prisoners of war were taken to the POW camp early this morning," Micah explained. "We'll tell you more when Kadroh joins us."

Outside, the air was crisp, and the day-moon was rising in a blue and rose sky. Micah led the group through a lavender terrace lined with rose bushes. Ahead, Glimmer, Adora, and Bow were talking solemnly. When Glimmer noticed her father and his entourage, she bid parting words to her friends and approached. Adora and Bow walked off toward the waterfront, then vanished as they passed behind the magical veil.

The hardness in Micah's eyes softened. Glimmer and Micah exchanged warm glances. Side by side, the queen and king-father led the group to the rhododendron courtyard. Standing outside of the workshop-tent, Entrapta and Kadroh were smiling and having a lively conversation. Kadroh had replaced his white and gray uniform with a deep purple tunic, slacks, and boots. When Entrapta noticed Hordak, she waved, beaming. Hordak felt delight wash over him again, and he smiled back at her.

"Kadroh, we need your help," Glimmer called out. "Come with us."

"Imp, stay here in the courtyard until I return," Hordak said to the child on his shoulder. Imp chittered, then took flight toward the tents.

Micah led Glimmer, Hordak, Kadroh, and five guards away from Bright Moon castle, into the nearby forests. Hordak and Kadroh each ate an apple as the royals explained their mission.

"Two Galactic Horde soldiers were captured in the early hours of the morning," Micah revealed. "Scorpia, Netossa, and Spinnerella discovered them a few hundred feet outside the veil. They almost found Bright Moon."

"Scorpia said her venom wasn't enough to knock them unconscious, but it slowed them down," Glimmer added.

"After they were restrained, guards blindfolded them and took them to the POW camp," Micah continued. "They're the first clones we've captured. So we have a rare opportunity now."

"Dad and I realized that we could learn about Prime's plans, using the two clones. We'll need you to help us," Glimmer told Hordak and Kadroh.

"Interrogating them will be futile. They've been conditioned to keep information secret," Hordak said bluntly, tossing an apple core aside.

"We don't want you to interrogate them," Micah replied. "We want you to peak inside the hive mind."

Hordak and Kadroh shared a wordless glance.

"Those clones still have a telepathic connection to Horde Prime. You can telepathically link with them. You can see what they're hiding from us," Glimmer explained. "And, you can see into Horde Prime's mind, through them."

Hordak's blood ran cold. He recalled Horde Prime as an emerald cloud in his mind's eye. A being who saw his thoughts, laid bare his memories, and effortlessly hurled him into unconsciousness. *Him.* Glimmer was asking Hordak to stare into *him*.

Kadroh shook his head. "I will liberate my brothers, but I will not stare into Horde Prime's mind." He tightly shut his eyes and winced. "I cannot gaze into him."

"Please. We won't force you, but think about what's on the line. You could draw out information that could turn the tide," Glimmer pleaded.

"I cannot," Kadroh repeated, face pained.

Hordak huffed. “Glimmer, understand what you’re demanding. In the hive mind, clones feel Horde Prime’s presence at all times. They receive his orders and submit to his probing. But clones do not probe *his* mind. They consider it a grave offense. We’ve never done such a thing before.”

“We also risk attracting Horde Prime’s attention,” Kadroh warned. “He could pinpoint the camp’s location, or possess the captive clone.”

“Knowing the general location of the camp is one thing. Sending forces to pinpoint its location are another, especially while it’s veiled” Micah explained. “Also, the clones were restrained. If Horde Prime possesses one of them, he isn’t going anywhere.”

“What if the clones glean secrets?” Hordak added. “As we stare into their minds, they stare into ours.”

“We know there are risks,” Glimmer admitted. “But the chance to learn Horde Prime’s plans is too valuable.”

Memories of violation, humiliation, and then silence pawed at Hordak’s mind. Memories of awe and terror scratched at Hordak’s heart. His muscles tensed. Finally, he shoved down his turmoil and made his decision.

“I will do it,” he finally agreed. “I will gaze into his mind through one of the clones, on one condition. The clone’s connection to the hive mind will be severed when I complete the task.”

“I will liberate the other,” Kadroh added.

“All right,” Glimmer assented.

“Show our brothers benevolence afterwards,” Kadroh insisted. “They will be distraught.”

The forest gave way to a clearing, where dozens of lilac-colored tents sat in rows. The aromas of oatmeal and sausage wafted from a mess tent. Former Horde soldiers strolled the camp, or sat on the ground in small groups, chatting. Bright Moon guards stood rigidly around the perimeter of the settlement and patrolled the paths between tents. Mystacore mages stood on nearby rock formations, maintaining a magical veil.

Near the entrance of the camp, a crowd of about two dozen ex-Horde soldiers had gathered in front of Spinnerella and Netossa. Sea-elves, reptilians, and anthros listened to the princesses with folded arms, cocked eyebrows, and sneers.

"We want to give you a better future," Spinnerella pleaded. "You deserve better than life in the Horde. Don't you see that?"

"Besides, what did the Horde ever give you?" Netossa asked the crowd.

Micah pointed to a small tent, pitched away from the others, where two Bright Moon guards stood at attention. "The clones are being held there. Hordak, can we depend on you to do this?"

"Yes," Hordak growled.

"They didn't come quietly. You'll have your hands full," Micah said.

Meanwhile, Netossa threw her hands up. "Okay, besides food, shelter, top notch medical care, electricity, computers, vehicles, camaraderie, a meritocracy free of speciesism, and revenge on the nobility who lorded over the commoners, what did the Horde ever give you?"

"Indoor plumbing," said Cobalt.

"SHUT UP!" Netossa shouted.

Murmurs rumbled through the crowd. All eyes were now on Hordak and Kadroh. Whispers of "It's him" and "He brought one

of them” came from the ex-Horde soldiers as their former leader passed by.

The guards waited outside as Glimmer, Micah, Hordak, and Kadroh entered the tent. Inside sat two cots, on which sat two Galactic Horde clones, wearing the tabards of mature soldiers. Their ankles were bound with steel manacles, and their wrists were bound behind their backs with cuffs.

As soon as the four entered, the shouting began. One of the clones snarled when he laid eyes on Hordak and Kadroh. "Infidels! Red-eyed fiends! You turned from the light of Prime! You let the Etherians seduce you with blasphemies and trifles! Your apostasy will end in utter disaster!"

The second clone smirked at Glimmer with an air of superiority. "It's you, Queen Glimmer. You've been hiding on Etheria all along," he said. "You rejected the hospitality of Horde Prime, emperor of the Galactic Horde, ruler of the known universe, regent of the seven skies."

"Greetings to you too, Brothers!" replied Kadroh.

"These are Hordak and Kadroh," Glimmer told the captives. “They’re here to talk to you.”

"The apostates even took names for themselves!" hissed the first clone. “Abominations!”

"They have forsaken the wisdom of Prime, he who brings the day and the night, revered one of the shining galaxies, promised one of a thousand suns. We will tell them nothing," sneered the second clone.

Hordak stood before the hostile clone, whose lip curled with malice. After a moment, the right words came to him.

“Brother, the bonds binding me to Horde Prime were severed. I no longer bask in his light,” Hordak said.

“And so you fell away from righteousness!” the hostile clone replied.

“I’ve discovered that I possess an ability, however,” Hordak continued. “I can gaze into the thoughts of my brothers.”

“Impossible.”

“Not impossible.”

“How?”

“How is unimportant. I fell from Prime’s holiness, but you bask in his light. I wish to gaze into your mind, so that I can feel Prime’s light once again, through you.”

The clone’s eyes sparkled with malice. He sneered, showing sharp green teeth. “You long to feel what you can never savor again? You long for one moment of Prime’s radiance that earnestly?”

“May I stand in his holiness, through you?”

The clone chuckled. “Yes. Feel the light warm your face, before you plunge back into darkness, forever. Let it remind you of what you forsook.”

Hordak knelt on one knee, so that he was on eye level with the hostile clone. Behind him, Kadroh was standing before the pious clone, softly telling him about the jeweled-mind-link. Glimmer and Micah stood near the entrance of the tent, watching silently.

Slowly, Hordak placed his hands on either side of the clone’s head. A fiery golden presence spilled into his consciousness. He closed his eyes as the soldier’s emotions splashed into him: contempt, superiority, helplessness, emptiness, impotent fury. Words such as *apostate* and *parasites* and *glory be to Horde Prime* floated in the soup of emotions. A tugging sensation came from the back of the clone’s mind, as if he were pulling information inward.

A green gossamer thread danced before Hordak. He clung to it, tracing its path with his mind. The thread snaked through the void, leading to a billowing, viridescent cloud in the distance. Hordak glided above the thread, following its path closer to the cloud. Holy terror, cold and thick and familiar, coursed through him as Horde Prime's consciousness grew nearer and nearer.

The emerald cloud loomed before him, churning. Every ounce of his being told Hordak to halt, to cease his journey toward that undulating storm. He willed himself forward, penetrating the cloud.

Swirling green and white clouds engulfed him. Blinding green and white light flickered around him. Like a thunderclap, a wave of POWERLESSNESS crashed into him. The POWERLESSNESS reverberated through the cloud, sending needling pain through Hordak's mind.

Images flashed in Hordak's mind as the POWERLESSNESS flooded it. The white and purple skies of the realm between worlds. Beings the size of cities made of twisting sinews and bubbling oil. Fleeing on hyperdimensional winds from a burning mass of cytoplasm the size of a moon. Hiding in gravity wells, waiting for the howling creatures to pass.

Just as the POWERLESSNESS receded, a wave of RAGE struck Hordak, stinging his mind like acid. More images assaulted Hordak's mind. A colossal vortex forming in space, swallowing Etheria whole. Etheria floating through the realm between worlds, firing a beam of magical energy at a planet-size jumble of tumors. Screams of agony. Horde Prime, standing on Etheria's barren corpse, brimming with JOY and RAGE. An oily green and black mass, inside Prime's body.

Another wave of RAGE struck Hordak, who cried out in pain. Seven eyes now stared at him. The oily green and black mass hovered above him.

*How dare you,* it rumbled.

Hordak's consciousness bolted from the cloud. He raced down the gossamer thread, frantically willing himself back to the hostile clone's body.

*How dare you probe my thoughts!* roared Horde Prime, close behind. Hordak could feel Prime's RAGE burning behind him, Prime's wrath reaching for him in the void.

Violently, Hordak's mind collided with the hostile clone's mind. Both men shouted in pain. In the fiery gold of their linked minds, Hordak could feel the clone's contempt melt away, leaving naked fear in its wake. Both felt Horde Prime worming his way into the clone's consciousness.

Hordak yanked his hands away from the clone's head, falling sideways. His head throbbed, and his heart was pounding. When he sat up, he saw the hostile clone writhing on the cot. The clone clenched his teeth as cracking noises issued from his joints.

Micah was wide-eyed, and Glimmer was covering her mouth with her hands. Kadroh was holding the pious clone's head in his hands, as both squeezed their eyes shut.

The hostile clone stopped writhing. Calmly, he sat up on the cot, then stood up, glaring at Hordak. His pupils glowed white. His expression took on a familiar cruelty.

"What are you doing, Little Brother?"

Trembling, Hordak rose to his feet and backed away. Kadroh was grunting. The pious clone was whimpering. Neither seemed to notice the possessed brother in the tent.

"You were probing my thoughts, Little Brother. An unforgivable sin. You truly do think you are equal to me!" Horde Prime raged through the clone host. His cheeks grew red. "ABOMINATION! YOUR FATE WILL BE—ahhhh!"

Micah ran over and pressed his hand to the possessed clone's head. His staff head glowed as he rose and lowered it in triangular

patterns.

“I’ve felt these energies before!” Micah shouted. “When *she* performed the Spell of Obtainment! He’s an eldritch being!”

The purple glow of the staff grew brighter. Bluish-purple light flashed from Micah’s hand. The clone yelped, then collapsed backwards onto the cot.

“I learned exorcism spells after that day,” Micah told the others. “So I’d be ready if I ever met one of those creatures again.”

Hordak rushed over and pressed his hands to the clone’s face. As their minds linked again, he saw the emerald cloud in the distance, darkening, thundering. Hordak focused on the gossamer thread binding the clone to the cloud, pouring all his fear, horror, and will into the green string. It snapped. It faded into nothingness. Hordak removed his hands.

The clone lied on the cot, shaking. When he opened his eyes, only solid green remained. Green slowly turned into red. He looked up at Micah and drew in a sharp breath.

“You … sent Prime back?” he asked weakly.

“Yes,” Micah replied.

Hordak shakily ran a hand through his blue hair. “You exorcised him. Out of the clone. Back into his body.”

The clone lied on the cot, motionless. “A lesser being … cast out Prime?”

“Prime isn’t as mighty as you thought,” Micah said.

“But Horde Prime is … invincible.”

“He’s not,” Micah stated. “He’s a dangerous being, but he’s not invincible.”

“A lowly Etherian … cast out Prime.” The clone flattened his ears. His brow was wrinkled, and his gaze was fixed forward.

Behind them, Kadroh and the pious clone gasped. Kadroh removed his hands from the clone’s head and sat beside him on the cot. Glimmer stood near them, watching the clone’s reactions.

“Brother, you’re free. I severed the thread binding you to Prime,” Kadroh said softly. The pious clone’s mouth was open, and his now-red eyes darted across the tent, focusing on nothing.

“Everything you showed me …” the clone whispered, over and over.

“We’re going to help you make sense of all this,” Glimmer assured him. “I’m going to ask one of the guards to find people who can look after you today.”

Micah turned to Hordak. “You got through. Prime’s reaction was all the proof I needed. What did you see?”

Hordak wiped sweat off his forehead. “He’s wants to take Etheria into hyperspace. Into the realm between worlds. He wants to use the Heart of Etheria to vanquish eldritch beings there.”

Glimmer turned pale. Micah stepped back. Kadroh lifted his head.

“He was small and weak there, once” Hordak continued, swallowing hard. “He despises the creatures there for their dominion. The Heart of Etheria is powerful enough to slay them.”

Micah and Glimmer locked eyes for a long time.

“He longs to rule this world, and the realm between worlds,” Hordak realized.

# Questions

Chapter Summary

> In the POW camp, ex-Horde soldiers confront Hordak. Old hostilities between the Horde and the princesses complicate Glimmer's efforts toward cooperation. Kyle exhibits an unusual ability. Hordak has a flashback to the fall of the Scorpioni.

Chapter Notes

> Content warning: descriptions of battle and killing (non-graphic).

Glimmer and Micah talked furtively, speaking so softly that "war council" and "she might know something" were barely audible to others in the tent. Glimmer then parted the opening to the tent, giving instructions to one of the guards stationed outside. When she stepped back into the tent, she was biting her lip.

"There's a crowd outside. About a hundred ex-Horde soldiers," she told Micah.

"Are they causing trouble?" Micah asked, parting the tent door to peek outside.

"No. They're just standing there. I think they're waiting for Hordak."

Hordak stood in a corner of the tent, rubbing his temples. Pain pulsed through his head. Sweat was still beading on his forehead. Images of the emerald cloud, blinding light, and eldritch beings churned in his mind. Something quaked deep in his stomach, and he struggled to smother the feeling.

"Are you all right?" Glimmer asked him.

"*Fine,*" he growled.

“About a hundred of your soldiers are outside. You should talk to them. I want to talk to them too.”

Meanwhile, Kadroh sat down on the cot next to the hostile clone, telling him that Horde Prime had lied, and that he was free. The hostile clone narrowed his eyes and hissed, but tolerated Kadroh’s hand on his shoulder. The pious clone watched them both with glassy eyes.

A guard entered the tent with two ex-Horde medics. One of the medics, a lynx woman with a motherly bearing, carried two blankets in her arms. The other medic, a short, wiry reptilian who resembled a velociraptor, carried two mugs and a cistern of hot tea.

“These medics will keep an eye on you today,” Glimmer explained to the clones. “They’re here to take care of you.”

“I wish to remain with my brothers for a few more hours,” Kadroh announced. “I can help them make sense of this upheaval.”

“That’s fine. One of the guards will escort you back to the castle when you’re ready,” Glimmer replied. “Hordak, are you ready?”

Hordak shoved down his torment and stood straighter. “I am. I’ll address them.”

Glimmer, Micah, and Hordak exited the tent. Outside the tent were over a hundred ex-Horde soldiers, murmuring to each other. Grizzlor was frowning. Octavia’s arms were folded. Kyle’s eyes pleaded for answers. A line of Bright Moon guards with spears stood between the crowd and the tent. Spinnerella and Netossa stood to the side of the crowd, watching the ex-Horde warriors intently.

As soon as Hordak appeared, a barrage of questions fired out of the crowd.

“What the hell happened last week?”

“Why did Catra send us into an ambush?”

“You put that damn kid in charge, and *now* look at us!”

“Where did you go for days on end? You just disappeared.”

“Who just invaded?”

“Why are the invaders wearing the Horde symbol? That’s our symbol!”

“Why do the men in white look like you?”

They had changed, Hordak realized. Gone was the fear in their eyes. Gone was the deference they’d showed him before. The need to know why had replaced trepidation. They would kneel before him no more.

He had changed too. He was no longer the commander of armies or destroyer of villages. He could no longer perform the character of Lord Hordak before an audience of soldiers, and he would not try.

Hordak raised his hand, palm out. “Calm yourselves. Didn’t Catra tell you what’s going on?”

“Catra didn’t tell us anything!” Grizzlor shouted, pointing to a tent at the end of a nearby row. “She just sulks in her tent!”

“The guards are tight-lipped too,” Cobalt added. “The princesses over there told us a little, but not much.”

“Lord Hordak, you were our leader. You have answers no one else will give us. *We need to know what’s going on*,” Octavia insisted.

All eyes were on Hordak. The POWs waited expectantly for his reply. Hordak ignored his headache, braced himself, stood tall, and spoke.

"A week ago, Etheria was invaded by the Galactic Horde, a vast empire spanning many planets," he began. "Its emperor, Horde Prime, has vowed to seize a weapon buried in the planet's core called the Heart of Etheria. The eruptions of the past week were bursts of magical energy seeping out of the damaged Heart."

A sudden stillness came over the crowd as he continued. "Prime cloned an army of slave-soldiers from his own genetic material. He maintains a telepathic link with his clones, monitoring the war effort through their eyes and ears. The men scouring the planet are his clones. As am I."

Several POWs looked at each other. A low rumble of voices came from the ex-Horde warriors. Hordak continued. "Years ago, I was cast out of the Galactic Horde for angering Prime. I fell through a spacetime anomaly to Etheria. My telepathic link to Prime had been severed, and my ship was too damaged to fly back to the larger universe. I resolved to win back Prime's favor by conquering Etheria and alerting him to Etheria's location using a portal."

Cries of "What!?" and "You brought him here?" rang from the crowd. Facial expressions shifted to anger, hurt, disbelief. The rumble of voices grew louder.

Micah struck the ground several times with the shaft of his staff. "Let him speak. There's more."

"After the failed siege of Bright Moon, Prime teleported Glimmer, Catra, and myself onto his spacecraft, the Velvet Glove. Prime still despised me, and I turned against him. Glimmer, Catra, a fellow clone, and I escaped from the ship and went into hiding for several days. When we returned to Etheria, I agreed to assist the Rebellion. The man who came with me is Kadroh, and he has resolved to fight Horde Prime as well."

The crowd erupted in shouting. An anthro woman clutched her hair and squeezed her eyes shut. A cat-man clenched his fists, on

the verge of tears. Faces full of outrage and pain were everywhere.

"You called the invaders here! You sold us out to another monarch!"

"You fought the princesses for years, and now you've teamed up with them?"

"You were lying to us all along!"

The guards extended their spears forward, keeping the POWs away from the tent. Spinnerella and Netossa assumed battle stances, waiting for the worst.

A slim young man with blond hair climbed atop a nearby tree stump. The din grew softer.

"I was born into the Horde," Kyle began. "I spent my whole life believing that we were fighting for a good cause. But we were fighting for some galactic empire the whole time. My whole life was a lie! Why did you lie to us?"

Hordak felt the throbbing in his head intensify. He squinted. "I was a slave who longed for my master's affirmation. The Horde was a means of securing that affirmation. I had been indoctrinated to regard Horde Prime's glory as the greatest good."

Kyle stared at Hordak, too bewildered to reply. A stocky, brown reptilian placed his hand on Kyle's arm. Kyle stepped down from the stump, and the lizard-man took his place. Hordak recognized the man as Force Captain Sorrowful. Two months before, Sorrowful had been written up for insubordination, after threatening to spank Catra during an argument over sleep-deprived troops.

"The Horde started as a slave revolt," Sorrowful said, struggling to keep his voice from shaking. "But it went from a revolution to another monarchy, with you on the throne instead of Leiurus. You held our lives in your hands, like he did. I was always afraid I'd be

thrown in a cell or sent to Beast Island if I screwed up. And then you put Catra in charge, and she treated us like garbage. I stayed because it was my least worst option. Now, I find out I wasted years of my life! You used us! You owe us!"

"Do you see now?" Spinnerella asked the crowd. "How the Horde used you? Don't you want something better? Let the princesses help you!"

Octavia now stood on the tree stump, facing Spinnerella. "Why? You never helped anyone before. The Scorpioni kept slaves for generations, but the princesses never lifted a finger."

Spinnerella's eyebrows arched. Octavia turned to the crowd, hands on her hips.

"I was born in a village outside of Salineas," Octavia recounted. "The sea elves lived in huts while High Prince Oceanus lived in a palace. Did the royals care about that? When I was eight, and slavers kidnapped me and sold me to the Scorpioni, did the royals rescue me?"

Octavia looked back at Spinnerella and Netossa. "The Horde was the best thing that ever happened to me. I wasn't a slave anymore. Everyone got technology. The leaders didn't live in luxury. They did more for me that the royalty ever did." She paused, looking at the ground. "But now? What happens now?"

"Those were our predecessors," Spinnerella protested. "We're different. We're fighting for the Etherians."

Grizzlor snorted. "You're fighting for yourselves. You still live in fancy palaces. You still keep all the power for yourselves. You think the royals would care about someone like me?"

"The Rebellion has been an anthro club for as long as I can remember," Cobalt pointed out. "The royals don't have a stellar record with the beast-people."

“Yeah, well, a lot of beast-people lost their homes because of the Horde,” Netossa reminded the POWs. “You stand there and lecture us about lording over your fellow Etherians, but you burned down their villages! How many people are refugees because of you?”

Angry voices thundered from the crowd. “Save it!” Netossa shouted at them. “You talk high and mighty about the beast-people, but you waged war on your own people! Own it!”

POWs were shouting at the princesses. POWs were shouting at Hordak. The tumult dissolved into an indistinct roar as pain pounded inside Hordak’s head. Images of an emerald cloud, bewildered soldiers, an oily black and green mass, and pained eyes flickered in his mind.

“Hordak?” Glimmer asked.

He felt nauseous. Sweat beaded on his forehead. His breaths were quick and shallow.

“Hordak?” she repeated. Her voice sounded like it was under water.

A strong hand wrapped around Hordak’s upper arm. “Talk to them. I’ve got him,” Micah said, leading Hordak to the side of the tent.

Glimmer fired a burst of light from her hand into the sky. The din quieted down. “The Rebellion is willing to make a deal,” she announced firmly. “We offer this to former soldiers, force captains, and support staff. Fight with us against Horde Prime. In return for your service, you will be granted amnesty at the conclusion of the war.”

Many of the POWs groaned. Others laughed bitterly. “You CAN’T be serious,” someone called out. A few fired questions at Glimmer.

Meanwhile, Hordak and Micah stood at the side of the tent. A breeze cooled Hordak’s burning face. He closed his eyes, forcing

his breaths to flow slowly and deeply. He stood in place for several minutes, his aching head bowed forward.

When he opened his eyes, he saw Micah, staring off into the distance, his jaw clenched. Beyond the crowd, from the tent that Grizzlor pointed to minutes before, a cat-woman cautiously emerged. Clothed in baggy lilac garments, she watched the crowd nervously before slinking off into the encampment.

“Is that her?” Micah demanded, watching the cat-woman trot off.

“Catra? Yes, that’s her,” Hordak answered.

“The woman who set off the portal,” Micah noted.

“Yes.”

Micah was clenching his staff so tightly that his knuckles had turned white. His eyes remained fixed on Catra’s tent.

“The portal that took Angella,” Micah added.

The king-father’s demeanor grew hard and cold. He stood in place, unmoving, statue-like, as Hordak watched him and Glimmer spoke to the crowd. After several minutes, Catra returned to her tent, carrying a plate of sausages and a mug. Micah drew in a sharp breath. A faint purple light began to shine from the head of the blisterwood staff.

“Don’t,” Hordak warned.

“She deserves it,” growled Micah.

“Don’t. Deal with her after the war.”

“Why are you protecting her?”

“I’m protecting Glimmer,” Hordak admitted. “If the soldiers witnessed you killing Catra, they would panic. They would assume

the Rebellion planned to do the same to them. A riot would erupt."

Micah and Hordak watched Catra slip back into her tent, unnoticed by the crowd. "Glimmer needs to win their trust if she wants any hope of recruiting them," Hordak continued.

The glow from Micah's staff slowly faded, but he refused to meet Hordak's gaze. A tense silence followed as Micah scowled at her tent.

"I've felt that wrath. Catra tore me from the woman I love as well," Hordak finally confessed.

"You got your Entrapta back. I won't get Angella back."

Micah's gaze finally broke from Catra's tent. He tilted his head back and stared into the sky. "On that island, the only thing that kept me going was the hope that I'd see my wife and daughter again. And then, I learned that Catra took Angella from me."

Micah seemed to lose himself in the blue sky and clouds.

"Everything's howling in your mind. Clawing at you," Hordak realized. "Years on Beast Island, losing Angella, then—"

Micah snapped out of his reverie and glared at Hordak. "I don't want your pity! You have no idea what it was like! Being trapped in a wasteland, with no way home, with that signal taunting me day and night!"

Hordak grunted and looked away. "What about Entrapta?"

"What about her!?"

"She survived Beast Island as well."

"She stole my food and hid from me."

“Perhaps she was afraid of you? She couldn’t tell if you were friend or foe,” Hordak explained. “Few people will understand what you endured there, but she is one of them. You scorn my sympathy, but would you welcome hers?”

Meanwhile, Glimmer was fielding questions from unenthusiastic POWs. Kyle was standing on the tree stump again, looking drained.

“Once the war is over, then what? What are we supposed to live on?”

“You’ll be paid for your service at the conclusion of the war, just like the other soldiers,” Glimmer assured him.

“What makes you think Rebellion soldiers will even want to work with us?” Kyle protested, extending his hands outward in frustration.

*FOOOOOM!*

Suddenly, curling flames flew out from his palms. Kyle yelped, recoiling from the flames. He fell from the tree stump, landing with a thud. Nearby POWs shrieked and jumped out of the way.

“DAMMIT KYLE!” someone barked.

Other POWs whispered “Him too,” and “Another one.”

Three guards surrounded Kyle, pointing spears at the young man. Kyle lied on the ground, gawking at his palms. His sleeves were singed black at the edges. A faint odor of burned cotton floated on the breeze.

“I have it too? Like Lonnie and Rogelio?” he cried out.

“Calm down! No one’s hurt. Put him in the observation tent with the others,” ordered Glimmer. One of the guards helped a wide-eyed Kyle to his feet and led him away. The ex-Horde soldiers gave him a wide berth.

"We have a Mystacore mage in the observation tent," Glimmer explained. "They'll teach him how to control it. He'll be fine."

Hordak watched the scene unfold with an open mouth. "What did I just witness?"

Micah watched Kyle and the guard disappear into the encampment. "Over the past week, we've been getting reports of commoners spontaneously developing magical abilities. All of them had been close to magical energy eruptions. Rebellion forces found him and two other deserters near an eruption outside the Whispering Woods. His two friends are showing signs too."

"They're becoming mages? Like the citizens of Mystacore?"

"No. It's static magic, not dynamic magic. It's usually hereditary, like it was for Netossa and Spinnerella. I've never seen it just appear like this before."

Awkwardly, Glimmer addressed the crowd again. Some POWs looked rattled after Kyle's burst of fire, barely paying attention to her words. Hordak scanned the crowd, taking in the devastated faces of his former warriors. He'd led some of those warriors for decades, going back to the slave revolt days. Now, their faith in him had evaporated. To them, he was a failure.

*Their escape from Leiurus' prison had been a success. Miksita and her warriors led the clone and his battle robots through a network of underground caves, branching out for miles underneath the desert. They arrived at a colossal cavern, where daylight poured in from a sinkhole above them. Beast-people and athros were cooking food, sewing clothes, and crafting stone and wood weapons.*

*For months, the clone and other revolutionaries carried out raids on Tip-of-the-Stinger. They returned to the caves with plundered metals and minerals, which the clone would bring to his forge. Inside a vast chamber, lit by lanterns, the clone melted down the metals and forged them into new creations. Battle robots. Data pads. Small laser rifles. Body armor that would shield the wearer from lightning blasts.*

*The clone was crafting other technology in his workshop. Cybernetic augmentation for his aching arms, long enough to cover the depressions forming on his forearms. A breastplate that created the illusion of muscles, but steadied his wayward heart and covered the white blotches forming on his skin.*

*Other raids harried the Scorpioni or liberated slaves. Miksita and her warriors often returned with men, women, and children in tow. Older children were taught how to wield bows and daggers, how to strike Scorpioni while dodging their stingers, and how to survive in the desert wilderness. Miksita told them that when they were old enough, they could fight the Scorpioni.*

*The underground community grew, as did their respect for the clone whose technology brought them victories. Later that year, Miksita called her warriors together.*

*"We have the numbers and the technology to overthrow the royal family," she announced. "Soon, we drive the Scorpioni from Tip-of-the-Stinger for good."*

*Her instructions were clear. Secure the palace, armories, and wells. Fight the Scorpioni from a distance as much as possible. Spare the children, even the high prince's granddaughter.*

*The day came when warriors and battle robots flooded the city. Laser fire struck down Scorpioni soldiers, who relished close-range combat with claws and stingers, but were unprepared for long-range attacks. Scorpioni civilians fled the city for far-flung kingdoms, never to return. Vultak the court mage fled with them.*

*Guards outside of the palace fell, one by one. Revolutionaries chopped down one of the date palms and used it as a battering ram to force open the palace doors. The clone led the Sand Unit inside, where skirmishes between revolutionaries, guards, and nobles spilled into the hallways.*

*The clone and his unit swung open the doors of the throne room. Leiurus was seated on his throne, touching his claw to an earpiece in his left ear.*

*"They're here! With the traveler. The palace has been breached. All of—"*

*A shot from the clone's laser rifle struck Leiurus in the chest. The high prince spoke no more.*

*The palace had fallen. The clone lifted a data pad out of his backpack to alert Miksita, when Cobalt led a slave into the throne room. The elderly bear-woman wore a gray tunic and was holding a Scorpioni infant in her arms.*

*"The nanny," Cobalt explained.*

*The bear-woman shuddered at the sight of the high prince's corpse, the battle robots, and the grim-faced revolutionaries. She held the infant tighter to her chest.*

*"We will not harm Scorpia, or you" the clone assured her. "Take Scorpia back to the nursery. Stay there with her until the fighting concludes." The bear-woman slowly nodded, too nervous to speak. Cobalt escorted the nanny out of the throne room.*

*Cobalt was left in command of Sand Unit, holding the palace. With two battle robots in tow, the clone raced through the streets and joined Wind Unit just outside the city. General Chactida and a platoon of Scorpioni soldiers had taken refuge inside a desert armory, pinned down by Wind Unit's laser fire.*

*Nearby, amidst rock clusters, Miksita's Sky Unit was fighting another platoon of Scorpioni warriors. Soldiers and revolutionaries*

*darted between giant stones, dodging laser fire and ruthless claws. The ground was littered with Scorpioni bodies, anesthetized revolutionaries, and crackling fragments of battle robots. At the center of the battle, a white-haired woman in white armor hurled bolts of lightning from her hands. Booms shook the air as arcs of red electricity tore apart battle robots. The smell of ozone traveled on the wind.*

*Even after the robots fell, the revolutionaries fired on the Scorpioni with laser rifles. Zabia's lighting struck Miksita, shorting out her rifle but failing to penetrate her armor. Miksita threw the smoking rifle aside and leapt at Zabia. Just as Miksita tackled the princess, a hum filled the air, growing stronger and louder. Suddenly, Zabia roared. A massive pillar of red electricity shot into the sky, then vanished. Zabia, Miksita, and everyone in a twenty foot radius had been reduced to ash.*

*Members of Wind Unit saw the spectacle from a distance and screamed. The clone and the howling unit charged up to the armory, where they broke down its doors. Soon, Scorpioni bodies covered the floor. Chactida was surrounded, with multiple laser rifles pointed at her.*

*"Don't hurt my daughter," she said wearily.*

*"Scorpia will not be harmed. You have my word," the clone replied. Laser fire followed.*

*That night, Tip-of-the-Stinger echoed with music and voices. Revolutionaries mourned for Miksita and their fallen comrades, singing dirges by the light of campfires. Freed slaves wept for joy. Couples kissed. Musicians strummed and blew instruments, filling the streets with melodies. A handful of liberated slaves had raided the palace storeroom, bringing wine and delicacies outside for an open air victory feast. Outside the city, the corpses of revolutionaries and Scorpioni soldiers burned on huge pyres.*

*The clone stood at the top of the palace steps, looking out at campfires and feasting warriors. With his technology, an army of*

*simple Etherians had conquered a city-state in one day. Conquest was pleasing to Horde Prime; would he commend the clone for this, if he only knew?*

*Possibilities swirled in his mind. Could this army subdue other cities? Could they bring the planet to heel? Etheria was small and technologically primitive. Conquering the major kingdoms was possible, with enough soldiers and technology.*

*An idea enticed him. Horde Prime had cast him out for being a defect. If he could conquer Etheria, if he could make an offering of this one planet, Prime would recognize his worth. Prime would welcome him back in love.*

*He remembered the words that flashed across his mind in those lonely days, after the crash. Horda (brother). Ṛdak (worthy). He would be a Worthy Brother. The thought warmed him.*

*"What happens now?" asked a girl's voice. He turned to see Octavia, holding a piece of flatbread. Grizzlor and several reptilians were with her, drinking from wine cups. "Miksita is gone. You're the closest thing we have to a leader now. What happens after this?"*

*"Many other kingdoms exist on Etheria, correct?"*

*"Yeah."*

*"Did their leaders ever attempt to free you from slavery?"*

*"No. They don't care about us."*

*"They live in palaces, like this? They enjoy luxuries, while their subjects toil?"*

*"Yeah. That's what royals do."*

*"Then aren't they failures? They failed all of you. They luxuriated in their palaces, ignoring your plight."*

*“I never thought about it that way.”*

*“What if the royals were vanquished? No Etherian would be enslaved to any other Etherian. No one would hoard wealth. We would all be … the same.”*

*“I like this guy,” remarked Grizzlor, taking a sip from his wine cup. “You need a name, though. You should pick out a name.”*

*The two words remained in his mind. Horda. Ṛdak.*

# Old Ways

Chapter Summary

> Hordak's trauma demands his attention. Glimmer, Micah, Castaspella, and Hordak seek information from Shadow Weaver. Kadroh reminds Hordak that a second chance is within reach. Horde Prime addresses the Etherians via hologram.

Hordak closed the door to his quarters. A platter of fruit, a carafe of water, and a glass were waiting for him on a folding table. With a heavy sigh, he sat down on the cot, reaching for the plate of plum slices, berries, pomegranate seeds, and starfruit. Soon, the plate was bare.

Kadroh was still at the POW camp, and Imp was still at the rhododendron courtyard. Glimmer and Micah were having lunch elsewhere in the castle, and would retrieve him in two hours. Finally, he had solitude, but not peace.

Alone, in silence, he could not shake his unease. An ache trembled deep in his chest. Hordak dug his talons into the cot, fighting to slow down his quickening breaths. The trembling would not cease. Something unbearable rose up in him like magma, too hot and forceful to be pushed down.

He seized a pillow and buried his face in it, so his wail wouldn't reach the ears of the guards outside. Tears spilled from his eyes. Heaving sobs poured out of him as he hyperventilated. He shook, fighting the urge to scream, and scream, and scream.

It was all too much! Pain coursed through him. Memories crashed together.

a clawed hand wrenching the crystal from his armor

a cable penetrating his neck port

Kadroh's thoughts flooding his mind

seven eyes watching from that oily black and green globule

*You had Catra send Entrapta to Beast Island so She-Ra would run off to rescue her*

an emerald cloud

a clawed hand lifting him by his throat

a b o m i n a t i o n

*Who do you think let the princesses in?*

Horde Prime probing his thoughts

If he screamed, the guards would throw open the door and see his sorry state. No. He must not scream. He wept. He hyperventilated. He sank his talons into the pillow, now wet with tears.

When the trembling stopped, Hordak was curled up on his cot, exhausted. The pillow was a damp mess of eye makeup, fabric and feathers. Four gashes marred the mural on the wall. Paint and gesso were trapped under the talons of his right hand. His face was hot. His eyelids were swollen.

He lied on the cot for a long time. Slowly, he sat up. After picking paint and gesso out from under his talons, he smoothed his disheveled hair. He gulped a glass of water, then another. He rubbed some of the water on his cheeks, cooling them.

He had to regain his composure. He could not let Glimmer, Micah, or the guards see him like this. He could not let *her* see him like this.

Shadow Weaver lounged on a scarlet couch, legs crossed. Glimmer and Micah sat on ornate rosewood chairs in front of the couch. Castaspella and Hordak sat on chairs on either side of the group. Hordak repeatedly adjusted himself, struggling to sit comfortably on a chair crafted for a smaller person.

Micah said very little. He sat rigidly, clutching his staff with a white-knuckled hand. Something seethed just under his skin, something he was devoting a great deal of effort into holding down. Tension hung in the air, as if explosives were about to detonate.

"Confining me to quarters was an overreaction on your father's part. I had good reasons for doing what I did."

Glimmer winced. "What "good reasons" could you have had for knocking out two guards with a sleep spell, sneaking into the throne room, and lounging on my throne while waiting for the Moonstone to go dormant?"

"I told you letting her have that magic garden was a bad idea," Castaspella reminded her niece.

Shadow Weaver ignored Castaspella, fixing her gaze on Glimmer. "You'd undertaken a dangerous mission. Against my advice, I might add. If you died, Bright Moon would be vulnerable. But if I tapped into the Moonstone, *I* could protect Bright Moon."

"You wanted the Moonstone all along, didn't you?" Glimmer remarked.

"No. I was preparing for a Horde offensive, in case your recklessness had gotten you killed."

“You wanted to take over,” Castaspella maintained.

Shadow Weaver uncrossed her legs. “But that’s not why you’re all here, is it? You wouldn’t have brought Hordak along if that was your only business.”

The sorceress looked Hordak up and down. “How the mighty have fallen. All your conquests, for nothing. Seeing “Lord Hordak” reduced to an ordinary man gives me some satisfaction.”

“And seeing *you* reduced to the princesses’ unwanted houseguest gives *me* some satisfaction,” Hordak retorted.

Micah abruptly cleared his throat. Glimmer sighed.

“He’s helping us,” Glimmer replied. “Tell her what you learned.”

"We uncovered more information about Horde Prime's plans this morning," Hordak began. "He will not be content to conquer Etheria, or harness the Heart. He plans to send Etheria into hyperspace, or what you call the realm between worlds."

“Prime wants to use the Heart to conquer that world, as well as this one,” Glimmer continued.

“He’s an eldritch being possessing a host,” said Micah. Barely suppressed wrath tinged his words. “The Veiled Ones know more about eldritch creatures and interdimensional spellcraft than any other order. You belonged to that order, once.”

“We’re here for information. Tell us what you know about the realm. About the beings there,” Glimmer said.

Shadow Weaver was silent for a moment. She tilted her head back slightly. “This … changes things. This is more dire than I realized. Very well.”

Glimmer leaned forward and Micah maintained a cold, rigid presence as Shadow Weaver began.

"The mages of Mystacore borrowed magical knowledge from ancient cultures all over the planet. The Veiled Ones' school of thought has some overlap with the shamanistic tradition of the Twiggets," Shadow Weaver explained. "The Twiggets were more than stone age people. They were the original inhabitants of the Whispering Woods, and their shamans knew the secrets of plants, animals, and spirits. They also cultivated knowledge about forbidden realms."

She folded her hands in her lap. "As a rite of mastery, the shamans would drink a potion called sprag. Early Veiled Ones were known to do so too. They brewed it from magical mushrooms, vines, and flowering plants found only in the Whispering Woods. The potion transported them to the realm between worlds for several hours, where they sought knowledge about the cosmos and the soul."

"That was the realm we were all thrown into, when Catra opened the portal," Glimmer noted.

"Yes. It’s the vacant space that sits between different universes. A vast, dangerous and unpredictable place, as you saw yourself. Some shamans found themselves in a dream world in which every desire was realized, as we all did. Other travelers found themselves in ever-morphing landscapes, or living storms. Others still met eldritch beings. Some were friendly, but many were hostile."

Shadow Weaver sat back on the couch. "Most shamans and mages who returned alive were shaken but whole. But sometimes, travelers came back changed. Some found themselves existing in two time streams simultaneously, or in two places at once. Others possessed farsight. Others still had parts of their bodies burned black from otherworldly energies they could not control."

The sorceress tilted her head at Micah. "And I knew at least one traveler who came back immortal," she added.

Glimmer turned to her father. "What?"

"We were waiting for the right time to tell you," Castaspella said softly. Micah shifted uneasily in his chair.

"Before you were born, Bright Moon forces captured me during a battle," Shadow Weaver recounted. "I talked with your mother during my captivity, before I escaped. Did you know that the First Ones brought new diseases to Etheria? Shimmer cough didn't exist here before their arrival. They brought another disease as well. Your ancestors, the Cherubim, called it wing rot. It caused a harmless rash among First Ones, but inflicted deadly leprosy on Cherubim."

Micah placed his hand on Glimmer's hand. "Your mother was the daughter of a First Ones woman and a Cherubim king," he told Glimmer. "Her First Ones blood protected her from the disease, but the rest of her people were dying. First Ones medicine didn't work on Cherubim, and magical healing only slowed down the disease's progression. Your mother traveled the world, trying to find a cure. Finally, she pleaded with a shaman friend in the Whispering Woods to let her search for a cure in the realm between worlds."

Micah sighed and closed his eyes. "She drank the sprag. She didn't find a cure there, but she did find an eldritch being. It defied description, in her words. The being made her immortal and forever youthful, maybe out of mercy, or maybe to be cruel. When she returned to Etheria, the rest of her people fell to wing rot. She was the last of her kind."

"Your mother is in that realm, again," Shadow Weaver said. "She survived her first visit there. She may have the tenacity to survive a second time."

Micah's eyes were unfocused, as if lost in thought. Glimmer looked downward, her eyes pained.

"But I don't think the *Etherians* could survive a second visit to the realm between worlds," Shadow Weaver commented. "Those not

killed when Prime fires the Heart will be at the mercy of the realm itself."

Glimmer lifted her eyes. "We need to plan for a worst case scenario. If Prime opens a portal, we need to be ready to close it."

Micah returned to the present, eyes focused ahead. "When *she* performed the Spell of Obtainment, that portal closed once it exhausted the magical energy expended on the ritual. If Prime opens a portal, could we stall Etheria's passage through it? Until he used up his energy source?"

Hordak shook his head. "The Velvet Glove is powered by a singularity core. It's an inexhaustible energy source."

"What if we hijack the core? Or the tech he'll use to open the portal?" Glimmer asked.

"The singularity core and the portal drive are the most inaccessible parts of the ship," Hordak explained. "Only Prime himself has entry codes to enter those areas."

"Couldn't we force our way in?" Glimmer suggested.

"Not with brute strength. You'd be too far from Etheria to use magic. You lack equipment powerful enough to breach such heavily reinforced areas."

Glimmer was not yet dissuaded. "Could Entrapta hack the Velvet Glove's computers?"

"If she were fluent in the Velvet Glove's coding language, I have no doubt. But it would take her days or weeks to learn the language, as with First Ones and Horde coding. By then, Rebellion forces would be exhausted, or the Heart could have torn the planet apart."

"If Rebellion forces captured another clone, could you find the entry codes in Prime's mind?"

Hordak's eyes widened, and his ears flattened. "Floating in Prime's mind and observing his most dominant thoughts was dangerous enough. Sifting through thousands of memories would take too much time! He would notice my intrusion immediately. I barely escaped his mind *last* time, and I will not ask Kadroh to do it."

The room was silent.

"A counter spell," Shadow Weaver finally said. Everyone turned to her.

"Horde Prime is doing on a large scale, with technology, what the Spell of Obtainment did on a small scale, with magic," Shadow Weaver deduced. "A counter spell, with enough magical energy behind it, could close the portal. Mages could tap into the immense amount of magical energy already in the air, from the eruptions."

"How would we keep it closed? Prime could just open it again," Castaspella pointed out.

"We need a larger strategy for stopping him. For preventing him from opening that portal in the first place," Micah said. "But we should have a counter spell on hand anyway."

Glimmer rose from her seat. Micah, Castaspella, and Hordak did likewise.

"Dad, Aunt Casta, we should meet with members of the Mystacore contingent. See if they have lore that could help with a counter spell," Glimmer suggested.

'Wait," Shadow Weaver said, sitting up and lifting her hand. "Let me help you. My order was well-versed in interdimensional spellcraft."

Micah inhaled deeply and clenched his jaw. "*No.*"

"Micah," Shadow Weaver continued, "I wanted power, not annihilation. Etheria came close to annihilation once, and none of

us want that to happen again. Let me help your war effort."

Micah seethed. His free hand slowly clenched into a fist at his side as he spoke. "You betrayed my trust. My daughter's trust. How many times do you think we'll let our guard down?"

"It's not just Prime's portal. I can help you with spells for entering the realm between worlds. If we work together, we could find Angella, if she is--"

Micah spun around, eyes wide. "*You're not going to manipulate me again.*"

"Micah, listen to me."

"No. You've caused enough harm. I don't want or need your help for this!"

Castaspella placed a hand on her brother's shoulder. "Let's go," she whispered.

Micah glared at Shadow Weaver. Purple light faintly glowed from his staff, then faded.

"I know who sent me to Beast Island, Shadow Weaver."

The sorceress glanced at Hordak.

"*I* was not the one who gave the exile order," Hordak told her.

Shadow Weaver was quiet for a moment before folding her arms and sitting back. "It was war, Micah. Unpleasant things are necessary in wartime," she stated casually.

Micah stood taller. "And you will answer for what you did in wartime," Micah replied. "When this is over. I promise you that."

"Shadow Weaver will remained confined to quarters," Glimmer instructed the guards as she exited the room. "Under no--Adora?"

As the group walked out of the room, they found Adora and Swift Wind standing in the hallway among the guards.

“The door was open. We listened to the whole thing,” Swift Wind admitted.

“She hasn’t changed,” Adora sighed. “And she never will.”

Swift Wind shot a dirty look at Hordak before turning back to Glimmer. “We know someone who might be able to help you.”

“Shadow Weaver brought up Twiggets, and shamans who lived in two time streams at once. We know someone who fits that description,” Adora explained. “Her name is Razz, and she’s living in the refugee camp. We can bring her here.”

A warm afternoon breeze blew through the palace windows. As guards led Hordak back to his quarters, he heard the faint flapping of wings in the hallway. A moment later, a familiar weight landed on his left shoulder.

"You've been exploring? I told you to stay in the courtyard."

Imp chittered and smiled proudly.

"You at least returned to the courtyard for breakfast and lunch?"

The child nodded.

Hordak returned to his empty room and closed the door. The shredded pillow was gone, and a white, intact pillow rested in its place. Glasses and a full carafe of water sat on a folding table.

Hordak sat down on the cot, and Imp crawled onto his lap. The boy opened his mouth, replaying a recording. Amidst the sounds of clinking silverware and liquid being poured, Glimmer and Micah took turns speaking.

("--were no takers. I'm hoping they'll change their minds, but ... I'm not holding my breath.")

("You tried. You made a generous offer.")

("And the visit with her didn't go any better.")

("You shouldn't have gone to that tent.")

("I just wanted to talk. And she looked at me like I was an idiot and said I didn't matter, that she only fought that clone because he was running at us, and why was I even there.")

("You were trapped together. You had to help each other on the ship. But that doesn't change who she is. Or what she did.")

("I really thought she was ready to change.")

("People like her don't change. She showed the world who she is when she opened the portal.")

("More tea, please. Thank you. It's not even noon and I need a nap. But if I lay down, I won't get back up.")

The two talked about exhaustion, how he missed the kitchen staff's bao after years in exile, and simple comforts like tea.

("Are you sure you're ready for this?")

("I'll have to be. She might have information--No more soup. I'm done.")

("This just--it just keeps getting worse. Every time I think I've seen or heard the worst, Prime just gets more twisted.")

(You have allies who know what's at stake. And you have a father who loves you. We'll figure this out. All of us.")

The door opened. Imp halted his replay. Kadroh walked through the door, closing it behind him.

“Our brothers are calmer now,” Kadroh announced.

Kadroh sat down on the second cot. As Hordak petted Imp’s back, Kadroh told him about his conversations with the captive clones, their kaleidoscope of emotions, the lynx woman who wrapped them in blankets, and the raptor woman who poured them tea and rubbed their ears. The clones were bewildered by apples and tea, but eventually ate and drank.

“The medics informed me that I was a “cutie” and massaged my ears too!” Kadroh recounted.

Castle staff arrived with folding tables and three plates of fruit. As the three ate dinner, Hordak described his encounter with the ex-Horde soldiers.

"And so, in my eagerness to prove to Prime that I was not a failure, I failed my army,” Hordak confessed.

Kadroh swallowed a fat, round goldenberry. "But now you can succeed, Brother. Now a second chance beckons."

"No. The Horde will never acknowledge me as their leader again."

"Not the Etherian Horde. Our clone brothers."

Hordak stopped eating. Kadroh's eyes were bright.

"Once, you were a liberator. You helped slaves overthrow their oppressors, and imagine a nobler existence. But you lost your way and donned the mantle of a conqueror. You can go forth as a liberator again. We can free our brothers. We can raze Prime's empire of lies and bring them liberty!"

*A second chance.* A chance to succeed at a worthy goal, this time. The idea made Hordak pause.

As they talked more about the Etherian Horde, Hordak brought up his role model.

"Did you know that I was mimicking Prime? I modeled myself off the most powerful being I knew."

"But you were not Prime. You let your soldiers have free will. And friendships, and families, and names! You rejected Prime's uniformity when you led so many different species. Even then, you were choosing to be different from him."

Kadroh finished his last apple slice. "It's so exhilarating, wielding the power to choose now. We can choose to be better men than Prime."

After dinner, Hordak washed off in a waterfall room near his quarters. Glossy rose quartz tiles covered the walls and floor. In the center of the room, a shallow pool was embedded in the floor. A waterfall cascaded down a polished quartz facade, emptying into the pool.

Hordak's armor, with its components spread apart, sat in a corner with his boots and garments. Hordak stood in the pool, with water up to his knees, letting the cool waterfall spill onto his head. The trembling from earlier had been replaced with a weary ache in his arms, his chest, and his soul.

He needed to see Entrapta.

After bathing and dressing, he collected Imp and asked the guards to escort him to the rhododendron courtyard. Per

Glimmer’s orders, Hordak was permitted to leave his quarters under guard to wash, seek medical attention, retrieve or care for Imp, and visit Entrapta.

As the guards led him through palace hallways, he heard a brittle, high-pitched voice nearby.

"So nice of you to spend time with Razz, dearie! Oh, I haven't seen Angie in ages. Where is she?"

The guards brought Hordak outside, where the day-moon was setting in a fiery orange sky. When they arrived at the rhododendron courtyard, Hordak came to a halt. In the distance, Entrapta and Micah were in the midst of a conversation. Entrapta sat calmly on a chair formed out of her hair, resting her chin on her fists. Micah sat on a chair from her workshop, leaning forward, elbows on his knees, his hands woven together.

“(The whole … Beast Island thing),” Imp replayed in Entrapta’s voice, perched on Hordak’s shoulder.

Micah had taken his advice. An odd sense of relief came over him. Entrapta now had someone who understood her exile. To one more person, at least, she was more than a Rebellion asset.

“Let’s go back. Let them talk,” Hordak said to the guards. As they were leaving, Scorpia turned a corner around a nearby tower. She stopped and froze. Her eyes grew wide.

“Lord Hordak! I, uh, didn’t know you’d be here.”

“I don’t use the “Lord” title anymore. You may address me as Hordak.”

“Oh. Of course. Sorry. Force of habit. I was, um, here to see Entrapta,” Scorpia said, rubbing the back of her head with her claw.

“As was I, but she is entertaining a guest. We should return later.”

The two paused, awkwardly searching for words. Finally, Hordak spoke again.

"Thank you … for what you did for Entrapta."

Scorpia smiled timidly and averted her gaze. "I couldn't just let her stay there. She's my friend." Her gaze returned to Hordak. "I thought you'd be mad that I left."

Hordak shook his head. "No."

As the two made their way back to the main palace complex, flanked by guards, Scorpia tried to make conversation.

"So … I heard that you went to the POW camp. How long are they going to stay there? Do you know?"

"I don't know. At least until well after the war, unless they accept Glimmer's amnesty deal."

"How is everyone? From the Horde?"

"The Rebellion is treating them humanely, but they're frustrated with their situation. Why don't you talk to them?"

"… No … I don't think they'd be happy to see me, after everything that's happened."

Suddenly, a tremor shook the ground. The group halted. On the eastern horizon, a flash of iridescent light shone in the far distance, then faded.

"It's been a week, and I still can't get used to those," Scorpia admitted.

By the time the group reached the palace entrance, the day-moon had set. Blues and purples now streaked the sky, and stars were emerging.

Imp shrieked and pointed. Hordak turned his head in time to see a hologram forming above a Galactic Horde spire far off, on the other side of the water. Even from a distance, the shape of Horde Prime was instantly recognizable.

*People of Etheria, your emperor greets you again,* Prime proclaimed, his voice carrying over miles. *My hand is still extended in graciousness, and my promise to you remains.*

Hordak heard tension under that smooth voice. Prime was struggling to hold something down, something just beneath the surface of his poise.

*Bring me the princesses. Bring me She-Ra. The time of petty kingdoms has passed, and the era of unity has come. Bring me these gifts, and Etheria will bask in glory as the resplendent jewel of my empire.*

His green image towered over the landscape, pristine, radiant, godlike. However, as Hordak stared at the hologram, a small imperfection caught his eye. At the lower right, near Prime's hip, faint, jagged lines radiated out from a single point, like a sunburst. Prime was projecting his image from a cracked screen. Did something strike the screen? Or had he punched it?

*I seek an audience with your mages as well,* Prime continued. *Bring me your magic users. Boons of wealth and prestige await those who honor my commands.*

Micah's exorcism had made an indelible first impression, Hordak realized.

Prime extended his arms in a gesture of mercy. *Horde Prime is abundant in his forgiveness. Stand in my light, Etherians, and my benevolence will pour down like rain. But recalcitrance can only be forgiven for so long. Your emperor will strike down the defiant and pour out wrath upon the proud.*

The message ended. Horde Prime's holographic image vanished. As the Rebellion grew more desperate, so too did Prime.

# War Council

Chapter Summary

> The Rebellion brings together a war council, but not everyone is happy to see Hordak. Adora and Entrapta develop a plan to avert a catastrophic failure of the Heart of Etheria. Hordak proposes a plan for bringing the fight to Horde Prime. The Rebellion discovers an ally right under its nose.
>
> Content warning: descriptions of ritualized killing, medical horror.

Chapter Notes

> Marzos are a unit for quantifying magical energy. I chose the word as a shout-out to Count Marzo from the Masters of the Universe franchise.
>
> I was puzzled by the fact that Frosta remains an eternal 11 year-old in the series, even though several years pass between season 1 and season 5. In this story, Frosta is in her early teens.
>
> Pickles and Yudi were names given to two season 5 clones by the spacebat fandom. Pickles was the name given to the devout clone captured by the Rebellion in "Horde Prime". The meanspirited clone who berates Catra on board the Velvet Glove was christened Yudi (U D -- "utter disaster") by Cruelfeline on Tumblr.

Hordak's dream that night began in the desert, with writhing.

Slaves from his days with the Scorpioni – Octavia, Huntara, Grizzlor, Cobalt, Miksika – struggled to free themselves from a winding mass of chains. Leiurus stood in the distance, holding the ends of the chains in his claws.

A flash of green light stunned him. Now, he floated in the hive mind void, where an emerald cloud loomed in the distance. Galactic Horde clones writhed in a jumbled net of gossamer threads, all tangled and knotted, all leading back to the billowing cloud.

“Brother, now is our chance!” shouted Kadroh’s voice behind him.

The next morning, when Hordak emerged from his quarters with Imp on his shoulder, the palace buzzed with activity. Rebellion leaders busied themselves with troop movements, ensuring that enough warriors would be stationed around Bright Moon castle and its environs while the princesses attended the war council. Mages and civilian warriors moved through the halls, often giving him hostile glances as he passed with a retinue of guards.

Outside, he heard mournful wailing.

“OOOOOOOHHHH … AAAAAAAAHHHHH!” a man howled nearby. None of the guards reacted to the sound.

Hordak clenched his teeth as the wailing continued. He soon found its source. When the group passed by one of Bright Moon’s gardens, he saw Kadroh standing under a live oak, crying out toward the day-moon.

“AAAAAAAAAAAHHHHHHH … I weeeeeeeeeep, oh skies, oh lands … Wail with me for my brotheeerrrrsss … Moons, bear witnessss … AAAAAHHHHH!”

Hordak turned to the guards and pointed to Kadroh, They nodded and escorted him into the garden.

“Kadroh, what are you doing?”

“Singing a lament song, brother! I had a powerful dream during the night. Battani were keening lament songs to their deceased.

They howled together in their native tongue, and their sorrow became sound. It was beautiful!”

Kadroh extended his arms to the open air. “And when I awoke, I resolved that I would sing lament songs too, in Galactic Common.”

“Was it … the jeweled-mind-link?”

“I believe so. It felt so vivid, like a memory.”

“Are you mourning for our dead brothers?”

“For our brothers under Horde Prime’s yoke! Their slavery is a living death. Would you sing a lament song with me?”

“I will decline.” Hordak paused, and his features softened slightly. “But, if these laments bring you peace, then continue.”

Imp flew off of Hordak’s shoulder and flitted onto a live oak branch. Standing tall and proud, the child closed his eyes and replayed a recording of Kadroh’s lament song. Kadroh wailed alongside the boy, and Hordak left them as they sang together.

Hordak and the guards made their way to the rhododendron courtyard, where Entrapta threw her arms and hair around him. Her face looked more relaxed, and the light in her eyes was brighter now. They spent the day together, performing maintenance on bird-drones and combing over Heart data. As guards waited outside the workshop tent, the two batted theories around and recounted the events of the prior day.

Amidst all the pain, all the upheaval, Hordak found solace in that tent. Once again, they were lab partners, reveling in science and technology, speaking with ease.

“What have you done to me?” he blurted out as they assembled a batch of nerve induction devices. Entrapta paused and looked up.

“With you, I feel joy. With you, I am home,” he confessed. “What is this feeling? What have you done?”

Entrapta put down her tools and rose from her chair. Hordak rose as well. Entrapta lifted herself up with her hair, hovering at eye level before him. The normally talkative scientist was silent, studying his face. Finally, she asked a question.

"Can I kiss you?"

Hordak froze. His eyes grew wide. Entrapta gazed at him earnestly, waiting for a reply.

"You wish … to engage in courtship behavior … with me?" he asked, brow wrinkled.

"Yes! Oh, but only if you want to," she replied, smiling. "I thought … we might like kissing. It would be an experiment."

Her eyes were so bright. Her voice was so warm. Sweetness filled him.

"That day, when we talked about working on the portal until it was perfect, I was about to ask you. But we got interrupted," she revealed. "But now, I have another chance. Can we kiss?"

His eyes softened. "Yes."

Slowly, Entrapta removed her gloves and tossed them on a nearby table. Gingerly, she placed her hands on either side of his face. Her skin felt warm against his cheeks. She closed her eyes and pressed her lips to his. Their tongues met, and a thrill shot through his body. Tenderly, awkwardly, they kissed for several seconds. When Entrapta gently pulled away, Hordak opened his eyes, and saw that Entrapta's cheeks had turned pink.

"I deem this experiment a success," she said, exhaling with a smile.

The following day, the war council convened. With warriors in

place around Bright Moon, the princesses could be pulled away from sortie duty for several hours.

The war room was a vast white conference room, with stylized murals of Queen Angella, King Micah, and other Etherian heroes adorning its walls. In the center of the room was a white marble table, its round top glowing with an electronic map of Etheria. Around the table were ornately carved marble chairs, including a long, cushioned platform on which Swift Wind was sitting. Glasses and carafes of water had been set out for the participants, and a bowl of water and a small dish with five sugar cubes sat in front of Swift Wind.

Already, the room was crowded. Glimmer sat at the head of the table, flanked by Micah, Castaspella, and a Bright Moon general. Adora, Bow, Swift Wind, Netossa, and Spinnerella had taken their seats. At the back of the room Sea Hawk was leaning back in a chair, smirking, looking to and fro for someone.

When Hordak entered the room, accompanied by a pair of guards, Entrapta, and Kadroh, several Rebellion warriors eyed him suspiciously. Scorpia and Perfuma walked in shortly thereafter, with Perfuma coming to a sudden halt upon seeing Hordak and a purple-clad clone. She winced and whispered something to Scorpia, who gently rested a claw on her back and whispered back. Perfuma frowned and stiffly sat down at the table, staring at Hordak.

"What? … No! Who invited *him*!?" shouted a woman out in the hallway. A teenage girl's voice muttered something inaudible. Mermista stormed into the room, followed by Frosta. With bared teeth and wide eyes, Mermista marched up to him, stretched out her open hand, and swung at him.

*SLAP!*

"What are YOU doing here? You have the nerve to show your face here!?" Mermista barked, as his left cheek began to sting. Hordak growled and bared his fangs, ears flattened. The corners of her

mouth stretched downward as she raised her open hand again. Suddenly, a pink tendril of hair coiled around her wrist.

"*Don't you touch him!*" shrieked Entrapta, jerking Mermista's arm downward with her hair.

"Are you stupid!? He burned down Salineas! *He torched my home!* And you're all just letting him stay here like nothing happened!"

The glass carafes started quaking. The water inside began to slowly float upward.

Soon, Adora, Scorpia, and the two guards had wedged themselves between the two parties. Sea Hawk had risen from his chair and was standing behind Mermista.

"Okay … okay … everyone settle down," Scorpia cooed, standing between Entrapta and Mermista with her claws raised.

"We didn't forget Salineas," Adora explained. "We're not acting like nothing happened. But we need his help to deal with Prime."

Mermista stepped out from behind Scorpia, pointing at Entrapta. "And *you* defend him! You chose him over your friends, Geek Princess!"

"What did you call her?" Hordak growled.

"You never treated me like a friend! He did!" Entrapta shouted. She paused, as if surprised by the words that sprang from her mouth.

Micah pounded on the floor with the shaft of his staff. Glimmer stood up. "All of you, *stop*!" she commanded.

"Wait," Hordak said, realizing what he needed to say. "Mermista, it's retribution you want? For the man who leveled your city?"

"I want you to pay for what you did!" Mermista replied through clenched teeth.

“Glimmer promised a war crimes tribunal, after Prime is thwarted. Would you like to see Lord Hordak, scourge of Etheria, brought to the tribunal in chains?”

“It’s better than you deserve.”

“You’ll see me in chains. You’ll tell the tribunal of my crimes. And you’ll see me punished. Let me help you oust Prime, and you’ll have your revenge. But if Prime wins, the day will never come.”

The carafes stopped quaking. The water in the carafes yielded to gravity. Sea Hawk placed a reassuring hand on Mermista’s shoulder. The princess glared at Hordak.

“It’ll come,” she vowed, before taking a seat beside Sea Hawk.

As Mermista fumed and Sea Hawk whispered kind words, a tense silence hung over the room. Hordak sat down at the table, with Kadroh to his left and Entrapta to his right. Entrapta seemed distracted, as if lost in thought. Kadroh smiled at Glimmer, who addressed the packed room.

"I've brought you all together to develop a new war plan. New allies and new information mean that we need to reevaluate our strategy against Horde Prime," Glimmer told the room.

"Hordak is assisting the Rebellion," she continued. "I realize that your distrust of him runs deep. I have not forgotten his crimes. He *will* answer for them. However, he helped me escape from the Velvet Glove, and he's brought us information and a new ally we couldn't have found on our own. He and his brother have first hand knowledge of the Galactic Horde, which we need. That's why he's here."

Glimmer smiled at Kadroh. "Kadroh protected me while I was off-world. He's been a helpful ally, and he belongs at this meeting too."

Hordak’s gaze floated over the Rebellion warriors, seeing contempt or discomfort on several of their faces.

"Kadroh is living proof that Galactic Horde clones can choose their own path, with the proper support," Hordak interjected. "Resent me if you must, but do not resent my brother. He never took up arms against Etheria, and wants only to help."

A brief silence followed.

"We learned more about Horde Prime and his plan since Glimmer returned. Let's assess the situation," Micah suggested.

"Horde Prime is no ordinary conqueror," Glimmer explained. "He's an eldritch being from the realm between worlds. For centuries, he's been possessing Battani hosts and telepathically controlling an army of clones through a hive mind."

"The clones are slaves," Kadroh added. "Prime robbed them of their free will and indoctrinated them to revere him as a god. He is your enemy, not the clones."

Glimmer nodded. "Prime perceives what the clones perceive. He knows their every thought. He can even possess them. But Hordak and Kadroh found a way to sever clones' connection to the hive mind. They freed three clones while we were in hiding, and two more here on Etheria. So, Prime's control over his soldiers can be broken."

"And, like other eldritch beings, Prime is vulnerable to magic," Micah pointed out. "I exorcised him when he possessed one of the clones at the POW camp. We have a theory that he's won't come to Etheria himself because the planet's magical energy is harmful to him."

"His ultimate plan is worse than we thought," Glimmer continued. "Prime wants to control the Heart of Etheria so that he can conquer the realm between worlds. He wants to open a portal and send Etheria into that dimension. He'll use the Heart to destroy his enemies there."

At this revelation, the Rebellion members gasped. The warriors exchanged tense and fearful glances.

"If Horde Prime wins, he'll drag Etheria into that realm again. If he fires the Heart, Etherians on the surface will die. *We cannot allow him to win*," Glimmer stressed.

“We’re developing a worst case scenario plan,” Castaspella revealed. "Adora and Swift Wind put us in contact with a Twigget shaman, possibly the last one left. Her name is Razz, and she’s helping the Mystacore contingent develop a spell for closing Prime's portal, if he opens one."

Glimmer turned to Castaspella. "Is Razz being helpful?"

Castaspella winced. "Yes, but working with her is surreal. One minute, she's talking about pies and long dead friends. The next minute, she's running circles around us with her knowledge of interdimensional spellcraft."

"We had to be patient with her, but it paid off," Micah added. "They’re close to finishing a counter spell.”

"The Rebellion has a major advantage, though," Glimmer explained. "The large amounts of magical energies released by the eruptions are interfering with Galactic Horde technology. Horde Prime can't teleport anyone to or from Etheria, so his troops have to fly down. The ships' scanners are down. Prime is blind, for the moment."

"Wait," Frosta piped up. "You said his tech won't work. But his robots work. So do his spires when he makes his stupid speeches."

"Oh, I can explain. The battle robots work because their technology is simpler," Entrapta chimed in. "He can use the spires for holographic broadcasts because their transponders use electromagnetic waves. They're unaffected by magic."

"However, the sensors on board the Velvet Glove and the ships rely on tachyon signals that are inhibited by magical energy," Hordak added. "Magic also disrupts Heisenberg compensators, making teleporter use highly dangerous."

Entrapta nodded knowingly. Frosta's face was blank. Adora was smiling sheepishly. Mermista groaned. The eyes of several Rebellion members glazed over.

"We also have the Heart of Etheria to worry about," Glimmer warned. "The eruptions and earthquakes are becoming more frequent. If the containment field fails, the results will be catastrophic."

Entrapta entered a code into the table's digital display. The map of Etheria was dotted with red spots, showing the locations of magical energy eruptions since the Heart's activation.

"I say we figure out a plan for the Heart first," Adora opined. "We may not have much time left. Entrapta, can we repair the containment field?"

Entrapta formed her hair into hand shapes and moved them as she spoke. "Well, the records on Beast Island said the containment field was made of a ganeshium-nazarium alloy that the First Ones brought to the planet. We would need massive quantities of the alloy, but that would be a challenge because nazarium only exists in small quantities in Etheria's crust. Even if we had enough, we'd still need a team of engineers to incorporate it into the fissures of the containment field without getting incinerated."

"So, no."

"Not really, no."

"Okay, what if we let out the magical energy a little at a time? Could we slowly empty the Heart?"

"A gradual, controlled release of energy might work! Hordak and I ran the numbers. The Heart core contains about 2 million marzos of magical energy, currently. One hundred thousand marzos, spread out over Etheria's surface, would be the safe upper limit at one time. If we released the energy in twenty waves of that size,

spaced at least one minute apart, we could empty the Heart safely."

Frosta was squinting.

"Okay, so imagine that the Heart of Etheria is a pot full of boiling water, with the lid on tight," Entrapta explained. "If we do nothing, pressure will force the lid up, and water will spill out. But if we lift the lid up and let the steam escape a little at a time, it won't boil over."

Frosta's squint relaxed slightly.

"But how do we do that? Crystal Castle is offline. Light Hope is gone. The sword was an administrative key, but it's broken," Adora said.

"Ah ah ah! The *sword* is broken. The administrative key isn't!" Entrapta insisted, pulling a smooth teal gem out of her overalls pocket. "I extracted and repaired the Runestone from the sword hilt. The sword was a restraining bolt on She-Ra, but the stone was the First One's administrative key. Here," she said, using a tendril of hair to extend the stone to Adora.

Adora looked down at the oval stone in her right hand. "Okay. We have a way to unlock First One's computers. Now where do we take it?"

"There has to be a control center for the Heart," Entrapta speculated. "The First Ones would have wanted a place where they could perform an override if Crystal Castle was compromised. Except ... I have no idea where that is."

Silence hung over the room. No one stirred.

After several seconds, Mermista stood up, staring at the map of Etheria. She leaned forward and traced her finger around one of the eruptions, forming a circle around it on the screen.

"You know, when I was ten or so, my tutor gave me a science lesson about earthquakes and tsunamis. When you live next to the ocean, you need to know stuff about tsunamis," Mermista recounted. "So, I had this lesson where I had to triangulate the epicenter of an earthquake. There were these spots on a map where the seismic waves were detected, and I had to draw circles around the spots."

Mermista traced a circle around another red dot on the map.

"And where the circles converged, that was the epicenter."

Castaspella's brow wrinkled as she traced a circle around a dot near her on the map. Adora's eyes widened, and she did the same with another dot. Others joined in, until the map was covered in circles that converged at a single point: Desolation Crater.

"A basin!" Entrapta said. "That's it! When the First Ones' texts kept mentioning a basin, they meant a geographic basin! That must be where the Heart is closest to Etheria's surface. The crater!"

Desolation Crater sat at the edge of the Crimson Wastes. Inhabitants of the desert spoke of an adit at the edge of the crater, blocked by a door that no one could open with crowbars or explosives. The basin was rumored to be cursed, and locals avoided it.

"There's one more thing," Entrapta reminded everyone. "The Runestone network draws its magical energy from the Heart. If the Heart is emptied, they'll lose their source of magical energy. You'll be left with whatever energy is left in the network and the stones themselves."

Glimmer grew pale. "You mean..."

"Eventually, the Runestones will run out of magic. If you use your powers sparingly, the magic that's left could last for another generation. If you use your powers heavily, though, it'll run out sooner. Either way, you'll lose your powers during your lifetimes."

"So releasing the magical energy in the Heart means that our powers will run out, someday?" Glimmer realized. Then, her expression hardened, and her eyes focused. "Then so be it. Do it."

"I agree. Do it. I'd rather lose my powers down the road than see Etheria get torn apart," Scorpia said sadly.

"I don't want people to die. We have to stop the Heart. Even if it means that," Frosta added.

Mermista frowned, but grimly nodded. Perfuma looked deflated as the realization slowly sank in, but she too nodded.

"Wait," Glimmer said. "The whole reason Horde Prime spared the planet was so he could use the Heart. If the Heart is neutralized, and Prime learns about it, he'd destroy Etheria."

"He's absolutely capable of doing so," Hordak assured them. "Prime ordered Galactic Horde ships to carpet bomb recalcitrant planets in the past, to make an example of them."

"All the more reason to strike Prime now!" Netossa argued. "Now is the time to strike the Velvet Glove, *and* neutralize the Heart. Prime's at his weakest. He won't abandon the Heart, but he can't or won't leave the Velvet Glove himself. His technology is disabled."

"But the hive mind is a problem," Spinnerella reminded her. "He sees everything the clones see. And he can possess clones, remember? Even if we got close to him, he could just jump to another body."

"Even the hive mind has to have a weakness. Everything has a weakness," Netossa countered. "If we could destroy the hive mind, he'll be kneecapped."

Glimmer turned her gaze to Hordak and Kadroh. "The two of you can sever individual clones from Prime. Do you know of any way to connect to the larger hive mind?

“No,” Hordak replied. Kadroh shook his head.

Entrapta placed a lock of hair on Hordak’s shoulder. “What about Horde Prime? There had to be times when he needed to communicate with the entire hive mind. Did he have any tools for that? We could hijack them.”

Hordak breathed in deeply and shared a glance with Kadroh. Finally, he spoke.

"Yes, such a tool exists. In the center of Horde Prime's private quarters is a large glass sphere full of ... green liquid. He calls it the Chalice, and uses it to communicate with the entire hive mind as needed."

Hordak swallowed. "The green liquid is extracted from clones' vesperto gland, located here," he said, pointing to his lower throat. "The liquid contains an enzyme called chiropterase that amplifies Prime's psionic reach across the hive mind.”

Kadroh was frowning, and his eyes were cast down. Several Rebellion members looked alarmed or nauseous.

"The liquid is extracted from Horde Prime's old, redundant vessels, clones who grow too old, and clones who die in battle. The latter are transported back to the Velvet Glove in stasis caskets to prevent the chiropterase in their bodies from breaking down. Diseased clones are sent to the front lines to die, and their chiropterase is not harvested.”

Hordak sighed and closed his eyes. “During the Rite of Outpouring, a ... clone's vesperto gland is pierced in Prime's presence, and the liquid is captured in a flask as other clones chant, "The many sacrifice for the one.""

He felt Entrapta's hair stroking his back. The room was silent.

"He won't even let them die in peace," Bow whispered.

"Brother," Kadroh began softly, "Our people have innate psionic abilities. The Chalice could amplify our abilities, just as it amplifies Prime's."

Hordak opened his eyes and held Kadroh's gaze. "You're proposing ... that we use the Chalice to disrupt the hive mind."

"Yes. Then, our brothers' deaths will not have been in vain. We could tear our living brothers free. If we defeat Horde Prime, no more clones will be sacrificed, ever again."

Hordak digested these words. His face grew grim, and he inhaled deeply.

“I will do it. I will use the Chalice to sever Horde Prime’s connections to the clones. Then, Prime can be captured.”

Kadroh sat up taller. “And I will accompany you.” The young man’s eyes sparkled. “If you tire, or are struck down in the attempt, I will utilize the Chalice.”

Hordak and Kadroh shared a look of resolve. “Thank you,” Hordak whispered.

“Whoa! Wait a second!” Mermista complained. “What makes you think we’d trust you to do that? How do we know you wouldn’t just take over the hive mind and take Prime’s place?”

Hordak’s eyes narrowed. “I have no desire to sit on Prime’s throne.”

“You’re a warlord,” Mermista reminded him. “You conquer. That’s what you do.”

“I sought to conquer Etheria to win Prime’s favor. But I will never win that favor, and his blessing is meaningless to me now. I have no reason to conquer again.”

Mermista huffed, unconvinced.

“Brother Mermista, we do not seek to seize power. We seek to liberate slaves,” Kadroh protested.

“What if a Rebellion member went with him?” Bow suggested. “Hordak needs a team for this. I’ll go with him. I’ll make sure everything goes according to plan.”

“I would be honored to brave the Velvet Glove alongside you," Sea Hawk volunteered, smiling brightly at Bow. "Someone needs to create a distraction. I can't refuse the call to adventure, and it would put my beloved Mermista's mind at ease. Besides," he said to Hordak, more subdued, "I have a soft spot for fellow screw-ups, trying to make up for the messes they made."

“I’m going too,” Entrapta announced. She and Hordak exchanged a warm glance. “I’m storming the Velvet Glove with you.”

Perfuma squirmed. “Entrapta has a habit of wandering, which does not make for harmonious teamwork.”

Hordak snarled at Perfuma. “*Leashes* do not make for “harmonious teamwork”, Princess. Yes. She told me about that,” he growled. Perfuma averted her gaze.

“I’ll come too,” Scorpia said.

“You can’t use your lightning magic on the Velvet Glove,” Glimmer reminded her. “You’ll be too far from the Black Garnet.”

“I was good at hand-to-hand combat before I ever got those powers,” Scorpia replied. “And my stinger will help with Prime. He’ll be easier to capture if we slow him down.”

“Rebellion brothers, please remember that thousands of clones will be disoriented, if we succeed,” Kadroh told the room. “Please show them mercy.”

“We will,” Glimmer assured him. “We’ll find a way to rehabilitate them.”

“There’s a stolen Galactic Horde spacecraft near Bright Moon. We can use it to fly to the ship,” Hordak said.

The sound of metal clanking on the floor caught the group’s attention. One of the guards had dropped her spear and was now sitting cross-legged on the tabletop near Hordak.

“Darling, let a professional help with this,” the guard said flirtatiously.

Suddenly, the guard’s sclera turned yellow, and her round pupils were replaced by vertical ones. The woman's body and armor turned black, shifting and folding before everyone's eyes. Then, where the guard once sat, was a chameleon-person with long blond hair and green skin, clad in black vinyl.

"I've been here since Prime showed up," Double Trouble revealed. "And you all had no idea."

Micah and Bright Moon's general quickly rose from their chairs. The other guard rushed toward Double Trouble. "Stop. Let them talk," Glimmer commanded. "That's Double Trouble. They're a mercenary who helped the Rebellion."

"Who *has been* helping the Rebellion, Your Highness," Double Trouble added, smiling broadly, revealing a mouth full of sharp teeth.

Entrapta leaned toward the mercenary. "You can shapeshift? Are perfectly mimic voices? Is it an innate biological ability, or magic? Are there others of your kind on Etheria? May I take a DNA sample for further study?"

Double Trouble touched their own face, pretending to be overwhelmed. " Oh, I'm flattered by all this attention!" They shot a knowing look at Hordak. "The star-crossed lovers have been reunited, I see. I love a romance story that ends on such a satisfying note."

As Entrapta squirreled away a loose strand of the mercenary’s hair that had fallen on the tabletop, Double Trouble walked around the table. The others eyed them suspiciously. “As I said, I’ve been helping you. Sometimes, I’m just a guard. Other times, I masquerade as a clone, get one of the princesses’ attention, and then run toward the nearest batch of robots or clone troops. A few times, I took the form of a clone and lead other clones away from Bright Moon. Do you know how many times those soldiers nearly breached the veil?”

Glimmer sat back and folded her arms. “Why are you helping us? I thought you worked for the winning side.”

“Times have forced me to change my business model. If the Heart fails, I die. If Horde Prime wins, life will be miserable. Bright Moon is the planet’s best chance of preventing both.”

Double Trouble touched the back of their left hand to their forehead. "But the past week has forced me out of my comfort zone. I'm upholding order, when my heart cries out for chaos! I need a change of pace. And helping Hordak over there cause headaches for Horde Prime is exactly the chaos I need."

"What are you proposing?" Glimmer asked.

"I want to know too. How exactly do you want to help?" Hordak added.

"First, I want to help you and your team get past the clones," Double Trouble began. Their form blackened and shifted, until they had morphed into a perfect imitation of a Galactic Horde clone. "Those red eyes will get you in trouble. I can pose as a soldier who captured you."

The shapeshifter's form morphed again. Now, they were the perfect imitation of Horde Prime. "And then, I can create a distraction while Hordak makes his way to the Chalice. It will be the performance of a lifetime," they promised, flawlessly imitating Horde Prime's voice and mannerisms.

Double Trouble returned to their default form. "I love chaos. Because you see, chaos is conflict, excitement, drama, the ingredients for unforgettable performances! I love my craft too much to pass up on an opportunity to create chaos for Prime ... for a price, that is."

“What’s your price?” Glimmer asked. “How much money?”

“Oh no, I don’t want money. I have enough of that. I want … a building. Just big enough to turn into a nightclub. I can pay for the interior decorating myself.”

“If this works, you’ll have it. Hordak, do you want Double Trouble on your team?”

“Yes,” Hordak replied.

“While Hordak and his team are storming the Velvet Glove, I’m going to Desolation Crater,” Adora announced. “If that really is a command center, I can tell it to release the Heart’s energy in small waves.”

“I’m going with you,” Glimmer promised. “I triggered the Heart. I’m going to help you fix this.”

“She-Ra needs to do this. For all I know, I might need to get close to the Heart core to pull this off. She-Ra is the only one who could survive the high concentration of magical energy.”

“But it’s going to be guarded,” Glimmer retorted. “Do you think the First Ones would leave something that important unguarded? We can help you fight your way in.”

“Go near the Heart alone, but let us get you there,” Swift Wind said. “I’m going with you too.”

Netossa, Spinnerella, Frosta, Mermista, and Perfuma also agreed to accompany Adora.

Adora nodded firmly. “All right. We have a team for Desolation Crater now. We’ll fly there in Mara’s ship.”

Bow sighed. “If both of these plans work, we could bring down the Galactic Horde and save Etheria. But if either plan goes wrong … it’s over.”

“I think we need a break,” Micah proposed. “Let’s come back in a few minutes to hammer out the details.” The others agreed.

As members of the war council sipped water, chatted, or slipped out of the room, a guard entered and spoke with Glimmer and the general. The three hurried out of the room. A few moments later, Glimmer reappeared.

"Hordak, Kadroh, come out here. Someone wants to see you," she told the two clones.

In the hallway, Hordak and Kadroh found two groups waiting for them. Standing next to Glimmer were Octavia, Grizzlor, and Cobalt, flanked by six guards. Further down the hallway were the two liberated clones from the POW camp, flanked by four guards.

"Three POWs soldiers accepted the amnesty deal," Glimmer explained to Hordak. "They insisted on talking to you."

Hordak studied the faces of his three former colleagues. "You weren't enthusiastic about Glimmer's offer when I last saw you. What changed your minds?"

Octavia placed her hands on her hips and gazed downward. "The sooner I get amnesty when all this is over, the sooner I can figure out ... where I go from here."

Grizzlor glared at Hordak. "Me and Cobalt signed up because of YOU."

"Me? Why?"

Grizzlor pointed an angry index finger at Hordak. "You owe us. YOU sold us out to Prime, and we're going to make sure YOU send him packing."

"We asked to work with you," Cobalt added. "So we can see to it that you fix this."

Hordak bore their grim gazes and stood tall. "You want to help me oust Prime, then? You came at an optimal time. I'll be leading a sortie on board the Velvet Glove, to capture Prime. Will you join me?"

Octavia, Grizzlor, and Cobalt looked at each other. The news seemed to improve their mood. "We'll join you," Octavia replied.

The six guards led the ex-Horde soldiers into the war room. Down the hall, Kadroh was cheerfully talking with the two liberated clones, who had traded their Galactic Horde uniforms for civilian clothing. Hordak, Glimmer, and the general walked up to them.

"Our brothers want to assist the struggle against Prime!" Kadroh cheered.

Glimmer was wide-eyed. "When did this happen? A few days ago, all you cared about was Prime," she asked the men.

"Days ago, I knew not what Prime had denied us," the first clone replied. He was wearing a light blue waistcoat, a loose-fitting white poet-shirt, and blue trousers. “When Brother Kadroh shattered my manacles, I learned about brotherhood, *true* brotherhood. From the medics, I learned about spellbinding pleasures I couldn’t have imagined. Blankets. Songs. Stories. Oatmeal. Apple slices. I named myself after the most decadent delicacy with which they enticed me.”

“You took a name?” Hordak asked.

“Pickles,” he answered proudly. “Now I know that we were but peons, deprived of joy by Horde Prime, emperor of hypocrisy, lord of lies, regent of dead asceticism!”

Kadroh beamed. Hordak turned to the second clone, who was wearing a long, form-fitting red tunic with long sleeves, and black trousers. He flashed Hordak a wicked smile.

"And you, Brother Hordak, showed me true strength. For years I believed that I basked in Prime's strength. But I was weak, submissive, always at his mercy. No longer. Now, my thoughts are my own. My flesh is my own."

"Did you take a name, as Pickles did?"

"Yes. At dawn, as I awoke, a word was burned into my mind. *Yudi.* It means strong. I…I'm unsure what language it is, or how I knew its meaning, but it was written in fire. In my head."

"You remembered a Battani word. It's from the jeweled-mind-link. We all receive flashes of ancestral memory from it."

Yudi's red eyes burned with an inner fire. "We want revenge on Prime."

"We wish to join the struggle. To repay Prime tenfold for using us. Deceiving us," Pickles added.

"Your Highness, can we trust them?" the general quietly asked Glimmer. "This could be a ruse."

Hordak and Kadroh looked at Glimmer, then each other.

"Brother, assure me that your heart is pure. Let me link minds with you," Kadroh implored Pickles.

"Yudi, may I link with you? It will not be like last time," Hordak beseeched the other clone.

Both consented. Hordak slowly placed his right hand on Yudi's cheek, as Yudi rested his hand on Hordak's face. Kadroh and Pickles did likewise. The men closed their eyes and breathed deeply.

Before Hordak blazed the golden light of Yudi's mind. Memories burned like glowing embers. The raptor-woman asking him if he liked the red tunic or yellow tunic best. The startling realization that he could *like*, that he could *choose*. Warmth for the lynx-woman as she tucked him into bed. The sounds of crickets and breezes at night, as he basked in mental solitude for the first time in his life. An anthro woman outside, in the camp, shuddering when she learned that Prime could thrust his mind into the clones' bodies. *Rage. Epiphany.*

Hordak gently removed his hand from Yudi's face, as Yudi lifted his hand. "No ruse," Hordak stated. "He's telling the truth."

Kadroh and Pickles opened their eyes and removed their hands from each other's cheeks. "Pickles' intentions are honorable," Kadroh confirmed.

"Kadroh and I are about to carry out a mission against Prime," Hordak informed the two men. "Two more clones who know the layout of the Velvet Glove would be invaluable. Will you join us?"

Later that night, as Hordak reclined on his cot, he gently scratched Imp's chin and cheeks. He explained to the boy that he, Kadroh, Entrapta, and others would be leaving for an important mission, that they were going to stop Horde Prime for good, and that they would all return soon. As he petted Imp's head, he pushed down the trembling rising inside of him, and hoped he was right.

# The Velvet Glove

Chapter Summary

> Hordak, Kadroh, Entrapta, and the rest of their team storm the Velvet Glove to disable the hive mind and capture Horde Prime. However, the Emperor of the Known Universe will not go down without a fight.
>
> Content warning: Violence.

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

A rogue Galactic Horde spacecraft soared through Etheria's skies. Rosy morning skies gave way to inky blackness and stars as Hordak piloted the ship out of the upper atmosphere. Beneath the ship, Etheria's green and blue surface gleamed in the light of the day-moon.

Hordak's hands rested on two metal spheres at the end of long poles, while a cable plugged into his neck port fed his commands to the central computer. Holographic screens on either side of his head displayed data on ship functions.

Entrapta was darting to and fro, taking in the black computer screens and glowing displays. The circular dais at the center of the bridge was of particular interest.

"The ship is steered through neural integration with the pilot? Genetic authentication is required to activate the ship's systems? Fascinating!"

She turned to Yudi and Pickles. "Have you piloted one of these ships? What is the sensation like? Is it *exciting* to fly through *space*?"

Nearby, Octavia was leaning against a titanium panel, arms folded, eyeing Bow suspiciously. "You aren't going to bum me out again, are you, kid?" she asked.

Scorpia and Kadroh were absorbed in conversation. Scorpia was expounding on the health benefits of platonic affection, especially hugs.

"Regular hugs are good for blood pressure, and they relieve stress! Would you like to try it?" she asked Kadroh, extending her claws. A moment later, Kadroh was reveling in his first hug.

Grizzlor and Cobalt emerged from the ship's sleeping quarters, flustered.

"I'm telling you, I heard rustling," Cobalt insisted.

"We looked! There's nothing there!"

"I know what I heard."

"You're just paranoid."

"Paranoia doesn't make flapping and rustling sounds, Grizzlor."

Double Trouble and Sea Hawk were gazing out the bridge's panoramic windows.

"I've sailed ships on every sea on Etheria, but I've never set sail through space," Sea Hawk said, marveling at the ocean of stars. "This must be how the mariners of yore felt, voyaging to new shores for the first time."

"They'll perform operas about this day, darling. Operas about a ragtag band of warriors. Underdogs fighting among the stars," Double Trouble predicted.

"It makes you want to sing, doesn't it? Do you know the old 'Warriors' shanty?"

"Of course I do! I love shanties!"

The two struck dramatic poses as they belted out the words to the old seafarer song. "Ohhhh, we're on the edge of greatness..." Before long, the two were arm in arm, swaying to the rhythm of the shanty.

Hordak grunted. Abrasive as their singing was, it lifted their spirits and distracted them from the danger awaiting them, so he tolerated their braying.

The singing and chatter grew quiet when the Velvet Glove appeared on screen at the front of the bridge. All eyes were on the silver and green vessel in the distance, where the Emperor of the Known Universe plotted his conquest.

“Everyone insert your ear pieces,” Entrapta instructed the team. Entrapta had created earpieces, customized for different species’ ears, that would allow the team to communicate over long distances.

“Stay focused and follow our plan,” Hordak reminded the group. “If we succeed, the war ends here.”

Bow, clad in the lightweight golden armor he’d worn when Bright Moon had been besieged, fixed his gaze on Hordak. “We’re putting a lot of trust in *you*. Don’t let us down.”

The sleek, narrow ship pulled into one of the Velvet Glove’s docking bays. Nearby docking bays were separated by transparent walls with sliding doors. Embedded in a titanium wall on the other side of the ship was a double door leading to the Velvet Glove’s interior.

The hangar doors closed. Air streamed into the hangar from overhead vents. After an all-clear chime sounded, two clone

soldiers entered the docking bay.

Double doors rose out of the smooth exterior of the ship and parted. A clone soldier emerged, holding Hordak and Kadroh by their collars. The two captives' arms were pulled tightly behind their backs, to make it seem as if their wrists were tied.

"Glory be to Horde Prime," the emerging soldier said reverently.

"Glory be to Horde Prime," the two clone soldiers replied.

"The apostates have been captured. They must be brought before Prime for judgment."

The two clone soldiers approached. Suddenly, an arrow struck one of the soldiers in the chest. A split second later, he was entangled in metallic netting. As the netted clone hissed and tore at the netting with his talons, Hordak and Kadroh tackled the second clone, knocking him to the ground.

The returning "clone" turned black, and their form undulated rapidly. Double Trouble assumed their default chameleon appearance as the others charged out of the ship. As the hissing clone shredded the metallic netting, Yudi and Pickles restrained his arms. Hordak and Kadroh held down the second clone as Octavia and Grizzlor ran over with wrist cuffs.

"Those compartments have *everything*," Octavia remarked as she fastened cuffs to the wrists and ankles of the clone that Hordak and Kadroh were restraining. The clone writhed, struggling to escape.

"The Promised One will strike you all down! Horde Prime's reign is eternal!" he roared, flashing his fangs.

"Brother, we mean you no harm," Kadroh assured him. "But we cannot permit you to interfere."

Grizzlor had cuffed the second clone's wrists and ankles as well. Yudi and Pickles were urging him to stop writhing, promising him

that he would be liberated soon. Sea Hawk untied two red bandanas he had fastened around his neck. Once Sea Hawk tied the bandanas around the restrained clone's mouths, the team ran down the docking bay.

Hordak slammed his palm down on a black rectangle embedded in the wall. With a hum and a hiss, an eight foot high rectangular hatchway appeared in the wall. Hordak opened the hatchway door and waved his teammates inside. Once everyone was inside the service tunnel, Hordak followed them inside and closed the door.

Overhead lights activated, illuminating the service tunnel. Entrapta was studying the screens and glowing green keypads embedded in the walls. Scorpia shivered in the cold, dry air.

Hodark paused, closing his eyes. Before him stretched the black void. An green cloud churned menacingly above them. All around him, blazing golden spheres darted through the Velvet Glove, but only the spheres of Kadroh, Yudi, and Pickles were in the tunnel with them.

He opened his eyes. "Pickles, take Double Trouble, Scorpia, Bow, and Octavia to the throne room. At this hour, Prime will be performing the daily Sacraments of Clarity and will be absent from his throne."

Pickles nodded.

"We'll join you there once the hive mind goes down," Hordak added. "Good luck."

"Don't you worry, darling. We've got this," Double Trouble promised.

Scorpia pointed her thumb at her stinger. "I've got venom waiting just for Prime."

Pickles led his four teammates deeper into the service tunnel.

“Yudi, take Sea Hawk, Grizzlor, and Cobalt to the banquet suite. Sea Hawk, do you have what you need?”

Sea Hawk smirked and patted his trouser pocket. “I bring them everywhere!”

“Good luck,” Hordak told them. Yudi and his team trotted down the service tunnel.

Hordak turned to Entrapta and Kadroh and nodded.

“Are you ready to do this?” Entrapta asked softly.

Hordak inhaled the cool air deep into his lungs. “I am ready.”

The three walked briskly to the end of the service tunnel. Entrapta's eyes darted over the titanium machinery and black screens. Kadroh's expression was haunted, but he held himself tall. Hordak ached, swallowing hard as he strode through his old home.

At the end of the tunnel was a vertical shaft hundreds of feet across, where green and white lights sparkled against white metal. The shaft stretched upward and downward for what seemed like miles. Hundreds of other service tunnels, connected by ladders, opened onto the shaft in both directions.

"Okay. Take the ladders up eleven levels, right?" Entrapta asked.

"Correct," Hordak confirmed.

"Brother Entrapta, the ladders are designed for clones," Kadroh pointed out to Entrapta. "Someone of your stature might find them--"

"Oh, I'm fine!" Entrapta answered as she raced up the service ladder in a flurry of hands, feet, and pink hair.

Hordak and Kadroh followed her up the ladders, until they arrived at their destination. After walking to the end of the new service

tunnel, they waited. Minutes later, a jovial voice rang out over their earpieces.

“This is Sea Hawk! My team made it to the ship’s kitchen.”

In the background, a klaxon was honking. Furious clones were shouting. Through the earpieces, they heard a soft ruffling sound, like a flag rippling in strong winds. Hordak realized he was hearing *flames*.

"Anything can be set alight with enough matches and cooking oil! *This is the biggest ship I've ever set on fire!*" a breathless Sea Hawk chirped. “Um, we’ve got company. Gotta go.” The earpieces went silent.

“One distraction in place. Now, we wait for the second,” Hordak stated.

Entrapta turned toward the vertical shaft. “Did you hear that?”

“I was listening to my earpiece,” Hordak admitted.

“I heard flapping,” she insisted.

A moment later, a saucy voice spoke through the earpieces.

"Double Trouble here. We made it to the throne room. Prime's not here. No clone guards either. Pickles is setting up the holographic transmitter. Time for my most unforgettable performance."

A moment later, a polished voice like Horde Prime's poured over the sound system of the Velvet Glove.

"People of Etheria, lift your eyes to the heavens and rejoice. Your emperor is about to bestow a majestic gift upon you, a sight more illustrious than all of Etheria's moons. In my beneficence, I will show you the galaxy's most sublime wonder."

The sound of rustling fabric followed.

"My glorious ass."

Hordak pressed his palm to a black rectangle on the wall. A hatchway appeared. Hordak, Kadroh, and Entrapta emerged onto a deserted hallway, white and sterile.

The sound of a hand slapping flesh clapped through the sound system. "Is it not perfect, Etheria? Is it not flawless? Is it not utterly spankable?" The sound of rustling fabric could be heard again.

“I will bestow another rare gift on you, Etheria. The gift of truth. A terrible secret I guard like a priceless gem. I am terrified of being *seen*. For I am a weak, wretched, *little* man. Each dawn, I rise from my bed, afraid that others will see me for the pathetic creature I truly am.”

“And so I hide, Etheria. I hide behind silken robes and ostentatious feasts. I hide behind pompous words and overweening mannerisms. I hide behind clone troops and battle robots.”

“Do you know why conquest pleases me, Etheria? Because war allows me to pretend that I am strong. I sojourn on planets across the galaxy, meeting leaders, innovators, creators, and I crush them because their genius remind me of my mediocrity. But no matter how many planets I grind under my heel, I cannot grind away my weakness. I can slay defiant subjects, but I can never slay my own wretchedness.”

As Double Trouble performed, Hordak, Kadroh, and Entrapta entered Horde Prime’s private quarters. Before them stretched a large sanctum, one hundred feet by one hundred feet. Etheria and the stars were visible through vast windows.

In one segment of the room sat a sprawling bed, adorned with silk pillows and shimmering emerald blankets. Multicolored tapestries depicting serpent-people farming, shephering, and feasting covered the wall behind the bed. A green, gold, and

white carpet, hand-woven with stylized images of stars and moons, rested on the floor. Cushioned green chairs and ottomans allowed for lounging. Glass display cases held a menagerie of cultural artifacts: jade figurines of anthros, stone disks carved with glyphs, obsidian blades, and an indigo orb.

In another segment of the room, bottles of strong drink from across the galaxy sat in a wine case. A small bar with glasses and mixology equipment sat beside the case. A bowl of star-shaped fruits and a glass dome filled with tiny delicacies sat on a malachite table.

Against the wall closest to the door was a master control panel, with computer screens and keyboards set in titanium. Here, Prime could monitor and override all functions of his ship.

At the center of the room, sitting on a dais, was the Chalice. The instrument was a glass sphere five feet in diameter, filled with green liquid. The Chalice sat on a stout white pillar about five feet high. A round outlet at the top of the pillar allowed Prime to absorb the liquid by inserting one of his cables. Replacement cables were coiled in a white stone basin at the foot of the pillar.

The sound of a hatchway opening came from the hallway. Hordah, Kadroh, and Entrapta froze, waiting for an opponent to appear in the doorway. Silence. Neither friend nor foe appeared. Entrapta closed the door to Prime's quarters with a tendril of hair.

Suddenly, Double Trouble's broadcast was interrupted by the sound of stomping feet. "HOW DID YOU GET IN MY THRONE ROOM!?" bellowed Horde Prime in the background. The ship's sound system went silent.

"He's in the throne room. Hordak, now's your chance to use the Chalice," Entrapta pointed out.

Hordak tensed. "If anyone intrudes—"

"No matter who comes in here, no matter what happens, *bring down the hive mind*," Entrapta stressed. "We'll cover you. Kadroh,

can you take the ship's defenses offline? I'll guard the door."

Kadroh tapped keys on the master control panel. As Entrapta chirped suggestions for "security alarms, tractor beams, force fields, weapons systems on the docked ships", Hordak stepped onto the dais. He picked up a spare cable from the basin and plugged one end into the pillar outlet.

*Brothers, forgive me for using your essence*, Hordak thought. *If I succeed, no one will ever die to replenish the Chalice again.*

He closed his eyes. Slowly, he inserted the other end of the cable into the port in his neck. A cool, tingling sensation flooded his neck, spreading through his upper back. He felt lightheaded. His heart began to race, and his mouth grew dry. A drug-like euphoria came over him.

And then, his mind flew open.

His consciousness billowed through the void. Tens of thousands of spheres, all glowing with inner fire, revolved around him. The mind of his brothers were close now, reflecting each other's fiery golden light. The hum of their thoughts vibrated through the hive mind. Thousands of gossamer threads danced in the void, leading up to the green cloud that hovered above.

The souls of so many, so close! Hordak reeled, disoriented by the humming, the blazing light, the corners of his mind stretching into the void. The euphoria was stronger now. He focused on the gossamer threads, steadying himself.

*Be free*, he whispered.

And he tore.

He roared into the void, slashing the threads. Hundreds, then thousands of threads split asunder, then faded into nothingness. He roared again, hurling his will at the gossamer threads. Threads snapped, one after the other.

Never again would Prime violate the clones, Hordak vowed. Never again would Prime probe their minds, or pour himself into their bodies.

He tore.

A woman's voice found him in the void. "Prime ran out of the throne room!" Scorpia warned over the earpiece. "There were too many clones, and we couldn't reach him. But they're not fighting anymore. They just…froze."

The green cloud was closer now, almost on top of him. Thunder bellowed from the cloud. *Prime knew.*

"I'm in the halls. I can't find Prime," Bow alerted the others over the earpiece. "Everyone, keep an eye out!"

The hum of the hive mind grew louder as he tore strings apart. Over and over, he cried out, and he tore. Time stopped. His soul burned. His mind pulsed. The threads were almost gone now.

Other sounds found him in the void. A man growling. Two men grunting. The crackle of electricity. Entrapta shouting, "Oh no you don't!" Heavy thuds. Glass shattering. More grunting. The crackle of electricity. A scream.

The last gossamer threads split apart, then faded away. It was finished. The hive mind was no more. Hordak cried out into the void, bathed in the gold light of the spheres.

The cable was suddenly yanked out of his neck port. A hand seized his collar and threw him backwards. Hordak fell to the floor.

"*You truly do think you are my equal!*" panted Horde Prime, standing above him. "I should have killed you! Years ago!"

Horde Prime's voice was ragged. His four eyes were opened wide, too wide. His cables writhed in the air around his head, serpent-like, unmoored from his back ports. His once immaculate hair was disheveled, with strands hanging over his flushed face. His left

sleeve was torn. Bruises were starting to form on his exposed chest. A few stray strands of pink hair were tangled around his neck. Clutched in his hand was a shock baton.

Entrapta was prone on the floor. Her hair twitched slightly. Kadroh was slumped against a wall, eyes closed, groaning. Shattered glass, artifacts, and broken furniture littered the floor.

Horde Prime placed his foot on Hordak's throat. Hordak's hands clamped on the foot, struggling to lift it. He gasped for breath as the room turned gray.

"This ABOMINATION believes he can mock the glory of his lord? That he can tear my brothers from my light without damnation!? *You will perish, Little Brother!*"

The head of the shock baton crackled. "But first, you will suffer." Then came the sound of flapping wings.

Suddenly, Horde Prime stumbled backwards and dropped the shock baton. His foot flew off Hordak's throat. Hordak loudly drew in breath, clutching his throat. As he coughed, he raised his head.

"GET OFF!" howled Prime.

Imp was biting and scratching Horde Prime's face. Hordak realized, in horror, that Imp had sneaked on board the spaceship they flew from Etheria.

Prime frantically tried to grab the boy. Imp leaped off his head before Prime could lay hold of him. Before Prime could react, Hordak's fist slammed into his face.

*"I am not your brother!"*

Prime stumbled backwards again. Wild-eyed, he screamed and raised his fist. Before he could swing, Imp's body smacked against his head, distracting him. As Imp flew away, Hordak punched Prime in the stomach.

“You made me in your image, but I am more than that. *We all are!*”

“(Failure! Waste!)” Imp repeated, taunting Prime in Hordak’s voice.

Blood was dripping from Horde Prime's nose. He swung wildly at Hordak, who barely dodged the blows. Imp harried Prime, smacking into his face or diving just above his head at random moments. Prime and Hordak bobbed and weaved, locked in a deadly dance.

“I gave myself a name! I made a life of my own! I made friends! *And now, so will they!*”

Prime swung again. Hordak stepped back to avoid the blow.

“I am Hordak,” the clone asserted, “and I defy your will—”

Hordak lost his balance. His foot gave way as he tripped on the shock baton that Prime dropped. He fell backwards, hitting the floor. A second later, Prime was on top of him, clutching his wrists. As Hordak struggled, a cable darted toward his head. A stabbing pain shot through his neck as the cable penetrated his neck port.

Hordak felt Prime's consciousness surge into his mind. Emerald green clouds billowed over his thoughts. Prime's RAGE and POWERLESSNESS thundered through him. Blinding green and white light illuminated his secrets, as hard as he fought to hide them.

The malfunctioning Heart. Adora and her team.

*Prime knew.*

Horde Prime's body went limp. Hordak felt himself plummeting backwards into his own head. His limbs moved, but not under his own volition. His flesh was Prime's vessel now.

Now piloting Hordak's body, Prime used Hordak's arms to push his old vessel to the side. Hordak's body rose to its feet. Prime's voice flowed through its lips.

"The Etherians tainted you, Little Brother. And this will be your penance. I will claim the Heart for myself, with your hands. And I will bring cleansing fire to hyperspace," he declared. He was speaking quickly and breathlessly, trembling with rage. "You are a failure, Little Brother. Unworthy to be my vessel. *But you must atone.*"

Hordak howled inside his head, screaming at Prime to let go. *No, no, no!* he cried out in vain as Prime led his body to Entrapta.

"You adored this Etherian more than me," Prime mused, reaching for her. "Let her come with us, then. Let her witness the fruits of your failure."

Prime slid Hordak's arms under Entrapta's unconscious body, lifting her off the floor. With one arm, he carried her like a sack of grain against Hordak's ribs. Next, Prime piloted his host-body to the control panel against the wall. Nearby, Imp was kneeling next to Kadroh, hissing. Kadroh wearily opened his eyes.

With Hordak's free hand, Prime typed instructions into one of the keyboards. In one of the screens, Hordak saw a reflection of his face with green eyes and glowing white pupils. Watching helplessly from his hijacked body, Hordak recognized the codes on the screen. Commands to the divert extra power from the singularity core to the portal drive. Portal coordinates the clones were forbidden from ever using. *Hyperspace* coordinates.

As fingers fluttered over keys, Hordak howled at Prime to stop, that nothing but annihilation could come from this. Prime's RAGE and POWERLESSNESS crashed into him. With his last keystrokes, Prime engaged the portal drive and locked the control panel.

Prime turned Hordak body around, so they could both see outside the windows. Beyond the Velvet Glove, a great purple vortex

swirled in open space, above Etheria. The vortex quaked, becoming a hole in the fabric of spacetime. The hole yawned. The hole grew. It would soon be large enough to swallow the planet, taking all of Etheria into hyperspace, the realm between worlds. White and purple skies glowed on the other side of the portal.

Carrying Entrapta, Prime steered Hordak's body out of the room. "No ... don't," Kadroh groaned weakly.

Chapter End Notes

> Having DNA in common with Horde Prime comes in very handy for opening doors on board the Velvet Glove, as Imp discovered.

# Son of the Morning

Chapter Summary

> Horde Prime has possessed Hordak’s body, opened a portal to hyperspace, and kidnapped Entrapta. At Desolation Crater, he comes face to face with She-Ra. Meanwhile, two unexpected heroes come to Etheria’s aid.

Chapter Notes

> The chapter title is a reference to Isaiah 14:11-13. "How you have fallen from heaven, morning star, son of the morning! You have been cast down to the earth, you who once laid low the nations!"

In Etheria's sky, a glint of the day-moon's light reflected off a metallic mass. A Galactic Horde spacecraft descended through Etheria's atmosphere.

Entrapta wearily opened her eyes. She found herself on the bridge of a Galactic Horde spaceship, hearing the hum of the engines through the floor. Her wrists had been cuffed behind her back, and her hair was bound up in tight metallic cords. The fabric of her overalls was burned in a small spot on her right leg, and a stinging pain lingered on her skin.

Slowly, she sat up. Standing in the central dais, piloting the ship, was a familiar figure.

"Hordak?"

His eyes now had green sclera, with glowing white pupils. His teeth, now the same acidic shade of green, were clenched. He was breathing heavily. A voice poured out of his mouth, but it was not Hordak's.

"My little brother is atoning for his conceit by serving as my vessel," Horde Prime growled through Hordak's lips. "And you are

about to watch all his efforts come undone."

A cry escaped Entrapta's throat. Memories flooded back: Horde Prime throwing open the sanctum doors, the fight, the shock baton. She was supposed to guard the door and protect Hordak, but she failed. Her stomach knotted as she watched Horde Prime's expressions contorting Hordak's face.

"Hordak, can you hear me in there!?" she demanded to know.

Meanwhile, Hordak watched helplessly as Prime steered his body. Emerald clouds, green light, and white flashes seethed around him inside his head. The horror of the situation was still raw. *Entrapta, I'm so sorry. For all of this,* he thought.

"Do you know why I asked Glimmer and Catra to bring you to me, before they fled?" Prime asked Entrapta. "It wasn't about the exoskeleton you constructed, although its craftsmanship was exquisite."

Prime glared at her through Hordak's eyes. "It was because you did the unforgivable" he confessed breathlessly. "*You* corrupted one of my clones. *You* drove him to rebel, and to wrench the other clones from my light. *You* replaced my perfect truth with delusions about apostasy and imperfection in his mind!"

Hordak listened from the depths of his own head. "Her imperfection is more beautiful than your "perfection", Prime. I know that now."

Prime grunted. "And as punishment for your transgression, little rebel, you will be present when I seize control of the Heart of Etheria. You will see that you were deluded, thinking you could oppose me. My order will triumph over your chaos--"

"How?" Entrapta asked.

Horde Prime paused. "What?"

"How are you going to take over the Heart?"

Prime sneered. "Prime knows all. Prime's will knows no limits--"

“You don't command any princesses. You aren't an administrator,” Entrapta pointed out.

"You'll fail. You have no idea how to operate the Heart," Hordak whispered in Prime’s thoughts.

"QUIET!" Prime bellowed.

Out of the panoramic windows, Entrapta could see Etheria growing closer. A purple tear in the fabric of reality was yawning in the distance, growing larger each minute. Her hair bristled against its bindings as she realized that Prime had opened a hyperspace portal.

A metallic chime sounded. A moment later, Bow appeared on the screen at the front of the bridge. Kadroh's arm was visible just to Bow's left.

“The hologram projector is broadcasting. Speak into the screen,” Kadroh said.

"Okay, we're sending this out to all the spires and any electromagnetic receivers. Everyone, listen carefully! This is Bow. Rebellion forces just invaded the Velvet Glove. Hordak took down the hive mind, so Horde Prime can't direct the clone soldiers anymore," Bow announced.

Kadroh moved into view. His eyelids were heavy. A very unhappy Imp was perched on his left shoulder. "The clones are disoriented," Kadroh said wearily. "Please show them compassion. They are not your oppressors. Horde Prime is."

Bow came back into view. "Horde Prime possessed Hordak and escaped. He kidnapped Entrapta too. We think he's headed for Desolation Crater in the Crimson Wastes. Everyone, be on the lookout!"

Bow moved aside, and Octavia stepped into full view. "We've got more bad news. Prime opened a portal into hyperspace. That's the purple thing in the sky. He locked the master control panel and put some kind of block on the portal drive. Yudi and Pickles are trying to hack in so we can close the portal, but this could take a while. Just...stay calm."

In the background, Entrapta heard sobbing men. She could faintly detect Scorpia's voice. "Hey! Hey! Everyone calm down. We're--" Scorpia said, before the broadcast ended.

Inside his head, Hordak was tossed around in a sea of Prime's emotions. Fury. Humiliation. Flailing. Desperation. Emptiness. A crackling pain had started to shoot through Prime, agitating the sea of misery.

"You still haven't explained how you're going to seize the Heart," Entrapta persisted.

"It lies in Desolation Crater. I will descend into the bowels of Etheria and take hold of it," Prime proclaimed.

"That's not a plan," she reminded Prime. "How are you even going to get close to it? The concentrated magical energies will kill you." Prime did not answer. "The Heart is unstable, too. Even if you could control it, firing it could tear Etheria apart. You'd die," Entrapta continued.

Hordak realized what was causing Prime's crackling pain. "The magic in Etheria's air ... it's hurting you, isn't it?" Hordak asked. A wave of misery crashed into him.

"I SAID QUIET!" Prime shouted.

Entrapta’s eyes widened. "Hordak? He’s fighting inside, isn’t he?”

"SILENCE!" Prime roared. He closed his eyes for a moment, then inhaled deeply. "Silence, little brother. And you as well, chatty little rebel."

The spacecraft was now soaring over Etheria's seas. The growing portal loomed over a quarter of the sky now.

Entrapta's gaze fell on Hordak's body. "You remind me of someone I knew. Someone I thought was my friend," she began. "Hordak said you were small and powerless once, when he peaked into your mind. She was too. She had an awful mother growing up. The other kids picked on her."

Prime said nothing. Entrapta's gaze rested on his hands, which were clutching the sphere controls tightly. "She swore she would never be helpless again. So she fought and lied and betrayed people. Betrayed me. She did horrible things to grab power, because she thought that if she had power, no one could ever hurt her again. But it was never enough. She had a hole in her soul that she couldn't fill."

Entrapta sighed. " You're the same. You have all this power, but it's not enough. You'll never really be at peace. Even if you *could* seize the Heart."

"*That* is where you are mistaken," Prime countered. "I am serene in my power. I will have dominion over this world and hyperspace--"

"No. No you won't. Because you've already lost," Entrapta stated. "That woman? You know how she ended up? Right back where she started. No power, no friends, and no future. That's where you are now."

"She's right," Hordak agreed. "Admit defeat."

"Both of you, BE SILENT!" Prime bellowed. Sweat beaded on his forehead.

Entrapta slowly stood up, still weary from her encounter with the shock baton. She stood near the panoramic windows, watching the gaping portal in the eastern sky. Her throat ached, and she struggled to hold back tears. *Hordak, I'm so sorry,* she thought.

In the far distance, *things* were falling out of the portal. Entrapta squinted as three objects plummeted toward Etheria.

Prime noticed them too. He pulled them up on the bridge screen, magnifying them until they came into focus. One of the objects was a horse-sized, pulsating mound of pink biomass, its surface lined with sinews and mouths. Two protrusions burst from the creature, which morphed into veiny wings that it used to glide on the air.

Prime sneered. "An old neighbor. I never liked him."

Pursuing the creature were two humanoid beings. Diving through the air was a tall, slender woman with translucent wings. Long brown hair rippled around her head. In her hands, she clutched a short sword made from chipped black stone. The other being looked like a duplicate of the woman, formed out of rose and violet gel. It too clutched a stone sword as it dived downward.

The ball of biomass spewed bits of flesh at the two humanoids. The flesh fragments transformed into claw-like chunks of keratin. The two humanoids dodged the fragments, swooped down on either side of the monster, and sliced off its wings with their swords.

Robbed of its wings, the creature plummeted downward again. The brown-haired woman now held her sword in her left hand as she hurled handfuls of light at the monster with her right. The gel-woman flew close behind.

Horde Prime decreased the ship's speed and lowered its altitude. The spacecraft now soared above dense forests and rock formations. On the bridge screen, Prime magnified a chaotic scene in the woods below. Multiple trees in a zig-zag line had been transformed into red sandstone. The line of trees led to a flickering cluster of red rhombuses, hovering just above the ground in a mossy clearing. A crowd of Bright Moon guards and POWs was swarming it. Entrapta recognized several Etherian Horde soldiers in the mob. Kyle was wildly waving his arms,

hurling flames at the rhombus cluster. Lonnie was lobbing crude cubes of blue light. Others were throwing stones and tree branches at the rhombus cluster.

The screen showed another crowd of guards and POWs nearby. Catra, Sorrowful, Rogelio, and other POWs were doing battle with what looked like a living pool of wax. The pool slid across the ground at alarming speed, lashing at its opponents with ropy tendrils. Rogelio swung at a tendril with glowing blue fists.

Entrapta shuddered. Before today, such creatures would have fascinated her. She would have busied herself with tests on tissue samples and theories about how such life forms evolved in the realm between worlds. Now, she could only wonder how many of those things had fallen to Etheria through the portal.

The spacecraft was rapidly approaching Bright Moon castle. The magical veil was absent, and the structure was visible from a distance. "I learned of Bright Moon's emergency plan from my little brother's memories," Horde Prime told her. "And I will not allow vulgar magicians to interfere."

On-screen, Prime magnified the main building of Bright Moon’s castle complex. On the roof, mages had drawn a giant octogram and sacred glyphs in blue light. Micah, Castaspella, the Mystacore mages, and a tiny white-haired woman wearing a mauve shawl stood in a ring around the octogram. They raised their hands to the eastern sky.

“Laser canons, lock on target,” Prime commanded. He paused. “Laser canons, lock on target!” he repeated.

“Oh, those won’t work,” Entrapta piped up. “Kadroh disabled the weapons systems on all the docked ships back on the Velvet Glove. You never got around to bringing them back online.”

Suddenly, a beam of brilliant blue light burst from the circle of mages. The pillar of light shot toward the eastern sky, into the portal. A deafening roar shook the air.

Prime winced at the bright light. The pain crackling through him grew stronger. “Etheria’s magic. It’s hurting you. You cannot survive here,” Hordak called out to Prime in his mind.

The brilliant beam faded. The edges of the portal quaked and flashed red. Immediately, the portal on the horizon began to contract. The counter spell had worked.

Entrapta yelped, her eyes bright. Prime emitted a raspy, animalistic shout. “I will trigger the portal later! I have no time for this! Only the Heart matters now.”

Inside his mind, Hordak felt Horde Prime trembling from the crackling pain. Hordak pushed against the green clouds and light, trying to pour himself into his limbs again. Prime raged. Another wave of anger slammed into Hordak.

The spacecraft banked as Prime tightly shut his eyes and grunted. “Hordak, fight him!” Entrapta cried out.

Prime opened his eyes and glared at her. He steadied the spaceship. “You will not overstep your lowly station, Little Brother,” he panted.

The portal in the eastern sky was shrinking. Horde Prime was breathing heavily, wild-eyed. Quietly, Entrapta strained her hair against the metallic bindings. She could not free individual strands, but she could swing the mass of hair side to side.

Several minutes later, the landscape turned to sand and stone. The spacecraft began its final descent. Through the windows, Entrapta could see a colossal basin. Desolation Crater was chalk-white and weathered from wind and sun. Mara’s spaceship sat near the crater’s rim. Tiny figures stood near it.

The ship landed a few hundred feet from the adit on the rim of the basin. The ground beneath them was trembling. An uncomfortable silence filled the bridge. Prime stared at Entrapta through Hordak’s eyes.

“Stop this! She-Ra must empty the Heart. You will die with everyone else if you interfere,” Hordak cried out to Prime.

Prime ignored him. He pressed Hordak’s hand to a black rectangle on the wall of the bridge. Double doors rose out of the wall, then parted. Hot, dry air wafted into the bridge from outside. Prime smiled a broken grin as he walked toward Entrapta.

“And now,” he announced breathlessly, “you will witness the fruit of your beloved’s failure.”

Prime loomed over her in Hordak’s body. Entrapta planted her feet on the floor, bending her knees slightly. Now was her chance. As a blue hand reached for her, Entrapta swung her mass of bound hair with all her might. The hair struck his torso, knocking Hordak’s body to the floor. Entrapta ran through the bridge and bolted out the double doors. Once outside, she started screaming.

“Help! Horde Prime possessed Hordak! He’s possessed!” she shrieked to her compatriots.

A moment later, Prime sent Hordak’s body out of the doors, sprinting after her. Hundreds of feet away, the princesses and Swift Wind were rushing toward Entrapta. Prime ran toward the adit, awkwardly finding his stride while wearing Hordak flesh and armor. The day-moon’s rays were beating down on the crater. Sand crunched under his feet. The trembling earth gave off a low, continuous groan. The princesses were running in his direction as he charged into the open doors of the adit.

Inside, a long, dim corridor was lined with blue and silver panels. Galactic Common script – First One’s script – was engraved into the panels. The engravings read HEART OF ETHERIA CORE and DANGER and ONEIRO-HAZARD and ENTRY FORBIDDEN.

Prime had only led Hordak’s body a few steps into the corridor when suddenly, the panels glowed blue. The ONEIRO-HAZARD glyphs shined with silver light. A flash of white light followed, and the corridor disappeared.

Hordak found himself back in the throne room of the Velvet Glove. Prime was no longer possessing his body. His head was blissfully clear. Before him, dozens of red-eyed Galactic Horde clones stood at attention. Instead of white uniforms, the clones wore black garments, with crimson Hordes symbol emblazoned on their chests. On the circular balconies surrounding the throne chamber, hundreds of red eyes stared back at him.

Hordak looked down at himself. Instead of Entrapta's exoskeleton, he wore a black and red tabard and robes, not unlike Horde Prime's. In the reflective silver floor, he saw locs of indigo hair hanging from his head, reminiscent of Prime's cables.

Hordak slowly turned, taking in the surreal scene. Horde Prime's empty throne was black and scarlet now. On the floor, in front of the throne, was an animal skin rug made from Catra's hide. Imp was perched on the back of the throne, grinning at him. On either side stood Entrapta and Kadroh. Entrapta wore a form-fitting pink catsuit, with the gear symbol of Dryl emblazoned on the sleeves. Kadroh wore a sleek black tabard and robes. The three watched Hordak expectantly.

A clone stepped out from formation and faced the other soldiers. "Today, we coronate a new emperor!" Pickles proclaimed. "Today, we exalt our liberator! Let us give glory to the render of gossamer threads, the breaker of shackles, the exiled one who returned triumphant! Emperor Hordak Prime!"

A thunderous cheer erupted. The clones howled with joy, applauding their new leader.

"Glory be to Emperor Hordak Prime! Glory be to Empress Entrapta! Glory be to Lord Kadroh, Right Hand of the Emperor! Glory be to Prince Imp, Heir to the Galaxy!" Pickles cried out, smiling broadly.

The cheering continued. The room vibrated with the sound of overjoyed clones. Hordak shivered. A sour taste rose in the back of his throat. He backed away from Pickles.

“No. I don’t want this. I want to topple his empire, not rule it!”

Amidst the cheering, the adoring faces, Hordak shook his head.

“No! I don’t want this!

His ears were ringing. He felt lightheaded. He clenched his fists.

“*NO! I don’t want this!*” he screamed.

The air shattered like glass. The hallucination fell away in pieces, revealing the corridor again. Far away, the princesses were shouting. How long had he been in that dream world? Only a second?

Hordak’s mind swirled with green clouds and lights. “Are you quite finished, Little Brother?” Horde Prime growled through Hordak’s lips.

Prime ran Hordak’s body further down the corridor. The silver walls echoed the sounds of his steps. The floor was littered with glass-like fragments of hard light spiders, smashed battle robots, puddles, and bits of desert shrubs. Along the walls, laser canons had been sliced in half, and computer panels bore hoof-shaped dents.

At the end of the corridor were two elevators. The crystal doors to one of the elevators were closed. The other doors were open, revealing a cylindrical, crystal elevator car inside. Prime steered Hordak’s body into the open elevator, where a control panel on the wall glowed in the dim light.

Hordak cried out in his mind, screaming that this was madness, that the Heart would kill them both. Prime ignored Hordak, ignored the pain, ignored the trembling walls and floor. He pressed Hordak’s fingers to a button on the control panel, and the crystal doors slid closed. Through the transparent doors, Prime and Hordak could see princesses running down the corridor. Glimmer spontaneously materialized in front of the elevator, just as the elevator car descended.

The car plunged down a cylindrical shaft, deep into the earth. The car grew dark as it dropped through rocky layers of Etheria's crust. The air grew uncomfortably warm. The shaft trembled, but did not break, a testament to the First One's sturdy construction. After several minutes, the elevator car came to a halt, and its doors flew open.

Outside the elevator, the air was oppressively hot. The rocky white floor was trembling even more violently than before. Man-sized quartz crystals jutted out from the walls and ground. A dull, monotone roar filled the air.

A massive cavern gaped before them. The white-walled cavern was several miles wide, and too deep to gauge by sight. One hundred feet ahead was shore of a giant subterranean sea that filled the cavern. Instead of water, the sea was made of fluid, iridescent energy. The glow of the energy sea illuminated the cavern. Choppy waves rollicked on the sea's surface. Occasional breakers would slam against the shore, splashing liquid energy everywhere.

Horde Prime was wracked with pain. Hordak's body began to throb with pain. His hair was soaked, and beads of sweat were racing down his face and neck.

"Prime … we'll die here … Turn back," Hordak demanded.

The green clouds and flashing lights in Hordak's head grew more violent. "No … this … this is mine, Little Brother … this weapon is … too magnificent to abandon," Prime muttered, forcing Hordak's body forward.

As Prime steered Hordak's body near the shore, they saw her. A colossal quartz crystal jutted out above the sea. At the tip was a silver monolith, ten feet high, on which glowing First Ones glyphs appeared and disappeared. She-Ra stood before the monolith, holding a teal stone in the air with her left hand.

“Prepare for partial core release!” She-Ra shouted. “One-hundred thousand marzos, evenly across Etheria’s surface!”

“HEART CORE IS CRITICAL. CORE CONTAINMENT FIELD IS UNSTABLE. CORE RELEASE NOT RECOMMENDED,” replied a disembodied feminine voice.

“Administrator override!” She-Ra replied. She turned her head at the sound of footsteps.

Horde Prime stepped closer to the quartz platform. With Hordak’s hand, he picked up a broken chunk of quartz on the ground. He clutched the melon-sized crystal, panting, smiling, delirious with pain. In a nearby crystal cluster, Hordak saw a reflection of his face, desecrated with green sclera, white pupils, and a rictus grin.

“Rejoice … Etheria … for your emperor … has claimed his marvel!” Prime groaned through Hordak’s lips.

She-Ra’s eyes widened. Her mouth dropped open.

Hordak howled in his head. Thoughts of Entrapta, Imp, and Kadroh drowned out his pain. In love, in fury, he swam against the churning green clouds. For a moment, the agony-heavy clouds gave way. Hordak willed his fingers to open. The crystal chunk fell from his hand. Straining against Prime, he seized control of his right arm and curled it toward his clavicle. With a grunt, he tore the First Ones crystal from his exoskeleton.

The exoskeleton sparked. Strength left Hordak’s limbs, and the armor became an oppressive weight on his arms and torso. His knees buckled. He teetered on unsteady legs. Inside his head, Horde Prime was raging, flailing, struggling to pilot his body forward.

In a nearby quartz, he saw his reflection again. One eye had green sclera and a white pupil. The other eye was crimson. Hordak looked up She-Ra.

“DO IT!” he bellowed.

Her expression was one of horror. She turned back to the monolith.

"Initiate partial core release!" she cried.

The ground quaked even more violently. The energy sea heaved, sending waves of fluid magical energy crashing against the shore. A massive wave slammed into a nearby quartz cluster, bathing Hordak's body in raw magical energy. Hordak screamed. Inside his head, Horde Prime screamed. The emerald clouds of Prime's consciousness tore asunder.

A second wave struck the shore. Hordak was again drenched with raw magical energy. He howled. His skin was aflame with pain. He could no longer see. Inside his head, Prime shrieked, again and again. In his mind's eye, Hordak saw the green clouds evaporate, and an oily green and black mass fly apart, until nothing was left.

Blindly, he crawled on the rocky floor of the cavern. He weakly pulled himself along the ground, away from the shore. All was agony.

Then, silence.

# Aftermath

Chapter Summary

> Horde Prime is gone, and the Heart of Etheria has been neutralized. Adora, Hordak, and their allies reflect on everything that just happened. Back at Bright Moon, someone is waiting for Glimmer.
>
> Content warning: abuse, off-screen torture, implied execution.

Chapter Notes

> "Preserves of Raspberry" is a reference to this song, which is a parody of the Wellerman shanty.
>
> EDIT: Minutes after I posted this chapter, I realized that I left out an important detail about the eldritch beings and magic. I have added several lines to the last segment of the chapter.

Silence. Darkness.

Hordak found himself standing in a steel-walled laboratory. Computer panels and metal equipment gleamed wherever he turned. At the back of the room, a ring-shaped portal device towered over him.

Standing in front of him was a tall, lean Battani man, dressed in gray and black protective clothing. His face resembled Horde Prime's, but the man had only two red eyes, devoid of pupils. The man's face was warm and serene, showing no trace of Prime's haughtiness. Instead of gray cables, the man had long white hair that tumbled past his shoulders.

Hordak realized that he must be Annilis. Prime's first host. The clones' true ancestor.

Annilis gently smiled, placing a hand on Hordak's shoulder.

"It's over now."

Silence. Darkness.

Hordak was dimly aware of warmth coursing through his body. The pain burning in every inch of his flesh slowly faded. As the haze lifted from his consciousness, he felt hands on his cheeks. When he opened his eyes, iridescent light shimmered around him. She-Ra was kneeling next to him, cupping his face in her hands. Her face was focused, serene. As his broken body healed, their eyes met.

The iridescent light slowly faded. She-Ra gently removed her hands from Hordak's face and helped him sit up. The ocean of liquid magical energy was gone. The cavern was dim now, illuminated by the faint glow of residual magic in the floor and walls. The air was warm, but no longer suffocatingly hot. The ground was still.

Hordak was no longer near the shore. He now sat at the back of the cavern, next to the two crystal elevator shafts. She-Ra must have carried him there, he realized. Fragments of broken and half-melted armor, bits of fabric, and red puddles formed a line from the shore to the elevators.

His head was quiet. The mental solitude was comforting. Horde Prime was gone, never to return.

He looked down at his body. His exoskeleton was absent. His dress had been reduced to a few burned ribbons hanging off his waist. Jagged vitiligo still covered his arms and shoulders. To his surprise, the gaps between his radius and ulna bones had sealed. The muscle tone in his arms and torso had returned.

The effects of She-Ra's healing were temporary, he would discover later. The cloning flaw would assert itself again months later, when familiar pain and fatigue returned. Galactic Horde tissue regenerators, a reconditioning pod, and supplements would help him treat the condition for many years into the future. But for now, his body was at peace.

Hordak blinked, mouth agape. "You … saved me."

She-Ra nodded.

"Why?"

"You saved me, long ago."

A memory stirred. *Computers registering a spacetime anomaly in the Citrine Grasslands. Racing through the air on a skiff, surrounded by his soldiers. Arriving at the anomaly point, only to find no portal, no evidence of Horde Prime's presence. Rustling in the grass. A small, high-pitched whimper. Finding an anthro infant, wrapped in a blue blanket. Holding the infant as a breeze rippled through the grasses. Tenderness stirring deep within. A tiny pink hand touching his. Both far from home. Both so alone.*

The infant he rescued from the grasslands had saved him. Hordak stared at her in disbelief.

She sighed and closed her eyes. "You, me, Etheria. Power-hungry people wanted to use us all as weapons. I wanted to be something more. Etheria can be something more. You deserve a chance to be something more."

Hordak's right hand was clutching something hard and pointed. He opened his hand. The pink First Ones crystal that once powered his exoskeleton sat in his palm. Entrapta's gift was still intact. The First Ones' script sparkled in the dim light. *Loved*, it read.

"Horde Prime is gone," he said softly. "I watched him die, inside my head."

She-Ra gently smiled at him. “It’s over. It’s finally over,” she whispered.

"Adora ... Thank you."

The crystal elevator doors parted. She-Ra stepped out into the corridor, followed by Hordak, who was holding a fragment of broken exoskeleton over his groin. In a brief flash of light, She-Ra reverted to Adora.

Waiting in the corridor were Swift Wind, Entrapta, and the princesses. Mermista, Perfuma, Frosta, and Glimmer had flushed cheeks, and their hair was damp with sweat. Everyone’s faces lit up when the pair emerged from the elevator.

“Horde Prime is gone forever,” Adora announced. “The Heart of Etheria has been emptied. It’s finally over.”

The group howled with joy. Their cheers echoed through the corridor. Glimmer threw her arms around Adora, planting a kiss on her cheek. Swift Wind pressed his muzzle to Adora’s head. Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta clasped each other in a tight hug. Netossa and Spinnerella embraced and enjoyed a long kiss.

Entrapta collided with Hordak, curling her hair around him. “Hordak!” she shrieked. She wrapped her arms around him and buried her face in his bare chest, wetting it with her tears. He held her tightly with his free arm.

The group laughed, hugged, and kissed for a long time. Spinnerella’s voice interrupted the celebration.

“Why is Hordak naked?”

Everyone except Entrapta and Adora paused, glancing uncomfortably at Hordak. Glimmer vanished, then spontaneously reappeared in a burst of sparkles a minute later, holding a bedsheet.

“It’s a good thing Mara’s ship has cots,” Glimmer said, handing the sheet to Hordak. He wrapped it around himself like a sari.

The group walked to the adit’s entrance. Adora came to a halt. “Can we rest? For a few minutes? I just … need to sit.”

The others agreed. Near the entrance, Adora sat on the floor, reclining on a seated Swift Wind’s back. Glimmer sat beside her. Netossa and Spinnerella held hands, resting their backs against a wall as they sat. Mermista, Perfuma, and Frosta sat against the wall opposite Adora. Hordak and Entrapta sat off to the side.

The princesses chatted breathlessly about what the Heart of Etheria looked like, what happened after Horde Prime descended in the elevator, and the heady rush that pulsed through the Runestone princesses every time the Heart released a global wave of magic. As the princesses talked, Hordak extended his hand to Entrapta, showing her the First Ones crystal in his palm. Entrapta smiled, placing her hand in his. They held hands, with the crystal resting between their palms.

Eventually, the conversations stopped, and the group basked in restful silence. Several princesses closed their eyes and breathed deeply. Eventually, Mermista spoke, gesturing to the blue and silver walls covered with First Ones glyphs.

“So … what did you all see? In there?”

Silence. Frosta stared into space. Glimmer swallowed hard. Everyone’s face wore a different expression: sorrow, shame, longing, fear.

Mermista sighed. “You know what people used to call my dad? Oceanus the Reluctant. He never wanted to be high prince. When the war got too hot, he fled to one of the royal family’s refuge islands with some servants. They’re outfitted with everything. Houses, supplies, boats, everything we’d need if we had to flee Salineas.”

She crossed her legs and leaned forward, clasping her hands. "I saw him. In that illusion. We were together on that island. It was sunset, and I was lounging on the beach. He brought me a margarita and said, "Now isn't this nice?" And it was. I wanted to stay there and just … rest. And not think about the war, or the refugees, or anything."

Mermista paused, lowering her gaze. "But then he started humming a shanty. Preserves of Raspberry. It's Sea Hawk's favorite. And then I remembered that Sea Hawk was on board the Velvet Glove. Risking his life for everyone. For *me*. And I remembered all my other friends were risking their lives too. And I was just … sitting there. I did that before, when Salineas fell. I swore I'd never do it again. I chose to fight."

Everyone was quiet. Mermista was still staring at the floor, but her eyes were intense now.

"I was back at Bright Moon," Glimmer recounted. "Hundreds of people were there. All the princesses too. But everyone was kneeling before me. I looked down, and I was wearing this ostentatious gown that was covered in pearls and diamonds."

Glimmer frowned. Her eyes were wet. "Dad presented me as *Empress* Glimmer, She Who Subdued Etheria. Guards brought out Hordak, Catra, and Shadow Weaver in chains. There was a gallows with three nooses. And then they …" Glimmer trailed off, fighting back tears.

Adora rested a hand on Glimmer's back. "And I screamed that I didn't want this. I didn't want them dead. I didn't want to be a tyrant. And then it all shattered."

Glimmer said no more. She exhaled, exhausted.

"I saw Catra," Adora admitted. "She looked so sad. She said she was sorry for everything. Over and over, she promised that things would be different now. She just wanted to be with me. I wanted to believe her so badly that I agreed."

Adora tilted her head back. "We lived at Bright Moon together. For a few days, we were so happy. But then she got moody. She snapped at me for spending the day with Swift Wind instead of her. She accused me of caring more about Bow and Glimmer than her. And then one day, during an argument, she scratched me."

Glimmer watched Adora with soft eyes as she continued. "She told Bow and Glimmer lies about me. She blamed me for making her angry. We were fighting, and she was about to punch me. She was shouting that I belonged to *her*. I realized that I didn't want to be miserable to make Catra happy. I was more than what I could give to her, or anyone else. I deserved happiness too. I fought back."

Her expression relaxed. Glimmer placed her hand on Adora's arm. Adora turned, smiled softly, and took Glimmer's hand.

Later, Adora, Swift Wind, and the princesses boarded Mara's ship and flew back to Bright Moon. Entrapta and Hordak boarded the Galactic Horde ship and followed close behind. During the flight, Entrapta explained the device that caused everyone's hallucinations.

"The First Ones used psychological weapons extensively," Entrapta told Hordak. "The signal on Beast Island induced despair. Catra told me about a First Ones structure that made her and Adora relive painful memories. That device we found today plunged us into immersive hallucinations of our secret desires. It was supposed to hold us in place so the hard light spiders and robots could attack us."

Entrapta paced around the bridge. "It may have been a test of character too. Only people who could set aside selfish desires could be trusted with the Heart. At least that's my theory."

"The time dilation was unexpected," Hordak added. "My hallucination felt like it lasted several minutes, but only a second had actually passed."

“That’s what it was like for me too. Swift Wind said I froze for two seconds, right after I charged in. It felt like half an hour.”

“What did you see?” Hordak asked. “You need not describe it, if it makes you uneasy.”

Entrapta came to a halt. For several seconds, she was silent. A strand of hair pulled her mask over her face.

“I had built these elaborate torture machines. Everyone who ever hurt me was hooked up to them. Catra. Perfuma. Mermista. An assassin who tried to kill my parents when I was little. This old engineering instructor who talked down to me. Their screams would flow through these shafts and come out of pipes in different pitches. It was like twisted music.”

She lifted her mask. “I shut off the machinery. It was *sick*. I didn’t want to be that kind of person.”

Hordak thought back to his atmospheric modification device, to traitors and would-be assassins whom he sentenced to Beast Island's signal. An uncomfortable emotion stirred within him, something heavy and painful and filthy.

“What about you?” she asked. “What did you see? You don't have to tell me if you don't want to.”

Hordak drew in a deep breath. He told her.

The two ships landed in a grassy clearing near Bright Moon castle. After the two crews came together, they hiked toward the castle. The early evening sky was a riot of colors. The air crackled with unseen energy.

In a field, they found a team of anthro laborers digging pits. In a nearby horse-drawn wagon were chunks of dead biomass. In another horse-drawn wagon sat barrels with “dead wax monster” written in charcoal on their sides.

“It was epic!” one of the anthro men revealed, leaning on his mattock. “The thing was huge! And those two women with swords chased it through the sky, until they killed it!”

“Two women?” Glimmer asked.

“Yeah, the two women with wings,” he answered. “I heard two other monsters fell in the woods. The Horde people and the guards brought them down. What’s left of one is in those barrels. The other one just sort of broke apart and disappeared, I heard.”

Adora and Glimmer shared an alarmed glance. The group marched to the castle at a quicker pace.

Later, as information flooded in from around Etheria, the group would learn that eldritch beings fell from the portal and landed all over Etheria. Some were hostile, and were slain by Rebellion warriors and the occasional band of terrified clones. A few were peaceful, such as a child-sized eyeball creature that landed in the Crimson Wastes. Lllrrpppwwzzzxxff the Unblinking went on to do stand-up comedy at Ramona’s bar, becoming Huntara’s favorite entertainer. Another eldritch being, a faceless spherical creature covered in brown fur, was last seen rolling through Plumeria, complaining about the stench of “party kale”.

The Rebellion realized that different eldritch beings had different sensitivities to magic. Horde Prime was vulnerable to magical energy, as was the rhombus entity that the POWs and Bright Moon guards fought. The moth-people of Elberron reported that a green and black "tadpole" swam through the air into the village, only to split apart and plummet to the ground, dead. Most of the other creatures that fell to Etheria from the portal had no such vulnerabilities, and survived comfortably on the planet's magically-dense surface.

Inside Bright Moon castle, the group approached the doors of the throne room.

“Bring my father, my aunt, and General Juliet to the throne room immediately. They need to be briefed,” Glimmer instructed one of the guards stationed at the door. The guard wore an uncharacteristically awed expression.

“They’re already inside, your Highness,” the guard replied. The two guards opened the throne room doors. Glimmer stood at the threshold of the doors, frozen, staring at something inside the room. Suddenly, Glimmer bolted inside.

As Adora and the others walked in, they were unprepared for what they saw. Glimmer was tightly embracing Queen Angella, sobbing. Angella’s arms were wrapped around Glimmer. Angella’s clothing was dirty and torn, and her hair was disheveled, but she was healthy and bright-eyed. A sword made from chipped black stone sat near her feet. Micah stood beside her, his eyes red and puffy, resting a hand on Angella’s back and Glimmer’s back. Castaspella and the Bright Moon general were standing nearby, beaming.

“Angella!” Adora shouted, running up to her. Soon, Angella was surrounded by overjoyed princesses and an awed horse.

Glimmer let go of her mother and wiped her eyes. Angella rested her hands on Glimmer’s shoulders. “I’ve missed you so much,” the queen said softly. “I’ve missed you all so much,” she told Swift Wind and the princesses, lifting her eyes.

“Angella-Relief-Joy is among her kind again,” came an inhuman voice from behind the queen, like the stridulation of cicadas, or the pounding of heavy rain. The group beheld a woman shaped like Angella, but seemingly made from rose and violet gel. In her left hand was a black stone sword, like Angella’s. Her eyes did not blink. Her lips did not move when she spoke, but rather her voice emanated from her body.

“Who are you?” Adora asked.

“Melog-Curiosity. Melog-Excitement,” the being replied.

“I owe Melog my life,” Angella explained. “They helped me when I was trapped in the realm between worlds. They are a denizen of that world, but they mean you no harm.”

“Melog-Curiosity explores. Tastes emotion, studies consciousness,” Melog told them. “Melog-Excited has a new world to explore now.”

“They’re an empath, and a shape-changer,” Angella told the room. “Please make them feel welcome.”

The creature walked up to Glimmer. “Glimmer-Exhaustion-Joy. Her body brought forth. Angella-Relief-Joy missed you. Described you many times.” Melog’s body softened, melted, and morphed, until they were a pink and purple duplicate of Glimmer.

“There were others. Others who helped me survive,” Angella added. “A clan of Harpies took me in. I think they trusted me because I was winged and humanoid, like them. They were coarse, but loyal and honorable. I regret that I never got to bid my friends farewell.”

The room practically pulsed with joy. As Angella basked in the love of her family and friends, she noticed Entrapta and Hordak standing near the doors. Her smile faded.

“Why is Lord Hordak here? Why is he wearing a bedsheet toga?”

Glimmer warmly smirked. “So much happened while you were away. We have a lot to talk about.”

# Voice

Chapter Summary

> Kadroh and the rest of the team return from the Velvet Glove with clones in tow. At the POW camp, Entrapta and Catra meet for the first time since Entrapta's exile.
>
> Content warning: violence, descriptions of injuries.

Chapter Notes

> I was disgusted at how the season 5 writers handled Entrapta and Catra's reunion. Entrapta cheerfully forgiving Catra after one "I'm sorry" was a sick joke, especially since Catra never made amends for exiling her. Entrapta deserved more. So, I wrote a self-indulgent scene in which Entrapta got to exact some revenge on Catra. To anyone who was ever hurt by a real-life Catra, this is for you.
>
> I also disliked how Entrapta was never allowed to express anger in the series. She experienced so much marginalization and suffering, but the writers never let Entrapta give voice to any anger. I thought it was high time that Entrapta got angry.

Hordak and Entrapta spent the next few hours eating, bathing, and in Hordak's case, being fitted for new clothes by Bright Moon's taylor and shoemaker. Hordak now sat on his cot, decked out in knee-high black boots, a black leather kilt, and a form-fitting black shirt with long sleeves that covered his throat. Entrapta's First Ones crystal sat in a black pouch hanging from a silver cord around his neck.

Sitting next to Hordak was Entrapta. As Entrapta petted Emily with a strand of her hair, she and Hordak held hands. The day's adrenaline slowly gave way to relief.

"For the first time in years, I can stride without armor. I look down at arms that are no longer atrophied. It's ... exhilarating. I am in

Adora's debt," he told Entrapta.

Entrapta squeezed his hand. "When everything calms down, I want to run diagnostics on your new body. To figure out the extent of the healing."

Hordak squeezed her hand in reply. He stared at his forearm, no longer withered. "What if this recovery is only temporary?"

"Then we'll adapt. We'll innovate. Together," she answered. "Whatever happens, I will help you."

Entrapta abruptly let go of his hand and stood up. She pressed her fingers to her right ear, where her earpiece still rested.

"Bow? Yes, I'm safe … I'm not hurt … Back at Bright Moon. Where are you? … Wait, just now?"

She turned to Hordak. "Our team just returned from the Velvet Glove. They're all safe," she chirped. "Bow, hold on. I'm going to put you on speaker. Emily, lock onto my earpiece frequency."

"--them to stay together. Okay, can you still hear me?" Bow asked, his voice now flowing out of Emily's speaker.

"I can."

"We just landed three ships in a field. About a mile from the castle. It's not veiled anymore?"

"No."

"Someone was digging here, it looks like."

"Oh, that's where they buried the wax monster and the tumor-thing with wings. We're pretty sure they're dead, so don't worry."

"...Okay..."

"We need to tell the royals," Entrapta explained, gesturing to Hordak and Emily to follow her. The three walked briskly down

Bright Moon's halls, flanked by two guards, as Entrapta brought Bow and the team up to speed.

"Okay, so Hordak and I are safe. Hordak's not possessed anymore. Horde Prime ran into the Heart of Etheria core, but the magical energies killed him. She-Ra neutralized the Heart, so the planet won't tear itself apart now. The mages at Bright Moon castle performed a spell that closed the portal. Some monsters fell out before that, but the POWs destroyed them. Oh, and Queen Angella is back, and she brought a friend named Melog."

"WHAT? Wait! Slow down!"

After Entrapta explained the situation, the guards outside of Angella's quarters granted them permission to enter. Inside, Angella and Micah were seated on a white silken couch. Glimmer, Castaspella, and Melog, who had assumed the form of Angella again, sat on silken chairs facing them. Angella had bathed and exchanged her tattered garments for flowing white robes. The five turned as Entrapta, Hordak, and Emily marched into the suite. Angella eyed Hordak warily.

"The other team is back on Etheria!" Entrapta announced. "Bow needs to talk to you."

"Angella? Are you there?" came Bow’s voice from Emily.

"Yes. I'm home. Oh Bow, it’s you. I can't wait to see you again," Angella answered warmly.

A gasp came through Emily's speaker. "You're safe! You're really here! Oh wow. Everyone missed you."

Glimmer leaned toward Emily. "Is everyone okay?"

"The team is fine. It's the clones who need help."

Castaspella blinked. "Wait. Clones?"

"We came back with the Velvet Glove's skeleton crew. Fifty clones. We divided them up between three ships. Kadroh, Yudi, and Pickles each piloted a ship back to Etheria."

"When the hive mind came down, they all froze. Then the crying and screaming began," Scorpia recounted through Emily's speaker. "We didn't dare leave them alone up there."

"They're not hostile anymore," Bow insisted. "When Hordak destroyed the hive mind and Prime abandoned them, they fell apart. They're distraught. They need help."

"Fifty soldiers, you counted?" Micah confirmed.

"Fifty liberated slaves," Kadroh clarified.

"Fifty orphans, I'd say," Sea Hawk added. "They were wailing like children who lost their mothers."

"The POW camp doesn't have enough room," Micah pointed out." The refugee camp would be inappropriate. Can you keep them on the ships until we figure out a plan?"

"Bring them to Bright Moon," Angella ordered.

"What!?" Micah replied. Everyone in the room stared at Angella.

"Bow, bring the clones to the rose courtyard," Angella instructed, standing up from the couch. "Deploy twenty guards at the rose courtyard. Tell General Juliet and the princesses to meet me there immediately," she ordered one of the guards assigned to Hordak.

Angella turned to Micah. "From what you and Glimmer told me about the clones, I'm willing to take this chance. Without Horde Prime to give them orders, they'll be too overwhelmed to attack the palace. When they learn that Prime is dead, they'll have no reason to fight anymore. We'll set up an encampment in the rose courtyard for tonight."

Melog rose from their chair. “Angella-Regret, will move among them. Taste their emotions,” Melog stated.

“I must speak to them,” Hordak insisted. “They deserve to know who destroyed the hive mind, and what became of Horde Prime. The sooner they can accept his death, the sooner they can acclimate to freedom.”

Angella hesitated. “I agree,” she finally said.

Minutes later, Entrapta, Hordak, Emily, Melog, Castaspella, Swift Wind, the princesses, and the royal family stood outside on the palace steps, waiting. The night air was warm and dry. Indigo clouds floated across the starry sky, veiling and unveiling Etheria's moons. The Moonstone cast faint light over the water.

"Why the mercy?" Glimmer asked softly.

Angella turned to her daughter, eyes weary. "Their world has come crashing down. I know the pain that comes from having one's world shattered. I felt that pain when the Cherubim perished. I felt it again when I was trapped, and I believed I'd never see you again."

Angella turned back toward the courtyard, gazing into the distance. "The clones were slaves. You described them as such. I will not disregard them, this time."

A breeze wafted over Angella's face. "Years ago, I ignored the plight of the Scorpioni's slaves. It was a distasteful foreign practice, and not my concern, I told myself. But in truth, I was a coward. The slaves’ desperation produced an uprising that gave birth to the Etherian Horde. The war could have been averted if I'd confronted the Scorpioni. I will not be passive again. I will help these freed slaves."

In the pale light of the moons and the Moonstone, they appeared. Bow, Kadroh, and Scorpia stepped onto the courtyard first, with dozens of clones behind them. Imp sat on Kadroh's left shoulder. Yudi, Pickles, Octavia, and Grizzlor, walked alongside the crowd.

Sea Hawk and Cobalt walked behind the group. Double Trouble slowly weaved between the clones, gently singing a romantic ballad about moonlight and strange shores. Kadroh, Yudi, and Pickles each carried a white backpack over his shoulder. The clones had heavy eyelids, and their faces wore a range of expressions: exhaustion, quiet fear, bitterness, solemn contemplation.

Glimmer and Adora threw their arms around Bow. Bow hugged them back.

"We did it," Adora whispered.

"It's over," Glimmer said softly.

As the two women led Bow to Angella, Scorpia swept Entrapta up in a hug. Entrapta's hair coiled around her. Emily trotted around the two, beeping.

"You're okay!" Scorpia cried out.

"Sure am! I'm glad you're back!" Entrapta shouted.

With a shriek, Imp sprang off of Kadroh's shoulder and flew at Hordak. A moment later, Imp's arms were wrapped around Hordak's neck. Hordak supported the boy with his left arm and stroked his head with his right hand.

"(There you are! You're okay!)" Imp replayed in Entrapta's voice.

"You're safe. Thank you for saving me," Hordak told the child.

Kadroh approached the father and child. "Brother! Your eyes! You're whole again!"

Imp flew off to greet Entrapta. Hordak walked toward Kadroh. "Horde Prime is gone. The energies of the Heart tore him asunder. I watched him perish in my mind."

"Then today is the day of our liberation!"

"Yes ... We're free."

Kadroh exhaled loudly, and his eyes sparkled. "Brother Scorpia demonstrated the custom of hugging to me. May I engage in a hug with you?"

Hordak sighed. "Very well."

Kadroh clasped Hordak in a tight embrace. After a moment, Hordak hesitantly wrapped his arms around Kadroh.

"He … can steal no more from us, ever again," Hordak said. Kadroh hugged him tighter.

After a moment, Kadroh stepped back. "I wish for you to meet someone," Kadroh urged him. "Brother Pickles and Brother Yudi were marching alongside him."

The rejoicing Etherians had suddenly grown quiet. All eyes were on the front of the crowd. Mermista had pulled away from Sea Hawk's embrace and was staring at a man being led to the front by Yudi and Pickles. Sea Hawk muttered something to her, and her eyebrows arched.

A man walked forward wearing torn white robes, with white hair and loc-like gray cables attached to his head. His four eyes were now scarlet, with vertical black pupils. Instead of Horde Prime's regal bearing, this man carried himself with uncertainty. Instead of Horde Prime's haughty expression, this man's face wore bewilderment. Hordak realized he was looking at Horde Prime's abandoned vessel, whom Prime had left behind when he possessed him. The clone’s consciousness, suppressed by Prime’s presence, was now in control of the body again.

Glimmer and Micah approached the man and spoke to him quietly. The former vessel stared at them blankly, struggling to form words. Pickles murmured something to the royals, and Micah nodded. Glimmer smiled and gently placed a hand on the former vessel's arm, whispering.

Kadroh led Hordak to the freed vessel. When the vessel laid eyes on Hordak, he let out a gasp, followed by a whimper. He took a step backwards, away from Hordak.

“I mean you no harm,” Hordak stated. “My opponent was Horde Prime, not you.”

The freed vessel stood still, eyes darting over Hordak’s face and body.

“Your flesh is your own now. You are free. Prime can never use us as steeds again,” Hordak solemnly assured him.

The guards pounded the ground with the shafts of their spears three times. Everyone’s attention was now on Angella, who stood at the top of the stairs.

“I am Queen Angella of Bright Moon, and I offer you sanctuary,” she called out to the clones. “The Kingdom of Bright Moon extends its hospitality to you. So long as you remain peaceful, you are welcome to take refuge here, outside the palace.”

Angella glanced at Hordak and nodded. Hordak climbed the stairs and stared out at dozens of glowing red eyes. On those faces, he saw uncertainty, pain, despair. Once, when his ship had crashed near Tip-of-the-Stinger, those emotions coursed through him too. A breeze ruffled his hair. He inhaled deeply.

“Horde Prime is dead,” Hordak proclaimed. The dozens of red eyes widened almost simultaneously. “I used the Chalice to destroy the hive mind, and Prime possessed my body soon after. After made his way to the Heart of Etheria core, he was killed by the magical energies present there. He was not an eternal god. He was a mortal being.”

A palpable tremble shook the crowd. “Today, we are finally free,” Hordak continued. “Horde Prime stole innumerable treasures from us: our bodily autonomy, our minds, our heritage, our species’ many gifts. Never again can he steal from us. Our liberation begins now—"

Hordak stopped as wails escaped the throats of his brethren. Soon, dozens of clones were screaming, weeping, clutching their heads. A handful fell to the ground, where they curled up in fetal position or buried their faces in their arms. The din echoed off the walls of the palace complex.

Angella's mouth was slightly open. She stared out at dozens of screaming, crying men, wide-eyed. Hordak could not read her expression. Surprise? Alarm? Heartache?

Kadroh was shouting something at Yudi and Pickles, who vigorously nodded at him. The three men stood at the front of the crowd, inhaled deeply, and began to howl.

"AAAAAAAHHHHHHHHH ... I weeeeeeep, oh skies, oh lands ... Wail with me for my brotheerrsss ... Moons, bear witnesss ... AAAAHHHHH!"

The lament song. Kadroh had dreamed of Battani lament songs, a gift from their ancestral memory. Kadroh must have taught his own lament songs to Yudi and Pickles, Hordak realized.

The three men howled into the night, ears flattened, eyes closed. Soon, some of the skeleton crew clones were wail-singing with them. Grief was transmuted into song. More clones joined. Melog morphed into a pink and violet copy of a clone and circled the crowd, throwing back their head and stretching their mouth open in mimicry of the mourners.

The air shook with men's howl-songs. The light of the Moonstone glistened on tear-soaked faces. Hordak gazed out at his brethren, and realized that his herculean work had just begun.

Most of Bright Moon's tents had been dispatched to the refugee camp, the POW camp, and various Rebellion outposts. The clones would have to sleep under the open sky for the night. The palace

storerooms had a few dozen cots to spare, but not enough. As castle staff carried cots out to the rose courtyard, others scrambled to find substitute beds for the clones and their sitters. Couches and ornate rugs festooned with cushions appeared alongside the cots.

Adora and Glimmer were carrying Adora's bed out to the courtyard. "Glimmer said I could bunk with her until we find a place for the clones," she told Micah when asked about it.

Two palace staffers were carrying out Shadow Weaver's couch, which Double Trouble claimed. "It's too small for a clone anyway," they reasoned, taking off their boots. "Besides, I'd like to sleep out here tonight. I can greet everyone with a rousing song in the morning." Soon, the shapeshifter was stretched out on the couch, fast asleep.

Frosta was saying something slowly and gently to the abandoned vessel. Netossa and Spinnerella offered reassuring words to a pair of trembling clones. A hibiscus unfolded in Perfuma's palms, and she handed it to a clone sitting on the ground. Melog, still shaped like a Galactic Horde soldier, sat beside a clone, staring at the stars with him, saying nothing.

Hordak and Kadroh requested that their cots be brought outside, so that they could sleep alongside their brothers. The two clones sat on their respective cots, looking out at clones who were sniffling, staring blankly into the sky, or sleeping. Imp and Entrapta sat on either side of Hordak. Emily was resting on the ground nearby. Imp's bassinette sat next to Hordak's cot. A pair of guards stood guard a few feet away, eyes fixed on Hordak.

Three white backpacks sat next to Kadroh's cot. He reached into one of the backpacks, pulled out a vial of liquid rations, and swallowed the green fluid in one gulp. Imp was leaning against Hordak and wolfing down a bundle of green grapes.

"An idea came to me," Entrapta said softly. "Crypto Castle has so much space. If I disabled the traps, and we set up cots inside,

there would be plenty of room for these clones.”

“I approve! Our brothers should have shelter,” Kadroh replied.

“What about food?” Hordak asked.

“The storerooms have plenty of nonperishable food. The question is, will the clones eat it? We’ll have to acclimate them to solid food,” she explained. “We can start with canned and dried fruit.”

Entrapta stood up. “I’m exhausted. I’m heading to my tent. I’ll talk to the royals in the morning about relocating the clones,” she assured the others. “Imp, why don’t you stay in my tent tonight? It’s quiet there.”

Imp squeaked, tossed aside the denuded grape stem, and hopped in the bassinette. Entrapta placed a hand on Hordak’s shoulder and kissed him on the cheek. A shiver raced through him. Entrapta walked back to the rhododendron courtyard, carrying Imp’s bassinette with her hair. Emily followed behind her.

Hordak watched the three depart. He then turned to Kadroh. "What happened? On board the ship?"

Kadroh placed the empty rations vial back in the backpack. "After Horde Prime spirited you away with Brother Entrapta, I was disoriented. Several minutes passed before I had enough clarity to summon Brother Bow over the earpiece. He aided me--"

Kadroh went silent. After a moment of hesitation, he spoke again.

"The day was so intense, Brother. My words would fail to capture the experience. I could show you through the jeweled-mind-link."

"You wish to link minds? After a day like this?"

Kadroh's eyes pleaded. "May I link with you? To show you what unfolded? To grasp what you endured?" Kadroh folded his hands together tightly, as if struggling to find words. “I want you to show me Horde Prime’s death.”

“What?”

“I need to behold the moment he perished. My heart must understand, with absolute certainty, that he is gone forever.”

Hordak contemplated the request. "What happened was nightmarish. Are you prepared to take in what I experienced?"

"I need to, Brother."

Kadroh and Hordak rose from their cots. Standing inches apart, each man pressed his right hand to the other's head and closed his eyes. Kadroh’s consciousness poured into Hordak’s mind, golden and bright. Waves of emotion – exhilaration, alarm, exhaustion, resolve – washed over his thoughts. Images, sensations, and sounds flooded his mind’s eye.

*Soreness in his neck port. Leaning on Bow as he shambled through sterile hallways. Imp running along beside them.*

*Prime’s throne room. Pickles hovering over a computer panel. Dozens of clones, some dazed, some weeping, some nervously pacing and clutching themselves, one ranting at the "infidels" and the "red-eyed traitors". Scorpia, Octavia, and Double Trouble watching them, at a loss. Yudi, Sea Hawk, Grizzlor, and Cobalt filing into the throne room with more sobbing clones. Grizzlor cheering, “The son of a bitch did it!”*

*Telling the others what he saw. Eyes widening. Gasps. Scorpia covering her mouth with her claws. Octavia shouting an obscenity. Wearily activating the hologram program. The broadcast. Yudi and Pickles both hovering over a computer panel, frantically tapping keys.*

*The beam of light from Etheria, piercing the portal on the giant screen. The portal shrinking. Everyone sighing with relief. Sitting on the throne, finding his bearings. Imp sitting on his lap, patting his hand.*

*Yudi and Pickles tending to the clones. "We can no longer sense his holy presence!" whimpered a clone. "Why did Prime abandon us?" one asked. "Were we imperfect in his eyes?" asked another. "Did we displease him?" asked yet another. "He abandoned us. Nothing remains for us!" wept one clone.*

*Scorpia singing a gentle song about nightfall, closing one's eyes, resting tonight. The clones staring at her. Some puzzled. Some shaken but spellbound. "It's like they've never heard music," Octavia remarking to Cobalt. "My nanny Ursula sang that to me when I was little," Scorpia telling the others. "My mama used to sing that to me too," Grizzlor replying. Scorpia and Grizzlor singing the lullaby again.*

*Etheria faintly glowing with brief flashes of light, once a minute. Twenty flashes. Time passing. Watching the screen. Stillness. Etheria was still whole. She-Ra had succeeded.*

*Plans among the team. Plans to fly. Plans to take liquid rations and medical equipment. Plans to take the clones.*

*Sea Hawk singing shanties to the clones. Double Trouble singing flamboyant showtunes to the clones. The clones, distraught and wet-eyed but rapt. "I've never performed for such an appreciative audience!" Double Trouble gushing.*

*Kadroh's memories rippled. Time jumped. The launch bay. Yudi, sneering, flashing his fangs, his eyes bright. "I wish for our brothers to thrive," Yudi admitting, "to spite Prime. To prove to Prime that we can prosper without him. Each brother who flourishes is another fleck of spittle in Prime's face."*

*"We will demonstrate oharada to our brothers," Kadroh assuring him. "Family loyalty. We will tend to them as they blossom."*

*Worry. Worry for Hordak, for Entrapta, for the many brothers.*

He felt Kadroh's mild yielding. Space opened between them in the mind-link, as if Kadroh was saying, "Your turn."

Hordak called forth the day's painful memories. Slowly, he poured them into Kadroh's mind. *Horror, terror, pain, hallucinations, a final desperate decision. The agony of being drenched in raw magical energy. Horde Prime screaming inside his head. An oily black and green mass, tearing apart. Silence. Annilis. She-Ra. Healing. Reunion. Relief. Waves and waves of relief.*

Slowly, the two men removed their hands from each other's faces. They opened their eyes.

"Now," Kadroh said solemnly, "*now,* it is over."

The next morning, Double Trouble crooned a jazzy tune at sunrise. The chameleon slowly wove between the cots, couches, and rugs, serenading the clones as they rose.

*I don't think I've ever seen a day*
*Quite this magnificent*
*Ever seen a sunrise*
*Quite this gold and red*

*We could cast aside these bedsheets*
*Run out to greet the sky*
*Or stay here in the blankets*
*And keep each other warm*

Hordak passed out vials of liquid rations from the three backpacks that his brothers had brought with them. Castle staff brought water and fruit to Hordak, Kadroh, Yudi, and Pickles, who circulated among the clones. Their presence, and Double Trouble's singing, seemed to steady the clones.

A group of clones had gathered around Hordak, asking questions about Etheria, names, purpose, and the future. "What function do we serve now?" one clone asked, half of Hordak and half of himself. "What *are* we now?"

“We are *worthy*,” Hordak replied.

Entrapta met with Angella, Micah, Glimmer, and Castaspella. The royals consented to her plan to house clones in Crypto Castle. Plans for transport and provisions took shape.

Over the next twelve hours, Rebellion soldiers slowly reported back to their commanders. Many brought along heartbroken clones as prisoners, whom they had found in Bright Moon's environs. The clone camp in the rose courtyard grew.

Information poured in from data pads around the planet. Rebellion forces were rapidly reclaiming territory in the Runestone-holding kingdoms, taking hundreds of clones captive. Puzzled insurgents reported that the Galactic Horde soldiers they'd been fighting suddenly turned into sobbing, shell-shocked wrecks. Bright Moon insisted that the clones be treated humanely, reminding allies that the clones were brainwashed slaves in need of rehabilitation, not punishment.

Kadroh, Yudi, and Pickles, escorted by Netossa, Perfuma, and Frosta, hiked back to the three Galactic Horde spacecraft with their now empty backpacks. The group returned with backpacks stuffed with medical technology. Galactic Horde tissue regenerators. Diagnostic and imaging devices. Small tanks for cloning organs. Antibiotics. The day before, the three clones took medical devices out of the Velvet Glove's infirmary/nursery bay, in the hopes of helping any clones injured in the fighting on Etheria.

Upon returning to the rose courtyard and conferring with Hordak, they sought an audience with the royals. The four clones asked for access to any of their brothers who had been injured. As a gesture of gratitude, they would also share their advanced medical technology with the Rebellion, to heal injured Rebellion warriors and Etherian Horde POWs. The royals agreed, as several guards, Rebellion fighters, and POWs had been injured fighting the eldritch abominations. She-Ra and the Mystacore mages were using healing magic for the worst cases, but any help was welcome.

Yudi and Pickles returned to the rose courtyard to watch over their brothers. Spinnerella accompanied Kadroh to a makeshift infirmary in Bright Moon's lower levels, where he taught medics how to use the new technology.

Hordak, meanwhile, walked with guards to the POW camp. Entrapta and Scorpia accompanied him, the former so she could learn about Galactic Horde medical technology, and the latter so she could help the Horde POWs. Angella and Micah were touring the Bright Moon infirmary and the refugee camp, and would tour the POW camp later to check on his progress.

At the POW camp, ex-Horde soldiers scowled at Hordak. As he bore their hateful looks, Hordak felt something stir inside. Dissatisfaction with having failed them. A gnawing impulse pushing him forward into the POW camp.

In the infirmary tent, Hordak met with ex-Horde medics. Entrapta, the lynx woman, the raptor woman, two anthos, and a reptilian man listened intently as Hordak explained how to calibrate the diagnostic tools, how to load species genome information into the tissue regenerators, and how to clone individual organs in the pitcher-sized tanks.

Soon, the injured arrived. Scorpia, Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle carried their injured comrades from their tents to the infirmary on stretchers, or escorted the ones who could walk. Hours later, the injured POWs left the infirmary with their lacerations healed, their broken bones mended, and missing fingers and ears restored.

Scorpia chatted with her old friends as they worked, swapping stories of all their adventures over the past two weeks. The POWs she assisted were not offended by her presence.

"I thought the others would be mad at me. You know, for leaving," Scorpia confessed.

"You’re a cinnamon roll. It's impossible to be mad at you," Kyle assured her.

“You’re also the least of their worries,” Lonnie reminded her.

Once the most severe cases had been treated, Hordak used the cloning tanks to create a new eyeball for Octavia. "You deserve this, after your courage yesterday," he told her. Octavia emerged from the infirmary tent with two eyes, her eyepatch gone. The sea elf's gaze floated over tents, trees, and people, drinking in all the depth and clarity she now saw.

"I forgot how everything used to look," Octavia said with a wide smile. "It's ... it's great."

Hordak, Entrapta, and the medics took a much-needed break. When Hordak and Entrapta stepped outside the tent, they noticed Lonnie, Rogelio, and Kyle focusing on something in the distance.

“About time,” Lonnie muttered.

About fifty feet away, Scorpia was speaking with Catra. The cat-woman's right wrist and right elbow were bandaged. Hordak was too far away to make out their words, but Scorpia's posture was stern. Catra said something, but Scorpia shook her head. Catra spoke more insistently, but Scorpia shook her head again.

Scorpia noticed that Hordak and Entrapta had emerged. She pointed a claw at Entrapta, speaking slowly and firmly to Catra. The cat-woman's ears flattened. Scorpia pointed more emphatically, speaking again. Slowly, Catra turned around and stiffly walked toward the infirmary tent. Scorpia followed close behind.

"Entrapta, Catra has something to say to you," Scorpia called out as they approached.

Catra now stood in front of Entrapta. Entrapta’s body was rigid. Her hair bristled.

“I’m sorry,” Catra said flatly.

Entrapta remained still, saying nothing. Her hair was still bristled, but the ends of her twin-tails were twitching.

“Can I get my arm fixed?” Catra asked. “That creature—”

A hair fist sent Catra and several of her teeth flying through the air. A second later, Catra was prone on the ground. Entrapta sat on her, coiling her hair around Catra’s wrists. A gloved fist slammed into Catra's face. The cat-woman roared, straining against the hair-tendrils holding her wrists. Entrapta punched her jaw again. And again. And again.

"No! Stop! This isn't what I wanted!" Scorpia shouted. Scorpia held her claws to her face. Kyle cringed. Rogelio grunted dismissively. Lonnie sneered. Hordak smirked. No one intervened.

*Thud. Thud. Thud.* Entrapta’s blows rained down on Catra’s face. Catra howled with rage, only to be met with more punches.

Four guards sprinted toward the brawl. By the time they reached Entrapta, Catra’s face was a bloody mess. The guards struggled to hold Entrapta’s swinging arms and hair-tendrils, but eventually, they peeled her off the cat-woman. Catra remained on the ground, groaning.

The noise had attracted attention. Several ex-Horde soldiers had emerged from their tents to see the commotion. Angella, Micah, and their entourage of guards, who had been touring the POW camp, soon appeared.

“We heard screaming. What’s going on?” Micah demanded to know.

“Entrapta attacked Catra,” one of the guards replied, clutching Entrapta’s left arm.

Angella stared at Catra impassively, then glanced at her husband.

"The Catra who opened the portal," Angella recalled.

"Mmm-hmm. The Catra who sent Entrapta to Beast Island," Micah reminded her.

"What action should be taken, Your Highness?" inquired the guard holding Entrapta's right arm.

"Take no action," Angella answered.

"Your Highness?"

"Entrapta gets this as a freebie," Micah explained.

The four guards released Entrapta. One of the anthro medics was slowly helping Catra to her feet. Entrapta seemed dazed, then alarmed.

“I … need to go … back to the courtyard …” Entrapta mumbled haltingly, before turning away and running out of the camp.

“Entrapta! Wait!” Scorpia called out, running toward Entrapta. “Talk to me!”

“Scorpia!” Hordak shouted. The scorpion-woman stopped and turned. “I need to finish a few tasks here, but I will join you and Entrapta soon. Please tell her I’m coming.”

“I will!” Scorpia assured him, jogging after Entrapta.

Minutes later, Catra was sitting on a cot in the infirmary tent. Medics had wiped most of the blood off her face. Several of her teeth were missing, and her jaw was swollen and asymmetrical.

"I shaid I wass shorry to urr an efferyfing! Wipe dhat shmurkh off your faish, Hordakh!"

Hordak did not wipe the smirk off his face.

"Guuuh! Juss hurry upf! Oww."

Hordak tapped the screen of the tissue regenerator. On a nearby table sat the cloning tank, in which feline teeth were slowly forming.

"Be patient, Catra. It's vital that I upload your genome information slowly and thoroughly. If even one line of genetic information is off, the regenerator could give you an oversized lantern jaw. Unless you would like an oversized lantern jaw, in which case—"

"OKHAY!"

After he repaired Catra's broken jaw and injured arm, he informed the lynx medic that her new teeth were ready for implantation. Hordak and two guards left for the castle complex.

The day-moon was setting, and the sky was streaked with red, orange, and purple. As Hordak and the guards approached the rhododendron courtyard, they heard two women screaming. "Entrapta?" he cried out, running toward the courtyard. The guards ran after him.

When he and the guards reached Entrapta's two tents, they found Entrapta screaming at the sky. Her eyes were tightly shut, and her flushed face was contorted with pain. She held her arms out to her side, with her fingers spread wide. Her twintails bristled. Her mask was on the ground, near her feet.

Melog, who had assumed Entrapta's shape, stood in front of her. The shape-changer threw their head back and opened their mouth wide, emitting high-pitched calls from their body. Entrapta and Melog screamed upward, over and over.

Scorpia was sitting on the ground next to Emily, watching Entrapta with a pained expression. Kadroh was standing off to the side, his face unsure.

"I wished to question Brother Entrapta about Crypto Castle. I came upon her like this," Kadroh explained to Hordak.

Entrapta and Melog stopped screaming. Entrapta lowered her head, panting. She opened her eyes and stared at her hands.

"I just … couldn't hold it in any longer," Entrapta said hoarsely.

"Entrapta-Rage needed eruption. Entrapta-Pain now has catharsis," Melog observed.

Scorpia stood up. "Entrapta, do you feel better?"

Entrapta sighed. "I feel … raw. And still angry. But I think … I feel better."

"I'm sorry. I should have known better than to bring over Catra."

"Maybe it's good that you did," Entrapta countered. "She deserved it."

"I mean, you're not wrong."

Entrapta turned to Scorpia. "I had so much anger. Toward Catra, all this time. It was always tormenting me inside. But I had to stuff it down because there was one crisis after another." Entrapta looked away. "And sometimes I'm still angry at you, for letting Catra do it. And at Hordak, for believing Catra's lies."

Scorpia sighed. "You have every right to be."

Melog took a step closer. "Anger and love, alongside."

"But I still care about both of you," Entrapta reminded them. "You still did the right thing. You told the Rebellion where I was so they could rescue me. And Hordak, he … Catra can be persuasive. I believed her lies too, once."

"Entrapta," Hordak breathed. "I was a fool to believe her. I thought I was unworthy of your warmth, so of course you would have left me. I should have never doubted your loyalty."

Scorpia extended her claws. "Hug?"

Entrapta closed her eyes and sank into her hug, exhausted. When she opened her eyes, her gaze wandered over Hordak, Kadroh, Melog, and now Micah, who was walking down the courtyard with two guards behind him.

"Is everything okay?" Micah asked when he reached the group. "After what happened, I was worried."

"I'm okay now," Entrapta said. She held Hordak's gaze, and her eyes softened. He smiled gently at her.

As Entrapta slowly stepped back from Scorpia's hug, Hordak turned his head, studying Scorpia, then Melog, then Kadroh, then Micah. They seemed to care about Entrapta. This realization, that others recognized Entrapta's worth too, gave him comfort.

# Dryl

Chapter Summary

> Entrapta, Hordak, Kadroh, and Imp take up residence in Dryl, where they rehabilitate dozens of clones. Elsewhere, Rebellion leaders assist the refugees and clones. The arrival of war crimes investigators reminds Hordak that the Rebellion has neither forgiven nor forgotten his conquests.

Chapter Notes

> In the series proper, viewers only see soldiers living in the Fright Zone. I refuse to believe that the Etherian Horde could have functioned without thousands of support staff to manufacture their equipment, procure their food, and maintain the Fright Zone. Thus, I included some lines about the thousands of noncombatants who remained in the Fright Zone after the catastrophic march on Bright Moon.
>
> Everyone likes Scorpia, so she talks to all the princesses, and thus she has the best princess gossip.

The magical glyph on the back of Hordak's left hand glowed blue in low light. As a condition of Hordak's release, Micah insisted that he be temporarily marked with an *ot-qayin*. The magical brand allowing any mage on Etheria to scry his location by performing incantations and magical gestures over still water. The *ot-qayin* would also signify to other mages that Hordak was potentially dangerous and should be watched closely.

"I am releasing you into Entrapta's custody, pending your war crimes tribunal," Angella decreed. "This is a *privilege* I am granting on account of your service to the Rebellion. I can revoke the privilege at any time, should your actions warrant it."

“I’ll be scrying your location daily,” Micah added. “Wherever you go, we’ll know.”

Hours later, Hordak was piloting a Galactic Horde spacecraft to Dryl, with Entrapta, Imp, Emily, and about thirty clones packed into the bridge and sleeping quarters. Kadroh followed in a second spacecraft with the rest of the Velvet Glove's skeleton crew. Soon, Crypto Castle would become a clone sanctuary.

Entrapta had disabled the castle's traps and fastened maps of the castle to the walls of all the hallways. Pink and purple tape on the floor marked paths to the banquet hall, bathrooms, and exits. Servant-robots assisted with food preparation and laundry. Eventually, Entrapta hired kitchen staffers – a stout athro man and two goat-women from nearby Geartown – to prepare meals for everyone.

Under the guidance of Hordak, Kadroh, and Entrapta, the weary clones slowly acclimated to freedom. Their first days in Dryl were a whirlwind of new experiences: dried figs, canned peaches, seltzer water, hot baths, cat paintings, and soft blankets at night. Luxuries once reserved for Horde Prime were now commonplace. Some clones reveled in the new sensations, while others lamented that they were unworthy of such indulgences. One clone decried Dryl for its "decadence", so unlike the asceticism of Galactic Horde life.

Hordak stood up and loomed over the seated clone. "*Prime is dead*, and so is life in the Galactic Horde," he growled. "Entrapta has extended hospitality to you, and you *will* show her gratitude."

"(Show her gratitude!)" Imp repeated from the rafters.

The clone never railed against Dryl's "decadence" again. Eventually, all of the clones were persuaded to eat, bathe, and sleep on cots with pillows and blankets.

When the clones closed their eyes, they saw their brothers as blazing spheres, leading several to panic. Hordak and Kadroh taught them about the jeweled-mind-link, about touch-telepathy among their kind, about the Battani ancestral memory.

"We never knew we were capable of this. Why did Prime suppress our gifts?" asked a devastated clone.

"To dominate you," Hordak answered. "To take away your power."

"To prevent you from bonding with your brothers," Kadroh added. "So that you would love him alone."

"No," barked another clone, baring his fangs. "They're deceiving us. Prime would not lower himself to duplicity. It's some kind of Etherian sorcery."

Hordak grunted. "Out there, light years from here, are planets with our Battani brethren," he said, pointing upward. "Kadroh and I have met them. Someday, you may meet them as well. They wield these abilities as a matter of birthright, as do we. No Etherian magic is involved."

Slowly, hesitantly, the clones tested their gifts. In a quiet hallway, or a rocky clearing outside of the castle, Hordak would often see two clones seated together, eyes closed, each resting a hand on the other's head.

The clones' days were filled with hikes through the mountainous environs of Crypto Castle, long conversations, and light chores. Several clones worked alongside Hordak and Entrapta, performing maintenance on the Galactic Horde spacecraft together. The tiny scientist always asked them questions and delighted in their answers. *How does the ship's neural integration work? How do you safely contain the microscale singularity core? Where did the Galactic Horde find enough carrefourium for all the portal drives?* Her cheerfulness and curiosity soon endeared her to her guests.

Many afternoons, clones could be found sitting around Hordak near the cliffs overlooking the valley below. As they basked in the sunshine and breeze, they asked him existential questions: how one makes choices, how one chooses a path in life, how one finds worth outside of Prime's blessed light.

“There is no worth to find. We’re already worthy,” Hordak assured them.

Many evenings, a group of clones would sit around Kadroh on the battlements of the castle, listening intently or having lively conversations long into the night. Kadroh shared the ideas he learned from Swift Wind, such as liberty, self-determination, and revolution, ideas which astonished the clones.

Imp had never looked so happy, Hordak realized. The clones marveled at their tiny brother, and he basked in all the cheek-rubs and laps to sit on. Crypto Castle and the wilderness around it offered him endless nooks to explore. When Imp sat on Hordak’s shoulder, he could feel new energy in the child’s movements.

The clones, forced into bland uniformity for so long, now reveled in their differences. The colors of their new garments. The foods they liked. Whether they found the most joy in harvesting edible mushrooms and plants from the mountains, working with technology, or singing the songs that Double Trouble had crooned to them after their liberation. Two clones begged the kitchen staff to let them watch the cooking and baking, asking them endless questions. The two clones eventually joined the kitchen crew themselves, earning the same wages from Entrapta as the Etherian cooks.

One by one, the clones chose names. A sight that struck them as a beautiful, or a sensation that stirred a powerful feeling were the most popular name choices. Falcon. Stillness. Day-Moon-Rising. Breeze-Through-My-Hair. Others chose abstract concepts as their names. Awe. Melancholy. Journey. One of the clones on the kitchen staff named himself Yeast, after “the most exalted smell in the universe.”

Prime’s abandoned vessel said nothing for several days. The other clones were at a loss as to how to approach him.

“Prime’s holy vessels were always honored with the Rite of Outpouring, but the rite is no more,” one clone said at breakfast. “What is his place now?”

“His place is among us!” Kadroh replied.

When served food, the abandoned vessel stared at his plate for several seconds, then ate, his face expressionless. When taylors from nearby Geartown delivered garments, he silently acquiesced when Kadroh helped him put on new clothes to replace Prime’s torn garments.

Once, Kadroh found him staring at his hands, slowly flexing and unflexing his fingers. Another time, Hordak found him pacing up and down a hallway, intently looking down at his feet. Then, when Entrapta was running a scan on his tendrils to understand how they interfaced with his nervous system, he finally spoke.

“When Horde Prime … flooded me … I sank bank … into my head. And I watched … everything he did.”

Entrapta’s hands and hair stilled themselves. She fixed her gaze on the abandoned vessel.

“He moved. I was … pushed aside. I forgot myself … like a sleeper, dreaming. But now ... I am … awake.”

Entrapta touched a strand of hair to his hand.

“I am. Awake,” he repeated. Awake was the master of his own body again.

Entrapta’s bed was large and warm, and Hordak accepted her invitation to sleep there. She taught him new delights: how to hold and be held, how to melt into kisses, how to fall asleep in anothers embrace.

Sometimes the night brought rest, more serene than any Hordak had ever known. No crisis menaced him. No danger threatened his loved ones. He slipped into dark and dreamless sleep.

Sometimes, however, the night brought nightmares. A dream about Horde Prime possessing his body, rampaging through Crypto Castle. A dream about his arms and legs withering until they were desiccated sticks. A dream about sailing to Beast Island, only to find shreds of pink clothing and bones on the shore.

His eyes would fly open. Chills raced down his back as his heart pounded. To his relief, he would always find himself cocooned in blankets, pressed against Entrapta. Her skin was warm against his, and the scent of her hair comforted him. His heart would slow, his eyes would close, and he would sink back into the restful darkness.

One night, Hordak was awakened by Entrapta's trembling limbs. She held herself tightly against him.

Hordak opened his eyes, gazing at her outline. "A nightmare?"

Entrapta nodded. "I didn't mean to wake you."

"What was it about?" he murmured softly.

"They came for you," she whispered. "The princesses. Perfuma bound you up in vines. They were all shouting that you belonged in a dungeon. They dragged you away, and I couldn't stop them."

Hordak wrapped an arm around her. He pressed his lips to her head and held her close to his chest. His *ot-qayin* faintly glowed in the darkness. They would come for him someday, demanding a tribunal. But not this night.

The other princesses had since returned to their kingdoms, where

they hunted down the remaining battle robots and rehabilitated the clones stationed there before Prime's defeat. The royals and their allies communicated via data pads provided by Bow and Entrapta. Many evenings before bedtime, Entrapta would sit cross-legged on her bed, clad in pink pajamas, watching recorded messages sent out to the major kingdoms, or chatting with a Rebellion member. Hordak would lounge beside her, unwinding.

"Soldiers haven't found any robots or clone stragglers in Bright Moon for five days. We decided it was safe for the refugees to go home," Glimmer revealed in a recorded video. "The refugee camp near the castle is now vacant."

"The clones who were guarding the Heart Blossom were so upset when I arrived. But our yoga regimen and drumming circle is restoring their inner balance," Perfuma explained in another recording.

"Can you believe it? Queen Angella chose my dads to be her royal historians!" Bow announced to Entrapta through the screen one night. "She wants them to document the war in the Great Lunar Record."

"I thought I'd check in," Adora said through the screen another night. "Is everything going okay with the clones? And you and Hordak?"

Scorpia was Entrapta's favorite conversation partner, and they talked over their data pads at least twice a week. Scorpia was a font of princess news: how Glimmer and Adora had started dating, how Mermista and Sea Hawk had gotten back together, and how Yudi and Pickles had become Frosta's favorite sparring partners.

Scorpia had returned to the Fright Zone with Octavia, Grizzlor, and Cobalt after the four were granted amnesty, Hordak overheard. After the troops left for the catastrophic march on Bright Moon, thousands of Etherian Horde noncombatants – factory workers, mechanics, hydroponic farmers, maintenance staff – had stayed

behind in the Fright Zone. When the Galactic Horde invaded and seized the Black Garnet, those same civilians waged guerrilla warfare against the clones. After the collapse of the hive mind left the clones disoriented, the civilians imprisoned them in the panopticon. Scorpia, Octavia, Grizzlor, and Cobalt explained the clones' situation to the other inhabitants, persuading them to release and rehabilitate their captives.

"So you're their princess now, right? Their leader?" Entrapta asked.

"Oh no, it's not like that," Scorpia answered. "There's a group that makes decisions now. The four of us asked if we could join the Fortress Council. The rest of the Fright Zone voted on it, and we got in."

"That's great! You'll be good at it."

"I hope so. I'm still learning all the rules. The council makes day-to-day decisions, but the entire Fright Zone votes on the big decisions."

"So, you're happy with this?"

"I am. It's working okay so far. I'll be honest. I don't want to be a monarch. And they don't want another monarch either."

"Is it … because you're Scorpioni?"

"That's part of it. Some people still remember my relatives. I grew up hearing stories of the horrible things they did." Scorpia paused. "I don't want to be like that. I want everyone to have a say here. And, well, I don't want to rule like Hordak either. No disrespect to your boyfriend, but we need something new."

Entrapta and Scorpia talked for several more minutes. When Entrapta set down the data pad on her end table, she noticed Hordak lost in thought.

“A democracy,” he mused, staring up at the ceiling. “The Fright Zone is a democracy now.”

“I can’t say I know that term.”

“Rule by the people. It was the state of affairs on several planets before Horde Prime conquered them.”

Entrapta slid under the blankets. “Do you think it’ll work?”

“It will work better than rule by a man who conquered and tortured and exiled.”

One evening, a recording by Queen Angella went out to all the major kingdoms. Hordak and Entrapta hovered over a data pad, watching intently.

“Today, Etheria received its first foreign visitors since the arrival of the Galactic Horde. A coalition of planetary leaders, led by Governor Zed of Azophi, arrived on Etheria today, accompanied by a team of criers known as "journalists",” Angella recounted. “They represent six planets that once belonged to Horde Prime’s empire. The group has been welcomed at Bright Moon castle and is being briefed about the Galactic Horde invasion, the Heart of Etheria, and the death of Horde Prime.”

An image appeared on the screen of a tall anthro man in his thirties, with short brown hair and beige skin. Like a Battani, he had long, pointed ears and black lines on his cheeks and chin. He wore a white silk jumpsuit, embroidered with gold and red.

“One of Horde Prime’s many children,” Hordak told Entrapta.

Surrounding Governor Zed was an entourage of alien visitors. A barrel-chested man with the same facial markings as Zed, pointed ears, and gray skin the texture of cobblestones. An eight foot tall woman with fur, an elongated proboscis, and thick, conical

fingers. A mantis creature wearing yellow gloves and a blue leotard. A purple-skinned anthro woman with long black hair, holding a small data pad. Dignitaries and journalists from many species stood along Zed, greeting Queen Angella and King Micah in the image.

"News of recent events is slowly reaching other planets," Angella continued. "Etheria must now think of itself as part of the galactic community. Bright Moon is in the process of establishing nonaggression pacts and diplomatic channels with our new visitors."

After Angella's message concluded, Hordak and Entrapta looked at each other.

"A momentous occasion," Hordak observed. "Etheria is no longer an isolated backwater."

"I wish everyone on the planet could hear about this," Entrapta admitted. "Think of how excited they'll be! New technology. New ideas. Trade. The Makers Guild will definitely want to know about this."

She blinked as an idea dawned on her. "You know, everyone on the planet can hear about this. Are you up for a day trip tomorrow?"

The next morning, Entrapta and Hordak were ascending a dormant Galactic Horde spire near Elberon. Entrapta, who had since learned Galactic Horde coding language, had a plan. Inside the green and silver-white control room, she propped her data pad against a computer screen and hit record.

"Hi guys!" Entrapta called out to the data pad, waving with her hair. "We're reprogramming the spires! Hordak and I figured out how to override the transceiver's genetic interface."

"When our work here is complete, the spire can be used by anyone with the proper technology, not just Galactic Horde

clones," "Hordak said offscreen, screwing a metal panel closed with a hex driver.

"We thought we'd do the spires near the Runestones and major population centers!" Entrapta explained. "Kingdoms could use them to broadcast big news to the rest of Etheria. Or use them as mass warning system if there's some planet-wide crisis."

Hordak appeared on screen. "Ten more spires remain on our list. Soon, we'll send instructions to Queen Angella, the princesses, and the Fright Zone Fortress Council, explaining how to broadcast live messages through the spires."

"Oh, and down the road, we're going to reprogram all the Galactic Horde spaceships too!" Entrapta yelped. "We already rewired one. Hordak promised he'd teach me how to fly it. A clone would still use the neural interface, but we figured out a way for a non-clone to manually input flying commands. Okay, bye!"

Entrapta ended the recording and sent the video to the princesses.

Hordak watched Entrapta vault over to a computer panel using her hair, hex driver in hand. They were alone, working on technology as a team, as they had in the past. A soft sweetness warmed him inside.

Months passed. One chilly afternoon, two repurposed Horde skiffs landed outside of Crypto Castle. When Entrapta, Hordak, Kadroh, and Emily walked out to greet them, Hordak's blood ran cold.

Two imposing men with silver skin, clad in elaborate Mystacore robes, stood to the left. To the right, a middle-aged anthro woman with brown skin held a thick notepad. A stern goat-man and another anthro woman with tan skin stood behind her.

“We are investigators representing the Etherian Global War Crimes Tribunal," the middle-aged woman announced. “We were tasked by the tribunal with investigating your roles in the Etherian Horde’s conquests and the summoning of the Galactic Horde to Etheria.”

Hordak stepped forward. His limbs felt leaden. “I knew this day would come soon. Very well. I will answer your questions inside.”

“I don’t think you understand,” the woman clarified. “When I said ‘your roles’, I was referring to you and Princess Entrapta.”

Hordak stiffened. “What?”

“Princess Entrapta is facing war crimes charges before the tribunal as well.”

Entrapta’s hair twitched. Kadroh glanced at her nervously. Hordak bared his fangs. “Entrapta is of no concern to the tribunal! She provided invaluable assistance to the Rebellion. Without her help, Prime—”

Entrapta rested a tendril of hair on Hordak’s arm. She sighed. “No … no, it’s fine,” she said deflatedly. “I’ll answer your questions too.”

Seven kingdoms that had warred against the Etherian Horde or the Galactic Horde, including Bright Moon, Mystacore, and the Salinean diaspora, had convened the tribunal. Queen Angella, King Micah, and a judge from each of the six other kingdoms would preside over the war crimes trials of Hordak, Shadow Weaver, Catra, and Entrapta.

For days, Entrapta, Hordak, Kadroh, and multiple clones answered questions. One of the silver-skinned men would cast a truth spell over the interviewee, preventing them from lying. The goat-man, Vero, acted as Hordak’s counsel, while the tan-skinned anthro, Istina, acted as Entrapta’s counsel. The middle-aged woman, Nermai, asked questions for hours. Her longest inquiries were

reserved for Hordak, probing every detail about his army and conquests.

*How often did the Etherian Horde take prisoners? How were prisoners treated? Who authorized the attack on Plumeria's Heart Blossom? Why were civilians targeted? Who planned the siege of Salineas? Why was a civilian settlement razed? What role did you play in the construction and deployment of the portal used to contact Horde Prime? What role did you play in the reality anomaly that disrupted the planet? What happened when you and Horde Prime reunited? Would you recount how you, Princess Glimmer, Catra, and Kadroh returned to Etheria, in your own words?*

When the investigators left Crypto Castle, everyone was exhausted. Entrapta pulled her mask over her face more and more as she tinkered with Galactic Horde technology. Hordak petted Imp more often, and took more hikes with Imp and Kadroh, saying little. One afternoon, Hordak hid in a food storage room, weeping alone among the flour, seltzer, and dried fruit. At night, Hordak and Entrapta held each other close as they slept.

The tribunal would begin any day now. They would be separated. The family they had crafted would be but a memory. An aching heaviness hung in the air. Two weeks later, Nermai returned, this time with four Bright Moon guards.

"The war crimes tribunal will begin two days from now, at Bright Moon. You will accompany us to Bright Moon castle. You have thirty minutes to pack."

# Tribunal

Chapter Summary

> Hordak, Entrapta, Catra, and Shadow Weaver are brought before a war crimes tribunal. Their sentencing comes with hard truths and surprises.

Chapter Notes

> Zephyr and Greensteppe are my headcanon names for the native lands of Spinnerella and Netossa, respectively.

For weeks, the tribunal had quietly tried Etherian Horde force captains and soldiers for war crimes. Sentences usually consisted of months to a few years of community service, rebuilding the settlements they destroyed or constructing new settlements for clones.

Kyle, for example, had been sentenced to a year of community service, assisting with a planet-wide census of new magic users who had been empowered by the magical energy eruptions. Kyle’s own magical awakening would make him relatable to other magic users, and his friendly personality would put them at ease, the tribunal reasoned.

Force captains who had committed particularly offensive crimes received special punishment. Destruction of cultural sites was punished with assignments to brick kilns, lumber mills, and glass works in different towns. With construction materials in high demand because of reconstruction efforts, their labor would be welcome. Force Captain Red Eye, who had burned down the library of Erelandia, was sentenced to two years in an Erelandia brick kiln, making bricks for a new library. Force Captain Sunder, who smashed Frit's Monument to Freedom, was sentenced to a year in the Rosewood glass works, creating glass for a new monument.

Horde warriors who accepted Bright Moon's amnesty deal during the war against Horde Prime, including Scorpia, Octavia, Cobalt, and Grizzlor, went free. Horde cadets and Fright Zone noncombatants were exempted from the trials. The Galactic Horde clones were also exempted from the trials, as the tribunal had concluded that they were not acting of their own free will when they attacked Etheria. Rehabilitation, rather than punishment, would better serve the cause of justice.

Soon, Etherian Horde leaders were on trial. All of Etheria held its breath, waiting for the outcome.

The tribunal and sentencing took place outside of Bright Moon castle, in the rose courtyard. At the front of the courtyard sat eight interlocking tables, curved and carved from mahogany, forming a U-shape. Seated at these tables were Queen Angella, King Micah, and judges from Plumeria, Mystacore, the Kingdom of Snows, Zephyr, Greensteppe, and the Salinean diaspora. Hordak, Entrapta, Shadow Weaver, and Catra each sat before the judges at small tables with their counsel. To Hordak’s surprise, and Mermista’s disappointment, none of them had been bound with chains, or struck by guards, or pelted with refuse by onlookers. The tribunal was orderly, restrained, dignified.

The tribunal audience was limited to princesses and high princes, Rebellion leaders, representatives of devastated communities, and a handful of journalists from other planets. Dozens of Bright Moon guards stood at attention around the perimeter of the courtyard, should any vigilantes try to reach the four defendants. Around the palace, daisies plucked from Shadow Weaver’s garden sat in vases.

The tribunal was broadcast live on eleven Galactic Horde spires across Etheria, the same spires Entrapta and Hordak had rewired months before. Residents of the largest kingdoms and city-states, including a trading town in the Crimson Waste, watched holographic projections of the proceedings. Near Bright Moon castle, across the water, a crowd of Etherians and clones stood

around a repurposed Galactic Horde spire, waiting for the broadcast to begin.

The investigators had been thorough, and the evidence was overwhelming. Interviews with princesses, Rebellion warriors, Etherian Horde soldiers, and refugees had given the tribunal a wealth of evidence implicating the four Etherian Horde leaders. Denying their crimes would be futile. The previous day, Hordak, Shadow Weaver, Catra, and Entrapta pled guilty, one by one.

Today, the four would be sentenced. Today, the Etherians would exact justice for years of war, the portal catastrophe, and the summoning of Horde Prime.

As judges and audience members filed into the courtyard, Hordak contemplated the wasted years. The war, the leveled towns, the play-acting as a warlord, the sad mimicry of Prime had all been for nothing.

Now, just as he had found joy and purpose, he would lose them again. Entrapta, Imp, Kadroh, and his brothers would be a distant memory. His devotion to a man who despised him would cost him the people who loved him. He sighed at the irony.

His mouth felt thick. He had been too melancholy to eat breakfast that morning, and his stomach growled softly. A dull ache had settled in his arms and shoulders that week. *The cloning flaw,* he realized. *It's returning.* Dread poured from him like sweat.

At the table to his right, Shadow Weaver sat quietly with her counsel, an anthro woman with bronze skin and angular features. To her right, Catra and her counsel sat at another small table. Catra's tail swished side to side as she stared at the tabletop.

"I had the wildest dream last night," Catra said to her counsel, a portly cat-man with gray fur. Hordak could just barely make out her words. "Horde Prime kidnapped me, but then Adora rescued me and flew me back to Etheria. Everyone back home forgave

me. Entrapta, Scorpia, Glimmer, even Adora. We all got to be friends. Stupid dream, huh?"

To Catra's right, Entrapta sat at a table with her counsel, Istina. She and Catra avoided making eye contact throughout the trial. With exhausted eyes, Entrapta let her gaze wandered over the judges and royals.

*Entrapta, I'm sorry,* Hordak thought. *For pulling you into this.*

As audience members filed into the courtyard, Adora and Scorpia walked up to the judges' tables. Scorpia glanced at Entrapta over her shoulder. The women addressed Angella and Micah so softly that Hordak could barely hear their words.

"Please don't be harsh with Entrapta," Scorpia pleaded. "She did a lot for the Rebellion. She's not a bad person."

"I still don't think Entrapta should be on trial," Adora asserted. "We were Horde too, once, but you didn't punish us."

Angella remained serene. "Do you trust us?" she asked.

Adora was silent for a moment. "I do," she finally answered.

"Trust us now. Trust us with your friend," Micah added.

A few minutes later, a frowning Mermista approached Angella and Micah. Mermista folded her arms, glaring at the ground. "The other three can rot, but … I think you should go easy on Entrapta," she grumbled. She turned and walked back to her seat in the audience, exhaling loudly.

When all of the audience members had arrived, Bright Moon guards pounded the shafts of their spears to the ground three times. The courtyard went silent.

"The sentencing hearing will now begin!" cried out one of the guards. "High Queen Angella will now speak."

Angella rose from her seat and walked into the space between the judges' tables and the accused.

"The four defendants here today have perpetrated or assisted in destruction on a massive scale. The Etherian Horde is responsible for nearly thirty years of suffering across the planet," she told the audience.

"This tribunal has been unprecedented," Angella admitted, clasping her hands. "Over the centuries, multi-kingdom courts have tried minor conquerors and summoners, but no one in Etheria's history has committed crimes on this scale. The court resurrected a crime category that had been out of use for centuries: aggression against the land. To address the magnitude of one defendant's crime, the court was compelled to create the new crime category of attempted omnicide."

Angella gazed out at the audience. "In centuries past, crimes of far lesser magnitude were punished with imprisonment or execution. Grave punishments were recommended by some members of the tribunal."

Angella paused, studying the faces of Hordak, Shadow Weaver, Catra, and Entrapta. "However, these defendants are unusual, having carried out acts of both villainy and heroism. For that reason, their sentences will emphasize restitution and restoration over punishment."

Audible gasps rose from the audience. Several observers shifted in their seats or exchanged troubled glances.

"In centuries past, conquerors and dangerous summoners were executed or imprisoned for far lesser crimes. Etheria would not be served by such punishments today. The court believes that justice would be best served by compelling the defendants to rebuild what they destroyed."

Angella stood before Entrapta and her counsel.

"Princess Entrapta of Dryl, you have pled guilty to aiding in aggression against the land, reckless endangerment of your fellow Etherians through manipulation of the Runestones, and treason against Etheria by assisting in the construction of the portal that summoned Horde Prime."

Entrapta and Angella held each other's gaze. Entrapta's face was pale, and her hair hung limply. Angella remained serene.

"However, the court is also aware that you were recruited into the Horde under false pretenses," Angella continued. "We are aware that you tried to prevent Catra's attempted omnicide. We are *keenly* aware that your work was *invaluable* to the war effort against the Galactic Horde, and that you acted bravely during the Velvet Glove mission. You've housed dozens of clones on your estate. You've adapted Galactic Horde technology for Etheria's benefit."

Entrapta's hair twitched. Her twintails rose off the floor slightly.

"You are sentenced to restorative work in service to Etheria. However, your positive work will be considered time served. Your sentence has been completed. You are free to go," Angella informed her, smiling gently.

Hordak exhaled. A weary smile spread across his lips. *She's free. She will not be punished for my war,* he thought.

Entrapta's eyes opened wide. Her hair rippled. "I'm … free?"

"Yes," Angella replied. "The judges, King Micah, and I were divided over whether you should face further consequences. King Micah persuaded the others to show you leniency."

King Micah smirked and stood up from his seat. "There's more. You're the most brilliant scientist and engineer on the planet. Etheria is rebuilding, and it needs a mind like yours."

"What do you mean?" Entrapta asked slowly.

“We want to offer you a special role,” Micah revealed. “Etheria’s new Technology Czar.”

“You would report directly to Bright Moon, if you accept the position,” Angella explained. “The Technology Czar will be responsible for modernizing Etheria. You would help different kingdoms incorporate Galactic Horde technology, so as to improve life for the populace. You will be handsomely compensated, and Bright Moon will provide any resources you need.”

“Other judges wanted to sentence you to the role. I didn’t want you to be forced. It’s your choice whether to accept the position or not,” Micah said.

Entrapta’s eyes were bright. Color flooded back into her face. “I accept!” she shouted.

Micah sat down, smiling broadly. Angella gently nodded.

Next, Angella stood before Shadow Weaver. For several seconds, she stared at the mage in silence.

“Shadow Weaver of the Fright Zone, you have pled guilty to aggression against the land, imprisoning King Micah and Princess Glimmer, attempted assassination of a royal by way of exile, and attempted seizure of the Bright Moon throne,” Angella told her.

Shadow Weaver said nothing. She held Angella’s gaze, tipping back her head slightly.

“Mystacore has also called for you to stand trial for the summoning of a threat to the populace, and for manslaughter of Norwyn, Asimati, and Maxia. You will be extradited to Mystacore, where you will be tried for your crimes. Should you be found guilty, the Mystacore authorities will convene with the tribunal at a later date to determine your sentence,” Angella announced. “Regardless of the Mystacore trial’s outcome, you *will* be made to repair the damage you inflicted on Etheria.”

Shadow Weaver's gaze did not falter. The mage and queen locked eyes again.

"Why did you do it?" Angella asked.

"Do what?" Shadow Weaver replied.

"Exile King Micah. Send him to Beast Island. You knew what awaited him there."

Shadow Weaver exhaled and folded her hands on her lap. "If Hordak knew that the Horde had King Micah in custody, he could have held Micah hostage to demand surrender from Bright Moon. If Bright Moon had fallen, other major kingdoms would have soon followed. The war would have ended. With Etheria under his dominion, Hordak might have decided that he had no use for me. I would have lost access to the Black Garnet, and the magical power it gave me."

Micah narrowed his eyes. "You sent me there … you kept the war at a stalemate … so you could stay with the Black Garnet?"

"Yes," Shadow Weaver answered, matter-of-factly. "I needed the Black Garnet's power."

Puzzling events from the past suddenly made sense to Hordak. Why his war of conquest stagnated for years after he had promoted Shadow Weaver to second in command. Shadow Weaver's fury when he defended Entrapta's right to "tinker" with the Runestone. Why the Horde had suddenly steamrolled its enemies after Catra took charge of the Horde's military strategy.

Angella's serenity dissolved. Her mouth curved downward. "Mages dead. Years that Micah will never get back. Settlements in ruins. And you regret none of it, do you?"

Shadow Weaver did not stir.

"No."

“What were you after?” Angella demanded to know. “Power? For its own sake? Or something more?”

“The pursuit of power is its own journey.”

Angella winced. “And every step of that journey led you *here*. A skiff is waiting to transport you to Mystacore. Guards, take Shadow Weaver to the vehicle.”

Shadow Weaver and her counsel rose from their chairs. Two Bright Moon guards flanked them on either side of their small table. As Shadow Weaver and her counsel were led away, one of the guards briefly glanced at Hordak. Their sclera had suddenly turned yellow, and their pupils were now vertical slits. The guard winked at him.

Shadow Weaver disappeared before she could stand trial at Mystacore. Rumors about her disappearance hummed across the planet for years afterwards. Some Etherian believed that Angella and Micah had secretly arranged for Double Trouble to assassinate her, but those closest to the queen and king rejected this rumor. Others insisted that powerful loved ones of the late Norwyn arranged her murder. Others still claimed that the mage had escaped justice with Double Trouble's aid, in exchange for some precious magical favor, and that she freely wandered the planet in disguise. Shadow Weaver was never seen, dead or alive, again.

Angella stood before Catra, who glared at the high queen. Her tail batted back and forth as Angella spoke.

"Catra of the Fright Zone, you have pleaded guilty to serious crimes, including aggression against the land, attempted assassination of a royal by way of exile, treason against Etheria by activating the portal that summoned Horde Prime, and attempted omnicide," Angella stated.

Catra's hands were balled into fists on her lap. Angella continued. "And yet, for all your efforts to destroy Etheria, you also took pains to save it. You persuaded Horde Prime to spare Etheria. You

helped Princess Glimmer escape from the Velvet Glove, dying in the process. You fought bravely against the eldritch creatures that descended from the realm between worlds. The tribunal found your choices ... perplexing."

Angella's gaze bore down on Catra. "Why did you commit those crimes?"

"You wouldn't understand why. You have no idea what my life was life," Catra growled. "Never feeling safe. Always at someone's mercy. And then Adora abandoned me, and—"

"Stop," Angella ordered. "Adora left the *Horde*. You chose to stay with the Horde rather than leave with her."

Catra snarled. "It was about proving something. Proving myself. You wouldn't understand."

"I understand that you chose to stay in an army you hated. You chose to abuse friend and foe alike. You chose to escalate the war, and to level Salineas. You chose to open the interdimensional portal, endangering everyone on the planet … and trapping me in a nightmarish realm for months. You *chose* to do terrible things, repeatedly."

"It wasn't that bad. The refugees had places to go. You're still alive. Entrapta's alive. Etheria wasn't destroyed."

Catra's counsel placed a meaty hand on her arm. "*Quiet*," he hissed. Catra yanked her arm away.

"That is your excuse for your crimes?" Angella replied, eyes wide. "That the ramifications of your actions weren't even more horrific?"

"I did what I had to. To show everyone. To show I wasn't weak. To show that I could *win*."

"And yet, you failed, repeatedly. You abandoned your gang in the Crimson Waste after a day. Your poor judgment brought down the

Horde. Your cruelty drove away every ally you had. By opening the portal, you attracted Horde Prime's attention, bringing down catastrophe on Etheria and yourself. You didn't "win" at being a leader, a general, or a friend. All you succeeded in doing was making others suffer."

The cat-woman said nothing.

"Catra … don't you want to be something more than a monster?"

Silence. Catra's lower lip quivered, and her tail twitched.

"Don't you want to be more than this? More than someone who controls and hurts others?" Angella asked. "I believe you are capable of better. Your words to Horde Prime are why Etheria still exists. You helped my daughter escape. You protected her. *You have the capacity to be more than what you've become.*"

Catra's tail bristled. She stared at the table, clenching her fists.

Angella stood straighter, looking out into the audience. "The tribunal took into account your upbringing and your young age when deciding on your sentence. It also took into account your dangerous past behavior. Your sentence will be humane, but it will also ensure that you can be watched closely."

Catra clenched her jaw as the high queen announced the sentence. "Catra of the Fright Zone, you are hereby sentenced to ten years of labor in Seaworthy's industries," Angella proclaimed. "You will begin by spending nine hours a day, five days a week, laboring in the brick kiln under guard. Bricks are sorely needed for the reconstruction of Salineas and coastal towns, and you will work in this capacity for a minimum of three years. As the demand for bricks lessens, you may be assigned to another industry, such as the saw mill or shipyard, based on Seaworthy's labor needs."

Members of the audience murmured as the sentence was announced. Mermista glared at Catra. Sea Hawk's eyebrows arched. Scorpia's face was solemn. Adora seemed lost in thought.

“Your food, clothing, lodging, and medical care will be provided,” Angella continued. “When not laboring, you will be free to participate in cultural and religious activities in Seaworthy, under guard, if you so choose. A local mindheart-healer, Grimalkin, has agreed to offer you his services twice weekly, to heal the wounds in your soul.”

Catra’s gaze did not rise from the table as Angella spoke. “You are forbidden from leaving Seaworthy during your stay. Failure to remain within the town, or to comply with guards’ orders, will result in a lengthening of your sentence. You will receive an ot-kayin mark on your skin, so that mages can track you if you abscond. Princess Netossa has agreed to be your liaison, and she will regularly report back to Bright Moon on your progress. You are hereby banned for life from owning weapons, or working in a military or mercenary capacity.”

Catra’s counsel sighed with relief. Angella addressed the cat-woman once more.

"For the next ten years, you will help repair the damage you wrought. When your sentence has been completed, you will still be young, and free to craft a new life for yourself. Craft a *good* life when that time comes," Angella urged her.

Finally, Angella stood before Hordak. She narrowed her eyes and inhaled deeply.

"And you, Hordak, started it all."

A jolt of pain coursed through Hordak's left arm as the high queen spoke.

"Hordak of the Fright Zone, you have pleaded guilty to aggression against the land, including attacks on civilian settlements, the most egregious of which was the destruction of Salineas and surrounding towns. You have also pleaded guilty to treason by summoning Horde Prime to Etheria, forcing us to defend ourselves against a galactic empire," Angella reminded him.

"This is true," he answered.

"Three decades of suffering can be laid at your feet. An endless war. A generation of Etherians who have never known a world at peace. So many injured. So many driven from their homes. And then, by recklessly summoning Prime to our world, you nearly ensured our annihilation. Do you grasp the enormity of what you've done?"

"I do."

"And yet," Angella said gently, "You helped Princess Glimmer escape from the Prime's captivity. You liberated multiple clones from servitude while protecting her. You provided the Rebellion with invaluable information about the Galactic Horde. You stormed the Velvet Glove, destroyed the hive mind that held your brothers in bondage, and fought Prime himself. When Prime possessed you, you resisted his influence, preventing him from attacking She-Ra during the Unleashing. After Prime's defeat, you assisted Entrapta with the rehabilitation of clones and repurposing of Galactic Horde technology."

Angella sighed. "Your actions, quite honestly, bewildered some members of the tribunal. You've shown yourself capable of great evil and great good. Hordak … explain yourself."

Hordak paused, drawing in a long breath. "Prime cast me out for falling short of his perfection. I believed that if I conquered Etheria, I could win back his blessing. I knew no other way of proving myself worthy of existence. But it was futile. Foolish. I know that now."

He exhaled and closed his eyes. "Just as Prime deemed conquest noble, I deemed it noble. Just as Prime treated me as disposable, I treated Etherians as disposable. I modeled myself off of a tyrant, having no other model."

Hordak opened his eyes and rested his gaze on Entrapta. "And then, I met someone who taught me that imperfect beings have

worth. Through her, I realized that I mattered. Others befriended me, and taught me to value my brothers. Prime's blessing was no longer precious to me. They were."

Angella stared at Hordak, studying his face. He struggled to read her expression. Finally, she spoke.

"The tribunal took into account the extenuating circumstances that gave rise to your actions," she explained. "You were a mass-produced clone soldier, programmed to show absolute fealty to Horde Prime. Your choices were shaped by indoctrination and holy terror that most Etherians cannot begin to imagine. You are also a father, raising a small child who needs you. Finally, Princess Glimmer promised you leniency in exchange for your help, and the tribunal has agreed to honor that agreement. For all these reasons, you will not spend your sentence restricted to one location, or under constant guard."

Hordak's stomach trembled. Hope quivered in his core.

"However," Angella continued, "the suffering you inflicted on the planet was immense, and you must work to undo it. Hordak of the Fright Zone, you are hereby sentenced to ten years of labor in service to Etheria. Your duties will be threefold. First, you will oversee the reconstruction of Salineas and the villages of Marinos, Estuaria, Windwave, Longshore, and Seiche. You will work with a team of engineers, architects, and urban planners to rebuild these settlements and equip them with modern technology. The Technology Czar will work closely with you and the team. All of your plans must be approved by Princess Mermista, who will have ultimate authority over the project."

"Damn right I will," Mermista whispered, far behind him in the audience.

"After this project is complete, you will assist the Technology Czar in adapting Galactic Horde technology, such as medicine, computers, and electronic communications, for Etherian use.

You've taken much from the Etherians, and you will compensate them with an improved standard of living," Angella commanded.

Entrapta smirked at Hordak. The quivering in his core calmed somewhat.

"Finally, Bright Moon reserves the right to call upon you for advice on interplanetary affairs. Etheria must now find its place in a larger universe. Your knowledge will be useful in the years ahead."

Relief washed over Hordak. As hope coursed through him again, he barely heard the rest of Angella's announcement, or the murmuring in the audience.

"With Princess Entrapta's consent, you will remain at Crypto Castle when not occupied with tasks directly related to your sentence, or to the care of your child. Your skin will bear the *ot-kayin* mark, so that mages can scry your location at any time. Adora has agreed to be your liaison. You will meet with her regularly, and she will report back to Bright Moon on your progress. You are hereby banned for life from owning weapons, or working in a military or mercenary capacity."

When the tribunal ended, the rest of the day was a blur. Hordak remembered Entrapta hugging him tightly, and his arms encasing her. He remembered the eyes of the audience members on him: wary, angry, pensive, expectant, satisfied, unsatisfied. He remembered a short katydid-man asking his counsel questions for the "Galactic News Service". Hordak's breaths were short and shallow. His shoulders ached.

Later, when he was alone in his guest quarters within Bright Moon castle, a dam broke inside him. An emotion he could not name flooded him. Trembling, he laid down on his cot, clutched the pillow with sharp talons, buried his face in the fabric, and sobbed loudly.

# Months Later

Chapter Summary

> Months after the tribunal, an unexpected visitor arrives in the Crimson Wastes. Double Trouble opens a nightclub in Seaworthy. Rigel composes a letter to Hordak. Adora and Hordak discuss the plans for New Salineas, and Adora's Eternian heritage.

Three months after the tribunal, a visitor made her way to the Crimson Wastes. The day-moon was setting over a cantina built out of sand-roughened fabric and giant bones. The sky was streaked with red, blue, and purple as the day-moon sank behind the dunes. A high mast light with solar panels illuminated the entrance to Ramona's Bar. The smell of yellowgrass smoke and liquor hung in the air. Laughter poured out of the bar as Lllrrpppwwzzzxxff the Unblinking delivered his latest stand-up routine.

"So I said to scrounger, if you're holding the hex driver, then where'd my drink go?" the eyeball monster recounted, standing on a crate. The patrons howled.

"So she scowls at me with her one good eye and says—" the child-sized abomination continued, then abruptly stopped. The laughter had gone silent. All eyes were on the entrance, where a young woman had walked in.

The cat-woman was wiry, with short brown hair, one blue eye, and one golden eye. She wore burgundy spandex garments, but no shoes. Her left arm was bandaged. Slung across her right shoulder was a leather backpack.

The patrons rose to their feet, growling.

"It's her."

"You brought the Horde here last time. You think we forgot?"

“You almost killed everyone!”

“She’s gonna pay.”

Goat-men, snake-women, and dog-folk lumbered toward her. Hands were clenched into fists. Knives and clubs appeared from under clothing. The cat-woman cast aside her backpack and sank her center, baring her fangs. She raised her claws, hissing.

“Catra,” said a woman’s voice behind her.

Catra pivoted, only to see a tall, muscular woman with pink skin and a white mohawk. Beside her stood a burly snake-man wearing olive green trousers and an olive utility vest.

Huntara leaned toward her. “You can’t fight fifteen people at once,” Huntara whispered. “You can stay here and die, or you can come with me and live.”

Catra glanced at the snarling patrons, then back at Huntara. The cat-woman nodded.

“All of you, sit down. I’ve got this,” Huntara called out to the patrons. They begrudgingly obeyed, grumbling.

Catra picked her backpack off the floor and slung it over her right shoulder. The snake-man pointed to the desert beyond bar entrance, and Catra walked out of the bar. Huntara and the snake-man walked on either side of her.

“We’re camped about half a mile from here, by that rock formation,” Huntara explained, pointing to stones in the distance. “We’re going there. No stunts, understand?”

“Who the hell are you?” Catra asked.

“Huntara. Bandit Queen of the Crimson Wastes,” she replied, sneering. “This here is Broom.”

Catra looked the snake-man up and down. “Why are you called Broom?”

“Because I clean up messes,” he answered with a basso profondo voice. He held Catra’s gaze as he slammed his right fist into his open left palm.

The sand crunched under their feet. The day-moon had set, and the air grew cooler.

“Not the reception you were expecting, I’ll bet,” Huntara guessed. Catra said nothing, staring ahead. “Bringing the Horde here didn’t endear you to them. And when we all watched the trial on that spire near Valley-of-the-Lost … well, when we learned you nearly wiped us all out, people were mad,” Huntara explained.

The sky became a deep blue tapestry of stars as they approached a semi-circle of massive stones and Joshua trees. Light from a campfire danced across the stones. Chunks of gray meat, impaled on wood skewers, roasted over the fire. Several yards away, the hollow carcass of a deer-sized beetle sat in the sand, with raw meat kabobs resting on its carapace. Two dog-women with tan fur sat on the ground, with their backs against the stones, eating cooked meat off of skewers. A two-foot tall owl creature, with pink feathers and enormous rainbow flaps attached to his head and back, turned over the kabobs on the fire.

“You’re back already!” the owl creature said. “And you brought a fr —oh. OHH,” he groaned, eyes wide, as he stared at Catra.

“Look who waltzed into Ramona’s,” Huntara announced. One of the dog-women snickered. The other growled.

“That’s Kuri, and that’s Kopek,” Huntara said, gesturing toward the dog-women. “And that’s Kowl,” she said, nodding toward the owl creature.

Catra studied Kowl, who stared back at her with a condescending gaze. “Aren’t you a little small to run with a gang like this?” Catra asked.

Kowl shook his fist at her. “I’ll have you know I can kick ass with the best of them! I helped Huntara take down Boss Hiss.”

“It’s true,” Huntara confirmed. “He bit Boss Hiss on the calf. Distracted him long enough for me to land a right hook. So I let him join my gang. How are those snapbeetle kabobs coming?”

“Just about done!” Kowl chirped.

“Give one to the Brickmaker here,” Huntara instructed.

Kowl lifted a skewer off the fire and handed the cool end to Catra, frowning. Catra dropped her backpack and sat on the sand, tearing into the meat. Huntara and Broom sat down on either side of her. Kowl handed them kabobs, then placed the remaining skewers of raw meat on the fire.

“I get the heart chunks,” Kowl said. “Best part.”

Huntara tore a bite of beetle meat off her skewer with her teeth. “Why did you come back? What were you thinking?” she asked Catra, her mouth stuffed.

Catra exhaled loudly and continued chewing.

“Didn’t you have a good thing going in Seaworthy? And you came *here*?”

Catra swallowed a mouthful of meat. “I … I couldn’t do it anymore,” she growled. “Every day … the same thing. Make bricks. Make more bricks. Eat dinner. Go to bed. Get up and make bricks again. At least every day was different back in the Horde. I was sick of shale and sand and the smell of wet clay. And when I’m not making bricks, I’m getting the grunt jobs at the kiln no one else wants. I used to be a general. Now, I sweep floors.”

The cat-woman stared at her kabob. “When I’m outside, people stare at me. They cross the street from me. They mutter just loud enough for me to hear. One day, I had enough. I waited until the guard’s back was turned, and I ran.”

“You ran because you were bored? And people were pissed at you?” Kopek asked. The dog-woman tossed her now bare skewer onto the sand. “Cry me a river.”

“They’re going to find you. ‘Cause they put a magic mark on you, right?” chimed in Kuri.

Catra held up her bandaged left arm. “Amazing what you can do with a little sandpaper and a lot of willpower.”

Kuri huffed, shook her head, and went back to eating.

Kowl lifted a skewer of beetle heart chunks off the fire. He sat in the sand, blew on his kabobs, and began feasting. The group ate in silence for several moments, until Huntara tossed her bare skewer down.

“So let me get this straight,” Huntara began, wiping her mouth with the back of her hand. “You’re the infamous Catra. You’re one of the fiercest warriors the Horde produced. But you crumpled when you got a boring job, and people looked at you funny. Something happened to you.”

Catra sighed. “After everything … I wasn’t that person anymore. And I was very, very tired.”

“So you came here, where misfits end up, thinking you could disappear. Well that’s not happening. Everyone in the Wastes is going to react to you the same way Ramona’s customers did. You can’t stay here.”

Huntara stood up, walked to a Joshua tree, and pulled a data pad out of one of the backpacks at the foot of the tree. She sat down next to Catra.

“You’re going back,” Huntara stated. “You’re safer in Seaworthy, and you’ve got work to do.”

Catra’s ears flattened. Her frown deepened. Broom smirked.

“Blondie told me a little about you. You survived a lot of things. You’ll survive the brick kiln too. You made it this far by being strong,” Huntara assured her.

“You sound like Grimalkin,” Catra replied.

“It’ll be over someday, and then you can do whatever you want. And if Etherians don’t want you around, maybe a clone village will take you in. The *clones* don’t have any beef with you, and they’ll probably have a soft spot for someone starting over. Or you can move to another planet. Years from now, they’ll probably have spaceships going to other worlds, with all the new tech Bright Moon is working on.”

Catra’s ear twitched. “How do you know about the clone settlements? And what Bright Moon’s doing?”

“I keep in touch with Blondie. She said there’s a BOLO out on you, by the way.”

Huntara pressed buttons on the data pad. The screen glowed, illuminating her face. After a few moments, Adora’s voice poured through the data pad speaker.

“Huntara? Hey! Good to hear from you.”

“Blondie! You got a few minutes?”

“Sure.”

“Tell Queen Angella I said thanks for the solar lights. We’ve got one outside of Ramona’s, and the other four are at Valley-of-the-Lost.”

“It was a good will gesture, she said.”

“Tell her I’m ready to negotiate. Let’s talk about this plan to give travelers safe passage through the Windswept Corridor.”

“That’s great! I’ll tell her first thing tomorrow morning.”

"Oh, and one more thing. I found your missing cat."

On planet Kadroh, a Battani man sat on a cushion, holding a thin rectangular disk on his lap. On the floor to his left were two airtight pouches full of dried morellas and two sealed vials, each holding a chunk of green jade. To his right were two other rectangular disks, both showing the same image of Eternians, Battani, and Adreenids with ropes, pulling down a jade statute of Horde Prime in the city of Kopar-nik.

Rigel pressed his thumb to a red circular symbol at the corner of the disk. The device's screen now showed his face. "RECORDING" appeared at the bottom of the screen in Galactic Common text. He spoke.

*Hordak! I hope this dataletter finds you well. I'm sending one to your brother Kadroh too. With luck, the Galaxy Couriers will find you and your brother on Etheria and deliver these two packages.*

Rigel paused

*When news of what happened on Etheria reached us, I was pleased. You took my words to heart. You didn't squander that second chance. Good. Second chances are rare and precious.*

*I read about the trial on Etheria. So you'll be fixing what you broke very soon. And the great hero of the galaxy is holding you to that. This is also right. Rebuild the cities, and then make a home with your little boy and the woman you love.*

*What a time to be alive. The galaxy is being reborn. Every planet is brimming with new possibilities. Even here on Kadroh, the future beckons, and none of us know what lies ahead.*

*The upheavals here took my breath away. I was seeing patients in Cassini when I heard the news about Horde Prime's death. People were crying and hugging. Dancing in the streets. The clones were*

*terrified. Just … huddled, trembling wrecks. There's a rehabilitation center in Kopar-nik now to help the clones adjust to freedom, and to learn the ways of the jeweled-mind-link. I came back to Kopar-nik to help there. Those three clones you and your brother awakened? They're helping there too.*

*The day I got back, a crowd was pulling down the Horde Prime statute. Once it crashed to the ground, a few of them smashed it with sledgehammers. I captured the scene on dataphoto tiles for both you. Just press the button on the bottom, and the video will play. That chunk of jade in the vial was from the statute. I thought you and your brother might want souvenirs.*

*There's a renaissance happening here, Hordak. Prime isn't suppressing culture anymore, so the planet is bursting with art, music, cuisine. Musicians are playing on every other street corner these days. The Battani can practice their ways in the open. It's beautiful.*

*Books are circulating as well. No more furtive book swaps in secret. The Battani classics are enjoying a rebirth among our people, and why should you and your brother be left out? Attached to this dataletter is a file: a copy of The Epic of Chiropterus, translated into Galactic Common. It tells the story of a just but proud Battani king who angers the gods. When the gods smite his kingdom with famine, he and his siblings embark on a quest to reach the gods' realm. There, they overthrow the cruel gods and end the famine. Something tells me it will resonate with you and your brother.*

*After Prime fell, new leaders rose to the challenge here. Randor and Marlena are heading the provisional government, and they've handled the upheaval well, given the circumstances. The people trust them. Their son Adam is leading the movement to repatriate Eternians to Eternia. Isn't Adora the She-Ra an Eternian? You should tell her.*

Rigel paused again.

*I would like to hear back from you and your brother. Tell me about your new lives on Etheria. Tell me how a warlord became an atoner. When the Galaxy Couriers set up an office on Etheria, send me a dataletter. Until then, enjoy the morellas.*

Seaworthy's night life was about to sizzle.

Months before, a high priestess sold a small Noh-El temple to Bright Moon, after the congregations catering to the town's cat-folk decided to consolidate. To honor Princess Glimmer's deal with Double Trouble, Bright Moon gave the de-consecrated building to the shapeshifter. The chameleon poured themself into redecorating.

Now, the opening night for Club Hurricane had arrived. Sailors, merchants, and shipbuilders walked on white marble floors. A sea elf bartender served drinks from behind a coral bar. Seaworthy's townsfolk sipped cocktails at silver and glass tables. For those willing to pay extra, two balconies overlooked the stage. At the front of the club stood the stage, where a band of sea elves was beating drums, tapping a xylophone, and blowing into shell-shaped metal instruments.

The club dimmed, and the stage lights brightened. The band picked up its tempo. Double Trouble strutted on stage, decked out in a dress that flowed and splashed like ocean water. As they sauntered to the center of the stage, they dragged the dress' train behind them, seemingly made of frothing sea foam. Double Trouble lifted their arms and sang.

*Did you ever believe that this day would come?*
*When no one would tell us no?*
*We made it, my love; it's a bright new morn*
*We're the envy of friend and foe*

Double Trouble's dress turned black, folding on itself. Now, they wore a tuxedo made out of layers and layers of iridescent scales.

*Did you ever believe we'd end up on top?*
*After everything came unfurled?*
*We made it, my love; now the night is young*
*We're gonna tell the entire world*

Double Trouble's clothes turned black again, morphing and churning. Now, they wore a three-piece suit covered in sapphires, sparkling blue under the stage lights.

*It's a new tomorrow*
*And we're greeting it with a roar*
*It's a new tomorrow*
*We're not gonna weep anymore*

That same night, on the other side of Seaworthy, Catra collapsed on her bed. She did not want to dwell on the extra six weeks added to her sentence, or the argument with Netossa, or the heartbroken look on Grimalkin's face. All she wanted to do was sleep.

As she slid her arms under her pillow, her hands brushed against paper. She paused, then sat up and lifted the pillow. Sitting on the sheets was an envelope addressed to "Kitten". She slid a claw under the envelope lip. Inside were two entry tickets into Club Hurricane, two drink vouchers, and a letter.

*Dearest Kitten,*

*One for you, and one for your guard. Come by some night after work. I'm on the corner of Anchor Street and Hightide Avenue. Knock on the door to the rear entrance. I've told staff to give you a balcony so you won't be seen (or hassled). My performance is truly a sight to see!*

*- DT*

At Bright Moon castle, the day-moon had set, and the stars were

emerging. Adora walked into a sunroom with a wall of windows overlooking the water. In one hand, she carried two books – *A History of First Ones Colonization, from First Contact to the Post-Despondos Period* and *Glacia, She-Ra of the Kingdom of Snows* -- and in the other hand, she carried a tablet and pen.

Hordak was seated at a round mahogany table, dressed in tall black boots, a black dress, and a lightweight gray and black exoskeleton that covered his arms, shoulders, and chest. The LUVD crystal sat in an indentation in the center of the exoskeleton's breastplate. On the table sat a glass of water, a saucer with green gel pills, and a small black box, inside of which were dried orange fruits and other sundries. Hordak was staring intently at a flat rectangular disk in his hands.

"About an hour ago, I received some unexpected visitors," he explained. "An anthro man, a cyclops woman, and a robot arrived in the rose courtyard, looking for me. They said they were Galactic Couriers, delivering a package from Rigel."

Adora sat down at the table. "Rigel?"

"A man who helped Glimmer, my brother, and me while we were in hiding. They're traveling to Crypto Castle next, to deliver a package to Kadroh."

Hordak returned the disk to the box and placed the box on the floor. He swallowed the green pills – supplements that eased the discomfort of his cloning flaw – with the glass of water. "Are you ready for the latest assessment?" he asked.

"Sure am," Adora answered, pressing her pen to the tablet. "What progress have you made?"

"I spent five weeks at Crypto Castle, devising a reconstruction plan. Entrapta submitted a supplementary report for a solar energy grid, light rail, and datapad network. She and I have been here at Bright Moon for two weeks, refining the plan with Mermista and the New Salineas committee."

Adora wrote notes on her tablet. “Are all of you getting along?”

“In a manner of speaking. The Etherian members are … reserved. But not hostile. They tolerate the presence of Stillness and Day-Moon-Rising. I think they realize that clone engineers can aid the project. Mermista, on the other hand, is endlessly sarcastic and passive aggressive. Her presence is taxing.”

“What did she say to your plans?”

Hordak was silent for a moment. “She approved all the plans, without hesitation,” he admitted with surprise.

As Adora wrote, Hordak continued. “We devoted two days to surveying the ruins of Salineas, so as to devise a plan for removing the debris. Two Salinean community leaders joined us. It was constructive, despite the unpleasantries.”

Adora lifted her gaze from her tablet, cocking an eyebrow.

“One Salinean spit on the ground near my feet. The other hurled crude insults at me. They both refused to acknowledge me afterwards, speaking only to Mermista and the committee members. I can hardly blame them, after what happened.”

Adora sighed. “Listen, I know things are tough.”

Hordak raised his hand, palm out. “No. The work is meaningful. I labor toward something greater than Prime’s approval now. Entrapta is by my side. Imp, and Kadroh, and my brothers wait for me back in Dryl. The past few months have been the happiest days of my life.”

Neither said a word for a few moments. “How did the meeting with the royals go this morning?”

“I told the royal family everything I knew about Omiros. I have done my best to prepare Glimmer for her diplomatic visit. I heard you and Bow will be going with her?”

Adora nodded. “On Mara’s ship. We wanted to see another planet,” she admitted. “Plus, Glimmer thought that diplomacy might go better with “the great hero of the galaxy” beside her. And, well, I just wanted to be with my girlfriend.”

Adora finished her notes. Hordak glanced at her books. “What are you reading?”

“Oh. These? George and Lance lent them to me. This book is about one of the ancient She-Ras. The other is about the First Ones. I’m … trying to figure some things out. About myself.”

“Ah,” Hordak replied.

They were both silent for several moment.

"Did you know that the Princesses can trace their lineages to two different civilizations?" Adora suddenly asked. "This book says that after the Despondos incident, the First Ones who controlled the Runestones married Etherians. Mostly anthros, Cherubim, and Scorpioni. The high queens and princesses were their descendants."

Adora inhaled deeply, folding her hands on the table. “The princesses know about their ancestors, but I don’t. Maybe that’s another reason why I want to go into space. To learn where I came from.”

Hordak narrowed his eyes, then reached into Rigel’s box. He pulled out the rectangular disk, then tapped the screen several times. “I’m reading as well. A Battani tale called *The Epic of Chiropterus*. Read this passage from the introduction.”

Hordak placed the disk on the table in front of Adora. She read the paragraph on the screen out loud. “Only fragments of the story in its original West Battanushri language survive. The modern Galactic Common translation comes to us from Old Eternian manuscripts dating to from 10,890-11,335 Kings Era. Ancient Battani emissaries visited the court of King Grayskull, a renown patron of the arts. Impressed with Battani poetry and

literature, Grayskull had several Battani works translated into Old Eternian, including the epic."

Adora sat back, blinking. "King Grayskull. *For the honor of Grayskull*. I never knew what it meant, until now. Grayskull was one of my people."

"Your people still live, out in the galaxy," Hordak reminded her. "Planet Kadroh has a large Eternian diaspora. Rigel says there's a movement to repatriate Eternians back to planet Eternia."

Adora was wide-eyed. Her gaze darted across the table as she lost herself in though.

"Perhaps you should talk to the royal family about a diplomatic visit to planet Kadroh? Or Eternia?"

Adora bit her lip. "That's an idea. Or I could visit myself, when things calm down, and I have free time."

"If you wish to learn where you came from, I would begin there," Hordak advised her. "I'm only now learning about my own people. We both have journeys ahead of us, it seems."

Outside, the night sky glittered with thousands of stars.

# Etheria Reborn

Chapter Summary

> A magical renaissance and technological revolution change Etheria in seismic ways. New Salineas rises from the rubble of the old city. Double Trouble's cabaret causes controversy. Adora makes a startling discovery while accompanying Glimmer on a diplomatic space trip. Queen Angella and the Princesses must plan for when the Runestones go dark, and must make peace with commoners who want their voices heard. Hordak, Entrapta, Kadroh, Imp, and Emily have new worlds to explore.

Chapter Notes

> A warm thank you to everyone who came along on this journey. Gossamer Threads has been a pleasure to write, and your supportive comments made the experience even more fun. I hope you all enjoyed the story.
>
> Chapter 22 is the most exposition-heavy chapter of the story, so it's not as rich in sensory details or dialogue as previous chapters. I hope it's not too dry.

From the rubble of ravaged Salineas, New Salineas rose. The city was a tapestry of sea green, blue, and violet, overlooking the Salindrus Ocean. The Sea Gate had been restored, and would protect the city from tsunamis as it had before. The odor of ash was long gone, and the air smelled clean again. The water was clear, no longer sullied with debris.

Inside New Salineas, everything gleamed. Mosaic walkways, murals, stained glass windows, and public gardens made the city look vibrant. Shell-shaped buildings boasted electricity, running water, and plumbing. Data screens, modeled off data pads, were embedded in the walls of every home. A new hospital, shaped like a white scallop shell, was equipped with medical technology

borrowed from the Galactic Horde. A light rail ran in a circuit around the city, lettings residents travel from place to place quickly.

Along the coast, Marinos, Estuaria, Windwave, Longshore, and Seiche had been rebuilt as well. The resurrected villages sported the same technological advancements as New Salineas – electricity, running water, indoor plumbing, data screens – and a light rail connected the settlements to New Salineas and each other. The houses retained the ocean motif of the region, shaped like shells, coral, and sea creatures.

Mermista traveled to nearby towns and refugee camps, addressing the displaced Salineans. "The city and villages are ready. After waiting for so long, *we can go home*."

Excitement spread through the Salinean diaspora. Sea elves and anthros migrated back, settling into new homes and old professions. A message spread far and wide among the Salineas: *come home*.

In New Salineas, Mermista launched a week-long celebration to mark the resurrection of her kingdom. For days, the city celebrated with seafood feasts, musical performances, boat races, and water sports. Sea Hawk hosted a bonfire one night, where he burned wood from decommissioned ships and led revelers in ale drinking and singing.

Melog was exploring Etheria, tasting new emotions. The eldritch being now wandered through New Salineas, soaking up the happiness of the festival. "Melog-Curious swims through thick emotions here," the creature told Mermista, morphing into a pink and purple copy of the princess. "Joy, hope, relief. Melog-Happy will tell Angella after the return."

On the final day of the celebration, Mermista invited her friends and colleagues to the new royal palace for a party. The clone engineers and the reconstruction committee were among those in attendance. However, Hordak and Entrapta were not. Hordak felt

that his presence would be inappropriate, and Mermista agreed. Entrapta did not want to attend without her partner, and declined the invitation.

Before the fete, Mermista addressed a crowd of Salineans from a palace balcony. Stillness and Day-Moon-Rising had built a sound system as a housewarming gift for the princess, and it carried Mermista's voice to the people.

"Hordak and Catra led the invasion that destroyed Salineas, and now, they've rebuilt it," Mermista told the crowd. "Hordak agreed to design a new city, and I held him to that. Many of the bricks used to rebuild came from the kiln where Catra was assigned. You could say she really did rebuilt Salineas, brick by brick."

Mermista's eyes were bright. "We can't erase what happened. Nothing will undo the past, or make us forget how much it hurt. I know you're still angry. I'm still angry too. But you know what? The future looks amazing now. Let's dive into it."

Club Hurricane became one of the hottest cabarets on Etheria. A must-see for tourists and sailors on shore leave, Club Hurricane hosted musicians, comedians, dancers, and theatrical performances that ended with thunderous applause. Sea Hawk sang shanties at the club several times a year. A mysterious Scorpioni woman named Lynda D'ream enchanted the audience with her singing one autumn day.

The main attraction, however, was Double Trouble, who mesmerized patrons with their songs and shapeshifting. Double Trouble hired a small troupe of actors, and together, they performed skits as well. The skits often poked fun at Queen Angella, the princesses, Plumerian "party kale" smokers, and Fright Zone cooks. The skits about Angella and the princesses triggered both laughter and shock from the public, and the controversy only brought more visitors to Club Hurricane.

“Did you think *they* were beyond criticism?” Double Trouble asked the audience one night at the end of a show. “Hardly, darlings! Maybe you should question them more.”

For all their irreverence and racy humor, none of the skits ever made the *clones* the butt of jokes. “Even I know that would be gross,” Double Trouble admitted to a Seaworthy theater critic. “Punching down is no fun. Punching up, on the other hand, causes maximum chaos, and I do so love chaos!”

When Double Trouble began selling tickets for a 21-and-over burlesque show about Horde Prime, public outrage was swift and loud. Picketers protested outside of Club Hurricane on the opening night of “Whored Prime, Emperor of the Galactic Hordonkers”.

With the stage decorated to resemble the Velvet Glove throne room, Double Trouble strutted out as Horde Prime, clad only in white boots and a G-string. With actors playing galactic dignitaries in various stages of undress, the songs and skits depicted Horde Prime as a buffoon. This Horde Prime was too lazy to run his empire, preferring to wallow in luxury. Scantily clad dignitaries rejected his advances, mocking his lack of finesse and cloying cologne. In a faux-melancholy solo, Prime slumped on this throne, thighs spread. He lamented his empty soul, and how all the wonders of the galaxy only reminded him of how pathetic he was.

The final scene took place in Prime’s bedroom. Two tastefully dressed actresses played Glimmer and Catra. Prime fawned on his bed and wiggled his rump, trying (and failing) to seduce the young queen. As “Glimmer” squirmed, complaining that Prime needed deodorant, “Catra” secretly snuck around the bedroom. The Magicat actress playing Catra hid behind the bed board then crawled under the bed, staying just out of Prime’s sight. Suddenly, she snuck up behind Prime, gave him a wedgie, grabbed Glimmer’s hand, and ran out of the room with her. The audience laughed and applauded.

The closing curtain fell, and the cast assembled on stage. “If you can laugh at something awful, it has less power over you,” Double

Trouble told the audience, shapeshifting back to their chameleon form as the cast bowed. “Prime has no power here.”

The recent upheavals sent shock waves through Etheria’s faith communities. Some Etherians abandoned their gods, pointing out that it was people, not gods, who saved the galaxy. Others dived into their faith with new fervor, insisting that the gods humbled the haughty and uplifted poetic heroes.

*We see the divine touch in the irony of the Unleashing. The First Ones shackled Etheria’s magic, and so the gods sent a First Ones woman to liberate it. We see divine justice in the overthrow of Horde Prime. A slave-master held the galaxy in thrall, and so the gods sent his former slaves to dethrone him,* wrote Torino, a Minotaur theologian.

Plumerians who worshipped Eterya, the goddess of the living planet, were divided. Some believed that Eterya was at work in the magical transformations spreading across the planet: new magic users, new species, and the greater vigor of flora and fauna. Others were aghast that their planet’s magic could be contained in the Heart so easily by mortals, and wondered if Eterya was even real.

The liberated clones were not a devout lot. Some took an intellectual interest in Etherian religion, eager to learn about their adopted planet. Most, however, were atheists. “We spent our lives worshiping a god. One was quite enough,” Yeast told his fellow cooks in Crypto Castle’s kitchen. “Horde Prime was a false god. Who is to say the Etherians’ gods aren’t illusory as well?” Yudi huffed, when a Plumerian offered him a copy of *The Book of the Verdant Mother.*

Some young Etherians, eager to understand the magical forces coursing through the planet, took an interest in shamanism. In the Kingdom of Snows, young people sought out the snow-shamans. Through breathing exercises, trances, and the singing

of ancient songs, the snow-shamans taught them how to feel the living magic in the wind, ice, and earth.

Elsewhere, a rumor spread among the young people of Bright Moon: if someone entered the Whispering Woods with a pure heart, they would find a Twigget shaman who would teach them ancient wisdom. The rumor was confirmed when a young goat-woman disappeared in the woods for several days, only to emerge with a story to tell. Razz the Twigget shaman was real, she told her loved ones, and had agreed to mentor her in the ways of plants, spirits, hidden realms, and pie-baking.

In no other community did faith grow stronger than among the Magicats, however.

*In the wake of the Horde-Rebellion War, the Galactic Horde invasion, and the Unleashing, the Magicat community saw a blossoming of religious zeal,* Royal Scholar George noted in *Etheria's Faithful*, a book he and Lance were writing about Etherian faith communities. *Noh-El temples saw an influx of believers. In a world of dizzying change, the temple community provided stability. Worship helped many Magicats cope with traumatic memories.*

*Nowhere was this clearer than Seaworthy, a diverse city where Magicats make up almost twenty percent of the population. Felissa, high priestess of the Temple of Her Shining Paw, allowed us to observe a worship service in celebration of the Night of Purring holiday. Worship is a passionate affair, filled with drumming, chanting, and ecstatic dancing in honor of the goddess. The temple sanctuary was filled with swinging limbs, pounding feet, hair whipping to and fro, and sweat.*

*We noticed a familiar Magicat in the crowd: a young woman with orange fur, one blue eye, and one gold eye. She seemed to lose herself in the wild dancing. Afterwards, we asked Felissa about the former Horde general's presence. "All are welcome to worship, even ex-Horde soldiers, so long as they are contrite," the priestess explained. "The goddess loves even her prodigal children."*

In the years following the fall of Horde Prime, planets forged new alliances. Etheria was no exception. Glimmer earned a reputation as a savvy diplomat, forging new alliances with other worlds.

When not monitoring Hordak, Adora transported Glimmer on Mara's spacecraft. Adora's legacy as a great hero earned her others' trust, bolstering Glimmer's diplomatic efforts. Bow was frequently by Glimmer's side. On these offworld trips, he would track down samples of alien technology that he could bring back to Entrapta. Sometimes, Swift Wind accompanied the group, eager to find beasts of burden to liberate on faraway worlds, and to advocate for the dignity of his fellow animals.

Adora had another traveling companion, a lizard with a tiny unicorn horn and rainbow-colored wings that called itself Caesar. Adora had first met Caesar at Razz's house during a friendly visit. The reptile pounded on the table with his tiny fist, demanding to know why Adora abandoned him after uplifting him to sapience. The two talked for hours, and both agreed that they wanted to make up for lost time. Now, Caesar was a friend, offering Adora advice, trading affectionate jabs with Swift Wind, and getting the team out of tight spots by creeping into tiny places.

The Best Friends Squad's travels would take them to planet Kadroh, where Glimmer negotiated a trade agreement with its leaders. Chancellor Randor found Adora unsettling, remaking that she looked so much like his wife and son. Prime Minister Marlena stared at her, saying that she was sure they'd met before.

During a walk with Randor and Marlena by the shore, Adora revealed that she'd been kidnapped by a First Ones AI as a baby, and arrived on Etheria through a portal. Marlena revealed that many years before, she and Randor watched in horror as a portal swallowed their baby daughter as she slept in her crib.

A urgent message summoned the best geneticist in Kopar-nik. Blood samples were drawn from Randor, Marlena, and Adora. Minutes later, the truth brought tears to their eyes. Genetics tests proved with 98.994% accuracy that Randor and Marlena were Adora's parents. Randor trembled. Marlena cried out. Adora held her hands over her mouth. Days later, Adam returned to planet Kadroh, throwing his arms around the twin sister he'd never met.

One night, as she and Glimmer prepared for bed, Adora burst into tears of joy. Two families embraced her now: her Etherian family, and her biological family. "It's like I've arrived at the end of a long journey," she told Glimmer, wiping tears away with her palms.

Ten years after the tribunal, when Hordak had completed his sentence, Adora visited Eternia, the home of her ancestors. Historians would write about how she and Adam discovered the ruins of Castle Grayskull, where a powerful magical core resided. Bards would sing about how Adam became He-Man, just as Adora had assumed the mantle of She-Ra. Poets would recount their heroic adventures, bringing down an extremist named Keldor.

Adora's home would always be Etheria, however. She visited Kadroh and Eternia often, but Etheria's hero would always return to Bow's smile and Glimmer's welcoming arms.

Etheria pulsed with magic. Across the planet, ordinary people discovered that they could levitate objects, conjure fire, heal injuries, sway chance in their favor, or see glimpses of the past. The release of the Heart's magical energy caused more and more Etherians to manifest magical powers, until approximately a third of the population had developed static magic abilities. Years after the Unleashing, the number of magically empowered Etherians kept growing, with no signs of abating.

Thinkers contemplated the future. Would Etherian society split into castes of magic users and non-users? Would society become even more stratified, with magic users at the top of the social

hierarchy? What if all Etherians developed magical abilities someday? What would an entire planet of static magic users look like? Mystacore mages, Runestone princesses, the odd shaman, and a handful of static magic users such as Netossa and Spinnerella once had a monopoly on magic; how would their relationships with the commoners change if large swaths of the population were magically empowered?

Mystacore, meanwhile, was in the midst of a renaissance. With so much raw magical energy around them, mages could cast spells more easily, and with greater power. New schools of magical thought emerged, as mages experimented with new spells and magical paradigms. New centers for magical healing, art, and education flourished on the floating island.

The mages of Mystacore were divided about the wave of new static magic users. Some mages mentored them, eager to help them harness their abilities and use them safely. Other mages saw the explosion of static magic as a fascinating consequence of the Unleashing, but still inferior to the mages' dynamic magic.

Another unexpected consequence of the Unleashing was the emergence of sapient animals. A Plumerian farmer screamed one morning when a doe pranced into his apple orchard and asked, out loud, if "those really tart ones" were ripe yet. A sea lion loudly argued with a Salinean pearl diver about scaring off his fish dinner. In the forests of Bright Moon, a hornet politely asked a pair of hikers if they lived in "the giant white hive" near the water.

While uncommon, these animals aroused curiosity. Mystacore scholars traveled the planet, researching the phenomenon. The emergence of intelligent animals had something to do with the dense magical energy on Etheria, but the process was poorly understood.

When not traveling the galaxy with Adora, Swift Wind and Caesar befriended these animals, helping them adjust to their new consciousness. Years later, Swift Wind fell in love with a sapient horse named Star Wind, and the two became parents of a foal.

As Etheria settled into peace, its inhabitants asked questions.

The Runestone princesses ruled because of their lineages and magical powers, but now many Etherians had magic powers too. What made the royals special, then?

The Horde-Rebellion War began as a slave revolt against the Scorpioni royal house. What would stop future rulers from enslaving their fellow Etherians?

Beast-people flocked to the Horde because it treated them better than many kingdoms. Many stayed in the Fright Zone because it gave them a voice. Who would look out for the interests of the beast-people in the different kingdoms? The commoners as a whole?

Static magic users, former slaves, beast-people, and other commoners coalesced into a movement, demanding rights for the common folk. Clones such as Kadroh and Yudi also joined the movement, adamant that the clones never be enslaved again.

Campfire vigils, public debates in town squares, and revolutionary music on street corners became common. Commoners gathered in the throne rooms of palaces, holding long and hard conversations with the royals. Kadroh quietly met with Glimmer, Angella, and Micah, urging them to give the clones assurances that they would remain free.

Queen Angella and the other royals took action. Five years after the Unleashing, Etheria's royal leaders convened in Mermista's palace in New Salineas to create a revolutionary new charter: the New Salineas Accords. The city was a symbol of new beginnings, and the charter would mark a new beginning for the planet.

The accords outlawed slavery, torture, military conscription, and speciesist discrimination. It acknowledged the inherent dignity of

all sapient beings, recognizing their freedom of speech, freedom of movement, and freedom of religion.

The New Salineas Accords established a Council of Commoners in each royal-led kingdom. Members of each council would be elected by the populace of each kingdom, and would advise the princesses and high queen on matters of policy. Many commoners were disappointed that these councils would not have veto power over the royals' decrees, but vowed to keep striving.

Lands that already had similar structures in place – the Fright Zone, Greensteppe, and Dryl -- were not required to set up Councils of Commoners. The Fright Zone was now a democracy. Greensteppe's rulers had traditionally been advised by a Circle of Elders chosen from the commoners. Dryl's affairs were largely managed by the mayors of the kingdom's five towns, with Entrapta presiding only over major affairs of state.

That night, Angella, Glimmer, Micah, Mermista, Frosta, Perfuma, and Scorpia held a secret meeting. In a marble room overlooking the ocean, the leaders lounged on blue cushions, poured themselves spicy Salinean tea from a teal samovar, and pondered the future.

The finite power remaining in the Runestones was a closely guarded secret, one that Etheria's leaders had not yet shared with the public. Someday, however, the Runestones would run out of magic, and the Runestone princesses would be forced to tell their subjects.

"Let it be later," Glimmer argued. "Etheria is changing so fast. Let the Etherians cope with all the changes right now. We can tell the public in a few years, when things settle down."

"Why not tell them now?" Scorpia countered. "They'll be upset if they find out we kept them in the dark."

"I say tell them in a few months," Mermista suggested. "They're happy now, with New Salineas and the accords. Let them have

their happiness for a while. Tell them later this year."

The assembled parties agreed. The conversation turned to the future of the monarchies. The royals drank cup after cup of tea as they talked late into the night.

"The Fright Zone won't be affected," Scorpia admitted. "When the Black Garnet goes dark, it just means that I can't use magic to protect the city. There will still be a Fortress Council. We'll be fine."

Mermista stared into her tea. "But the rest of us? Our ties to the Runestones give us authority. Our descendants won't have that authority. The Runestones will be empty by then."

"What about having the commoners councils take over our kingdoms? After we're gone?" Frosta proposed. The others looked up at the young woman. Frosta's gaze passed over each of them. Her eyes were bright.

"We'd have time to get everything in place, before we're old," Frosta continued. "To be honest, I'm thinking about doing it sooner."

"Why?" Angella asked, breathlessly. "Why would you give up your throne?"

Frosta's gaze softened. "Because I … I want a normal life. I don't want to be a princess until I die. I was put on the throne too young. I missed too much. I want to live, while I still have time."

"Etheria's changing, too," Scorpia added, gingerly holding a tiny tea cup in her claw. "People aren't content to let royals make all the decisions now. Someday, they won't want monarchs anymore. Definitely not monarchs with empty Runestones. I think Frosta's plan makes sense."

Angella, Micah, and Glimmer were wide-eyed. Angella's mouth had opened slightly. Finally, Micah spoke.

"Wait a few years. Promise me you'll do that. Let the commoners council find its footing," Micah advised Frosta, holding up his hands. "When everything's stable, and you're sure it's what you really want, then step down."

Frosta nodded, swallowing the rest of her tea. Mermista narrowed her gaze, staring at the carpet.

"That's not a bad idea. I mean, I don't want to do it now. But after I die, I could see a commoners council ruling Salineas," Mermista said. "And … I just … it's better than getting an heir ready."

Perfuma turned to Mermista, surprised.

"My parents always told me that I needed to marry and give birth to an heir someday," Mermista groaned. "Continuing the royal line and all that. But I don't want to be a mother. I never did. And if my Runestone's going to go dark anyway, what's the point of the royal line?"

"Oh, but I love children. I want to have lots of children," Perfuma confessed. "But…I don't want to force any of them to become rulers. They should be free to choose their own path. I give Frosta's idea my blessing."

The group was silent for a moment.

"None of us chose to be rulers, except maybe Angella and Micah," Frosta mused. "It was chosen for us."

"Dumped on my lap, in my case," Mermista groaned.

"We don't have to do that to our children. We don't even have to have kids," Frosta insisted.

"All of you, slow down," Angella demanded. "I agree that the fate of the Runestones is a serious matter. It will have ramifications for our authority. But what you're proposing is drastic."

Angella folded her hands on her lap and inhaled deeply. "I plan to remain High Queen, even after the Moonstone loses its magic. I have held the throne for centuries, and thus my situation is different from yours. My age and long memory will legitimize my authority, even after the Moonstone grows cold. Doing so will give Etheria a central leader, even if other kingdoms choose councils someday, to run their internal affairs."

"But … like Scorpia said, the day may come when Etherians don't want monarchs anymore," Glimmer said slowly, gazing at her mother with heavy eyes. "What will you do, centuries from now, or maybe decades from now, if they don't want a high queen?"

Angella pondered Glimmer's question, staring out at the ocean. "I don't know," she admitted softly. "I have a lot to think about."

Micah rested his hand on Angella's hand, and the two gazed at each other solemnly. "We'll hammer out a plan," he assured her. "We don't have to figure it all out tonight."

That night, Frosta, Mermista, and Perfuma made a decision. They would compose secret decrees that their respective commoners councils would assume leadership of the Kingdom of Snows, New Salineas, and Plumeria after their deaths. Frosta was seriously considering abdicating the throne before then, but agreed to wait a few more years before making a final decision.

Glimmer returned to her guest quarters, lost in thought. Micah looked mildly alarmed. Angella looked exhausted.

Hordak had witnessed so much in the years since the tribunal. He had watched his brothers' rebirth as free men. He had seen Etherians develop magical powers, each more surprising than the next. He had led the reconstruction of New Salineas. He'd been present at the signing of the New Salineas Accords, and when others complained, Entrapta pointed out that she was entitled to bring her *prince-consort.* ("It has a nice ring to it. Even better

than “royal bedfellow”, which is what I told Mermista my official title should—” Sea Hawk chirped, until Mermista elbowed him in the side and grunted.)

Now, he was witnessing Etheria transform from a backwater into a modern planet. He and his beloved Technology Czar had devised countless projects to improve life on Etheria. Light rails for travel within kingdoms. Datapads that allowed for instantaneous communication among the commoners. Hydroponic farms, like the ones used by the Horde. Clinics in multiple cities with Galactic Horde medical technology: cybernetic body parts, tanks for cloning individual organs, reconditioning chambers for severe injuries, and a gamut of new medicines. Between the new clinics and advances in healing magic in Mystacore, Etherians were healthier than ever before.

Hordak was healthier too. Entrapta’s new exoskeleton, combined with supplements and regular sessions in a reconditioning chamber, kept his cloning flaw dormant. No longer tormented by pain and weakness, he threw himself into his work, and into his life with Entrapta, with vigor.

A team of engineers and technicians, along with an army of laborers, worked alongside Hordak and Entrapta for years, bringing each project to fruition. Members of the Etherian Makers Guild, tech experts from the Fright Zone, and clones made up a sizeable portion of the team. Several of the laborers were magically endowed Etherians, using their new abilities to move chunks of earth, levitate heavy objects, or instantly heal the occasional injury.

“Don’t you love it? Watching it all come together?” Entrapta asked Hordak one night as they slid into bed.

“Yes. Nothing is impossible anymore,” Hordak replied. He wrapped his arms around the Technology Czar and kissed her cheek.

While some clones preferred to live in clone villages, others started new lives in the towns and cities. There, they became a

sort of intelligentsia, teaching the Etherians how to use new technology, operating the medical clinics, and training new doctors. Some clones became school teachers, instructing Etheria's youth in everything from evolution to astronomy to physics. Some Etherians were still wary of the clones, and anti-clone bigotry was not unheard of, but most Etherians coexisted with them.

Eight years after the fall of Horde Prime, the Honorable Keepers of Royal Protocol selected Dryl to host Princess Prom. One morning, a messenger arrived at Crypto Castle and presented Entrapta with a declaration scroll, listing elaborate and stuffy prom protocol. The messenger returned to the Honorable Keepers and unfurled the scroll. Entrapta had written a one word reply in red ink on the paper: **NOPE.** The Honorable Keepers chose Plumeria instead.

Several months after Plumeria hosted Princess Prom (which Entrapta and Hordak did not attend), Dryl hosted its own unforgettable event. Technology Czar Entrapta hosted the first Etherian World Fair in Geartown. The festival covered the fields outside Geartown in stages and tents, where festival-goers took in new technological marvels, magical innovations, cuisine, and arts. All were welcome to attend.

On the north stage, Kyle performed an interpretive fire-dance, swooping and twirling as flames danced around him in the night. A troupe of three other fire dancers – Etherians who developed pyromancy powers after the Unleashing – spun and stomped around him, pouring out their own flames. A lizard woman pounded a goblet drum as they danced.

In West Tent One, a Zephyr mountaineer and a Mystacore mage showed off their collaborative inventions: light sticks, avocado-sized gems that emitted warmth, and canteens that spontaneously filled with water, all of which drew their energy from ambient magic in the air. "Think of how many adventurers this can help!" the mountain climber insisted, smiling broadly.

In East Tent One, hungry visitors could sample dozens of new foods. Some of the foods, such as freeze-dried ice cream, foam curry, tea spheres, and edible clothes, were the products of inventive gourmands with technology. Others were a host of magical foods concocted by Mystacore chefs: fruit juices that made drinkers feel different emotions, candies that caused eater's bodies to emit windchime sounds when they walked, and edible flowers that made forgotten memories resurface when eaten. In East Tent Two, the temporary effects of Make-Me-Blond-Ale and Stout-Muscles-Stout made the beers a hit. The amniotic fluid mojitos were less popular.

In the South Field, Etherians set foot in a Galactic Horde spacecraft. Entrapta and Hordak had long since reverse engineered such ships to obey commands from non-clone pilots, but this ship was different. The bridge now had rows of padded seats. A crystalline cabinet rested in the wall, holding bottles of water and snacks. The panoramic screen showed a video display of outer space, stars, and gas giants. This ship, christened the Twelve Moons' Rays, was one of five ships that would form Etheria's first space travel fleet. Soon, commoners would be able to visit other planets. While off-world, Bow had acted as a go-between for Entrapta and alien leaders, arranging for ships to travel between Etheria and other planets.

Imp, who was now ten years old and almost five feet tall, reveled in the festival. The first evening, he sat down at the dinner table with Entrapta and Hordak, grinning and bright-eyed. Imp began rapidly tapping keys on the fabric keyboard sleeve he wore on his left arm. "Best festival ever!" came an androgynous voice from a small speaker on the fabric keyboard. "The hologram cave was awesome."

Hordak smiled and poured the boy a glass of water. Imp's enthusiasm for new experiences never ceased. Imp had often accompanied Hordak and Entrapta to different cities for their work, so he grew up marveling at the world. Secretly, however, Hordak missed the days when Imp was small enough to sit on his lap and perch on his shoulder.

Ten years had finally passed since the tribunal. Hordak's sentence was complete. Entrapta took a sabbatical from her work as Technology Czar, and the couple spent several weeks relaxing in Crypto Castle with Imp, Emily, and Kadroh. After years of work, they relished the opportunity to rest, to breathe.

Weeks later, Kadroh and Imp boarded a repurposed Galactic Horde spacecraft, each carrying a duffel bag. Kadroh had long wanted to visit planet Kadroh and see Rigel again, and he thought an interplanetary trip would be good for Imp as well. Hordak and Entrapta agreed, wishing them both safe travels.

Anthros, lizard-folk, and clones boarded the flight with them. Flights into space had only started a few months before, and Etherian tourists were eager to travel.

As Kadroh and Imp took their seats, a cat-woman passed them, sitting down in another row. She wore black spandex garments and a black jacket, but no shoes. She carried a leather backpack over her shoulder, from which a Club Hurricane pewter charm dangled. Around her left wrist was a bracelet of red jasper prayer beads, commonly worn by devout cat-folk. Her hands, roughened by years of manual labor, were strong. Her eyes – one blue, one gold – glimmered with hope. After sitting down, Catra ran a hand through her short hair, sighed with relief, and closed her eyes.

"Welcome aboard the Twelve Moons' Rays," came a clone's voice over the sound system. "This is flight 10, leaving from the Bright Moon Sky Harbor on Etheria, with stops on planets Kadroh, Trannis, Phantos, and Geolon. We will be taking off shortly. Please remain seated and refrain from using magical items during the flight."

A still image of the Velvet Glove, floating in deep space, appeared on the panoramic screen.

“We’ll be flying past Miksita Space Station, formerly the Velvet Glove. There, a portal jump will take us to our first stop, the Kopar-nik Sky Harbor on planet Kadroh,” the voice continued.

Horde Prime’s ship was now manned by liberated clones and Etherians, who monitored space traffic and assisted ships with emergencies. Space travelers from different planets now used it as a meeting place, and its many rooms had been converted to sleeping quarters and canteens for travelers. The station had since been moved millions of miles away from Etheria, so that Etheria’s magical energies would no longer interfere with its sensors.

The image of the station disappeared from the screen. The clone pilot inserted a neural cable into his neck port and rested his hands on two metal spheres. Two holographic screens appeared on either side of his head. A deep humming rose from the back of the ship.

Kadroh turned to Imp and smiled. Imp smirked back. A faraway planet was waiting.

Back on Etheria, Entrapta, Hordak, and Emily carried duffel bags and metal boxes onto their private Galactic Horde ship, the one Hordak had used to flee from Horde Prime many years before.

“Okay, do we have everything?” Entrapta called out, slowly spinning on her corkscrew-shaped hair as she surveyed the luggage. “Emergency repair tools, data pads, diagnostic equipment, tiny foods, seltzer water, mini telescopes, spare parts for Emily, spare parts for the exoskeleton, clothes, personal care items, supplements, and first aid. Anything else?”

Hordak entered the ship’s bridge from outside, carrying a sealed, 5-gallon bucket in each hand. “Your shampoo and conditioner.”

“Oh yeah! Thanks. I completely forgot.”

Emily trotted among the bags, buckets, and boxes, beeping cheerfully. The doors to the ship sealed. As Hordak took his place

at the pilot's dais, Entrapta bounced around the bridge on the ends of her twintails.

"I have wanted to do this for *so long*!" she squealed.

"You deserve a vacation. We both do," he replied.

"I know, right? Sightseeing gas giants from space. Hunting for lost magitech in Battaniya ruins. Attending my first intergalactic tech conference on Geolon. This is going to be *amazing*!"

Entrapta turned to Hordak. "Doing all this with you makes it even better," she said warmly.

Hordak nodded, drinking in her happiness. "It will be the first of many journeys, together," he promised.

The years with Entrapta had been the most incredible journey of his life. Loving her, being loved by her, and building new creations by her side had brought him new joys, every single day. Staring into her eyes, he felt a warm sweetness fill him. Their journey had just begun.

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